



Author Nagatsuki Tappei

Illustrator Shinichirou Otsuka

Translators

Witch Cult Translations

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28

Re:ゼロ

Re: Life in a different world from zero

から始める異世界生活

Manifesto

Hello, this is Phantaminum. This is a continuation of a project that aims to standardize nomenclature and formatting, while dividing Web Novel chapters in the same way the Light Novel does. Colored illustrations have also been added where possible for maximum enjoyment. You may find a list of all volumes I have already finished, or plan to work on, at the [final chapter of this document](#).

This document is a compilation of Re: Zero Web Novel chapters that correspond to Volume 28, spanning Web Novel Arc 7 Chapters 25 to 39. Witch Cult Translations ([website](#)), was used as a source of the translations for all the Chapters. Chapters 25 to 39 were produced with use of Machine Translation tools.

For the sake of completeness, I leave you with the same wall of text detailing what I did using the available translations. Feel free to skip it if you don't care/have already read it.

The original translations have been proofread, edited and reformatted by myself, on top of whatever original editing and proofreading work was done by Witch Cult Translations. This means that the formatting should remain consistent no matter which source is used.

I have tried to follow naming conventions present in the Light Novel as much as possible, only diverging when community-given names differed greatly. I have also tried to conserve as many of the original translator notes by Witch Cult Translations as much as possible.

As a fun quirk, I have done something which I admit is probably not consensual: to flip the languages whenever someone speaks what is colloquially coined as Engrish. This means, that in the case where the story uses English, where possible, Japanese will be written as Romaji (Japanese in Latin script). When this happens, a note was added with the original expression (and its translation), and the new expression that was converted to Romaji. Basically, I made everyone using Engrish look like weeaboos.

I hope you enjoy this as much as I did. If you have anything to point out, I'm often lurking in pretty much every Re: Zero discussion site, be it the Reddit Discord Server, the Subreddit, or 4chan's /a/ board. Alternatively, feel free to use [this document](#) to suggest corrections or other changes.

P.S.: Much thanks to Joy Kirbs from Discord for aiding me in redesigning the covers.

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Arc 7 Chapter 25 - A Reunion Akin to Scorching Blood

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 1 “A Reunion Akin to Scorching Blood”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

—There was a girl of “crimson”, like a vivid, scorching flame, richly scented in blood.

Amidst the sudden battlefield, upon the upper levels of City Hall, this violent beauty dominated the desolate scene while holding a radiant treasured sword.

With her dazzling orange hair, a luxurious blood-colored dress, and feminine figure, the person grasping that sword was one whose back exuded strength.

Subaru: “———”

Staring at her in exasperation, Subaru’s thoughts were stirred into confusion as stood with arms open wide.

Momentarily forgetting the pain that coursed through his entire body and the need to breathe, a single word bounced chaotically in his empty head, “Why”.

Why, was she here.

Why, had she saved Subaru.

Why, was she able to face Arakiya with such calm.

Why, why, why, why, why, why, why, why, why, he could not stop wondering why.

Overwhelmed by endless questions, Subaru felt like time itself had halted. Then, as if to ridicule the motionless Subaru, the woman of “crimson” gave a snort and—

Priscilla: “What an idiotic visage. Have your eyes been scorched by my nobility?”

Subaru: “—What, do you have eyes in the back of your head?”

Priscilla: “Nonsense. Does it appear like I have such a deformity? I can tell a foolish commoner’s expression just by their respiration.”

Still with nary even a glance back, came a proud retort of the woman— of Priscilla Barielle.

Whilst gazing at the woman who should not be present, Subaru did not have any words to refute the preposterous notion that she would be capable of knowing his expression just by his breathing.

The situation slowly progressed in front of Subaru, who could only be stunned and dumbfounded.

Priscilla: “Well.”

After taking a short breath, Priscilla looked around as she continued to firmly wield the ornate crimson sword.

She recognized that the City Hall had been completely transformed by the sudden intruder’s rampage.

Even accounting for the injured People of Shudraq and the comatose Zikr, the only ones who could move, albeit barely, were Subaru, Rem right behind him, and Abel, atop the balcony.

And the one who was the cause of all this—

Priscilla: “—Arakiya.”

Arakiya: “———”

Narrowing her crimson eyes, Priscilla focused on the other girl quietly.

The one who maintained her silence under such circumstances was the brown-skinned, silver-haired demi-human— The Imperial General First-Class, ranked Second, Arakiya.

She had been said to be the second strongest person in the Vollachia Empire. Her abilities had showcased this well. She met Priscilla’s gaze, brimming with strong will, head-on, with her red right eye that remained uncovered by her eyepatch— Nay, actually, she did not.

Arakiya: “Prin... cess...?”

Until now, Arakiya had given the impression of an otherworldly presence, imposing a solid world of her own. However, under Priscilla’s stare, that world collapsed in a single beat.

Instead, what emerged was intense agitation and equally great joy.

Arakiya: “Princess, Princess, Princess... Hk.”

The dangerous atmosphere fizzled out, while Arakiya uttered those words over and over again, as if to confirm it.

Almost as if she were a lost child reunited with their parents, or a small brother and sister trying to regain their bond; one could see the obsession of the weak trying to cling onto the strong.

—The relationship between Priscilla and Arakiya was unknown to the others.

Odd as the sight was, Subaru could not figure out the reason why Priscilla would need to come to this place, and could only guess that there was an unusual past between the two.

It could be this past relationship had broken Arakiya’s fighting spirit, who was by far the most dangerous being in this place.

Arakiya: “—Hk.”

Lowering the thin tree branch in her grip, Arakiya, overcome by emotion, tried to step forward. It seemed as if she were about to jump straight into Priscilla’s chest.

Perhaps she desired to follow the passion welling up in her heart, and embrace Priscilla. However—

Arakiya: “Princ—”

Priscilla: “Silence.”

However, that did not come to pass.

A short, fierce command was accompanied by a flash. As Arakiya was about to take a step forward, a red glow swept across, just mere centimeters from the toes of her bare feet, and glaring flames flared up to prevent her from advancing further.

Arakiya: “———”

At best, the flames contained the power of a bonfire, which went up to her shins.

They were not great enough to hamper Arakiya’s long legs from stepping over them. She easily could—yet despite that, she was unable to move, almost as if she faced an insurmountable wall.

As they stood, Priscilla continued to stare coldly at Arakiya, whose eyes widened at the unexpected action.

Priscilla: “Arakiya, why do you wish to come to me now?”

Arakiya: “Wha...?”

Priscilla: “Did you believe that I would be so excited to reunite with you as to welcome you into my arms? If such is the case, I cannot help but be amazed at your optimism.”

Priscilla’s words were tinged with contempt and disgust, completely blocking Arakiya from approaching.

Arakiya must have understood that there was distance between them. Her eye trembled in astonishment, as she desperately attempted to find the best answer to Priscilla’s words. But——

Arakiya: “P-Prisca-sama...”

Priscilla: “Prisca is dead—— Have you not changed after all this time, even after obtaining your newfound position?”

Arakiya: “——Hk.”

Priscilla: “How dull. It has been a long time since I have last gazed at the soil of my homeland, but it is difficult to feel anything when it has grown so emaciated.”

Priscilla was unable to dismiss the fact that she was deeply disappointed.

To be honest, he lacked enough understanding of her position in this situation to even begin to guess what Priscilla was thinking. Even so, Subaru knew that her heartless words had shaken Arakiya to the core, insofar as making her shed blood.

It was a deep wound. One of being disrespected by a person with whom she had formed an important bond.

Arakiya's eye wavered upon being labeled a disappointment. She could have cowered at the verbal wound; however, instead of faltering, she instead reflected a fierce look from her exposed red eye.

Not anger, but a glimmer of determination and resolve.

Arakiya: "...I don't care what the Princess thinks of me. Even though it's painful. But I've made up my mind."

Priscilla: "—Ho, so you have made up your mind? Can you regain my interest then? Try telling me what you have decided."

In response to Arakiya's quiet appeal, Priscilla threw out a provocative statement, whether she intended to or not. In turn, Arakiya looked up and yelled, "I will!"

As she howled, Arakiya flexed her slender knees,

Arakiya: "I will regain the Princess's rightful place! In the Empire! And to do that..."

The aim of Arakiya's outburst was not directed at Priscilla, who was only half listening.

The gaze of her one eye strayed from Priscilla, heading toward Abel, still perched on the balcony as these events unfolded. He became the target of her shifting emotions.

Arakiya: "You're a liar, Your Excellency, and for that, I shall— Hk!"

Her eye blazing with passionate fury, Arakiya's slender body leapt high in the air. Ignoring the barrier of fire between her and Priscilla, she vaulted forward, her destination being Abel on the balcony.

Her leaping prowess was extraordinary. However, it was not that surprising, considering she held the title of the second strongest in the Empire.

The main problem was that, aside from Priscilla, there was nobody who had the means to stop her.

Subaru: “Shit, Abel’s going to...! Priscilla!”

Priscilla: “Do not raise such a fuss. Why are you acting so familiar, you foolish commoner? With whose permission did you call me by my name?”

Subaru: “This isn’t the time to...”

Priscilla: “—I said, do not raise a fuss.”

With her ornate sword lowered in one hand, Priscilla ignored Subaru’s pleas.

After this threat, which made Priscilla’s next actions unreadable, Arakiya’s form surged like an arrow, approaching Abel in the breathless Subaru’s vision.

Abel: “———”

Abel was leaning onto the railing of the half-destroyed balcony, blood pouring from his forehead.

He had not displayed any signs of dismay at Priscilla’s sudden intrusion, and was still standing firm, regarding Arakiya with his intense black eyes.

It was a known fact that he was not a particularly skilled fighter. His lone uninjured arm, of course, was not strong enough to take on one of the strongest in the Empire. Therefore, Subaru did not know why he refused to fall into despair.

Without knowing——

Subaru: “Abel——!!”

He knew it was pointless, yet nevertheless he tried to dash toward him. But his legs lost their strength at the first step. Having fallen on his knees, Subaru could only reach out as Arakiya approached Abel.

——The very next moment, a chain of events beyond Subaru’s comprehension occurred.

Abel: “———”

Abel stomped hard on the balcony floor, keeping his eyes on the enclosing Arakiya. Immediately after doing so, cracks spread further across the half-destroyed balcony, and the place he took as his foothold collapsed instantaneously.

Naturally, Abel, being on top of it, fell helplessly— so had been thought, but that was not what happened.

Abel's body instead remained suspended in midair. His outstretched right hand had grasped the curtain, which hung from the top floor.

Abel had hidden a lifeline beneath his hand, that he had up against the railing, and then he had intentionally collapsed the place he was standing on.

Perhaps, had the enemy been small fry, the strategy could have been to have them swallowed by the collapse and consequently fall downstairs all at once.

However, the opponent was one of the Nine Divine Generals. Furthermore, she was also ranked Second among them.

Arakiya: "What fun...!"

Swinging like a pendulum, Abel held on for dear life to the curtain, as Arakiya bared her fangs.

Although she had lost the foothold necessary to land after her leap, Arakiya's strength came not only from her enhanced physical abilities, but also from her superhuman powers.

Her legs flickered like glowing embers, and from her knees down, her body transformed into flames, her posture flexed in midair like that of a missile with jets blowing from her legs.

The flames that had immolated Mizelda, the fierce tornado that had blown away the common soldiers, the crude craftwork that had supported a collapsing pillar, the gale that had disarmed Rem, and finally the transformation of a part of her own body into flames.

From all these past events, they had become painfully aware of the endless versatility of Arakiya's abilities.

Arakiya: "Your Excellency, die—!"

At this rate, a branch with unknown power was going to strike Abel. Hanging from the drape, Abel was unable to maintain his position and spun around.

It was unclear if the branch was going to stab him, if it was going to release magic, or if it was going to create some sort of other supernatural effect— it was unknown, yet regardless of what it would do, Abel was going to be torn to pieces.

That certainty alone made the pupils of Subaru's dark eyes narrow with impatience and urgency. Yet—

???: “—Oh damn, bro. I didn't even know that it was you 'til I heard your voice just now.”

Instantly, a figure intervened between the demonic Arakiya and the suspended Abel.

From beside Rem, who was knocked down, a figure ran over the pillar that Arakiya had caught, and threw an attack from the side, aiming for the branch that she held. The strike of the broad *dao*¹ was blocked by the branch, its swing produced by a flick of Arakiya's wrist, but the resulting momentum sent her flying.

After the person's surprise attack was parried without any difficulty, they let out a “Daaah!”, and angrily stomped the ground.

???: “Shit, my arm hurts! Don't effortlessly parry a strike someone put their all into, it's gonna make them depressed.”

His whine and waving of his aching arm concluded the chaotic series of events. That person was, once again, outside the scope of Subaru's imagination.

It was a man who sported a jet-black helmet, dressed in a bandit-like fashion from the waist down. The man, who looked like a brigand or a thief, was characterized by his missing left arm, while his thick right arm held the *dao*.

It was a man he knew. In fact, this was the first person he should have thought of, if Priscilla was here. He was—

¹ This sword is called a “青竜刀”, literally translated as “Blue/Azure Dragon Sword”, but a more accurate, and neutral name would be a “Chinese *dao*”. The literal name could perhaps have certain implications, however.



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Subaru: “—Al?”

Al: “Hey, bro! Didn’t think I’d run into you on the other side of the border. I’d like to share my thoughts on your attire and this strange reunion...”

Priscilla’s Knight—or rather, servant, Al, tilted his head and raised his voice in an out-of-place greeting.

He responded to Subaru in the same aloof tone as usual, while prohibiting Arakiya’s advance, still floating in the air with her legs morphed into flame.

In this case, Subaru did not know if he should be more impressed by Al’s ability to block Arakiya’s attack with just one strike, or by the durability of the tree branch which had clashed straight-on with the *dao* and came out unscathed.

Al: “You can be surprised, man. After all, it wasn’t like this was something done in one shot.”

Arakiya: “Get out of the way! I can’t kill His Excellency like this!”

Al: “I’ve come all this way to interfere, how can I get out of the way now? I can’t just stand here and let my head fall off my body. But...”

Arakiya howled in anger, and Al looked at her from the front without hesitation.

Arakiya’s outfit was overly revealing, but Al did not look at her with lewd intentions. His gaze only contained feelings of nostalgia and deep emotion.

In fact, Al let out an admiring sigh.

Al: “Haa-. You’ve really grown up. I always knew you’d be beautiful.”

Arakiya: “...Who are you?”

Al: “You saying that, it really hurts! Even though we’re friends who trusted each other with their lives!”

When Al called out to her as if she was a familiar face, she raised her eyebrows in suspicion. In order to keep her at a distance, Al kicked up a piece of the broken floor at her slender body.

Looking over Al’s work, Priscilla called out to him.

Priscilla: "Al. You know what I desire, I brought you here, not Schult. Do your job."

Al: "I'm doing it! Do I look like I'm having fun with this cutie? If I'm not careful, I'll be ripped to shreds in ten seconds, okay?"

Priscilla: "Taking a look at the situation, you certainly have not accomplished much."

Al: "It's better than being ripped to shreds, isn't it? Whoa!"

Al, whose concentration was disturbed by the impatient remarks of his master, was nearly killed by Arakiya's blow.

Flying in the air, Arakiya circled more freely than a bird, and Al desperately parried the attacks from her branch being launched one after another.

Arakiya: "You're in the way...!"

Al: "It really hurts an old man's heart to hear a girl your age say that."

Abel continued to hang, and Al continued to protect him.

Glaring down at both of them, Arakiya's eyes became angrier, and every inch of her body was filled with fighting spirit. Still, the reason she would not unleash the fearsome ranged attack she had initially showed was—

Subaru: "Priscilla..."

Princess, that was what Arakiya had called Priscilla.

Priscilla's attitude was nothing but cold and disconnected, but not towards Arakiya. That was the only reason as to why she had not created even more destruction.

Therefore, if anyone could alter this stalemate, that person would be Priscilla, who kept the floating Arakiya in check.

Subaru: "——"

Priscilla: “Do not regard me with those clingy eyes, foolish commoner. I may praise you for your feigned good looks, but wishing to utilize them to make me stir would be irreverent.”

Subaru: “Guh... Hk!”

Subaru, on his knees, turned around, but Priscilla was far too arrogant to take him seriously.

Instead, it was Rem, who had been sheltered by Subaru’s back till now, who moved. She pursed her lips, stepping in front of Priscilla with a perilous gait. And then—

Rem: “Please, I beg you. Please, lend us your strength.”

Priscilla: “—Hmm, what an auspicious thing to say. I would state you to be more polite than this foolish commoner.”

Rem: “Then...!”

Priscilla: “Do not get too carried away. And just, observe. Already, the provisions to shift the state of affairs are underway.”

Rem’s plea, and the possibility of Priscilla’s disapproval, sent a chill down Subaru’s spine.

However, Priscilla did not lose her temper; instead, she indicated to the battlefield with a slight turn of her head.

Rem followed her gaze with a surprised “Eh?”, and Subaru followed suit.

In that battlefield atop the balcony, were it left unchecked, Abel and Al could be slaughtered by Arakiya in seconds. And in fact, the risk of such a thing increased with every passing second.

Al: “Da! Ga! Ao! Guah! Ubaa!”

Arakiya danced in the sky with her legs ablaze, and Al managed to block her attacks, though his movements were terribly clumsy and unrefined, resulting in him being repeatedly pushed back with one blow after another.

But the succession of miracles would not be everlasting. The damage from the accumulated strikes began to show on Al's body, and as soon as his reaction began to be visibly delayed, his upper body was shaken by a huge blow.

With that, Al lost his stance and was defenseless against the next attack, and at that moment---

Arakiya: "—Hk!?"

Arakiya tried to kick the air, yet her body unnaturally swayed, causing her to lose some control.

Even to the run-of-the-mill layman, this was no ordinary sort of offensive motion, as demonstrated by the eyes wide in astoundment and choked out cry of distress.

Arakiya: "-----"

All of them had been startled by the change that had afflicted Arakiya.

The two people who had not been caught off-guard were Priscilla, who was looking at the situation leisurely, and the one who had instigated it, who was supposed to be in the middle of a fierce battle---

???: "—Attack!"

The order slammed into the air with a mixture of a burning and dusty smell.

It had come from Abel, suspended in midair, whose voice was more stern than angry, more ostentatious than arrogant. The man, still hanging from the curtain, shouted at the opportunity that arose in the battle overhead.

It was as if he had known this moment would come.

Al: "You can tell me what happened later!!"

In response to Abel's command, Al flew.

In an awkward leap and twist, the *dao* drew a parabolic line and mercilessly slammed into the slender body of Arakiya bereft of mercy— no, there was mercy.

The wrist holding the *dao* twisted, and the blunt side, not the blade, headed for Arakiya.

Priscilla: “Fool.”

Perceiving that non-lethal trick, Priscilla curtly remarked.

Her eyes, boundlessly arrogant, had correctly foreseen the situation.

Arakiya: “Stay back...!”

At the moment of collision, there was a dull sound that made Subaru want to turn his eyes away.

Al’s powerful blow flew into Arakiya just as he had intended, and she took it head-on with her raised left arm. Her elbow snapped in the opposite direction, broken bones pierced her brown skin, and blood sprayed.

It was a painful blow, but not a fatal one.

Behind his jet-black helmet, there was a low growl from Al, and an indication that his cheeks were surprisingly tense.

A moment later, Arakiya’s thin foot struck him in the neck from the side, sending him crashing to the floor with a fierce impact. His bouncing body was blown away, and went straight out of the collapsed balcony.

Al: “Dohhh, AHHHHH— HK!?”

An ugly scream tailed off, and so, Al’s figure disappeared from sight.

He was safe, of course, but now the obstacle between Abel and Arakiya had vanished.

Arakiya extinguished the flames from her legs and planted her feet on the floor. This time, she was going to pluck the life out of Abel’s body.

—Suddenly, a black shadow leaped furiously at Arakiya’s back.

???: “GRAAAAAAAAAAH...!!”

A shadow blew away the rubble and rushed at Arakiya with a fierce yell. It was a being that grasped a large knife in a backhand grip, and launched an offensive wielding its hunting instinct.

For a moment, the sheer spirit of the shadow's surprise attack almost overwhelmed Subaru's understanding of its true identity.

Her tall, well-built body, wounded and burnt black, her black hair dyed red, and the white pattern on her skin indicating her as one of the People of Shudraq— Subaru then shouted.

Subaru: "Mizelda-san!!"

Mizelda: "TCHAAAAAAH!!"

Without answering Subaru's call, Mizelda continued to roar as if she was spitting up blood.

Mizelda had been the victim of the first strike from Arakiya's intrusion. And with her whole body still in a pitiful state due to the burns it had sustained, she continued to attack as if burning away her very own life.

The relentless blade she wielded was aimed at Arakiya's vitals.

Unlike Al, Mizelda had no mercy or compassion to give to her prey at the last minute. Seeing the way she fought, Subaru belatedly realized that she was the target of Abel's order from before.

Abel had foreseen Arakiya's slump, and inspired the dying Mizelda to fight harder.

Subaru could not imagine how much thought had gone into performing this divine calculation, under such sudden and seemingly unrecoverable circumstances.

But still, this extra step was not enough.

Mizelda: "———"

Despite Mizelda's struggle, she still remained in bad shape, and Arakiya's expert ability would easily be able to deal with her.

Frowning in annoyance, Arakiya easily blocked many of Mizelda's attacks with some rough swings of her branch, while the latter burnt through the dying drops of her life.

No longer was there any point in mentioning the strength of that branch.

The impact of the cleaving branch drove Mizelda's knife out of her hand, and a moment later, the branch was thrust into Mizelda's unarmored torso.

Her well-developed abs of steel were pierced with a sickening sound, without much resistance.

It bored through Mizelda's body, shredding vital internal organs and forcing the mighty amazoness's body nearer towards death—

Arakiya: "Now, finally..."

Mizelda: "—Where are you *looking*?"

It happened the moment when Arakiya's attention shifted from the interloper she thought she had eliminated.

Mizelda's eyes glistened as she froze in place, blood bubbling at the corners of her mouth. She gave a fierce smile, red blood staining her white teeth, and grabbed Arakiya's right hand that held the branch with both of hers.

She gripped it more and more tightly, then made herself immobile.

Mizelda: "———"

The moment of stagnation that was created was, or was to be, the final opportunity.

But there was no one on their side, including Subaru, who could take advantage of the moment created by Abel's wisdom and Mizelda's dedication.

The People of Shudraq, led by the struggling Chieftain, had yet to recover from that last raging storm, and neither had Subaru, who could barely stay conscious.

Even Rem, who had broken off a pillar, was unable to reach the two due to her weak legs.

Without everyone working as one, the once-in-a-lifetime opportunity was lost. However—

Priscilla: "—You may hold your head aloft, oni girl. It was your plea that brought about this swing of mine."

However, even though Subaru's allies were incapable to reach out, that was not the same for the third force on the battlefield.

Priscilla: "-----"

Priscilla, who had a bird's eye view of the battle, closed the distance with a single step and aimed for Arakiya's unprotected back.

For a moment, Arakiya was aware of the presence behind her and moved to engage it. She wanted to throw Mizelda's tall body, which was grabbing her arm, and slam it into the enemy behind her.

But she could not do that— she could not do it, because she could see who that presence belonged to.

Arakiya: "Prin—"

Arakiya, who had been unable to break her obsession with Priscilla from beginning to end, was struck by a flash of the crimson sword.

With a bang, her gushing blood was incinerated by the flames, and Arakiya's body shook terribly.

Priscilla: "I did tell you, Arakiya— that you should have prepared your resolve for the time you met me next."

A promise made in the past, the true meaning of which no one else had the right to intrude on.

The only thing they knew, was that Priscilla's merciless blow was the answer to that promise, and also the answer to Arakiya's unbreakable longing.

Arakiya: "-----"

Arakiya's body collapsed on the floor as the treasured crimson sword collided with her back.

Mizelda, who had grabbed her arm and was blocking her movement, was also caught up in it. The two of them fell in a tangle, throwing their arms and legs out like sluggish ragdolls.

Mizelda: "-----"

The situation, which had been moving at a dizzying pace, as the air that seemed to be stirred endlessly with swords and flames, was suddenly engulfed in silence. Subaru felt as if time had stood still.

It was as if the mere movement of one breath or one step would ruin everything, and it would all fall apart like a dream.

Rem: “—Mizelda-san!”

It was Rem’s tense voice that shattered the stillness of that moment.

With faltering arms, she crawled across the floor and hurried to Mizelda, who was lying folded up against Arakiya.

Mizelda’s whole body had been scorched all over, blown away by a gale of wind, and even pierced through the stomach.

Rem, kneeling beside her, gasped, and with a desperate expression, placed her hands on Mizelda’s body and tried to hold her together with a pale light of healing magic.

Abel: “Is this really the situation to be gawking? Give me a hand.”

Subaru: “—Ah.”

Abel’s voice reached Subaru’s ears, stunned immobile after seeing Rem in action.

Abel was still unable to climb up from his suspended position. Shaking his head, Subaru hurried towards the former balcony and looked down at the empty space below them.

Abel, hanging by his right arm with a curtain wrapped around him, pierced Subaru with his eyes.

Abel: “You survived. You really have the luck of the devil, do you not?”

Subaru: “...Looks like you’ve got plenty of bark left in that hateful mouth of yours.”

Subaru’s cheeks twisted at Abel’s inability to stop talking, then he grabbed the curtain and pulled him up.

To be honest, if Subaru was a mess, then so was Abel, being drawn up. The former wished to stretch his limbs out and let go of his consciousness right now, but he could not do that.

Subaru: “It’s not just Mizelda-san...”

A large number of injured people had fallen victim to Arakiya’s rampage.

In an environment where those who could use healing magic were rare, non-magical first aid was necessary. There was no time to pass out.

To fall here would be to allow oneself to be lost.

That should not be allowed to happen. For that reason—

Subaru: “Hurry up and get up here...”

Clenching his molars, he pulled the curtain and grabbed Abel’s hand once he came within reach. Relying on the feeling of Abel’s tight grip, he managed to pull the man who was taller than him up.

Abel, upon his return to solid ground, gasped slightly before Subaru fell on his ass.

Abel: “That was a great deed. I commend you.”

Subaru: “Shut up...”

Rejecting the praise that did not show a shred of sincerity, Subaru clucked his tongue softly.

As it was, he was about to get up to start carrying out the other wounded—

Priscilla: “—Do not move on your own, foolish commoner. Who do you take as ruler of this place?”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru, who was on his buttocks, and Abel, who was on his knees, closed their mouths in unison.

What intimidated them without a word, with her arms crossed as to emphasize her voluptuous chest, were those crimson beauty’s— Priscilla’s, eyes and voice.

They were acquaintances, not strangers.

But if one asked him if they had a good relationship, he would hesitate to nod in assent. This was not only because they belonged to opposing camps in the Royal Selection, but also because of Priscilla's temperament.

Pompous and uncompromising, Priscilla could be a powerful ally were she willing to cooperate, and an unpredictable bomb if she was not.

In the battle of the Watergate City of Pristella, she had been a reliable ally. On the other hand, what about this time?

Was it okay to consider her as an ally after she lent a hand fighting off Arakiya? In any case—

Abel: "While I resent it, you are the one in control of this situation, Prisca Benedict."

In place of Subaru, rendered immobile and mute, it was Abel who opened his mouth in place of Subaru.

With one knee on the floor, Abel called Priscilla by a different name, and it sounded like the one Arakiya had said before collapsing.

Priscilla gave a tiny snort at being called that,

Priscilla: "Unfortunately, Prisca Benedict was defeated in battle and died in vain. How could one who lies beneath their grave speak like this?"

Abel: "...I see. Then who are you, and what do you call yourself?"

Priscilla: "Priscilla Barielle. That is mine name. You shall do well to remember it, Vincent Abellux."

Priscilla's and Abel's gazes met as she answered his question in a dignified manner.

A storm of pressured glances, like either fire or lightning, passed between them. Subaru, standing beside them, was caught in the middle and had to turn his head slightly to avoid being blown away.

Priscilla, who knew Abel's name, and Abel, who called Priscilla by a different name.

Subaru gulped quietly, foreseeing the alarming relationship between the two. Such a brutal atmosphere—

Al: “—Hey, can anyone help me out here? I’m almost at the end of my rope.”

The only sound in the air was Al’s pathetic plea for help, as he hung from a crystal light fixture below the balcony’s edge.

Arc 7 Chapter 26 - A Dancing Roundtable Conference

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 1 “A Reunion Akin to Scorching Blood”, Parts 3-4

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

Al: “—Oi, wait? Is anyone listening? I’m in serious trouble here!”

The tension in the air was shaken by a foolish voice, but that did not relieve the situation of its tension.

If anything, the pressure between Abel and Priscilla kept escalating, and even Subaru, standing on the fringes, was unable to make a move.

Subaru: “———”

If he made the wrong move, he would risk the wrath of Priscilla, the one in charge of the now half-destroyed hall.

Out of fear, he was hesitant to point out that Al was on the verge of falling to his death. The only way to break this situation was for Abel or Priscilla to speak—

???: “—Don’t *move*.”

However, neither of them were the one to change the predicament.

The unexpected voice came from the staircase that connected the hall to the lower floor. He glanced over to see a new figure looking at Priscilla, an arrow notched in their bow, aimed straight at her.

It was Taritta, whose strong eyes were filled with intense hostility.

Under Abel and Mizelda’s direction, she had left the City Hall before Arakiya’s assault, but had now returned.

Naturally, seeing the upper floors of the City Hall in pieces, Taritta would have inferred that there had been an enemy attack. The problem was that she had no idea what that specifically entailed.

With the heavy atmosphere, and Priscilla looking down at Subaru and Abel, there was no doubt in her mind that Priscilla was the source of all this destruction that had rained down upon the City Hall.

Taritta: “Move, and I’ll shoot you in the *head*.”

Priscilla: “Oh, my head? It is already bad enough that you could not even get to your ally in time.”

Taritta: “—Hk.”

Taritta’s cheeks tightened at the unnecessary provocation, and Priscilla turned to her with composure.

With an overwhelmingly dignified attitude, Priscilla dismissed the threat of being shot. In fact, Priscilla made a point of walking straight up to Taritta.

???: “That is enough.”

However, Abel halted Priscilla from taking any further steps.

Quietly, Priscilla’s crimson gaze turned to Abel again. Abel, down on one knee, met her gaze firmly.

Abel: “Taritta can be more resourceful than you think. Do not take her lightly.”

Priscilla: “If you say so, but do you think I shall turn a blind eye to her disrespect?”

Abel: “I am sure you cannot. But Priscilla... how many times have you pulled out the Yang Sword?”

Setting aside the unexpected evaluation of Taritta, Abel’s question struck Priscilla.

Subaru, however, could not understand the question’s intent. She was holding the Yang Sword— a treasured sword of dazzling crimson, that held an indisputable amount of power.

But now that she had defeated Arakiya, she had it sheathed, with the sky as its scabbard. Certainly, she would once again pull it out if required—

Abel: “Taritta, put the arrow down. She is not your enemy.”

Without waiting for Priscilla's response, Abel went on to tell Taritta to drop her weapon. However, she was not convinced.

With the arrow still drawn, Taritta persisted, prefacing with "And yet... Hk".

Taritta: "That woman is clearly *dangerous*."

Abel: "I am aware of that which you are saying. But she is not the one you ought to be paying attention to, currently."

Taritta: "—?"

Abel's gaze shifted to the side as he conveyed that to Taritta, who had yet to lower her guard.

That gesture guided her gaze, and, while keeping Priscilla in sight on the corner of her vision, she turned her attention in that direction, and gasped.

Taritta: "S-Sister...!?"

As her eyes were ushered, Taritta saw Mizelda undergoing treatment from Rem.

With half of her body having been scorched by flames, and her abdomen pierced by a branch, Mizelda was gravely injured. Although Rem was doing her best to treat her, the pain was unbearable.

Rem: "Taritta-san, please call out to her. Call out...!"

Taritta: "Sister, Sister... Hk!!"

Instantly, the atmosphere from before fizzled out and Taritta rushed over to Mizelda. She grabbed her sister's hand and began to call out "Sister" over and over again, just as Rem had requested.

So once again, there was nothing that could keep Priscilla in check.

Abel: "——"

The standoff between Abel and Priscilla resumed— or so it seemed.

Priscilla: "—Foolish commoner. Pull him up, you. He shall spoil the fun with all his noise."

Subaru: “Eh...”

And with that, Priscilla pointed her chin towards the broken balcony.

She had ordered Subaru to rescue Al, who was doing his best to hold on for dear life. Subaru gasped as she gave the order without a care in the world.

Of course, he could not say anything except yes to her request, unless he wanted to take the risk of ruining Priscilla’s mood. Above all—

Priscilla: “I shall see to that man myself. What, I am not going to let him die. Do not fret too much.”

Pointing to Abel, Priscilla’s mention of Subaru’s concerns also gave some encouragement.

It was not because he had enough of a trusting relationship with Priscilla to believe her outright on that statement, but because he knew that she would not back down from what she had declared.

Abel: “Staring at each other is not going to get us anywhere. For the time being, you should do what she says.”

Subaru: “...Alright. I’m not your subordinate, though.”

Abel added that as Subaru pondered over Priscilla’s words.

He did not like the fact that he was being directed by Abel to do something. Leaving that thought for another time, Subaru immediately went to rescue Al, who was stuck hanging off a light fixture at the edge of the building.

Subaru: “———”

His mind was a jumble of different factors as he did so: the safety of Mizelda and the People of Shudraq, the future of Guaral, and the relationship between Abel and Priscilla.

Subaru clenched his teeth and put those thoughts aside for the moment, concentrating on what was in front of him.

Just as Rem was desperately trying to save the life in front of her, Subaru too, was trying to get as close as possible to the Bloodless Siege that he had envisioned.



Al, who had been bathing in the exterior light of the City Hall, was much harder to rescue than expected.

To begin with, Al only had one arm, the other having been lost in his time in this other world. As his lone arm was currently occupied, busy hanging by a thread, his options were limited.

Al: “So this is what it means to have a hand full... No, it’s more like I’m busy as hell at this point. Which one do you think it is, bro?”

Subaru: “Shut up! If you want to be saved, don’t demotivate me!”

Replying to the out-of-place tease, Subaru ripped the curtain Abel had been hanging from before, made a loop at the end, and guided it towards Al.

The loop was then threaded around Al’s torso to secure him in place, and he was ready to be pulled up. Then he tugged at the curtain to pull the dangling and swaying middle-aged man out from his predicament,

Al: “...And up, up I go. Whew, barely escaped death there. You saved me.”

There had been a few close calls, but Subaru finally succeeded in pulling Al back up.

After crawling the rest of the way up with Subaru’s help, Al patted his chest and sat on the floor of the wrecked hall. Looking over at him, Subaru wiped the sweat from his forehead, having completed his task.

He then turned to the person who had helped him rescue Al— Medium.

Subaru: “Thanks, Medium-san, that would’ve been pretty tough on my own.”

Medium: “It’s ok, it’s ok! Also, I’m sorry for collapsing at such a critical moment earlier!”

Laughing cheerfully despite her battered appearance, Medium apologized for what happened in the prior battle.

She apologized for not being able to help during the fight with Arakiya, but her apology was far from necessary. In the first place, both Medium and Flop were not in a position in which they needed to be involved in this battle.

Medium: “Both big bro and I haven’t been diligent enough! I’m sorry, I’m sorry!”

Subaru: “No, it’s not your fault, Medium-san! You couldn’t move because you were protecting Flop, Utakata and... Louis.”

Stumbling over his words somewhat, Subaru praised Medium’s achievement.

At the time the tornado that was Arakiya had blown through the hall, Medium had protected Flop, who had been right beside her, as well as Utakata and Louis, who she had been carrying on both shoulders.

As a result, she hit her head and was too stunned to move. But thanks to her efforts, the three of them were safe, and Medium was spared from further damage.

Medium: “Hmm, it makes me happy that you say so, Natsumi-chan. But it’s no good. I’m big bro’s bodyguard, so I gotta do my job properly!”

Subaru: “Medium-san...”

Medium: “Next time! Next time, I won’t be so pathetic! Look forward to seeing that from me and big bro tomorrow, Natsumi-chan!”

Subaru: “—Yes. It’s reassuring to hear you say that. But I don’t think the two of you should...”

Subaru tried to continue, saying that they were not required to go along with him.

However, the slurring of his words was easily drowned out by how bright as the sun she was when she exclaimed “Ah!”, rounding her eyes in amazement.

Medium: “I’ll go over there and help big bro! It’ll be hard for big bro, with how fragile he is, to carry the injured!”

Subaru: “Yeah, right...”

Medium: “Okay, Natsumi-chan, I’ll see you later! I’m glad that the masked person didn’t fall!”

With a big wave of her hand, Medium ran off restlessly.

She began to help Flop, among others, with the injured, and to carry and treat the injured People of Shudraq and Imperial Soldiers alike.

The O’Connell siblings did not even receive a word of appreciation, and Subaru felt more and more indebted to them.

He wondered if one day he would be able to repay the favor he had been given.

Al: “That was a big, cute young girl. As expected of bro, you’re living it up across the border, ain’t you?”

Subaru: “I shudder because I don’t have any idea what do you mean with “living it up”, though I agree, Medium-san’s a big, cute person. More importantly...”

Al: “Hmm? What’s up, bro?”

Subaru glared at Al, who casually cracked his neck and returned the glance with his usual lighthearted demeanor. Subaru then suppressed his anger towards Priscilla, forcing it back down like a rising hunger.

It was only natural. Subaru’s suspicions and questions had been on the back burner for a while now.

Al: “Don’t look so angry. You’re ruining your makeup and wig.”

Subaru: “I’m sorry, but my makeup and wig have already been trashed due to a last-minute firestorm. Don’t get it wrong, the real Natsumi Schwartz’s much prettier.”

Al: “Natsumi Schwartz, was it?”

When Al heard Subaru’s horrible fake name, he cleared his throat with a rumble and gave a laugh pregnant of meaning.

With Subaru skeptical of his attitude, he shook his head,

Al: “No, no. I’m just impressed with your pseudonym. I didn’t know you had crossdressing as a hobby, bro.”

Subaru: “Don’t be silly, I’ll fill you in on the correct information about Natsumi next time. But more importantly, answer me— Why are you and Priscilla here?”

Al: “———”

Subaru: “It was a big help to us, but there’s something I really don’t understand. It’s not just the reason as to why you’re in Guaral. It’s about why you’re in the Empire at all.”

In response to Subaru’s serious question, Al closed his mouth softly and fell silent.

It was an inexplicable intervention, no matter how much he thought about it.

It just did not make sense for Priscilla and Al both to be in the Empire with complete impunity. Of course, from their point of view, the same could be said for Subaru, and others too—

Subaru: “Let’s put that aside for now. The sooner I learn, the better, though.”

Al: “That’s a novel idea, but that’s not what you really wanna hear, bro.”

Subaru: “What?”

Al: “It doesn’t matter why the Princess and I are in the Empire. Bro, what you really wanna know, is the way back... from this scary and dangerous country, to the home you know. Ain’t that right?”

Subaru fell silent this time. The question the other party posed had hit a sore spot.

The way to return from the Empire to the Kingdom; that was the information Subaru was seeking the most right now— towards that, Subaru possessed zero words of denial.

He had his doubts. There were other questions, as well as a nagging sense that he was being treated unreasonably. But wasn’t it more important to solve the largest problem right now—

Subaru: “Then you have the answer to that question...? A way to get back to the Kingdom of Lugunica, and cross the border of the Empire...?”

Al: “Nah, I’m sorry. I dunno. I was just trying to get your hopes up.”

Subaru: “YOU...!”

Al: “Wait, wait, don’t be mad! To be precise, I’m talking about how difficult it is to get out of the Empire right now. It’s hard enough to get in, let alone trying to escape.”

Subaru was frustrated by the way his emotions were being played with in the palm of Al’s hand.

As usual, Al refused to show his true feelings— Did Subaru also look like that, from other people’s perspectives? If that was the case, then it would be something for Subaru to reflect on. In any case—

Subaru: “You can get in, but you can’t get out... And the reason for that is...”

Al: “Oh, come on, I don’t gotta tell you that. It means that there are people who don’t want a situation where a certain someone could easily leave the country.”

Subaru: “—Does that mean you know Abel’s true identity too?”

In response to Al’s comment, Subaru naturally arrived at that conclusion.

He’d heard before that the Vollachian Empire had strict border control, but if the emigration ban was being strengthened under the conditions that Al mentioned, then the reason for that was none other than the existence of Abel— no, the existence of the Emperor of Vollachia, Vincent Vollachia.

In order to prevent Abel, who had been ousted from the Emperor’s seat and was now on the run, from escaping to another country, border security was being tightened.

All that meant was that in order for Subaru and the others to return to the Kingdom of Lugunica, they would need to overcome some major obstacles.

Subaru: “Al, if you have more information than we do...”

Al: “Oops, I’ll have to keep my mouth shut about this. I don’t want the Princess to get mad at me for blabbering about unnecessary things. If there’s something you wanna talk about, talk to the Princess. However...”

He put his right hand on the metal clasp of his helmet, and a moment later, it made a gentle click. He then continued,

Al: "I can't guarantee that the Princess'll be honest about it, though, can I?"



Al: "Princess, I'm back. How's the discussion going over there?"

Priscilla: "How is it going, you ask? We are not getting anywhere. I have been listening to everyone that has woken up, one-by-one."

Al, who waved his hand in an easy-going manner, had only been asking about the progress. Meanwhile, Priscilla replied back to him by resting her chin in her hands.

The upper part of the building had been destroyed during Arakiya's attack, but the foundation remained strong, and fortunately, the contents of the City Hall were still intact.

Thanks to this, they were able to use the conference hall for important discussions with no relocation necessary.

Abel and Priscilla sat on opposite sides of a large roundtable. In addition, Zikr and his Imperial Soldiers, as well as Kuna and the People of Shudraq, were present.

All of them possessed relatively mild injuries, and if Priscilla's words were true, they had probably already been questioned.

Kuna: "Yo, you *okay*, Natsumi?"

Subaru: "Kuna, I'm glad you're awake. Are you hurt?"

Kuna: "Holly's big frame came in *handy*. To be honest, I don't feel comfortable in this place, so I want to get the hell *out*..."

Subaru noticed Kuna's pained face as he joined them at the roundtable.

Directing his eyes towards the rest of the Shudraq, Subaru could guess the reason for Kuna's bitter face. In a nutshell, she was the one representing all Shudraqians in the current moment.

Kuna: "Taritta can't leave the Chieftain's side and there's no point in letting Holly do the *talking*. But why put me in this *role*..."

Subaru: "No, you're attentive and keep a level head, so I think you're the right person for this job. So, how are the discussions going?"

Kuna: "Well, I think we've got a pretty good idea of what's going *on*. I believe we're about to start the so-called *discussion*."

Kuna answered while shrugging her shoulders, and Subaru nodded saying "I see".

Soon after, he was at a loss as to where he should be in the room. In the first place, Subaru's position in this group wasn't very clear.

Although he had been the one to plan the operation for the fall of Guaral, because of Arakiya and Priscilla's intrusion it would be difficult for him to say he had been successful.

???: "Miss Natsumi, if you are in trouble, how about you sit next to me?"

And so, Zikr stood quickly and pulled a chair out in front of Subaru, who had been lost in thought.

Small and stocky, Zikr looked at Subaru and smiled like a gentleman. At his grin, Subaru pointed to himself,

Subaru: "Um, I'm sure you've noticed this already, but you know I'm just crossdressing, right?"

Zikr: "If you are posing as a woman, then I am also posing as a man. My idea of a man is to behave like a gentleman with a woman, regardless of who is posing as what."

Subaru: "So this is the Womanizer...!"

Instead of using "womanizer" as a derogatory term, "womanizer" was used as a term of respect with a different idea behind it.

Subaru was embarrassed to be dressed in women's clothing, but he took Zikr's advice and proceeded to sit down in the chair that had been pulled out for him.

Complementing that, Subaru gave Zikr a "Pardon me" as he took his seat.

Subaru: "Also, thank you for protecting me upstairs, I would've been in danger if Zikr-san hadn't protected me."

Zikr: "No, it was just a matter of my body moving in the spur of the moment. I do not know if I could repeat that feat next time. I am the Coward, after all."

Upon hearing Subaru's thank you, Zikr proudly referred to himself as the Coward.

This was because the Imperial General Second-Class, Zikr, had been remembered this way by the Emperor to whom he had sworn allegiance.

And Abel, the aforementioned Emperor who was held in such high esteem by the worthy Zikr—

Abel: "—The Fortress City of Guaral has fallen, and the commander of the garrisoned troops, General Second-Class Zikr Osman, has shifted to our side, complementing the forces of the People of Shudraq of the Buddheim Jungle."

Priscilla: "That is surely not enough. While I have heard of the bravery of the People of Shudraq, we are still far too weak to take the Empire on."

Abel: "No doubt. Priscilla, where are your men?"

Priscilla: "I do not have my private army in the Empire. Aside from that, the only people I could call my army include that clown in the iron helmet, a drunken swordsman, and a pipsqueak whose only qualification is his cute face."

Abel: "——"

While Subaru was in the room talking with Kuna, Abel and Priscilla were having their own discussion.

The two of them looked at each other thoughtfully as they gauged the other's strength and circumstances, but Subaru intervened with a "Wait a minute".

He had been pushed around completely and wished to not be left behind again.

Priscilla: “What is the matter, foolish commoner? You are still present?”

Subaru: “I’m here, and I can’t believe I’m saying this, but it’s a hell of a thing that you can look at me without being impressed. The last time she saw me like this, Beako had nightmares for a good while.”

Priscilla: “I believe I had already given you a compliment concerning your attire. Surely you do not believe you shall receive a reward for pulling Al up with a dirty cloth?”

Subaru: “I’m not expecting anything! No, I kind of am. I’m hoping that you’ll at least listen to me a little bit.”

Priscilla’s eyes narrowed at Subaru, who was leaning forward with his hands on the roundtable.

She looked as if she was trying to judge him, but Subaru was not afraid. Unlike before, Kuna and Zikr were here as well. That said, though, he felt like he made for a pathetic bulwark.

Subaru: “Anyway, why’re you even here? I can’t get anywhere asking Al. Let’s hear it clearly from your mouth.”

Priscilla: “That is an annoying question...I am here to speak with that guy, Vincent Abellux.”

Subaru: “———”

Jutting her chin in his direction, Priscilla replied as if this were something obvious. In response, Abel, who sat comfortably with crossed arms, closed one of his sable eyes, while the other swirled with complicated emotions.

It was a bewildering look that could be of joy, anger, sorrow, pleasure, or something else, something inexplicable that unaffiliated to any of those feelings.

Subaru: “Talk to Abel...? But how did you know where Abel was?”

Priscilla: “The throne of the Emperor, in the Imperial Capital of Lupugana, has a device that allows them to teleport elsewhere. Should they any sense potential political change, they may escape to the east through it— to the tomb where Emperors have been buried for generations.”

Subaru: “The Emperors’ Graveyard?”

Priscilla: “That is where that mechanism would take him. I believe I am correct, Vincent... No, it is more convenient to call you Abel, presently.”

Priscilla’s eyes blazed red as she turned the conversation away from Subaru to Abel.

Exhaling under her burning gaze, Abel nodded,

Abel: “Yes, call me Abel, right now. At least, I am not qualified to call myself Emperor now that the throne has been taken from me.”

Priscilla: “Exceptional, law-abiding, and foolishly honest... In any case, you think too softly. It appears that during your time sitting on the Emperor’s throne, you have forgotten how to stand up.”

Abel: “Gaze upon me, and tell me I have forgotten how to stand up.”

Priscilla’s unrelenting taunting did not deter Abel’s swarthinness.

At that moment, their gazes clashed feverishly, and the air in the conference room even smelled of rising heat. As it was, it seemed inevitable that the discussion would break down and fire would rage—

???: “Well, well, calm down, both of you. There’s nothing to be gained by getting into trouble, right?”

However, there was a man who had the audacity needed to poke at a powder keg on the verge of explosion while puffing on a cigarette.

It was Al who easily stepped into the uncomfortable atmosphere with what must have been a wry smile. Instead of sitting down, he remained standing, under the combined smoldering glares of both Abel and Priscilla.

Al: “Even though the Princess acts like this, she’s got her cute sides too. As soon as she found out that she had to rush extra-fast to Guaral, she spurred her flying dragon at full speed, almost enough to exhaust him. That’s how much she was looking forward to seeing you... Guah!?”

Priscilla: “Such foolishness.”

Al went behind Priscilla as he spoke and tried to defend her humanity, but his master did not take his thoughts to heart and slammed her fan into his stomach with fierce force.

Al yelped and fell to one knee on the spot, his body bent into a crooked shape.

Priscilla: “To presume to speak for what I feel is of hubris to the extreme. When did you become so full of yourself? Know your place, clown.”

Al: “The fact that you’re running out of patience’s proof enough... But you’re really here to help, ain’t you?”

Priscilla: “———”

Priscilla’s crimson eyes narrowed as she revealed her displeasure at Al’s words.

But the fact that she did not explicitly deny it in words, was a sign that Al’s words had been right on the mark.

Subaru: “Priscilla came to help Abel...?”

It seemed so unreal that Subaru was unable to shake the feeling of discomfort. Of course, looking at the results alone, there could not be any doubt that Priscilla had already helped Abel, Subaru and the others. However, her nature, as Subaru knew it, prevented him from being convinced.

Was fighting to protect someone, even if it had the benefit of defeating an enemy not of her liking, really logic that applied for the person known as Priscilla Barielle?

Priscilla: “You have a gleam in your eyes that suggests unpleasant thoughts. Do you wish them to be gouged, foolish commoner?”

Subaru: “Don’t look people in the eye and tell them something so scary. To be honest, I’m not sure how much I believe you...”

Priscilla: “—In any case, Abel, I understand that you reached the east using the mechanism on the throne. If that is the case, were you expecting me to join up with the People of Shudraq and come to the Fortress City?”

Subaru: “Expecting to be here...?”

While Priscilla was admittedly exceptionally perceptive, Subaru found it difficult to fathom the circumstances that Abel had so readily accepted.

Certainly, the given conditions seemed to satisfy the speculation though.

Al: “Don’t get it wrong, bro. The smart guys here are convinced. If we keep it together here, we can avoid trouble we don’t wanna deal with.”

Subaru: “And you’re okay with that...?”

Al: “Good or bad, we’ll just have to suck it up. Even if you try to fight, you’ll lose— Because me and the Princess are gonna win anyway.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Al, still on his knees, slid up to Subaru and declared so with a whisper.

To be honest, it was surprising for Subaru to hear Al assure him that they would win. Originally, Al had a tendency to draw an arbitrary line in regards to what was around him, rather than being humble.

In fact, the other Knights of Royal Candidates were all renowned and talented— and neither Subaru nor Al were special enough to be overconfident among them.

This was why Subaru felt a certain amount of sympathy for Al.

That was why his assertion here was so surprising to Subaru.

Even though he seemed to be unchanging and unconcerned, change was coming. This was because of his master-servant relationship with Priscilla and the accompanying battle of the Royal Selection.

Al: “But I can only speak highly of those who have a chance of winning, even if it’s only by a hundred millionth of a percent. In that respect, this Arakiya girl was in a class of her own. I couldn’t see any way to win.”

Subaru: "...I see, the Nine Divine Generals are the strongest members of the Empire. You could say they're kinda like Reinhardt and Julius in the Kingdom of Lugunica."

If one were to select the strongest members within the Kingdom of Lugunica, they would probably find that most of them would be Knights. Reinhard and Julius dispensed being mentioned, Marcos, the captain of the Royal Guard, and Roswaal, the Head Magician of the Court, could likewise be included.

Subaru would also like to add Wilhelm and Garfiel to the list, and have an all-star lineup to face the Nine Divine Generals.

Subaru: "No, that's not important, no matter how many times you speak of the Nine Divine Generals, it's hard to believe that someone would be able to match Reinhard..."

Abel: "—I am afraid that is not so."

Subaru: "What?"

When Subaru tried to gauge the strength of the Nine Divine Generals as the most important opponent to be wary of, Abel said something that made him doubt his ears.

What did he just say? —That there's a being that can rival Reinhard?

Subaru: "Are you saying that there are other *mutekino shujinkou*² like Reinhard?"

Zikr: "I'm not familiar with this vocabulary, but if you mean comparable, I will have to agree. The Nine Divine Generals have a First, above Arakiya."

Subaru: "The First of the Nine Divine Generals is...?"

Zikr: "—Cecilus Segmunt."

Next to Subaru, who opened his mouth with a gulp, Zikr quietly said those two words.

² English flip. Means "invincible protagonist/hero" (無敵の主人公), originally "バグキャラ" (bug character).

Subaru understood that it was a person's name, and that it was the name of the First Rank in question. The person with that name was the strongest of the Empire, the pride of Vollachia, an overpowered character.

Abel: "The Blue Lightning of Vollachia, as he is called, is a swordsman of the highest class, ranked alongside the Sword Saint of Lugunica, the Admirer of Kararagi, and the Mad Prince of Gusteko."

Subaru: "Umm... I remember hearing that nickname before... So you're serious?"

Abel: "If you were to antagonize him, you would lose your head in the blink of an eye. That is the kind of man he is."

Abel, who had his arms crossed, nodded in response to Subaru's question, as his cheeks tightened.

In this situation, there was no reason for Abel or Zikr to tell a lie or a joke. In other words, what they had spoken must be the simple truth.

Cecilus Segmunt, the strongest man in the Empire, who was as skilled as Reinhard.

Subaru felt a chill run down his spine as he wondered just how dangerous and fierce this superclass swordsman was.

It was a battle of vast differences in strength. Being both outnumbered and outclassed in quality, how could they possibly hope to win?

Al: "...However, if you think about it that way, there's still some hope. The fact that I could beat Lil' Miss Arakiya, ranked Second, here, was a big win for us."

Subaru: "Al..."

Despite the heavy mood of Subaru and the others, Al said this with a cheerful voice.

It was a very optimistic opinion, however it was also a reality that the others could not get on board as easily. However, taking in Al's spirit, Subaru exhaled, "That's right".

If they only considered the negative side of things, they would not be able to make any progress. In fact, Subaru and his team had been able to conquer the Fortress City with minimal damage. They had even

managed to add Priscilla and Al as reinforcements, although it was hard to state whether they were friend or foe.

He was sure Rem would do her best to heal the injured Shudraqians, and Mizelda would return to the front lines. They could expect to see more of her relaxed, stoic demeanor, and all-around combat ability.

Henceforth—

Subaru: “Al’s right... It’s great that we were able to defeat one of the Nine Divine Generals... and a pretty highly-ranked one at that. I’m sure she’s got some information, considering her position.”

Al: “Yeah, you could say that! That’s brilliant, bro. Information’s more valuable than gold during a war. Since she was left alive, let’s hear what she has to say.”

Subaru: “Right. She might have a lead...”

Subaru forced himself to get in the mood, and Al matched him. At that rate, the subject of the conversation changed toward the acquisition of information from Arakiya, who had been successfully captured alive.

???: “*Wait*, Subaru and Iron-Mask. I’m going to have to disagree with you on *that*.”

But then Kuna, who was participating as the representative of Shudraq, intervened.

As Subaru and Al turned around, Kuna stroked her own green-dyed hair, and said—

Kuna: “That woman is *dangerous*. You never know what she’ll do if she sees an *opening*. It’s definitely better to kill her as soon as *possible*.”

Subaru: “I understand that, but that’s too short-sighted. Killing her is not...”

Kuna: “The Chieftain ended up badly hurt *already*. I don’t care what Subaru *says*, we and the others need to execute *her*.”

Kuna mentioned Arakiya’s execution upfront, and glared at Subaru with stubborn insistence.

When she pointed out Mizelda's condition, Subaru had no choice but to keep his mouth shut. Her safety had been left to Rem, but even if her wounds healed, the fact that she had been injured would not disappear.

If the Shudraquians found that unforgivable, then Arakiya would have to pay the price.

Subaru: "-----"

While searching for a response to Kuna, Subaru glanced at Priscilla.

He wanted to see what kind of reaction Priscilla would have to Kuna's insistence on executing Arakiya, as she seemed to have an unusual relationship with her. However---

Priscilla: "I have already decided on my attitude towards Arakiya. First and foremost, it was me who slashed down the back of that thing. Are those black eyes on your face merely decoration?"

Subaru: "Guh..."

Priscilla: "I possess no intention to say anything for the sake of Arakiya. If her fate ends here, it will be part of Arakiya's own path--- although it would be a shame."

Subaru: "...I don't understand you at all."

Subaru shook his head at Priscilla, who spoke simply as she weighed the value of Arakiya's life.

At the end of the day, their relationship seemed to be sour, but judging by Arakiya's attitude, it could have been intimate. Yet, Priscilla's attitude was terribly disconnected.

As an outsider, Subaru had no idea what their relationship was like.

Subaru: "But if you die, it's all over. Life doesn't come back."

Priscilla: "You dare to teach the value of life to me? Do you believe that I can misjudge the value of another's life?"

Subaru: "---You're not omnipotent. Even you can make mistakes."

Directly facing Priscilla, Subaru answered without a pause.

As soon as he said that, the air in the room became tense.

Kuna and Zikr gasped, while Al could be seen putting his hand on the forehead of helmet. Subaru, too, was aware that he had said something foolish in a spur-of-the-moment manner.

Only after speaking those words, did he realize that it was a pattern that would likely end up with him losing his life by incurring Priscilla's displeasure with those words.

The next moment, he might be beheaded by that shining crimson sword. But even so—

Subaru: "I'm not wrong. Even you can be wrong."

Again and again, Subaru repeated the statement that could cost him his life.

A moment later, in front of Subaru. Priscilla's eyes narrowed with a cold glare. And then, the scorching "death" that would make Subaru pay for his indiscretion—

Priscilla: "Even I can err, yes? It is a spiteful thing, really."

Never came.

Subaru: "Eh..."

Subaru's eyes widened in surprise, and he exhaled his clenched lungs.

Taking one look at Subaru, Priscilla opened her fan noisily and directed her gaze past Subaru, its aim Kuna.

Priscilla: "Before we cut off that thing's head, it would be best to find a use for it."

Kuna: "—What, are you trying to tell us what to *do*? You're an *outsider*."

Priscilla: "If you wish to ignore my advice, do it."

Withdrawing her opinion, Priscilla's gaze stroked over Kuna's slender body as if it were attempting to burn her.

Hugging herself involuntarily, Kuna ended up naturally demonstrating the pressure that could be felt from that gaze. Unfortunately, Priscilla and Kuna were at different levels.

Al: “Honestly, I was a bit anxious. But now we’re all on the same page!”

As if to break the tense atmosphere, Al struck the roundtable with his hand with force.

Having thus attracted everyone’s attention, he looked at Subaru through his steel helmet and,

Al: “It’s good news that you didn’t die, bro, but it’s also good news that the world didn’t lose that *ero-kawaii*³ girl. That said, when she wakes up, we’ll talk——”

???: “——Big *problem*~!”

Al was just about to summarize their opinions of what to do with Arakiya, when he heard the sound of hurried and panicked footsteps.

It was Holly, her large body twisting around the entrance of the room, as she burst inside the conference hall with a flurry of footsteps and a panicked voice.

Her body and breath bounced as she drew everyone’s attention, and there were words. Those were——

Holly: “A couple of Imperial Soldiers got in, and the Divine General we captured has *escaped*~!”

³ Meaning “sexy and cute”. This is given in Japanese obviously, but since it’s slang, might as well keep it as-is.

Arc 7 Chapter 27 - The Haves and the Have-Nots

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Intermission “The Haves and the Have-Nots”

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

???: “If you’re alive, you’ll get a chance to clean off your disgrace. But if you die, that’s the end. So, I’m going. I won’t get into a fight I don’t think I can win.”

There was no lie in those words.

Throwing oneself into a fight with little chance of winning was a folly only an unbelievable fool would commit to.

He did not believe himself wise, not in the slightest, but for that reason he knew he should approach his decisions carefully. While a wise person might reach a conclusion in an instant, a fool would take an eternity to reach it.

Todd knew that this was how those who were untalented waged battle.

He did not get into fights he could not win.

However, paradoxically speaking—

Todd: “—There’s absolutely nothing wrong with getting into a fight you have a chance of winning.”

He brought his clenched fist in front of his right eye, and looked longingly into the distance through the small pinhole he had created.

A primitive means of seeing farther, achieved by narrowing one's field of vision. If he squinted, Todd's eyes would be able to see quite far, but he would not be able to make out what was going on inside the chaotic City Hall, let alone past the burning flags.

And that applied even if the situation had the winds in his favor.

Jamal: "Oy, the roof of the City Hall's gone! What's going on?"

Right next to him, Todd's ferocious companion was overwhelmed by his own growing sense of urgency, creating a ruckus.

His concentration was disturbed by the noise, so he flicked his hand towards the man to instruct him to shut up. As for what was going on, he was earnestly evaluating the situation.

Todd: "Pretty sure one of the Nine Divine Generals has joined."

If not, there was no point in staying in the Fortress City, which had fallen into enemy hands.

As mentioned before, Todd had considered abandoning the city and fleeing once the City Hall had fallen due to the enemy's plan. He had no intention of politely complying with any disarmament order and surrendering.

In the first place, as long as the shots were being called by the poster child of war—the man who called himself Natsumi Schwartz, dangerous people like Todd and Jamal would be the first to be dealt with.

Even in Vollachia, executions of surrendered prisoners of war were frowned upon, but that man would certainly make up a good reason to excuse such travesties.

At least, that was what Todd would do. It was a natural consideration for survival.

Hence why he had chosen to abandon the city without hesitation. In spite of this, his curiosity got the better of him, so he hid just close enough to confirm the existence of reinforcements heading for the city.

Jamal: "There ain't any doubt about it. That's the woman I saw two years ago, when I served during the defeat of the barbarians— General First-Class Arakiya, ranked Second."

As he peered at the scantily-clad woman who had leisurely entered the city by jumping over the closed main gate, Jamal declared those words with a hint of excitement in his snorts.

He was the kind of man who walked around with his wild instincts on his sleeve. Both in terms of his strength as a living creature, and in his male disposition to be able to gauge females, he wasn't the sort who would forget anyone who tugged at his heartstrings.

In other words, one of the strongest among the Empire's Nine Divine Generals had made their appearance to suppress the rebellion— So this must be the "chance" that Todd had previously judged to be missing.

Even so---

Todd: "To act or not to act, it's more than worth the trouble."

Although Natsumi's tricky tactics were brilliant, he had no direct combat power, at least, not within a third of a soldier's own power. The People of Shudraq who followed him were known for their toughness, but that was only relative to ordinary people.

Those who were truly strong, such as the Nine Divine Generals, were not constrained to such criteria.

Even Jamal, whose only claim to fame was his tremendous swordsmanship and fighting prowess, was only about as good as a dozen regular Imperial soldiers. That was the measure of how well one could gauge an ordinary person. Members of the Nine Divine Generals were prime examples of ones who would "take care" of Jamal— the City Hall that had fallen into enemy hands would be reclaimed.

Todd: "Then it's wise to back the winning ground dragon."

There was no need to work with a member of the Nine Divine Generals.

All they had to do, was to be more useful to the General than the Soldiers who had been captured and rendered unable to do their job. If they could detain the enemy, interrogate them, and deliver some proper payback, then the General First-Class would remember their actions well.

If they did that, they would be promoted to a higher position, and may be able to find their way back to the Imperial Capital sooner rather than later.

Todd: "Alright, we're heading back, Jamal. We're going to help her retake the City Hall."

Jamal: “Oh? Oh, yeah! Haha, that’s good. I’m glad to hear that! I’ve been itching all over for a while, since running away ain’t my style. I ain’t gonna let the General First-Class hog all the credit!”

Todd: “Don’t be silly. We’re going to gain the favor of the General.”

Todd sighed at Jamal, whose fists hardened in anticipation for a return to battle in response to the change of plans. Setting out for the City Hall, they located a position with an optimal view for monitoring the situation, instead of directly entering the building.

Following his own beliefs to the last, he was careful and cautious, and—

Todd: “—Kill him, Arakiya.”

The top floor of the City Hall was blown away by gale-force wind, the barely-visible General First-Class on a rampage.

From a distance, the Second Ranked silver-haired, brown-skinned woman wielded a tree branch that looked like an improvised weapon, and rampaged about as if she were the highest law of the world.

Between all the bodies indiscriminately strewn around the hall, there was no distinction between Shudraq and Imperial Soldiers.

Under these circumstances, the one who stood in front of Arakiya with a blue-haired girl behind his back was none other than Natsumi Schwartz.

Todd: “———”

As soon as he saw him, the thoughts that came to Todd’s mind were not dismissive like, “How could he be stupid enough to stand in front of a General First-Class?” or “How is he still alive?”.

Rather, with utmost vigilance, Todd shouted out loud in his heart.

—Kill that man here, for sure, Arakiya!

Above all else, for better or worse, he did not care what he got credit for. He did not care if the time he spent thinking about his decision to stick around ended up being meaningless.

He did not care about anything else, as long as he could make sure that the life of Natsumi Schwartz, the poster child of war, had been terminated. It would be---

Todd: "...Oi oi, you've got to be kidding me."

In the instant Arakiya was going to kill Natsumi, Todd's sincere hope was shattered just as something flashed above his tunneled vision, while he was focusing on letting that decisive moment go unmissed.

A flash of red light separated Natsumi and Arakiya.

It both majestically challenged Arakiya and sheltered Natsumi behind her back, as though it seemed to be the absolute strongest thing in the world. The moment he saw this, the balance in Todd's mind tipped significantly.

Jamal: "What was that thing that just fell from the sky!? A flying dragon!? Where's the flying dragon!?"

Todd: "-----"

Jamal: "Are you listening to me, Todd! What about us? Shouldn't we be backing General First-Class Arakiya! Hey! Listen to me..."

Todd: "--Shut up, Jamal."

Jamal, whose voice roughened at the change in the situation, gasped at Todd's words.

Without acknowledging Jamal any further, Todd kept his gaze on the scene in the City Hall. The woman in the crimson dress who had suddenly appeared was facing Arakiya head-on.

He knew at a glance--- That woman also belonged to the side of the "haves", far removed from normal people.

Natsumi, having managed to survive what seemed to be a desperate situation, made Todd keenly aware of the fact that he also had something to offer. Something he "had", that was different from combat power or luck.

Todd: "-----"

Before the red woman intervened, Arakiya alone would have been enough to make up the difference.

However, the situation had changed, and no resolution was in sight. Would the weight of Todd and Jamal be enough to tip the scales back in their direction?

Jamal: “Todd...!”

Todd: “Don’t move, Jamal— There’s nothing you can do right now.”

The odds were against them, and the longer Todd watched, the worse it got.

Todd knew Jamal’s anger was getting the better of him, but it would be a waste of time to act now. After all—

Todd: “Because, General First-Class Arakiya’s been defeated just now.”

The red woman’s blade had struck her in the back, and Arakiya had fallen helplessly to the ground.

The balance was broken, and it would never tilt the other way again.



Todd: “———”

Arakiya collapsed, and the situation in the City Hall came to its terminus.

This time, the Fortress City of Guaral had completely fallen into the hands of the enemy. There was no way to recover from this.

The Second Ranked of the Nine Divine Generals had just been defeated, and there was no way that other reinforcements would come rushing in.

The Nine Divine Generals were mighty warriors, the pinnacle of the Vollachian Empire’s military might.

The strength of each of the Nine Divine Generals was equivalent to a sizable army. There was no chance that the Empire would dispatch two or three actual large armies to deal with a single situation. This was the end.

The balance had been tipped. The only thing left to do was to find a way to deal with the withdrawal that would come next.

Todd: "What to do next?"

In the shadows of the building from which he had watched the developments at the City Hall, Todd pondered quietly.

In all honesty, he was seething with a mixture of anger and frustration, but letting it out would not solve anything.

Now that the reason for his return was gone, the smart thing to do would be to get the hell out of there. However—

Jamal: "Oi, Todd... you bastard, you're not planning to run away, are you?"

The search for any words with which Jamal would be persuaded had been fruitless, the latter with a blue vein popping from his forehead.

Initially, convincing Jamal had been painstaking, even right after the fall, as of the moment the flag of the City Hall had been burned.

And yet, back then, it had been easy to guide Jamal's emotions still... Reluctant as he was, Todd had still managed to make him obey, and he had reluctantly put away his half-drawn swords.

However, this was not the case this time, where things had repeated themselves, where now he'd let Jamal draw his sheathed blades once again. Even if Todd told him to put away his blades and turn around quietly again, he would not listen.

In fact, depending on what was said next, he might turn the point of the blade he pulled out against Todd.

If that happened, there would be no reason to not kill Jamal— his future brother-in-law. Killing him would be the least favored path.

If he were not brought back safely as well, keeping the promise that had been made would not be possible.

Todd: “Let’s go with that.”

Jamal: “Ahh?”

Todd: “...I understand how you feel. But you need to calm down. Now that General First-Class Arakiya’s been defeated, there’s no chance for us to win even if we go in. Do you want to make your sister sad by dying in vain?”

Jamal: “———”

An attempt to persuade him using the love of family as a shield.

As soon as he stared at his opponent, hoping that this would work, an arm quietly stretched out and grabbed him by the scruff of his shirt. Then, with a grunt, the one-eyed Jamal bared his fangs as he drew Todd toward his face.

Jamal: “Hey, if you think I’m gonna back off anytime you mention Katya, you’re definitely wrong.”

Todd: “I see... Too bad.”

Shaking his head loosely, Todd announced his disappointment rather sincerely.

If it made Jamal feel any better to get a couple of hits in on him, Todd would allow it, but it seemed Jamal possessed no intention of doing that, as he instead clicked his tongue and pushed Todd away.

There didn’t seem to be any need for him to be so direct with things, but there was no way to stop him.

As it was, Todd turned to face Jamal, and thought about climbing over the wall of the citadel on his own.

Fortunately, he had already grasped the geography of the city back when they were trying to find any secret paths. Though Arakiya had not achieved her goal, she too had managed to create some confusion. In fact, it would be easier to escape than before Arakiya's arrival.

Apparently, Jamal would be making one more rampage to get himself noticed.

Todd: "Jamal, I'm sorry, but I'm leaving. I'll say it again, but you probably won't listen. You'll die a dog's death. Even if you go in there, you won't be able to kill them all..."

Jamal: "You dumbass! I'm not gonna do something so worthless! I'm going to rescue General First-Class Arakiya."

Todd: "...What?"

He had expected meaningless sentimentality, however, the other had blurted out some unexpected words instead.

Todd stopped in his tracks and stared at Jamal's face, from whom slurred out a "What?",

Jamal: "Did you really think I was gonna charge in with the resolve to die?"

Todd: "Yes, I did. I thought you wanted to die like a dog."

Jamal: "Cut the crap! I'm taking advantage of your clever thinking, but I've got a brain to think for myself too! I can tell the difference between what I can and can't do."

Jamal seriously surprised Todd with his unexpected statement.

There were some accomplishments to be seen in his wartime experience, but other than that, he was so direct and unsophisticated that Todd thought him to be a man unknowing of what thinking was supposed to be.

Jamal: "It can't be helped if you're a coward, I guess Katya wasn't a good judge of character. I'm gonna rescue the General First-Class. She's got a nice ass."

Todd: "—Wait, I'm coming with you."

Jamal: “Oh!? Don’t tell me, you’re not satisfied with Katya’s ass...?”

Todd: “I had no intention of going along with your suicidal mission, but if it isn’t one, then it becomes a different story.”

Not dealing with the disgraceful allegations, Todd sealed Jamal’s mouth with his palm. Forcing him to shut up, Todd assembled a schedule of actions that followed the change of plans in his mind.

It was not in Todd’s nature to do things in the spur of the moment in the first place. Sadly, however, the more time he spent with Jamal, the more experience he gained in the field of improvisation.

If Jamal was going to die an honorable death on his own to retake the City Hall, he would have left him alone. But if his goal was to retake Arakiya, that was a different story.

Todd: “———”

The situation in City Hall was slowly clearing up.

The only things to watch out for were Natsumi and the red woman. It would be suicide to take action in their presence. However, it did not mean that their enemy had been able to resolve the situation unscathed either.

If they forgot to maintain vigilance, there would be an opportunity to take advantage of.

Jamal: “I’m gonna go in and make a scene. If we take advantage of that opportunity and rescue the General First-Class...”

Todd: “I was impressed earlier, but that’s all gone now... There are two people we need to be wary of. You must avoid doing anything around them. What, there’s no need to worry.”

Todd’s lips loosened as he looked at Jamal from the gap between his fingers, as he chided him for this barbaric distraction. He poked his white canine tooth with the tip of his tongue and smirked.

Out of the corner of his eye, he saw Arakiya being taken, even though she was dying.

If she was not dead, there was a way to get her out.



—It was easy to sneak into the City Hall.

After all, it was where they had been headquartered, even if it had been for a short time.

Todd usually had a habit of grasping the geography and layout of any place he stopped by even once. He did not feel safe unless he had an idea of where to run or hide.

That was why, after the camp in the Buddheim Jungle had been burnt down and he entered Guaral, he visited every part of the city, including City Hall, and constructed a mental map.

He knew where to kill unnoticed, and where to hide to avoid detection.

No matter where and what kind of threats they would encounter, he always had a way to murder, and a way to escape.

Todd: “Five.”

As he snuck inside the City Hall, he crushed a few watchmen here and there.

Standing guard were not the Imperial Soldiers nor the People of Shudraq, rather, that task went to guards of the local government that had been conducting the security of the city. They had been called in as soldiers by the disturbing elements who had caused the city to fall— Though no longer could the fence-sitters they’d used be called a fine “Rebel Army”.

Jamal: “I ain’t gonna show you any mercy at all.”

Jamal spat in annoyance as he snapped a sentinel’s neck backward in a two-handed grip.

Jamal was prouder of being an Imperial Soldier than of being Imperial Nobility. His anger towards the guards cooperating with the rebels that were fighting against the Empire was immeasurable.

They had been cooperating with the Imperial Soldiers before the fall of the city, so it was understandable that he would be angry at how quickly they had changed their tune.

Todd: “Well, that’s not my way of thinking.”

He only killed them because he had to, and if it were not required, he would not have done so.

They could not be blamed for switching sides so quickly if they were just following the stronger side to survive. Of course, they had to pay for their wrong decision with their life.

So, the pair made up of Jamal and himself proceeded to their destination while eliminating the guards in their path.

There was a prison in the basement of the City Hall, and it was customary for criminals awaiting trial by the City Mayor to be placed there. It was highly likely that Arakiya, having been taken prisoner, would likewise be held captive there.

Naturally, an iron cell was no better than a cage made of sugar against someone from the Nine Divine Generals, but even so, they could not just be giving all the hospitality of a guest room.

Todd might have done the same as well—

Jamal: “—There she is, the General First-Class.”

In the underground space downstairs, several cells were placed on both sides of the hall. The lesser criminals were placed in order from the front, while the most dangerous ones were securely at the far end.

Naturally, the cell at the far end, where Arakiya was kept, was heavily guarded.

Unlike before, the person standing in front of it was not a guard, but a Shudraqian woman. She was a large woman with yellow-dyed hair, and he could tell with just a glance that she was very skilled.

In addition, due to the layout, it was impossible to reach Arakiya’s cell without being detected by the woman. In other words—

Jamal: “I guess that’s the end of our little sneaking around.”

Todd: “...You, why do you look so happy?”

It was hard to understand Jamal’s happy attitude when an inevitable battle was imminent.

Todd's desire was to avoid killing, and he did not want to fight if he could help it. If both were inevitable, he would choose the easier and less dangerous way.

Yet Jamal looked as if he enjoyed jumping into danger.

He was probably thinking that the more dangerous it was, the more blood he would shed, and the more loyalty he would show to the Empire.

Jamal: "It's obvious, ain't it? Fight like an Imperial Soldier and win the war! Only then can I be proud to say that I'm an Imperial Soldier."

Todd: "-----"

Jamal: "Oi, what are you surprised about?"

Todd: "No, it was almost exactly what I thought it'd be."

It was rare to find a person whose words and deeds were so consistent.

Jamal looked uncomfortable at Todd's answer, but quickly shook his head. Then he traced his fingers through his stubble and snorted.

Jamal: "Ah. Well then, you're the one who's having second thoughts, ain't you?"

Todd: "I can't go along with a suicide mission. If it's not that, I'll think about it. So I'm not having second thoughts."

Jamal: "You were trying to escape, but you didn't."

Todd: "I decided to bring back a souvenir while on the run. The plan hasn't changed."

Jamal: "You say this, and you say that... Hk."

Jamal gritted his teeth angrily, his eye bloodshot.

With that look on his face, Todd detached his attention from him and focused on the target at hand.

The woman standing guard was thick, and her limbs were protected by a reasonable amount of flesh. Given a Shudraqian's athletic ability, even Todd's axe might not be able to dice even one of her limbs.

Inevitably, then, the sweet spot would be from the neck up.

There were options of smashing her head, decapitating her, or splitting her face, but—

Jamal: “—This is where I come in, ain't it?”

With that, Jamal foolishly stepped forward.

Todd wondered for a moment if he should call him off, but in the end he said nothing. In fact, the best move would be to push Jamal into action, get her attention, and then proceed from there.

It would save a lot of time and trouble, and if he was willing to do it, there was no need to discourage him.

Holly: “Mmmm, who are *you*-!?”

Jamal: “Do I gotta answer that? You people have defiled the Sword Wolf of the Vollachian Empire. Don't you dare think you've won in a battlefield I wasn't in!”

Holly: “A strange guy's *here*-!”

Looking at Jamal, who had advanced into the hall, the Shudraqian woman held a large spear at her side. On the other hand, Jamal, who was facing her, drew his twin swords and danced with a maniacal smile on his face.

Jamal'd had his fair share of problems, but his abilities were renowned. At the very least, as long as his opponent was a single member of the Shudraq, he would not fall short.

Jamal: “Take this! And this! And this!”

Holly: “...Hk! You're a strong *guy*-!”

The raging twin swords slashed toward the Shudraqian woman countless times while Jamal barked in a loud voice. The woman sidestepped them with her spear-handling, but she was on the defensive.

She must be someone with a certain level of skill, to keep an eye on Arakiya. However, it seemed she had not expected anyone to show up to retake their prisoner as soon as she was placed in confinement.

Additionally, the lack of reliable troops was also a critical flaw for the rebels.

Todd: “Nevertheless, they’re not useful assets at the moment.”

Moistening his lips with his tongue, Todd leapt out from behind Jamal and jumped straight toward the cell, passing by the two of them as they fiercely clashed weapons, sparks flying.

Holly: “Ah! His *comrade*... Kya!”

Jamal: “Do you have time to look around? Ah!”

With the assistance of an unusually witty Jamal, Todd slammed his axe into the lock of the cell with all his might.

There was no time to look for the key. He could not destroy the cell, but he could at least break the lock.

There was a dull sound and a stiff response, as the tip of the axe cracked loudly. But instead, the lock of the cell broke with a flourish, and Todd jumped in past the creaking door.

Todd: “General First-Class Arakiya!”

Inside the cell, a girl lay face down upon a simple bed.

Even if they belonged to the same Imperial Army, a mere Soldier would not have many opportunities to meet a General. Even a General Third-Class was a commander of an army. A General Second-Class, let alone a General First-Class, would be something from above the clouds.

Therefore, this was the first time that Todd had seen one of the Generals First-Class, one of the Nine Divine Generals, up close.

Arakiya: “———”

The reason why the unconscious Arakiya was lying on her face, was because of the slash she had sustained on her back, covered with a painful scar which had been scorched shut on top of that.

The wound had been cauterized at the same time it had been received, becoming a horrible scar— had she not been injured by a scorching blade, she would not have gotten this kind of wound.

Todd: “That red woman, what’d she...?”

That woman was no ordinary person, and the power of that ornate sword she held was also extraordinary.

There were no further details, and Arakiya did not answer when called. So Todd had no choice but to pick up Arakiya’s body, then running straight out of the cell.

Todd: “I got her! Jamal, let’s go!”

Holly: “I’m not going to let *you*... Ouch!”

Jamal: “That’s why! Looking away again! Don’t you dare! Neeeee— Hk!”

The Shudraqian woman’s mind was momentarily distracted as Arakiya was taken away.

In a moment, Jamal jumped at the woman like a flash with his twin swords. She immediately held her large spear vertically to prevent it, but the impact ripped the spear from the woman’s grasp, and Jamal’s backward kick pierced her unguarded torso as he sprung up.

The woman let out a small scream as her body slammed into the wall of the prison; her head hit the ground with force, and she fell motionlessly limp.

Looking over at her, Todd was about to order Jamal to finish her, but—

Todd: “—Hey, there’s a commotion upstairs. Did they find the body of the guard?”

Jamal: “Tch, we can’t stay around. The General First-Class is...”

Todd: “She’s unconscious, but not dead. That should be enough.”

Answering Jamal’s question in a straightforward manner, Todd ran out of the dungeon. Jamal, who was ahead of him, was in charge of clearing the way for Todd, who easily overtook him.

???: “Who in the world... Guah!”

Jamal: “Outta the way, you dimwitted bastards!”

The guard who looked into the basement was blown away by a slash, and Todd ran through the City Hall behind Jamal as they became increasingly alert.

Unfortunately, he did not have the leisure of caring for Arakiya’s body as he carried her. If she was one of the Nine Divine Generals, her body would probably be strong enough. He just had to trust his endurance and run.

Jamal: “We’re outside! Where are we going?”

Todd: “Main gate’s closed— Follow me.”

Stitching their way through the dark and tumultuous night of the city, Todd jumped into the back alleys with Jamal. He made full use of the narrow streets and side roads to mislead the enemies tracking their whereabouts.

The battle had just ended, the chaos was still raging, and there were at least three-hundred identically-dressed Imperial Soldiers in the city. It would be difficult to tell them apart.

All that was left was—

Todd: “—Hk!”

The moment he heard the sound of wind, a blade swung right behind Todd.

He turned around, and there stuck just right below his feet was a single, thick, large arrow. Someone had cut it down. It had been aimed at Todd, carrying insane momentum, and Jamal had been the one to swiftly deal with it.

That had been a precise shot, aimed at the two who were running and hiding in the city.

It was, beyond the shadow of doubt, the same archer who had shot Todd in the torso a few days prior.

—They were being observed.

If that were the case, they could not move carelessly.

If they left the alley, that would make them an easy target, and Todd, with Arakiya in tow, would have difficulty moving with agility. Even if they tried to kill the archer, the enemy was located at the City Hall— and there would be no option but to return there for the third time.

So, should they abandon Arakiya and flee? That would be the way most likely to save themselves, but if that was the case, they would not know what they were risking their lives for to begin with.

In light of the current situation, he searched for an optimal way to take action, and the one that would yield the most results was—

Todd: “—Jamal, you know we’re being targeted.”

Jamal: “Yeah, they’re a pain in the ass. They’re too far away for me to kill them, but if we don’t, they’ll just shoot at us one way or another. What should we do?”

Todd: “...Then, there’s only one way.”

Jamal narrowed his single eye at Todd’s words.

To Jamal’s gaze that sought a solution, Todd exhaled deeply and closed one eye,

Todd: “As soon as we jump out, the enemy’s going to shoot at us. I’ll have you get ahead of me and cut off their arrows just like before. Not just one shot, but two or three will follow. I’ll run as fast as I can, so I don’t shake the General First-Class off.”

Jamal: “Huh, that doesn’t sound like you. That’s really your move? Smells of desperation, no?”

Todd: “Ultimately, that’s what happens when you run out of cards. But I’m still lucky, aren’t I?”

Jamal: “Huh? What do you mean?”

Todd: “You got a pretty strong hand left, you know.”

The strategy he presented was almost entirely based on Jamal’s swordsmanship.

If Jamal were incapable of cutting off the flying arrows, they would both perish. It was insane, given Todd's beliefs, to risk his life in such a reckless manner.

However, that was his suggestion. With Jamal's swordsmanship, the odds were not null.

Jamal: "...I knew Katya wasn't a good judge of character. I thought you were smarter than that."

Todd: "Don't talk bad about my fiancée, onii-sama."

Todd replied to Jamal scratching his head, his cheeks twisted. Hearing this, Jamal let out a short "Haa", and then gripped the hilts of his twin swords once again.

Then, turning his imposing back to Todd.

Jamal: "Aight, I'm in. Sometimes a stupid bet ain't so bad."

Todd: "If I wasn't here, you'd probably be making all those types of bets."

Jamal: "Shut the fuck up— Be quiet and stay behind my back."

Jamal's Spirits quietly rose as they exchanged hateful words.

Watching his back, Todd tightened his hold on Arakiya's body.

Todd: "Jamal, when you get out of the alley, run straight. After that, when you get to the end, take the right road. That should give you enough time to catch your breath."

Hearing these instructions, Jamal pondered on them in his head, slowly closed his eye, then re-opened it as he stepped forward.

Jamal: "—Hk."

As soon as he stepped out of the alley, a single arrows, clad in a gale, pierced toward Jamal.

Jamal responded to it with amazing reflexes, and cut it off with a clash of his twin swords. The impact bounced onto Jamal's wrist, and his clenched teeth chattered as he laughed like a rabid dog.

The sensation of blood burning, heart leaping, and life boiling, overtook Jamal.

His extreme concentration made the world retard, and he felt as if he could feel every drop of sweat that ran down his skin, every grain of sand that flew around, and even the existence of air that should have been invisible.

Jamal: “—Hahaa!”

One after another, a storm of arrows poured down like a deluge.

Stepping on the ground, swinging his sword as if dancing, slicing the arrows and striking them down.

What ensued was a sword dance, the sword dance of Jamal Aurélie.

If things had gone well, they would have been able to enjoy the dance of the dancer who had been invited to the City Hall, the following day.

Jamal laughed at the thought that it had been ruined, and that he was the one dancing instead. But it was a dance with all his heart, a dance with all his body, a sword fight with all his energy.

Todd likewise marveled at Jamal’s efforts as he furiously handled the attack.

Todd followed without raising his voice, as a storm of lethal arrows rained down on him. This was a sign that he knew that if Jamal were distracted, it would directly lead to his death.

So Todd pushed Jamal away from his consciousness and focused all his energy on avoiding the impending “death”.

Straight ahead, evade, strike off, step in, jump, dispel, and cut open.

Jamal: “End of the corr— Hk.”

Miraculously, they had finished the straight path of death and hit the end of the indicated path.

The passage of time was vague, and the sword dance must have only lasted several seconds, even if it felt like it had persisted for hours. However, they had only broken through the first barrier. Refusing to relax, Jamal did as he was told and turned right at the end of the road, where—

—At the end of the broken path, there stood a group of Shudraqians, their spears trained on them.

Jamal: “—Fuck.”

It would be difficult to handle that many Shudraquians with that archer aiming at them. One could say it was impossible.

He was prepared to fight hard until he ran out of steam, but even if he did, he could not set any of it in reserve. He had no idea that he would be so perfectly anticipated, and it seemed that luck had completely abandoned him.

Jamal: “Even if you strut around being all sorts of a smartass, in the end, luck’ll run out on you, huh... Heh, it’s in vain. But, it wasn’t all that bad.”

Checking the feel of the twin swords in his bloodied hands, Jamal spilled this out to Todd behind him.

“It wasn’t bad at all”, he had said, and he meant it.

In many ways, Todd’s thoughts and actions had been overwhelming and frustrating.

In the end, however, he chose to exert himself like an Imperial Soldier.

Jamal: “I’m sorry about Katya, but it can’t be helped. She’s part of Imperial Nobility as well. I’m sure she was prepared for this to happen to you and me.”

Thinking of the sister he had left behind in the Imperial Capital, Jamal felt a faint tingle in his chest. However, it was soon drowned out by the will to fight the enemy in front of him, and the smell of blood that coated everything.

He was relieved for that— He was, to the bone, a Sword Wolf of the Vollachian Empire.

Jamal: “Let’s do this, Todd. Let’s at least show them what we’re made of, for one last time.”

Leaning forward, Jamal licked the blood flowing from his eyepatch-covered right eye.

Then, fiercely, he jumped headlong into the enemy, as to display his final prestige as an Imperial Soldier.

Deadly attacks rained down on him like a storm, but he no longer held any regrets.

The fact that he had been able to be himself till the very end, had been the greatest prize for Jamal.



???: "...You were an idiot until the very end, weren't you?"

Hearing Jamal's fierce roar in the distance, Todd muttered so as he dove through the wall.

The hole he had passed through was collapsed immediately afterwards, and he carefully erased all traces of his presence, so that he could not be pursued. They in the city would probably be occupied with Jamal for a while, so there should be time to escape.

It was just like Jamal had stated.

Todd would never entrust his life to a desperate plan, even if he were dead— no, he would never do such a thing, precisely to avoid dying.

Todd: "If I let them chase you out of the alley, they'll be distracted. Well, I feel sorry for Katya..."

The promise to bring back his brother-in-law would go unfulfilled, and his fiancée would be terribly heartbroken.

In order to comfort her, he wished to return to the Imperial Capital as soon as possible.

Fortunately, in return for losing Jamal, he had been able to find another way to return to the Imperial Capital.

It was a wildcard that could lead to a much bigger foothold than Jamal's current one, which was that he had been on the verge of promotion to General Third-Class.

Arakiya: "...Princess."

Todd: "Oh dear, you look so innocent. Even so, if you're one of the Nine Divine Generals, then the number of people you've killed would be more than a hundred or two."

In Todd's arms, Arakiya's tears flowed from her closed eye. As he watched the tears roll down her cheeks, the vague thought that his current companion was wearing an eye patch, just like his previous one, passed Todd's mind.

After thinking about it, Todd suddenly inclined his head. And—

Todd: “On which side did Jamal have that eyepatch...?”



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by DdukaE ([source](#))

Arc 7 Chapter 28 - Victory Conditions

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 2 “Self-Proclaimed Hero Natsuki Subaru”, Part 1

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Heretic Translations, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

—The news that the captured Arakiya had been taken sent a tremor through the conference hall.

Kuna: “What a *disgrace*. Even Holly’s bow couldn’t catch up to *him*, they got *away*.”

Holly: “*Right-*.”

The two people who hung their heads and apologized were Holly, who held a bow in her hand, and Kuna.

With Holly, the bearer of bad news, alongside her, Kuna had immediately gone up to the top floor to chase after the runaway, Arakiya. Then, using a combination of Holly’s arm strength and Kuna’s eyesight, they had fired at the fugitives, just as they had done with Todd when Subaru and the others had originally escaped Guaral.

However, the fugitives had been able to deal with the two-man long-range snipe, and successfully outmaneuvered the both of them, taking Arakiya away.

Kuna: “One of them stayed behind as a *decoy*, and the other one took the Divine General. We can’t let it end like *this*, we have to go after *them*...”

??? & ???: “—It is pointless.”

The frustrated Kuna, her nose wrinkled in regret, had her words interrupted by two voices.

The same exact words were uttered simultaneously by both Abel and Priscilla, sitting motionlessly at the roundtable. The two glanced at each other, and Priscilla closed her eyes.

It was a sign that she wanted to hand it over to Abel.

Abel: "...It was a way to get behind our lines with a small number of people, achieve a singular goal, and escape. The two had their roles clearly defined in case they got split up. Their courage in deciding to do it, and the judgment to escape, are worthy of appraisal. They shall not be caught even if someone is sent to chase them."

Kuna: "—Hk, but even so..."

Abel: "In less than half a day, Arakiya shall wake up. If that happens, any pursuers we send her way will not pose a chance. And if they change their mind and return to the city, it shall also be futile. Let me tell you, we shall not have the same luck twice. At the very least, I would state that it would be quite reckless, to make a stand with our current forces."

Kuna: "Guh... Hk."

Holly: "Kuna... What Abel's saying is *right*-."

By rattling off a string of words, Abel tried to discourage Kuna's insistence. Holly, standing beside her, gently patted Kuna on the shoulder as if to offer some consolation.

Being a representative of the Chieftain at the roundtable, and confident in her archery skills, Kuna must have felt bitterly disappointed. However, despite his harsh way of putting it, Subaru nodded in agreement with Abel's argument.

The Imperial Soldiers who had invaded the prison would not have dared to challenge them without a chance of winning. They had set an objective that was achievable under their circumstances, found a way to beat the odds, and executed it.

Naturally, they would not do anything half-hearted like a one-way trip, so they must have had an appropriate plan for escape.

Priscilla: "No matter how you spin it, that thing's fate did not end here. With that as the case, I am sure it has a role to play still."

Subaru: "Priscilla..."

Priscilla casually threw those words into the air upon the fall of silence.

For Subaru, who had been discussing the treatment of Arakiya just before, his feelings about her not being executed and having been taken away without being able to talk to her were complex.

But what did Priscilla, who had taken the stance of staying out of Arakiya's life and death, think of her being taken? That could not be read from her crimson eyes.

Al: "So, in the end, what are we gonna do about that girl, Arakiya? Have you decided to leave her be?"

Subaru: "...If she's been taken away, there's nothing else we can do."

With a pained look on his face, Subaru responded to Al's words, who was incapable of reading the mood.

Having managed to deal with Kuna's and Holly's sniping, they could not expect anyone with only half-decent skill to take pursuit of the fugitives. In that case, this limited who they could choose for the pursuit, and all of those with good skills could not be permitted to be absent from Guaral at the moment.

Despite all his efforts to come up with a solution, Subaru's strength lay in surprise attacks, which made him particularly ill-suited to occasions in which his opponent took the initiative. And this state of affairs made that clear.

Subaru: "By the way, I don't think it's likely, but what if they're still hiding in the city, pretending to have escaped?"

Zikr: "I do not think so. Although the city is claimed to be solidly fortified, there are other secret paths besides the two large gates, but all of them have been meticulously closed off in the past few days."

Subaru: "Meticulously..."

Zikr: "Yes. We were expecting you to use the secret passages to infiltrate the city. We certainly did not believe that you would attempt a reckless plan to break through from the front."

He had been caught flat-footed, but Zikr responded calmly without a trace of displeasure.

As the commander-in-chief of the Fortress City, it was a matter of course to be wary of any secret pathways. However, the defensive stance taken under Zikr's leadership lent a tailwind to the soldiers who had taken Arakiya and fled.

Zikr: "Perhaps the soldiers who took the General First-Class were part of the search party for the secret paths. As Abel-dono said, they are not amongst those who would take up a challenge without a prospect of victory. That being the case, I wonder if they were able to do it because they knew there was a way out."

Subaru: "Isn't it possible to find the location of the paths you eliminated on a map?"

Zikr: "—It would be possible to make a map, but not right now. The city has fallen, and the soldiers are pretty shaken. This chaos will not settle any time soon."

Subaru: "...If only this were a *kyougi*⁴, it'd be that easy."

Were this an act in a video game, once one got the commander of the defeated enemy to join their side, and the subordinate units would likewise ally themselves. However, reality was not a game. In a game, soldiers were represented by numbers, but each of them had a life of their own here.

After mulling it over for a while—

Subaru: "Holly-san, are you injured?"

Holly: "Hm? Are you worried about *me*? Natsumi is so *kind*-."

At Subaru's inquiry, Holly threw her arms up while smiling broadly. She showed her large biceps to emphasize that she was alive and well.

Holly: "I'm a little banged *up*, but I'm not badly hurt, so I'll be fine in no *time*-."

Subaru: "I see. I'm glad to hear that... But."

⁴ English flip. Means "game/competition" (競技), originally "ゲーム" (game).

When Subaru fumbled his words and dropped his gaze, Holly put a puzzled look on her face. Noticing Subaru's inner thoughts, Kuna scratched her head with an "Ah". Then---

Kuna: "Some of the guards we had standing inside the building have been *killed*. They were all *dead*, so we couldn't do *anything*."

Subaru: "...Some? Tell me how many?"

Kuna: "...Seven *men*."

When asked the exact number of casualties, Kuna, even though hesitant, answered.

Seven. The number of casualties stabbed deeply into Subaru's heart--- on the top floor, Rem had been making a great deal of continuous effort to treat the Imperial Soldiers and Shudraquians who had gotten injured in Arakiya's attack, and they had not received any reports of deaths. They had not received those, but---

Subaru: "...How's this a bloodless siege?"

Brushing up his long black wig, Subaru let out a heartbreaking breath.

The bloodless siege, which he had undertaken with such vigor, and which he had said he would accomplish, was supposed to succeed in bringing about the fall of Guaral without loss of life. Yet instead, it had resulted in many deaths.

His promise had been broken; even if he were accused of being a liar, he would not be able to retort. Even if no one accused Subaru of lying, Subaru would condemn himself as one despite that.

Because he was the biggest liar here---

???: "---A bloodless siege?"

Overhearing Subaru's mutterings, a voice repeated to themselves as if reflecting on those words.

It was Priscilla, leaning on the round table, resting her cheek on her hand. In an unusual expression, she had slightly raised her well-shaped eyebrow and studied Subaru.

With that expression on her face, Priscilla prefaced her statement with a single word, “You”.

Priscilla: “I thought I heard a very foolish thing. Did you really believe that you could bring down an entire city without shedding blood? In the middle of this war, without an overwhelming military force?”

Subaru: “...Yeah, that’s right, my bad. No, it was really my fault, wasn’t it? After all, at the end of the day, it was my mistake...”

Priscilla: “It was merely a stupid idea, that is what amazed me. I am astonished that you would even attempt to put that pipedream into practice— Abel, are you insane?”

Abel: “—The plan itself was sheer madness to begin with.”

The question was directed at Abel, who crossed his arms and replied quietly.

Subaru’s proposed plan was pure madness. In fact, anyone that heard the outline would probably agree. And yet, Abel had gone along with it.

Priscilla, who was apparently acquainted with him, did not seem to understand it.

Priscilla: “Looking at the Empire from the throne made you that much more lax. There is no war without sacrifice. There is no pride without bloodshed. That is the way of the Empire, is it not?”

Abel: “I have no intention of disobeying the code of the Sword Wolf. I said it was madness, but the odds were in my favor. In fact, if it weren’t for Arakiya’s presence, the siege would have been bloodless.”

Priscilla: “———”

Abel: “It was not the plan that went wrong. It was my judgment. Priscilla, I shall not allow even you to make a fool of my military strategist’s offering. It was my decision. The blame lies with me.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Abel confronted Priscilla head-on with a statement that had been far too unexpected.

Abel’s words and actions were clearly in defense of Subaru, even though he had been appointed to the unheard-of role of military strategist. He could not interject between the dangerous standoff of the two.

Al: "What's the matter, bro? He likes you an awful lot, looks like you're getting a big promotion."

Subaru: "...My position as Emilia-tan's Knight and Beako's guardian's good enough for me. I don't want to be given any more positions I'm not familiar with."

Subaru pushed Al away from him, and also pushed away the responsibility that was pressing down on him.

However, thanks to Abel's protection, Priscilla's attention seemed to have turned in that direction. In spite of that, this did not heal the wound to Subaru's internals.

The responsibility for the lives lost should be placed on Subaru, the one who had come up with and implemented the plan.

Al: "You can't save them all, bro."

Al muttered, fiddling with the metal fittings on his helmet, as he looked at Subaru's profile. When Subaru glanced at him, he turned his gaze up towards the ceiling, and said,

Al: "You can't save all the people you get involved with. No one's stopping you from saving them, but your heart's gonna be broken while doing so. I don't recommend it."

Subaru: "Al..."

Al: "We all live and die as we please. Like you said bro, it ain't a *kyougi*. It's up to them to take care of their own lives."

This was the cynical attitude that Al sometimes displayed.

On one hand he was giving a sermon to Subaru, on how tragic events happened and that he should accept them as-is, although there seemed to be good advice and counsel there. On the other hand, it also felt like the admonishment of an obstinate child.

It was a sound argument, to some degree.

In fact, Al's words were right. Saving everyone and anything was not possible, and there would be no end to it if he did decide to save them all. That was why Subaru had never been able to save every last thing till this point.

The sheer scale of war was different— could he really say that his choice was correct?

The number of lives that could be saved by a single action taken by Subaru did not even reach ten, much less a hundred.

Priscilla: "This is even worse than farcical, you know."

While Subaru and Al were talking, Priscilla and Abel continued their standoff.

To Abel who took the blame, Priscilla pulled out a fan from her cleavage and pointed the tip of it at the conference hall— No, at the entire city.

Priscilla: "Even in a situation in which you managed to successfully bring down the city with the help of your military strategist, you shall not be able to repeat the miracle of driving Arakiya away a second time. Will that method ever work again?"

Abel: "Indeed, there shall not be a second time."

Abel nodded without hesitation in response to Priscilla's question.

With the mention of the method that had driven away Arakiya, a thought also occurred to the frowning Subaru— There had been a moment, during Al and Arakiya's bout, in which her behavior had become strange.

Subaru: "That wasn't something that Al did..."

Al: "What? Yeah, it wasn't me. In the first place, if it were me, I would've done it a little smarter. You know, I was the one who got bounced and thrown off."

Subaru: "That's right."

Now that he mentioned it, it had not gone down very well, even with Al's skills.

The conversation between the two drew the attention of the conference hall to Abel. Only he could tell what somehow happened, and so he sniffed, being annoyed with the gathering attention.

Abel: “Arakiya is the Spirit Eater. She feeds on the Spirits in the air and absorbs their power.”

Subaru: “Spirit, Eater...?”

Subaru had no recollection of hearing it before, but the unsettling title made his eyes widen.

He had already guessed that the Vollachian Empire had different rules and a different environment compared to Kingdom of Lugunica, but the idea of a Spirit Eater was quite the novelty.

Subaru himself was a Spiritual Arts User who borrowed the power of Spirits, but this sounded distinctly different, and to put it simply—

Subaru: “I definitely don’t want to bring Beako into this... Is being a Spirit Eater a common thing?”

Priscilla: “No, it’s not. Spirit Eating was originally one of the secrets of the tribes that lived on the borderlands of Vollachia. But it was so powerful that the technique was banished, and the method to possess it lost.”

Abel: “At least, as far as I know, there are no known Spirit Eaters outside of Arakiya. If there had been, I would have politely protected them. That was the Observers’... No, it matters not, now.”

Not wanting the conversation to get off-topic, Abel shook his head, as he encouraged them to get back to the topic at hand with “Returning to the main topic”.

Subaru, who was relieved to hear that Spirit Eating was not a common practice, and that Beatrice was no longer in danger of being munched on, asked,

Subaru: “So how did you confuse the Spirit Eater, Arakiya?”

Abel: “I did not confound her— I just gave her Mana poisoning.”

Al: “Mana poisoning... Haha, I see. That’s a very clever thing to do.”

Abel’s answer made sense, and Al nodded admiringly as he stroked his chin.

Subaru had heard of the term “Mana poisoning” before, and then it clicked.

Subaru: “As I recall, it was something like, people who are hypersensitive to Mana tend to get sick when they go to places where the concentration of Mana is really high.”

Priscilla: “Arakiya is susceptible to that kind of influence, due to her Spirit Eater characteristic. It is a prerequisite to have a reasonable level of resistance to Spirits, in order to take them in. However, if you go beyond that principle and try to make Arakiya sick off Mana, you shall end up with...”

Abel: “Yes, she made me utilize one of my treasures. Including that which he has already used before, I hold nothing else on hand.”

Whilst saying “that”, Abel nodded towards and indicated Subaru. That made Subaru go “Treasure?”, and he tilted his head to the side whilst raising his eyebrows.

Even though Abel had stated that Subaru had used one of his treasures, he honestly had no clue at all as to what he meant.

Subaru: “What treasure are you talking about? When did I get your...?”

Abel: “During the Lifeblood Ritual, you broke the ring to cleave the Witchbeast’s horn off. That’s the one.”

Subaru: “Ah...”

He’d lost track of it, but it brought back memories of a ring he had borrowed, which allowed him to cast magic.

In the throes of battle, he had no choice but to hit the Elgina’s horn with said ring, shattering it and snapping the Witchbeast’s horn, leaving Subaru’s arm and the ring in shambles.

And something else that was mentioned in the same breath, was what Abel had made use of in the fight with Arakiya?

Abel: “As I dropped from the balcony, I shattered the ring I had hidden. It took a while for the Mana it contained to flood the area around it, but...”

Al: “So that Arakiya girl was like that because she got Mana poisoning. Oh come on, I got my ass kicked by that girl.”

Subaru: “Did you pull that little trick at that moment...?”

Even though they were all in a battered and wounded state, Subaru tipped his hat off to Abel’s unwillingness to give up. That he was still searching for a way to win even though he was being cornered by the second-strongest ranking General in the Empire was admirable.

Subaru’s resilience was quite good, but his intelligence was so far removed from Abel’s that he could not get over the difference between a bad move and a desperate counterattack. In any case—

Subaru: “Isn’t this an original plan prepared specifically for Arakiya? It’s very bold of you to prepare such a plan when you didn’t know she would be going against you.”

Abel: “The more people one keeps close, the more one must prepare for the time of their betrayal... Arakiya in particular, I never knew when Arakiya would turn against me.”

Priscilla: “—However, you only get one chance to use your wiles. It is not easy to procure enough Magic Stones to give a person Mana poisoning. It shall be essential to secure a decent fighting force before the next time around. But.”

Having declared that much, Priscilla cut off her words meaningfully.

Covering her mouth with her fan, Priscilla narrowed her crimson eyes at Abel. With a somewhat probing, testing look in her eyes, she let out a small breath and,

Priscilla: “Adding the People of Shudraq to your ranks was expected... However, it is difficult to see how you could be foolish enough to adopt a naive military strategist’s plan for a bloodless siege of the Fortress City.”

Abel: “———”

Priscilla: “At this rate, I shall never be able to advise my collaborators to support you.”

Subaru: “Collaborators!?”

Subaru was astonished by Priscilla, who had said it in a matter-of-fact and natural way. It was not just Subaru who was surprised, but everyone in the conference hall except Abel and Al.

Aside from Priscilla's companion, Al, it seemed unreasonable that Abel was also not surprised, but Subaru opted to not mention it.

Subaru: "Wait, wait, wait, this is going all over the place! Collaborators... In the first place, I don't understand your position. I heard that you came to help Abel, but..."

Priscilla: "I am not here to lend aid. Do not listen seriously to the ramblings of my clown."

Subaru: "I get it! I don't care if you've come to help Abel or not. That's not the point. What I want to hear, is your ultimate goal."

As they heard, the immediate subgoal was to have some dialogue with Abel.

However, what Subaru desired to know was why Priscilla— why her, Al, and possibly the other collaborators they had brought alongside them, were in the Vollachian Empire to begin with.

On top of that, it would be best if he knew whether they were willing to side with Abel or not.

Subaru: "Answer me. Honestly, I and everyone else here aren't sure what to think of you."

Priscilla: "That is hubris at its finest. I do not care what you plebeians think of me. I shall do what I wish to do. After all..."

Subaru: "—«The world is made to suit me», isn't it?"

Priscilla gave a snort at Subaru's tracing of her philosophy, which was familiar to his ears.

Then, noticing the increased number and sharpness of the glances directed at her, Priscilla shut one eye.

Priscilla: "Mine aim, is to restore the Emperor to the throne he was ousted from. If I do not, I shall be receiving a constant stream of annoying visitors."

Abel: "It goes without mentioning that those assassins were not dispatched by me."

Priscilla: “I did not even suspect it. Henceforth, I took the trouble to arrive here. Or, it would be more accurate to say that I had my wings carry me.”

With one eye closed, Priscilla answered Abel and turned her gaze upward. Without the ceiling present, what could be observed was the night sky beyond.

More to the point, it was not just the sky, but an existence that made the sky its own—

Subaru: “No way, did you and Al just fly in from the sky?”

Al: “Oh, it’s like a flying dragon express service. To be honest, I thought it’d be the end of the world when the Princess jumped off by herself. I certainly couldn’t follow, so I couldn’t get down until it lowered itself a bit.”

Subaru: “A flying dragon... The water dragons in Pristella scared the hell out of me.”

In addition to the water dragon, which was a fantasy creature aside than the ground dragon, the existence of flying dragons surfaced.

From what he had heard, flying dragons were extremely ferocious and required specialized skills to be tamed. Since there tamers capable of that were not numerous, being able to ride a flying dragon in the first place was a rare thing.

Subaru: “In other words, the person who can provide a flying dragon express delivery is a collaborator of Priscilla’s?”

Priscilla: “Do not perform lowly deeds such as picking apart people’s words. In your case, your lowliness outweighs your cleverness. Polish up your pretty face. You are still capable of looking good if you fix your makeup.”

Subaru: “If I fix my makeup now I’d definitely be a crazy person, right...?”

Now that she mentioned it, the fact that he had not been able to shed his womanly attire thus far might be regarded as a problem, but the people present here could read the atmosphere, so they did not touch the issue.

Anyway, he was getting way off track again, however—

Subaru: “If the goal is to get Abel back on the throne, does that mean we can cooperate with each other?”

Priscilla: “In truth, I cannot give you a straightforward assent— I have not forgotten my earlier words. If he does not possess the qualities of an Emperor, there will be no point in bringing him back.”

Abel: “———”

Abel glared at Priscilla, his gaze sharpened as he was questioned about his own qualities as an Emperor to his face.

What Priscilla saw as a concern, was the Bloodless Siege proposed by Subaru and approved by Abel— not so much the failure to carry it out, but rather the problem of the idea to begin with.

As per the way of Vollachia, naïveté could be fatal. In fact, lives had been lost because Subaru’s endgame had been naïve. Her disapproval was irrefutable. However—

Abel: “I shall reclaim the throne. No matter what anyone says, that much is certain— Priscilla, no matter what you may state, that much remains indisputable.”

With Subaru having fallen silent, Abel took his place and made a strong declaration.

It was the same, or perhaps an even more passionate declaration than the one he had made upon revealing his true identity and divulging that he would take back this country in front of Subaru.

Priscilla: “———”

Hearing Abel’s resolve, the expressions on the faces of those in the conference hall shifted.

Kuna and Holly had the will to continue fighting as the People of Shudraq, while Zikr bowed his head as if he were in the presence of something divine. Al turned to Priscilla to see her reaction, while Priscilla’s eyes narrowed as she continued to assert herself, undaunted.

Priscilla: “Your spirit is undiminished, but reality is not. In fact, you have been forced to abandon your throne.”

Abel: “———”

Priscilla: “The circumstances are already apparent. The question is, who set it in motion? Whose plan was it?”

Abel: “—I am certain it was Prime Minister Berstetz who brought it all to fruition.”

Abel answered Priscilla’s question with a hint of hostility in his dark eyes.

The Prime Minister’s position was at the top of the state government, as it was closely associated with the Emperor. If the pinnacle of the armed forces were a general or the head of a knightly order, then the Prime Minister may be said to be the pinnacle of civil services.

In any case, it could be said that being second-in-command made it easy to carry out betrayal.

Priscilla: “That old tree. How dare he waste what he got from Lamia?”

Abel: “Of course, I had foreseen his rebellious intentions and prepared accordingly. But...”

Abel broke off there and exhaled quietly.

It was a reaction that was very much unlike him, the first time he had displayed anything close to fragility. As Emperor, he had never wavered, even when forced to leave his position, but this was the first time he had shown a faint weakness.

The cause of this weakness was not the Prime Minister’s betrayal—

Abel: “With Chisha Gold watching over me... I was unable to see through the rebellious intentions of the Nine Divine Generals’ Fourth Rank.”

Zikr: “—Ridiculous, General First-Class Chisha!?”

As Abel spat out his ashamed thoughts, Zikr was incapable of containing himself and raised his voice.

Zikr, as a General Second-Class of the Empire, must have been familiar with the name of this particular member of the Nine Divine Generals, a name that Subaru was not.

Attracting the gaze of those at the roundtable, Zikr stroked his ample hair and spoke—

Zikr: “General First-Class Chisha is unique among the Nine Divine Generals, in terms of his capability. The General First-Class himself is more famous for his wisdom than his military prowess, and he was the one who supported His Excellency Vincent the most during the Imperial Selection Ceremony...”

Subaru: “Does that mean he was his right-hand man? You mean this guy was betrayed not only by his political right-hand man, the Prime Minister, but his long-time right-hand man, the General, too?”

Abel: “Do not utter those words again. My right arm is still attached to my right shoulder.”

Subaru: “When you say that now, it just sounds like you’re just trying to be tough...”

Listening to Zikr’s explanation, Subaru was surprised by Abel’s popularity, which was unexpectedly lacking.

However, keeping the Vollachian Empire’s radical ideology in mind, an Emperor who was deemed insufficiently powerful would immediately be rebelled against, so perhaps these situations were not all that rare.

Subaru: “Is it common for Emperors to run for cover in this country?”

Abel: “Since I have been on the throne, there have only been two times in which I was pursued, at least formally.”

Subaru: “But you’ve got a record!”

Abel: “Nonsense. It was the Kingdom’s Royal Guard who dragged me around in that previous venture. If you want to complain, you can take it up with them.”

He gave Subaru a seriously disappointed look, he took the hint and held his tongue.

He thought that Julius had once mentioned that he had gone to the Empire as an emissary, but he had not thought it had anything to do with that. If so, the world was too small.

Al: “Ah, so His Excellency the Emperor was chased from the throne by his confidants and aides, and Lil’ Miss Arakiya’s become an enemy as well... Doesn’t that sound dangerous? Don’t you have an ally or something?”

Abel: “Another one of the Nine Divine Generals, Goz Ralfon... He was instrumental in my escape. Were it not for him stalling for time, I would not have been able to activate the transfer mechanism.”

Zikr: “Oh, as expected of General First-Class Goz...!”

Abel: “However, if the Nine Divine Generals, other than Chisha and Arakiya, have too turned against me, I do not know how Goz alone could have survived. It is far more likely that he was killed.”

The existence of any Divine General who had risked their lives to protect Abel was a hope, albeit a very fleeting one. However, Zikr with a “No” shook his head,

Zikr: “If I may be so bold, I have not received any news of the death of General First-Class Goz. Whether he perished in battle or from illness, the death of a man of General First-Class Goz’s status cannot be hidden for long.”

Abel: “Then there remains the possibility that he is being held captive.”

Zikr: “Perhaps. No, surely! For a warrior of the caliber of General First-Class Goz, that is likely the case!”

At Abel’s words, Zikr bowed reverently.

If he had earned this kind of respect from Zikr, then this Goz must be a very reliable man. Or maybe a woman, contrary to the stern name.

Priscilla: “—With the Prime Minister and the Nine Divine Generals as foes, the Empire is very much a place of certain death.”

Priscilla, who had finished listening to the conversation before interjecting uselessly, muttered that. In agreement with her words, Subaru raised his hand, and,

Subaru: “Hey. I know it’s a tad late, but what if Abel comes forward as the Emperor? That way, the people who’re quietly running the government in the Imperial Capital can be branded as rebels and traitors...”

Al: “Unfortunately, it’s impossible to expect an angry populace and soldiers to kill the administration’s coup d’état before the battle even starts, bro.”

Subaru: “I wasn’t thinking something that crazy, but why not?”

Abel: “—Because this is the Vollachian Empire, where the powerful are respected.”

Subaru’s suggestion was rejected, and Al’s words were supplemented by Abel’s.

The Emperor, removed from his throne, folded his arms, his shapely eyebrows slightly furrowed.

Abel: “If I come forward and announce my intention to reclaim the Imperial Capital myself, I would be welcomed. But that does signify that they shall support me. What was taken from you, you must take back yourself. That is how it is.”

Subaru: “Not only goods and lands, but also the Emperor’s throne...”

Abel: “There are no exceptions... Therefore, I know what must be done.”

Subaru, who was attempting to wrap his head around the situation, was surprised by Abel’s words.

Just when he thought he was at a loss, Abel’s answer was rather the opposite. He stood up and slowly put his hands on the roundtable. And—

Abel: “General Second-Class Zikr, the map.”

Zikr: “Yes! Right away!”

When told to do so, Zikr sent instructions to the Imperial Soldiers waiting in the corner of the room.

They immediately peeled off the map hanging on the wall of the conference hall, and moved to spread it out atop the roundtable.

It was a world map showing, well, the entire world, including Vollachia.

Abel: “Here we are, in the east, at the Fortress City of Guaral. And the Imperial Capital of Lupugana, which must be reclaimed, lies in the center of the Empire, roughly.”

Subaru: “...Vollachia’s pretty big.”

The map showed Subaru the size of the country, which he had not been aware of till now. The Vollachian Empire, which occupied the southern portion of the world map, was the largest when compared to the other countries.

The Buddheim Jungle, which had posed so much trouble for Subaru and the others to get through, was merely a small geographic area from the perspective of the whole of Vollachia.

Abel: “Each city in the Empire is controlled by its own Mayor or Lord. As is the case with Guaral, each of these cities possesses its own autonomous military force and shall not hesitate to fight in case of an emergency— We shall add these to our forces and secure the strength required to retake the Imperial Capital.”

Subaru: “...I get this is a *moyou* of kingship in a conquering *mogijikken*⁵.”

Abel: “You seem to be displeased.”

Subaru: “Of course. It was an enormous undertaking just for Guaral. I don’t think it’s going to keep working out this way.”

Pointing to the map, Subaru had managed to keep up with Abel as he explained. He could manage to keep up with him, but this was a matter of logic, not emotion.

As stated earlier, this was not a game. There was no way that a method that held water when it came to simulation RPGs and things of the sort would be easily applied in actual reality.

Abel’s opinion seemed to be quite optimistic. Nevertheless—

Abel: “There is a way to dispel your concerns. Rather, there are essential conditions that must be met in order to do what I must.”

Subaru: “Essential conditions...”

Abel: “—By securing Divine Generals.”

⁵ Two English flips. First one means “pattern” (模様), originally “パターン” (pattern). Second one means “simulation” (模擬実験), originally “シミュレーション” (simulation).

Upon hearing that reply, Subaru's eyes went wide.

That was natural. After all, Abel had just told them that he had been expelled from throne because of the Nine Divine Generals' treachery.

Those of the Nine Divine Generals that favored him were unaccounted for, and the two members of the Nine Divine Generals they were aware of, were already enemies. As for the others—

Subaru: "What about the other Divine Generals...?"

Abel: "There."

Abel pointed a finger at the sudden question and nodded at Subaru's agitation. Then, he surveyed the faces of everyone except Subaru,

Abel: "The people of the Empire must be strong. The Nine Divine Generals are the incarnation of this rule. In other words, if one wishes to be the supreme Ruler of the Vollachian Empire, you must unite the Nine Divine Generals."

Subaru: "So, in other words..."

After Abel's words, Subaru's eyes widened as he realized what was to follow. Abel's cheeks twisted at Subaru's reaction, as he smiled belligerently. And then—

Abel: "—The Blue Lightning, Cecilus Segmund. The Spirit Eater, Arakiya. The Vicious Old Man, Olbart Dunkelkenn. The White Spider, Chisha Gold. The Lion Knight, Goz Ralfon. The Master of Curse Tools, Groovy Gumlet. The Flamboyant, Yorna Mishigure. The Steelman, Moguro Hagane. The Flying Dragon General, Madelyn Eschart."

Subaru: "——"

Abel: "The winner of this battle shall be the one who recruits the most Divine Generals. That is the path toward triumph, and that is the absolute condition I must fulfill."



Arc 7 Chapter 29 - To Each Their Stance

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 2 “Self-Proclaimed Hero Natsuki Subaru”, Parts 2-3
(half-way)

Original Web Novel Chapter – [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by SapphireComet, Translation Checked
by [Ice/Ice Occultism](#), Averitius, Aehein) – [Complete](#)

—Securing the Nine Divine Generals; that was the victory condition for reclaiming the Imperial throne.

With the condition for victory presented, along with the names and titles of those necessary, the Nine Divine Generals, Subaru could tell from experience that the air in the room had become tense.

Of course, the names of the Nine Divine Generals, which would be familiar to people in the Empire, were all novel to Subaru.

Subaru: “...If this were a manga or an anime, it would have been an exciting development to see all the names of the Generals revealed at once.”

However, as this was something that was actually happening to him, the development was one he could not be openly pleased about.

As Abel mentioned the name and corresponding title of each of the Nine Divine Generals, Subaru could imagine how troublesome each one of them would be, with each of them sounding effective in how they were talked up.

As Arakiya’s nickname, Spirit Eater, corresponded with a special trait of hers, Subaru could imagine that the others’ aliases were somewhat related to their abilities or fighting methods.

Subaru: “The only ones whose names give me a clear image of their abilities would be the Master of Curse Tools and the Flying Dragon General?”

The two names he pointed out were probably both derived from the way they fought and the tools they used.

The other nicknames were probably inspired by their appearance or anecdotes of their exploits. In China's Romance of the Three Kingdoms and the Water Margin both, characters would often take on aliases for such reasons⁶.

Come to think of it, one could say that those stories were also about taking a country. Unfortunately, Subaru was not very familiar with them, having only a cursory knowledge of their contents.

Subaru: "This is no time to be spacing out. Well, I've heard that securing the Nine Divine Generals is the condition for victory, but there are some things I want to ask you."

Abel: "What. Is there any room for doubt?"

Abel raised one eyebrow and placed his hand on top of the map on the table as Subaru recovered from his initial shock.

If he thought that he had explained everything with that, he would be the ultimate example of a clever man short of words. Compared to the other people here— Zikr and the others, not to mention the People of Shudraq, Subaru had far less information about the Vollachian Empire.

Subaru: "So there's clearly room for me to doubt. If you keep skipping explanations because you yourself know what you're talking about, the people around you won't know what you're thinking about exactly."

Abel: "I shall take that as advice and ignore it. State your question."

Subaru: "Keep that «ignoring» bit to yourself..."

Subaru sighed as Abel crossed his arms and responded arrogantly. Then, having resigned himself to the attention gathering around him, he said, "Ready?", as he held up four fingers on one hand and five fingers on the other.

⁶ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "The Romance of the Three Kingdoms and Water Margin are considered to be two of Four Great Classic Novels of China; for more information, see [here](#)".

Subaru: “There are Nine Divine Generals, but thankfully that’s an odd number, so it’s easy to understand that it comes down to a battle of numbers. But the ones who favor us are unaccounted for, and, right now, Arakiya and this Chisha guy are most definitely enemies. We’re already way outnumbered.”

They supposedly needed to secure no less than five, but their enemy already held two of the Nine Divine Generals under them.

In addition, it was unclear whether the person who had aided Abel, Goz, was alive or dead. So there was a high chance that one of the cards they could play had been permanently removed from play.

Subaru: “The situation becomes bleaker by the minute. It’s good that the victory conditions clear, but is it actually realistic to persuade five of the Nine Divine Generals?”

Al: “Hey hey, bro, I think you’re still underestimating the Emperor too much. I said it earlier, but he’s already won the Imperial Selection Ceremony. They can’t just flat out refuse his request to talk. As long as they don’t turn him away at the front door...”

Priscilla: “—Then we shall get the opportunity to behead those who oppose us at the same time.”

Subaru: “We need to get them on our side!”

Al’s remarks, posing as an attempt to dissolve Subaru’s doubts, were incinerated by the extreme comment of his mistress, of all people. They were talking about how to get the Nine Divine Generals on their side, but devising a way to kill the Nine Divine Generals who would not be on their side would be putting carriage before the ground dragon.

Abel: “But the clown in the iron helmet there is correct. In fact, if I state I want to meet them, there would be no General who would refuse. The problem is what happens after we meet.”

Al: “Is the clown in the iron helmet me?”

Subaru: “There’s no one else with an iron helmet. If you have a problem with him treating you like a clown, you can *hajimeru*⁷ with a petition to Priscilla.”

⁷ English flip. Means “(to) start” (始める), originally “start” (スタート).

After silencing Al's teasing, Subaru returned to the topic at hand.

Subaru: "In the first place, I don't understand the system of the Nine Divine Generals. I've always imagined them as nine Generals who report directly to the Emperor, but doesn't that mean they're all in the Imperial Capital?"

Priscilla: "Generals of the First-Class are the cornerstone of this nation. Consider how uselessly vast the Empire is. Even though the Imperial Capital lies in the center of the country, how can they move quickly in an emergency if they all sojourn in the Imperial Capital?"

Zikr: "Yes. Although it has been dramatically reduced during His Excellency's reign, there is still no end to the fires of civil unrest that smolder in the Empire. Having a firm foothold in the Imperial Capital is not enough to guarantee the safeguarding of the Empire."

Subaru: "...In other words, the Nine Divine Generals in question are scattered all over, outside the Imperial Capital?"

As Priscilla and Zikr supplemented information, Subaru put his hand on his chin in understanding.

Following a familiar example, Roswaal had also been bestowed with the grandiose title of Margrave of the Western Lands in the Kingdom of Lugunica, and was obligated to act quickly in the Kingdom's time of need.

Of course, he had the permission to set up a private army in his territory for that purpose— However, in Roswaal's case, it seemed that his individual strength was greater than that a poorly-organized army.

Just by raining down fireballs while flying in the sky, he would be able to completely defeat most opponents.

Subaru: "When you think about it, that guy's also quite the *yuushi butai*⁸... I'm a little curious to see where he stands compared to the Nine Divine Generals."

Kuna: "I don't *know*, but I think we're getting off track *here*, Natsumi."

⁸ English flip. Means "overpowering troop" (雄視部隊), originally "チートユニット" (cheat unit).

Subaru: “My bad. Anyway, I know now that the Nine Divine Generals are scattered across the country. If that’s the case, am I correct in understanding that not all of them were involved in the coup d’état in the Imperial Capital?”

Abel: “From what I have seen, and from a practical standpoint, I would say so.”

Abel nodded his head to Subaru in confirmation.

To be honest, Subaru was unsure about Abel’s assessment, as he had just been found to be quite unpopular, but the fact that no one around him had pointed it out suggested that it was something that could be accepted for the time being.

Anyway, the good news was, that not all the Nine Divine Generals had become enemies.

The victory condition that the more Nine Divine Generals they secured, the more likely they were to win this battle, made sense. Other than that, if there was one thing that Subaru had doubts about, it was—

Subaru: “Sorry for asking so many questions, but I got an additional question. If the Nine Divine Generals are simply ordered by strength, then priority should be given to the ones of the highest rank, correct?”

Abel: “Yes, that perception is correct.”

Subaru: “Then the one strong enough to be on par with Reinhard, is Cecilus, right? It’s common sense that we go for that person... wouldn’t he be enough?”

One among the four strongest human beings, those who had made a name for themselves in the Four Great Countries.

If Cecilus, who had been mentioned to be amongst these four, was a person considered to be on par with Reinhard, then it would be very much as if the outcome of the battle would be decided by that person alone.

In fact, that Reinhard could win even if he fought everyone in the Kingdom, was an extraordinary expectation and view that had sprouted in Subaru.

So, naturally, he held such sort of presupposition for Cecilus, who was Reinhard’s equal. However—

Abel: "...It is true that if we secure that person, all the problems of our strength shall be solved in one move."

Subaru: "If that's the case, why do you look so bitter?"

Frowning, Abel's expression was poor as he answered Subaru's question.

While Subaru's expectations did not appear seem to be far off, there was no improvement on his gloomy expression. Abel revealed the reason for this with a small exhale.

Abel: "The reason why securing the Nine Divine Generals is a condition for victory, is because Generals and Soldiers alike shall follow their military orders. The more Nine Divine Generals one possesses under their banner, the more troops shall join your forces. Do you understand?"

Subaru: "—? Yes, I understand. That's why I'm saying we should aim to have the strongest guy on our side. Or is it that him being called the Empire's strongest is not true?"

Abel: "No, there is no question that he is the strongest in the Empire. However, there is a problem."

Subaru: "A problem?"

Abel: "—He is not very popular."

Subaru stopped thinking for a while, due to the words that had been uttered in pent-up frustration.

The words he was told slowly penetrated his brain, as he wondered what the problem was. "Lack of popularity", that information was digested correctly.

Subaru: "Should you be saying that?"

Abel: "It is factual. His rank is that of the First, amongst the Generals of the First-Class of the Empire, but he holds no authority. Even if I were to give him the power, he would be incapable of doing anything with it. The only thing he can do, is to cut people down."

Subaru: “You can’t put someone like that in the *kaku*⁹ of army general!”

Al: “Easy, easy, calm down, bro! That’s just the way of the Empire, you know!”

With that criticism of Cecilus being spoken by Abel, Subaru was held back by Al. With his one arm around Subaru, Al tilted his head to look at Abel, and said,

Al: “Actually, you’ve given him nothing but the title of First. Maybe you should’ve tried giving him the authority he deserves for his position. Maybe he’s been taken advantage of by someone who was sweet-talking him, you know?”

Abel: “Of course, that person being utilized by anyone other than me is not within my wishes. If there were such a danger, I would have disposed of him earlier.”

Subaru: “But you were in the forest, alone and helpless...!”

Even if he said that he was holding the reins, if the actual circumstances differed, then he was just bragging.

In the first place, could the idea that the person labelled as the strongest in the Empire was unable to gather popularity in the Vollachian Empire, dedicated to this strength as it was, be taken seriously?

Subaru: “What about that part, Zikr-san!”

Zikr: “Me, huh?”

Subaru: “Eh, yeah. As a General of the Empire, I’d like to hear your honest opinion. What do you think of General First-Class Cecilus?”

Being probed for information, Zikr spoken “Right then,” and crossed his arms briefly in thought.

Then, nodding several times at the expectant gaze in Subaru’s eyes.

⁹ English flip. Means “position/rank” (格), originally “ポジション” (position).

Zikr: “First of all, there is no doubt that Cecilus-dono is the cornerstone of our national defense and the symbol of the strength of the Vollachian Empire. «The people of the empire must be strong», he is the embodiment of that way of life.”

Subaru: “Oh, that sounds good? So, what is it, then?”

Zikr: “As a person he is carefree, friendly, and has a sunny and pleasant demeanor towards anyone. Overall...”

Subaru: “Overall...?”

Zikr: “Many of the troops fear Cecilus-dono to be an incomprehensible monster and impossible to communicate with on a deeper level. I believe His Excellency is correct in his assessment.”

Subaru: “Your assessment has taken a sharp turn, hasn’t it!?”

Zikr, who had only painted the picture of a good person up to this point, chose his words quite carefully in his evaluation.

Some people would think that he was just trying to be considerate of Abel, the Emperor, but the wrinkles between his eyebrows showed that he was putting in a lot of effort, so he probably told the truth. In other words—

Priscilla: “It would be unacceptably reckless to even attempt to suppress the First of the Nine Divine Generals with the intent to tip the scales in a single swoop. I cannot comprehend how you would come up with a suitable *aidea*¹⁰, even if your head was not filled with foolish ruminations.”

Subaru: “Shut up! Don’t blame me for his lack of popularity! If the Emperor and the Generals aren’t popular, it’s no wonder a coup d’état was called!”

Abel: “How many times are you going to repeat this? Do not think that your disrespect shall be overlooked forever.”

¹⁰ Priscilla mispronounces the English word “idea”, denoted by it being written in Hiragana (あいであ) instead of Katakana (アイデア). To make this a tad more evident, the word is misspelled.

Receiving sharp glares from Priscilla and Abel respectively, Subaru stuck out his tongue at them.

However, it was true that his plan had been shattered with ease. If securing the Nine Divine Generals was equivalent to securing battle numbers, then securing those who were not popular possessed no merit whatsoever.

Subaru: "In fact, if they're not popular can we leave them alone...?"

Abel: "That is also a problem. That person has the ability to change the course of the war all by his lonesome, depending on the situation. Even if we are capable of securing all of the remaining Divine Generals, there is a good chance that he alone could take my head."

Subaru: "That's a hard guy to handle! He's an absurd hindrance, isn't he?!"

Rushing to secure him was not warranted, but he was too dangerous of a bomb to leave unattended.

It was only now, in a foreign land far away from home, that Subaru realized how much of a good asset Reinhard was, whose ability and humanity were guaranteed.

Perhaps if he were called out loud enough, he would rush to the neighboring country?

Priscilla: "Let me tell you something, foolish commoner. If you are contemplating summoning the Sword Saint, he cannot cross borders because of the non-aggression-pact. It would be wise not to get your hopes up."

Subaru: "Don't read people's minds. I'm not considering it for real... Relying on them only when I'm in trouble isn't the proper way to treat a friend."

If used for convenience, just because he could call upon him and have him rush to his side, it would not really be something he could call a friendship.

If the situation were to become really, really bad, he would not be able to say the same. However, till that moment arrived, Subaru was resolved to keep his morals intact.

Priscilla: "So? Foolish commoner being treated as Abel's military strategist, have you run out of inquiries?"

Subaru: “I haven’t run out of questions yet, and first of all I’m not a military strategist...”

Subaru replied, frowning as Priscilla took a dig at his position.

Then, just as he was about to move on to the next topic of the meeting—

???: “—Miss Natsumi and Village Chief-kun! Excuse me!”

At the same time a cheerful voice resounded, the door was opened, and a new person appeared in the conference hall with vigor.

The one who had arrived was Flop, a beautiful man clad in blue, his long golden hair swaying briskly.

Flop was supposed to be tending to the injured on the upper floor where the damage of Arakiya’s rampage remained. While becoming the focus of all eyes in the room, he looked at Subaru and Abel, and nodded, saying “There you are”.

Flop’s figure was stained all over with blood, accentuating the horror of the makeshift field hospital.

But the fact that he showed up here meant that—

Subaru: “Flop-san, how’s everyone’s treatment?”

Flop: “We just wrapped things up for now...! Hmm? From the looks of it, you’re in the mood for Husband-kun instead of Miss Natsumi? If so, I’ll revert to calling you Husband-kun.”

Subaru: “Well, either is fine. But, yeah, things are getting wrapped up...”

While receiving Flop’s rather oblique words of consideration, Subaru reflected with simultaneous relief and anxiety, upon hearing that the healing process had come to a close.

The relief was simply because of the fact that the aid of the injured had finished. The anxiety was more for the fact that he would hear of the results from the healing mission.

The goal of the “bloodless siege” had already failed.

Seven guards had fallen victim in Arakiya’s extraction. The only question now, was whether any of the wounded would join them.

Flop: “There have been no deaths, Husband-kun.”

Subaru: “Eh...”

Flop: “It was a tough situation for all of us, though. But I think it was thanks to the efforts of the Wife-san and the Niece-chan. The promptness of Miss Taritta and Miss Utakata as well. Of course, my sister and I had to work hard, too!”

Having read his inner feelings from Subaru’s complexion, Flop gave him the answer first.

Flop boasted about his contributions while pointing at himself, looking rather manly. The answer he had given was concise, so Subaru needed only the time of a heartbeat to digest the information.

However, after his understanding deepened a heartbeat later, a great big sigh escaped him.

Subaru: “No deaths... Hk.”

Flop: “Yeah, it’s a sign that everyone did their best to stay alive. As for me, if it weren’t for my sister protecting me, I would’ve hit my head and died! Hahaha, I’m no match for my sister!”

Subaru: “Yeah, yeah, that’s true. I’m no match for Medium-san either...”

Flop laughed vivaciously while in front of him, whereas Subaru cast his eyes downward and shook his shoulders.

Without exaggeration, without jesting, he was completely of the same opinion. If Medium—or anyone else for that matter, were not present there, this report would never have been heard.

There were lives that had been lost. But there were also lives that had not been lost.

The emotions that brought to his heart were great—

Abel: “—Merchant, what happened to that practitioner of the healing arts?”

Despite Subaru’s excitement, Abel forced himself into the conversation with an indifferent tone...

“Practitioner of the healing arts”, Subaru raised an eyebrow at the unfamiliar sound, and Flop put his finger to his lips. “Practitioner...”, he murmured as he gave it some consideration.

Flop: "Is that... You're talking about Husband-kun's Wife-san?"

Abel: "Who else is there? Did you believe there was anyone else in that place who could cast healing magic besides that girl?"

Flop: "No, I can't think of anyone else! Just..."

Abel: "Just?"

Flop: "I think you should try to say things in a way that makes people like you better, Village Chief-kun. Even when you call out to them, things'll go much more smoothly if you're conscious of being friendly!"

Abel raised one eyebrow in response to the incredibly direct cheerful protest in front of him.

The statement that Flop had made was a dignified one, but it was quite a harrowing statement to listen to from the bylines in frankness.

Naturally, to have Rem referred to in a way that reduced her to just her capabilities did not sit well with Subaru.

Al: "That impression does not sound very convincing after those disrespectful words from just now, bro."

Subaru: "Considering how far we've come, I got the right to say that much... Flop-san does too, then, right?"

Al: "Dunno, but I'm dying to hear about your adventures bro."

It was too turbulent a story to tell, but that was a topic to be delved into some other time.

Regardless of how Abel had put it, Rem's safety was Subaru's top priority. Of course, he had confirmed with his own eyes that she held no noticeable trauma.

Subaru: "Did she do anything like work too hard and collapse?"

Flop: "Don't worry about that, Husband-kun. Of course, all that hard work's taken its toll on her, but it's nothing that can't be remedied with some rest. It's really wonderful that you've got such a hardworking Wife-san."

Subaru: “I see...Well, that’s good.”

Stroking his chest in relief, Subaru was glad to hear Flop’s guarantee.

The situation was what it was. Even though he had to rely on Rem, he was frankly afraid that she would try too hard. What Subaru said mattered not; were it within her capabilities, Rem would not listen to him.

Al: “—Wife-san?”

Al muttered quietly beside Subaru, who had patted his chest in relief.

He put a hand to the chin of his steel helmet, and cocked his head, puzzled,

Al: “I don’t think I saw her up above, but did the girl from bro’s group come here too?”

Subaru: “The girl from my group... you mean Emilia-tan? No, she didn’t come here. How reassuring it would be to have her here... on the other hand, I don’t think I would want her to be here.”

Emilia’s gentle nature and the Vollachian Empire’s way of being were probably like water and oil.

Although there was also a chance that Emilia, who tended to be someone who acted before thinking, would find the Imperial approach more comfortable, the cruelty of the Empire itself went much further than that— Emilia was not suited for the Empire.

Al: “—A wife other than your girl, huh?”

Subaru: “...Just to tell you, we’re passing it off as a matter of convenience. To tell you the truth, she’s a girl I’ve decided to treat with that much care. I’ll bring her home, no matter what.”

Al: “———”

Subaru explained to Al, who mumbled in a low tone with his hand on his chin.

As long as they were also in the Empire, it was impossible for strange rumors to spread from Al’s mouth, but he did not want Al to get the wrong idea. He did not want his resolve to get rained on.

Priscilla: “That delicate-looking man, the one they call merchant... Are you one of Abel’s subordinates?”

Flop: “No, I’m not his subordinate. My sister and I are in a position of cooperating with Husband-kun and Village Chief-kun. Well, I guess it’s appropriate to call him my newest friend!”

Priscilla: “Oh, a friend, huh?”

Priscilla, exchanging words with Flop, loosened her lips at his answer. Hiding her loosened lips with her fan, Priscilla sent a meaningful look in Abel’s direction.

Priscilla: “I did not know you were hard at work making friends. It seems the throne of the Emperor of Vollachia has become such that it can easily be vacated.”

Abel: “Cease the sarcasm. I do not recall being friends with that man.”

Flop: “What are you talking about, Village Chief-kun? We’ve gone through the verge of death together in women’s clothing!”

Abel: “If you give death the slip alongside someone, you become friends immediately? If that is the case, then every single Imperial Soldier is my friend. And the one who has been on the verge of death closest to me, is my enemy.”

The perfect rebuttal making use of his own position made Flop hold his tongue upon receiving it.

However, it was a double-edged sword that did not leave Abel unscathed either.

Subaru: “Anyway, Flop-san brought us some good news. I’d like to talk about some more good news as well...”

Abel: “—Wait.”

Subaru: “...What is it?”

It was an optimistic subject in a not-so-positive meeting. Interrupting Subaru’s attempt to spur him on, Abel cocked his chin at Flop.

Subaru’s gaze was guided by that movement, and he also looked over at Flop.

Subaru: “Flop-san?”

Indeed, the reason why Abel pointed at him was because he had noticed the change in Flop's facial expression.

Flop had not lost his bright, cheerful expression, yet in his eyes, which had always carried a cheerfulness as dazzling as the sun, there was a faint hint of hesitation and melancholy.

Abel: "If you are a merchant, you should be careful about how you talk about things. In that respect, I do not believe you are cut out to be a merchant."

Flop: "I've received quite a few of those opinions, so I have some thoughts on that matter, but I'll leave it at that for now... Husband-kun, there was something I forgot to mention earlier."

Subaru: "-----"

Giving a sidelong glance towards Abel and his remark, Flop fluttered his eyelashes in melancholy, then directing his eyes at Subaru.

His well-groomed face, and the wistfulness in it, made Subaru's heart tighten. He could not help but think that he did not want to hear what Flop had to say, but he had no choice but to listen.

In that sense, Flop had a natural talent for making others listen to what he had to say. Were it not for this situation, Subaru would have praised him for his talent as a merchant. Despite that, however---

Flop: "It's not unrelated to Village Chief-kun, either. I want Miss Kuna and Miss Holly to come with us as well."

Now that he was unable to stop Flop from telling him, he hated it, as if it were a cursed talent.



???: "...Abel and Natsumi have come *too*, huh."

After being called by Flop, Subaru and the others left the conference hall and went to the upper floor of the City Hall.

In the space that looked like a field hospital, where the wounded had been gathered, the one who greeted Subaru and the others was Mizelda, who had cut off her scorched black hair.

The party that had stormed Guaral had been caught unprepared by Arakiya's surprise attack, yet Mizelda had been the one to receive the most grievous injuries, having been overwhelmed by the flames in the first instance, and then by the blows exchanged with Arakiya at the end.

After having had her whole body scorched and then swallowed by the tornado, Arakiya's blow clawed deep into her insides afterwards.

No matter how tough her body was, it was unmistakably a situation that tested Mizelda's vitality, as if to see how far she could go with Rem's healing arts, which could not be said to be at their best.

Mizelda: "I'm sorry to call you *here*. I just thought I needed to tell you as soon as *possible*."

Subaru: "Mizelda-san..."

Mizelda smiled thinly as she said this, having taken a seat on an object near the wall.

As one of the most powerful amazonesses, Mizelda's smile was devoid of the wild demeanor that she had displayed towards Subaru and the others on numerous occasions.

However, the willpower in her eyes was yet to be lost. It was unbalanced.

Mizelda: "First of all, thank *you*. Thanks to Rem, I'm *alive*. It's a *miracle*."

Subaru: "——"

Mizelda: "You took the city as *well*. As Shudraq's *Chieftain*, I'm impressed with your *work*. In *addition*, I must make a declaration for the future of this *war*."

Praising Rem's dedication and Subaru's contribution, Mizelda straightened her posture. And then——

Mizelda: "The position of Chieftain of the Shudraq will be given to my *sister*, Taritta. I can't fulfill my duties *anymore*."

She patted her right leg, which was missing from the knee down, and announced that her sister would take over the role.

Arc 7 Chapter 30 - Self-Proclaimed Hero Natsuki Subaru

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 2 “Self-Proclaimed Hero Natsuki Subaru”, Parts 3 (half-way)-5

Original Web Novel Chapter – [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Shukx, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) – [Complete](#)

Mizelda’s expression was resolute as she declared that she would give up her position as Chieftain.

The dominance of her wild, strong-eyed beauty had not diminished, and she was still exactly the same as when they had first seen her. Through thick and thin, the impression of her being a strong woman remained the same.

And with that notion still present, having lost her right leg, Mizelda had decided to step down from her position as Chieftain.

Everyone: “———”

The ones surrounding Mizelda, were the ones who harbored a deep sense of regret.

The People of Shudraq, those who had witnessed Mizelda’s, their Chieftain’s, strength from up close, would not be able to discard their bitterness and sense of loss that easily.

Kuna’s lack of expression was intensified by her usual coldness, next to Holly, whose usual relaxed state was replaced with a somber expression. A teary-eyed Uakata bit her lip and cast her head down, while all the remaining Shudraqians too, displayed gloomy expressions on their faces.

However, the one most shaken up amidst them all——

Taritta: “Oh, sister, it’s *impossible*. There’s no way someone like me could be a good *Chieftain*...”

Mizelda: “—Taritta.”

Taritta: “It’s because it’s you, sister, that you were able to do *it*! I don’t have the ability to do something like *that*...”

Shaking her head in disagreement, Taritta frantically pleaded.

That she, Mizelda’s younger sister, who had personally been nominated to be the next Chieftain, respected and practically worshipped her elder sister was easy to imagine, based off of every single one her daily words and actions.

For that reason precisely, Taritta was in denial, unable to accept the fact that Mizelda had lost her leg. She appeared even more upset than Mizelda herself was.

Rem: “...It’s because of my inadequacy.”

Taritta’s grief-stricken plea was met by a weak, self-condemning voice.

It came from the other end of the room littered with injured bodies, from Rem, who was in a state of exhaustion, making use of her cane to stand.

She was the sole existence at this place able to use healing magic. Making herself useful, Rem bustled left and right, going from person-to-person endeavoring to save many of the injured. One could only guess from her blood-stained clothes, disheveled hair, and fatigued expression how draining it had been.

Nevertheless, the person in question did not care, and even the appreciative words of Subaru at the beginning had been met with a simple “I’m fine” of dismissal.

Even so, no one had the right to condemn Rem for her lack of strength.

Without her, they would not have been able to attain a result devoid of fatalities from Arakiya’s attack. Everyone understood that much. Therefore—

Mizelda: “Rem, there’s no need for you to be *upset*. I was lucky to get out of the battle with the Imperial General having only lost one of my *legs*... No, it’s because I had your *help*.”

Rem: “Mizelda-san... that may be true, but—”

Mizelda: "I'm grateful to *you*. I have nothing more to *say*."

Rem was blocked from speaking any further, as Mizelda repeated her gratitude.

Louis, her long blonde hair in disarray, snuggled up beside the silent Rem. As the former gently picked at the hem of the latter's dress, Rem quietly lowered her gaze, placing her hand on Louis's shoulder.

The remorse and helplessness that Rem was feeling was painfully obvious to Subaru. But the dark-haired handsome man stepped forward faster than Subaru could say anything.

Abel: "Mizelda, you have no intention to change your mind, do you?"

Abel's question as he stepped forward was met with a nod from Mizelda, who sat on an object.

As she felt the surface of her amputated, bandaged leg with her fingers, she said,

Mizelda: "Ah, I have no intention *to*. The pact between the Shudraq and Emperor of Vollachia will be *kept*. From here on out *though*, you should ask Taritta... or *rather*, the *Chieftain*."

Abel: "—I understand. Mizelda, you have done a great service."

Mizelda: "*Mh*."

Mizelda had hardened her resolve to resign, and Abel showed his understanding to her answer while folding his arms. With that, Mizelda let out a small breath and showed a wide grin.

With a faint smile, she glanced upward at Abel.

Mizelda: "If it's going to be that *way*, show me your *smile*. It's the duty of a good-looking *man*."

Abel: "—Hmm."

Mizelda: "Good *enough*."

Despite losing her leg only recently, Mizelda was still much too fierce.

Even Abel, arrogant as he was, did not criticize her for her disrespect, and even smiled at her attitude.

Above all, this was proof that the Emperor, whose throne had been usurped, displayed his respect towards the female warrior who lived in the jungle.

And then—

Mizelda: “—Listen *up*, my *brethren*!”

Mizelda’s smiling face hardened, as she raised her head to speak in a loud voice.

Hearing the fierce sound of her voice, the Shudraq all straightened their posture as to listen carefully.

Mizelda: “As I told you *earlier*, I am fulfilling my duty as *Chieftain*! I now hand over the role of Chieftain to my *sister*, Taritta! *Everyone*, obey Taritta from now *on*!”

Shudraqians: “———”

Mizelda: “This is my last command as *Chieftain*— Thank you for your ancestral vows and ancestral *pride*.”

Shudraqians: “—Thank *you*!”

Mizelda concluded, and the Shudraqians seemed to be reciting something.

He knew not of their customs or longstanding practices. But even Subaru, an outsider and a layman, could sense that it was a ritual of succession.

It was short, informal, and a combination of practical and conceptual inheritance.

In this place, the position of Chieftain of the People of Shudraq had been inherited, going from Mizelda to Taritta.

Taritta: “*Sister...*”

Mizelda: “Don’t lower your *head*, *Chieftain*. Your hesitation is our *hesitation*. Your faltering is our *faltering*. Your death leads to our *death*.”

Taritta: “———”



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Approaching her, Mizelda encouraged the new Chieftain, Taritta, the latter's expression was murky.

That would not make Taritta feel any better at once. However, Taritta must have realized that clinging onto her would not change the situation.

After a few moments of silence, Taritta nodded timidly, and silently.

Mizelda: "———"

The complex emotions that flitted in Mizelda's eyes as she saw this, were something that went unnoticed by Taritta as she lowered her head— And it was something that no one but her would mention.



Subaru: "...To be honest, that was unexpected."

With the Chieftain's succession spiel and the damage report concluded, Subaru called out to Abel.

Abel furrowed his brow at being stopped without receiving a concrete subject. Showing displeasure, he then inquired about Subaru's true intention with a "What was?",

Abel: "I have much to ponder. You, of all people, should not be bothering me."

Subaru: "You sure are harsh like always... It's just that I was surprised. You accepted Mizelda-san leaving the frontlines so readily."

Abel: "———"

Subaru: "I thought you'd say that all she lost was one leg for sure. I thought you were going to tell her to work herself to death for you."

Even though he thought it far too extreme, Subaru declared his honest feelings to Abel.

This was the Emperor who had appended the People of Shudraq to his troops for the sake of reclaiming the throne, and someone who had considered polluting the Fortress City of Guaral with poison, if worst came to worst.

Abel— no, Vincent Vollachia, was very much willing to do such things.

Abel: “Nonsense. What in the world would be the meaning of being so forceful?”

However, Abel’s response to Subaru, who had been prepared to hurl words of abuse and his true opinion, was calm and sober.

In front of the disappointed Subaru, Abel looked at the Shudraquians conversing in the distance.

Abel: “Well, I do not wish that my subordinates do any more than they are capable of. Even if I order them to do their utmost, it would be delusional to expect them to go any further than their limits.”

Subaru: “———”

Abel: “If they overperform in comparison to what they had been evaluated as being capable of, the plan shall be thrown into disarray. I simply request nothing more and nothing less than what I demand from my men. And Mizelda has fulfilled her duty. In that case, the only thing I can present her with, is a reward.”

With words, motivate them. With rewards, get them to exceed their abilities. With praise, make them promise to improve next time.

Subaru had always thought, with absolute certainty, that this was how powerful people subjugated their subordinates. Therefore, Abel’s reply was in direct contradiction to what Subaru had in mind.

He would not request labors beyond the capabilities of his subordinates.

It seemed like a good environment for subordinates to work in, albeit simultaneously a lonely one as well.

Abel: “Goes without saying that endeavoring less than what is expected shall be met with punishment. Definite punishment or reward, you do comprehend what it signifies, right?”

Subaru: “...Then, does that mean I’m going to be punished?”

Abel: “If you were my subordinate, that would be correct. But are you my subordinate?”

Staring straight ahead, Subaru's eyes widened at Abel's words.

Of course, Subaru did not recall ever becoming Abel's subordinate. In his discussion with Priscilla, Abel had treated Subaru as a military strategist, but he did not have any intention of formally becoming one.

Subaru: "It's not that I'm not attracted to the title of military strategist, but I don't wish to be something like your subordinate."

Abel: "And so that is how it is. You are not my subordinate, and therefore, you do not fall under the category of receiving definite punishment nor reward."

Subaru: "Thinking about it, just what are you to me...?"

Because of their situation, they were forced to accompany each other. They did not have the relationship of a master and a servant in the first place, nor any kind of personal one.

They were two people caught in a flow of obstacles, and once these obstacles were cleared, their paths would separate. That was the type of relationship they had.

Calling them friends, or allies, or comrades, would just be untrue. If there was something they could be classified as, it would be crossdressing companions.

Abel: "Some have taken the liberty of calling me a friend, but you have not."

Subaru: "Ah. I'm a shy guy, so I can't become your friend that easily."

Given the current situation, the person who may have been able to call him a friend here would either be a very good person or a fraud, and Flop would be the former. Anyhow—

Abel: "I shall resume my conversation with Priscilla. Go do whatever else you need to do."

Subaru: "What I need to do..."

Abel: "It should not be required of me to tell you that."

Being dived by those almond-shaped eyes, Subaru's gaze left Abel and headed towards the corner of the room.

There, he found the figure of Rem sitting on the floor. He could not make out her downcast expression from a distance, but there was no doubt that leaving her alone would not do.

He was somewhat annoyed that Abel had told him to do it first, though.

Subaru: "I don't want you to get in trouble with Priscilla and start another fight. Just be careful with how you talk to her."

Abel: "I am certain many would advise that you, not I, should be the one to receive those words."

Hateful words were riposted with further hateful words, and Subaru parted ways with Abel, who returned to the conference hall.

Mizelda's leg would change the situation of the People of Shudraq, so it would be necessary to take that into account when engaging in discussions with Priscilla.

However, there was little room for Subaru in the conversation between the celestial beings, Abel and Priscilla.

The priority for Subaru was to speak to the only person he could.

Subaru: "—Rem, is now a good time?"

He lightly took a deep breath and calmed himself down, before heading over, towards Rem.

Sitting with her knees folded and her back against the wall, Rem slightly stirred at Subaru's words, his figure faintly reflected on her pale-blue eyes.

Rem: "...Is that you? When are you going to change your clothes?"

Subaru: "Rem has priority over changing clothes. As soon as this conversation ends, I will change my clothes."

Rem: "Is that so? Well then, this conversation has ended. Please go change your clothes."

Subaru: "That's so crude!"

Subaru was left helpless and raised his voice after Rem's blunt retort. At Subaru's voice, Rem's eyes sharpened and she said, "Please be quiet".

Then she jerked her chin toward the girl leaning on her left shoulder.

Rem: "At this rate, you'll wake up the sleeping Louis-chan. Please consider her."

Subaru: "Well, I..."

Rem: "Or is it just that you do not want to put that much consideration into this girl?"

Subaru: "Don't say it like that. My bad..."

Taking tiny breaths while sleeping, Louis cuddled closer with Rem.

Louis had been helping Rem to treat the wounded; her white clothes were stained with blood here and there. From what he had learned from Rem's attitude and from Utakata, she had done exactly as she had been told, albeit poorly.

Naturally, Subaru's inner thoughts were mixed, though.

Rem: "It throws me off when you make a grim face in that appearance."

Subaru: "Oh, yeah, my bad. My makeup's messed up, it's rather unsightly."

Rem: "It looked unsightly even when you had it on properly."

Subaru: "Tohoho..."

Subaru's shoulders slumped in depression at Rem's remark, which was as harsh as ever. Subaru then slowly sat side-by-side with Rem, at her right, opposite of Louis.

He peeked at Rem's protesting gaze, but consciously ignored it.

Subaru: "Rem, you did great. Everyone survived thanks to you."

Rem: "...I'm keenly aware of my lack of power. To tell you the truth, I'm useless."

Subaru: “Rem...”

In response to the words of gratitude, Rem looked down at her hands in frustration. As she regarded those pale fingers, Rem was biting her lip weakly.

Subaru: “You’re definitely not useless. Even though your memories are fuzzy, you were able to use your healing magic splendidly and saved a lot of people. But...”

Rem: “I know. If I were whole, this magic wouldn’t have been like this.”

Subaru: “Like this?”

Rem: “My healing magic. The magic I’m using right now is by intuition, in other words, self-taught. Though with Louis-chan’s assistance, I’ve managed to get it into shape. Even then...”

Rem’s words did not continue beyond that point.

The reason why she did not continue after that, was because it was something that went without saying. She knew that, if she put it into words, it would become a blade that she would hurt herself with, and that the pain would console her, albeit slightly.

Complaints, when spoken, would hurt oneself and others. In compensation however, it would lighten one’s heart merely a little bit. And Rem disliked the idea of lightening her heart.

It was proof that she truly blamed herself for her inability to save others, because of her lack of power.

Subaru: “———”

Once again, Subaru painfully understood Rem’s feelings.

To rue that one could have done more, was more painful than an unreachable wall. It would be even worse when it regarded someone else’s future, someone other than one’s own.

——The loss of Mizelda’s leg had left something weighty in the recesses of Subaru’s heart.

It was not a life. But it was not hard to imagine the magnitude of losing one of your four limbs.

The closest example was certainly Al, a one-armed man who had lost his left arm. Additionally, there was the Watergate City of Pristella; during that battle, Ricardo had lost one of his arms in a confrontation against Gluttony.

It had been an extremely shocking event, but it was not a tragedy so remote that it could not happen. In fact, for those who put themselves in harm's way, it may be more appropriate to call it a familiar tragedy. Still—

Subaru: "That's harsh."

Rem: "...Yes."

Subaru's parched murmur was met with a small nod from Rem right beside him.

This was the first time he had ever gotten a straightforward nod without repercussions, yet he was unfortunately not in the right frame of mind to appreciate it. Rem glanced at Subaru, the latter holding a lump deep in his chest.

Rem: "The previous... If it were the previous me, I wonder how it would've gone..."

Subaru: "...If it was the you when you still had memories?"

Rem: "Yes. If it was the past me's healing magic, Mizelda-san's leg could've been..."

"Could've been saved", Subaru closed his eyes at the words that would have followed.

It was not that he could not comprehend what Rem was thinking. But it was difficult for Subaru, being on the outside, to judge the extent to which the presence or absence of memory had affected Rem's healing magic.

Even if it were possible to quantify the healing power, it would be difficult for Subaru to assess it. However—

Rem: "——"

Rem, her pale-blue eyes filled with earnest emotion, were directed at Subaru.

If the answer she was looking for was something that Subaru could provide he did not know, but there were only two choices in front of him: “The previous Rem could” or “The previous Rem couldn’t”.

Which of the two would turn out to be the salvation for Rem?

—Or rather, which of the two would save Rem from being hurt even more?

Subaru: “...Even with your memories, I think it would be helpless.”

Rem: “———”

Subaru: “Even healing magic isn’t all-powerful. In that case, Rem would have done the best she could.”

He replied after a few seconds of agonizing thought, which felt much longer in Subaru’s mind.

Even if Rem had her memories, even if her healing magic had been in perfect condition, she would not have been able to save Mizelda’s leg.

The truth was that it was not about “ifs”.

If they started talking about “ifs”, there would be no end to it. It was true that Rem had not been able to salvage Mizelda’s leg. But beyond Mizelda, she had saved the lives of many other injured people.

She should be praised for her achievements, and there was no reason for her to blame herself.

In fact, if someone should be blamed, it should be——

Subaru: “I wasn’t strong enough.”

Rem: “Eh...”

Subaru: “I didn’t think enough. I should’ve examined things more seriously.”

Upon hearing this answer spat out by Subaru, Rem’s round eyes went wide.

In front of Rem, Subaru clenched his molars with force, and covered his face with both of his hands.

If anyone were to curse the lack of strength, the blame should fall on Subaru.

Subaru: “All of it. It’s my fault.”

Despite the pompous claims of a “bloodless siege”, reality was far from such results.

Arakiya’s intrusion had caused many injuries, and her recovery had brought death to multiple guards. There had been no casualties within their own ranks, but taking into account Mizelda’s missing leg, how could it be called “bloodless”?

He had failed. It was a pile of failures, and the chance for recovery had been lost.

All he wanted was the best possible happy ending, and what Subaru had obtained was either a so-so happy ending or what should be called a so-so bad ending.

To paraphrase Abel’s words from earlier, definite punishment or reward— castigation ought to follow.

Had Subaru been one of Abel’s men, it would not be strange for him to have his head chopped off.

—Worst-case scenario, he would have to Return by Death.

Thoughts like these crossed his mind.

In that case, he would most likely go back to the most recent point of return, to the time of the bloody battle against Todd in Guaral— The fear caused by the recollection of that time made his entire body tremble.

Still, even if he returned to that moment of terror, if he could recover what they had lost—

Rem: “...Why?”

Suddenly, that word struck the brooding Subaru’s eardrums.

Raising his face immediately, he was met head-on by Rem’s eyes staring right toward him.

Rem’s eyes, which had been moist with remorse until just before, were now staring straight at Subaru, holding even stronger remorse within.

Rem: “Why did it turn into your fault?”

Agitated by Rem's gaze, more words were piled up upon Subaru, rendered unable to move.

She extended her hand, her eyes damp, and while indicating the devastated City Hall she said,

Rem: "So Mizelda-san's leg, Louis-chan's and Uakata-chan's injuries, Medium-san's and Flop-san's wounds, all of it is your fault?"

Subaru: "They are, yes. It wouldn't have turned out like this if I'd been more careful about my preparations."

Rem: "You thought of a plan, and your seemingly reckless plan had a proper pay off. You were able to hold the General Second-Class in place, and get them into the city without letting anyone fight. Just like we planned."

Subaru: "But then after that..."

Rem: "—Who cares about what happened after!?"

At Subaru's persistence, Rem raised her eyebrows and made her voice louder. Rem quickly turned her face, and because of this, Louis, who was leaning against her, fell into her lap.

Louis jerked slightly and groaned softly, without waking up. While supporting Louis's shoulder, Rem puffed slightly and looked at Subaru again.

Rem: "No one could've foreseen what would happen after that. The appearance of that half-naked woman and her rampage were all unpredictable. So..."

Subaru: "——"

Rem: "So why are you responsible for all of that?"

Subaru gulped as the question of "why" was once again asked toward him.

If one were to ask him why, he would think it was the responsibility of one that had power.

In the same way that Rem lamented the lack of power in her own healing magic, Subaru sometimes regretted and lamented the fact that his own Authority could not make up for it. The scope of Return by Death was greater.

The future could improve or worsen, depending on whether Subaru exercised his power. However---

Subaru: "It's..."

---It was a truth that could not be told to another, even if the person was Rem.

It was not restricted to merely Rem.

The Authority Subaru wielded, this alone he could not propagate to anyone, no matter how open-minded the other party was--- No, he was unable to speak of it even to someone with whom he'd established an emotional bond.

If he told them, there was no way he could disclose the truth without possibly causing the death of that person.

He was afraid of pain. The pain brought about from trying to tell someone about Return by Death was terrifying.

Who could get used to that intense pain that gripped one's heart no matter how many times they experienced it?

But what was truly frightening was not the pain, but the loss.

Was there anything in this world that was more terrifying than loss?

Was it not because of this extreme fear precisely, that this Authority had been granted to Natsuki Subaru?

Rem: "...Why did you protect me?"

Subaru: "Huh...?"

Rem continued to speak as if she had given up on Subaru, the latter silent and unable to answer.

For a moment, Subaru blinked, unsure of what she was talking about.

Rem: “When that half-naked woman attacked me. I knocked down a pillar, and when that didn’t work... That woman came at me, and you stood in front of me.”

In a selfless attempt to save her from being attacked by Arakiya, Subaru had stood in front of Rem.

His hands outstretched, he had been desperate to keep any threat away from Rem. At that moment, Subaru did not care if Arakiya were to take his life.

He wanted Rem to outlive him, for even a second longer. That was—

Rem: “The result of your bloodless siege, the fact that you covered for me at that moment, and even the fact that Mizelda-san lost her leg, you’re trying to take on everything on your own...”

Subaru: “———”

Rem: “You’re not strong enough to do all those things... At first, I was wary of you because of that horrible smell.”

That was where Rem broke off her words, and once she did, she looked down at Louis on her lap.

Gently stroking her golden hair, Rem choked and calmly turned her gaze back to Subaru, saying

Rem: “I, Louis-chan, Abel-san, Mizelda-san and the others, Medium-san and Flop-san are all human beings with a will, and you don’t have to get worked up to protect them.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Rem: “Please don’t try to do anything like that all by yourself. You don’t have to take responsibility for our actions.”

Subaru’s mouth opened and closed repeatedly, overwhelmed by the shower of words.

His brain refused to comprehend what was being said, in a prompt fashion. However, an unidentified sense of urgency scorched Subaru’s heart, forcing him to listen no further.

With earnest emotion, directed at a Subaru cursing his own lack of power, Rem bit back.

He had to stop her from saying anything beyond that—

Rem: “You aren’t a special person—”

He knew he should not have allowed her to say it.

Rem: “—Because, you’re not a hero.”



Staggering, Subaru walked through the City Hall as if wandering.

He had no destination in mind. It was not even clear when he had started walking, to begin with. When he had come to, he was walking, and if anything, his consciousness still remained in a state of vagueness.

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Suddenly, he was hit head-on by a hard impact.

Taking a look at it, it seemed that he had hit a wall. He was walking while only staring at his feet, that was the reason. Slamming his forehead against the bare wall, Subaru held his aching forehead and exhaled.

Then, without thinking, he slammed his forehead against the solid wall again.

A firm impact and a dull sound, and Subaru felt a stinging pain in his brain.

As he shook his brain from the outside, he felt as if the stagnation that permeated his whole body was slowly receding.

In the same manner, Subaru slammed his forehead against the wall again and again.

Slam, slam, slam—

???: “Hey, hey, stop that, bro.”

As he pulled back to strike again, his shoulder was grabbed from behind. He had been called out.

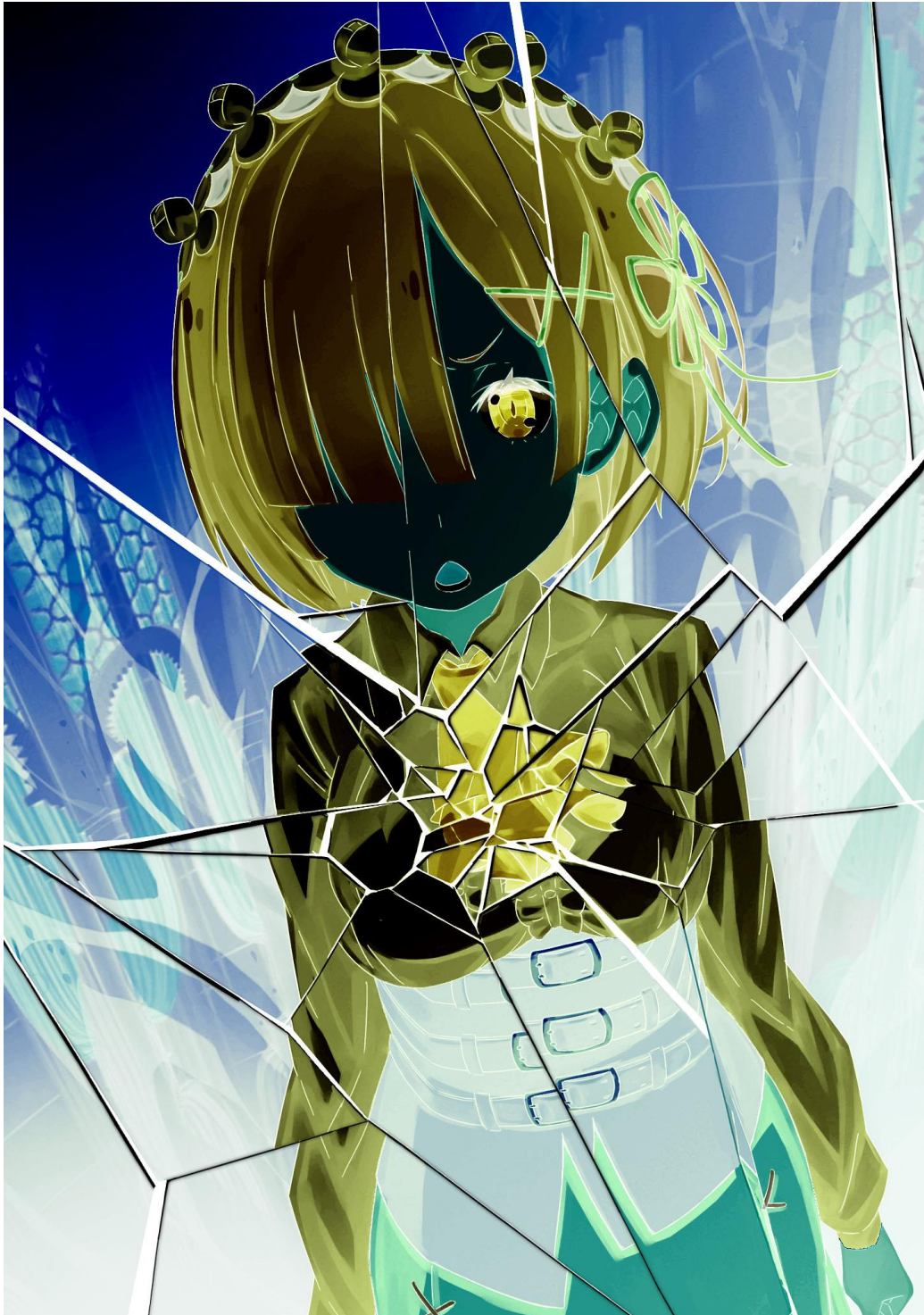


Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

What came into view when Subaru turned around, was a gaze that met his own from behind a steel helmet directed his way. Still grasping Subaru by the shoulder, the other party cracked the bones in his own neck and spoke,

Al: "I understand the feeling of wanting to die. But no matter how many times you do that, there's gonna be no end to that sorta thing."

Arc 7 Chapter 31 - A Talk Between Compatriots

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 3 “The Path Onwards”, Part 1

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Shukx, Translation checked by [Ice/Ice_Occultism](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

Subaru’s eyes widened as a strong arm grabbed him by the shoulders, making him turn around.

The iron helmet staring his way— Or rather, Al’s attitude, was rather unexpected.

Subaru: “———”

Ignoring the force of the arm that had seized his shoulder was somewhat difficult. His intent to halt Subaru from banging his head against the wall and harming himself could be keenly felt.

Al: “You should stop that.”

Subaru: “...Ah.”

Their gazes met, and a breath escaped as the words of restraint were repeated.

Immediately, Subaru felt a pang of shame well up from the bottom of his stomach, as if he had been blamed for his eccentric behavior. It was as if he were a character in a game being made to run against a wall.

Looked like it was exactly like that, including the part where he had not thought anything about it.

Al: “Don’t come crying to me if you end up an idiot after doing that. No, rather, it’s because I couldn’t leave you like that, that I came to stop you.”

Subaru: “...Sorry for the inconvenience.”

Al: “Why so formal? Also, your voice is so raspy it’s scaring me.”

With Al pointing out that Subaru’s voice was surprisingly hoarse, he once again ridiculed himself.

The one who had suffered from a complete mental breakdown and the one whose shameful behavior had forced him into this broken state of mind, was none other than himself.

It was natural. After all, it was none other than Rem who had told Subaru—

Al: “—Was it so painful for you to hear what that girl said?”

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Al: “Oh, scary! Don’t look at me like that. I’m gonna get nervous if you keep staring at me looking like that.”

Subaru looked up as if he had been hit by a bullet, meanwhile Al shrugged his shoulders as if jesting.

His glare had caused Al to step back, but Subaru closed the distance between them, and directly tackled Al’s earlier statement.

Subaru: “You, were you listening...!”

Al: “I wasn’t trying to eavesdrop, y’know. You just happened to be in the middle of an important conversation when I went to call you, bro. I just thought it’d be wrong to interrupt.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “Even if you look at me with those distrustful eyes, I ain’t lying. Well, after that, bro, you started walking like it was the end of the world, so I got worried and followed you. And sure enough...”

As he said this, Al pointed to the front part of his helmet.

And as he had expected, his fears were right on the mark. It was not like Al was paying particularly close attention, but it was more that Subaru’s desperation was clear as day.

The pain from his forehead, which he had been hitting right at the spot Al had pointed at, came back, causing Subaru to cast his eyes downward awkwardly.

Subaru: "...Rem."

Al: "Hmm?"

Subaru: "That's right, what happened with Rem? I mean, after she talked to me..."

Al: "Whoa, whoa, don't tell me the *shingai*¹¹ you got because of what that girl said made you lose your memories? Please gimme a break. If you get amnesia, bro, I'll lose my only buddy."

Al answered Subaru's question while fiddling with the metal clasp of his helmet with his hand around his head.

Unfortunately, what Al had feared would happen had already come to pass. That said, for Subaru it was something equally grave compared to amnesia, so it was inevitable that his mental balance would be disturbed.

Perhaps seeing Subaru's anxiety in his expression, Al prefaced with "Don't worry about it",

Al: "Even after you turned pale, you were still giving decent answers, bro. So I think the girl didn't suspect anything, yeah?"

Subaru: "Ah, I see..."

After receiving Al's guarantee, Subaru felt the faintest of the faintest senses of relief.

Apparently, Subaru's disgraceful behavior had started only after he had left Rem's presence. If he managed to keep up appearances around Rem, he would not have worried her. In any case—

Subaru: "Al, about what you just said... What did you mean?"

Al: "Just said?"

Subaru: "...About understanding my feeling of wanting to die, or something."

¹¹ English flip. Means "terror/shock" (震駭), originally "ショック" (shock).

With his hand on his aching forehead, Subaru asked the truth behind Al's words.

Al: *"I understand the feeling of wanting to die. But no matter how many times you do that, there's gonna be no end to that sorta thing."*

The statement that he understood the feeling of wanting to die, and that there was no end to it, no matter what one did.

To be honest, he thought that it was not an expression that would bother him much. But at the same time, it was an expression too meaningful to be telling Subaru in this situation.

Rather, that statement seemed as if Al also wished to make Subaru believe that he perhaps knew about Subaru's peculiarity, his Authority.

Al: "—Oh, that."

Subaru: "Yeah, that. It was... It was a very meaningful thing to say. You..."

—*You know something about it, right?*

Subaru sent Al a gaze shrouded with suspicion. Even if he strained his eyes, he was unable to peer into the eyes and the emotions hidden behind the cold steel helmet.

And with that, his expression and eyes hidden, Al snorted and spoke,

Al: "I don't wanna say this, but I've been getting along in years, right? I've been in the same kind of mess as you, bro— I've even acted lame in front of a pretty girl."

Subaru: "Ah...?"

Al: "What's with that «ah»? Stuff like making a big fool of yourself and then wanting to die's a road any man has walked. If you ask me, even at my age, I do it quite often. When I do it, the Princess looks at me like I'm a bug."

With a chuckle, Al patted Subaru on the shoulder and gave him a lesson typical of a senior.

Taking in that content and his demeanor, Subaru stared back at Al, trying to determine if he was being deceptive or serious.

Al: "Hmm? What's up, bro?"

Subaru: "...No, it's nothing."

However, even if Subaru attempted to uncover Al's true intentions, he would be incapable of doing so, as his view was obstructed by black iron.

Till this moment, he had always dismissed Al's outfit as nothing more than one of his eccentricities. But when confronting him, attempting to ascertain his true intentions, he became aware that it was a protection much more potent than expected.

But, at the same time, he also reflected on getting too nervous.

Subaru: "There's no way he knows, huh..."

It was just a coincidence that Al's comment had caught Subaru's attention.

If Al knew about Return by Death, he would have tried to show it to Subaru in a way that was easier to understand— The very existence of that Authority, of Return by Death, was a perilous affair.

Were he to be aware of it, he would not keep himself from alluding to it, much like Roswaal. Simultaneously—

Subaru: "—I guess not everyone who gets summoned to another world gets some kind of power."

He was not in the know regarding the details of Al's situation, but he thought it safe to assume this.

Because, if Al possessed some kind of special power dwelling inside him, it seemed to him— that the loss of his left arm could have been prevented.

For example, if Subaru were to lose one of his arms in similar fashion, then he could utilize his Authority to prevent the loss of his left arm before it happened, by—

Subaru: "...Returning?"

With that thought in mind, Subaru stared at his left arm intently.

It was merely hypothetical, but very possible. In the first place, the only reason Subaru had been able to survive with all his body parts intact so far, was because he had been able to make full use of Return by Death.

Many times, among the loops in which he had been robbed of his life, he had suffered the loss of an arm or a leg.

Had he been able to survive without Return by Death, he would have been plenty able to live with missing body parts.

—Subaru had decided that he would never fully rely on Return By Death.

But then, to what extent should he rely on it?

How many of his arms, legs, fingers, and eyes would he have to forfeit before he decided to rely on it? Above all, what if it was not his own limbs, but those of Emilia or Rem?

In the Watergate City of Pristella, Subaru had not Returned by Death for the sake of Ricardo's lost arm. Today as well, he had not Returned by Death because Mizelda had lost her leg.

Even though he knew that, via the use of his Authority, he might have been able to procure better results.

Even though he was aware that the number of those who had lost arms or legs, with the paths they had taken so far cut off, could be reduced.

Subaru: "I'm..."

Al: "——"

Subaru: "I'm a hypocrite."

Conscious that the Authority he had been bestowed with was a mighty one, he was unable to take a decisive step.

Natsuki Subaru was far too impotent and selfish. Therefore——

Subaru: “Rem too... Zuah?!”

Al: “You’re in a bad *junkan*¹², bro.”

He had ended up allowing Rem to speak those decisive words.

Right before he was about to fall into depression, Subaru’s forehead was struck by a powerful finger flick. The strong pain brought tears to eyes, and while uttering “Wha, wha...”, he looked at Al.

Al: “Oh, that made a pretty good sound. Wait, did I hit you right where you slammed your forehead? Sorry, sorry, I didn’t mean to.”

Subaru: “It’s fine... Not, what the hell was that!”

Al: “That was a finger flick. So, the questioning power shifts to me, and I’ll ask the questions now.”

Al pointed the flicked finger at Subaru, whose surprise overrode the pain. Upon having that finger thrust at his nose, Subaru involuntarily backed away and kept his mouth shut.

Then, Al continued with a “Listen”,

Al: “How unsettled are you by that girl’s words? It’s a shame, just because she told you something. Don’t you think so yourself?”

Subaru: “Well, I...”

Al: “I don’t want you to get woozy over something like that. I’m embarrassed to say this, but... I got expectations for you, bro.”

Subaru: “—Expectations?”

Subaru was simply surprised to be given a talk that he had never expected.

Seeing Subaru’s reaction, Al gave a deep nod, and said, “Yes, that’s right”,

¹² English flip. Means “cycle/loop” (循環), originally “ループ” (loop).

Al: “You remember that speech you gave at Pristella, right bro?”

Subaru: “Oh, yeah, I do, but ...”

Al: “I’m pretty sure that, back then, I told you that that broadcast would mean that you’d have to carry «heroic reveries», bro.”

It had been a tense situation, with the city being assaulted by the Sin Archbishops, and many people in dire straits.

Subaru recalled the words Al had given him upon being requested to play a role in that situation, yet been unable to take the next step. Those were the “heroic reveries”.

He was an existence burdened with the expectations and hopes of many people. He could not be allowed to lose.

He was carrying the “reverie” of being the “hero” everyone wished for there to be.

And at that time, Subaru responded way too relaxedly.

—It was the same as it had always been.

Al: “It’s the same here. One person denies you, so what? It’s not like it’s going to change what you’ve done, bro, or turn your resolve inside out.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “Don’t break, bro. Go get ‘em, bro— Live up to expectations, bro.”

Al, who knew about Subaru’s achievements in the Watergate City, patted him on the back.

Neither Rem, who had forgotten everything, nor Louis, who had regressed to an infant, and obviously, neither Abel, Flop, Medium, nor the People of Shudraq, were cognizant of Subaru’s achievement.

Priscilla also knew, but he doubted she would remember about it in the first place.

Al: “I haven’t forgotten. And I’m sorry, I’m not letting go of it, bro.”

Subaru: “Not letting go of it, you say...”

Al: “You’ve started it. I’m telling you, that’s a reputation you gotta keep up until you die.”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru’s breath was taken away yet again, due to Al’s critical words.

He knew that the broadcast in the Watergate City had spread not only to the people in that city, nearly consumed by anxiety and fear, but also to the rest of the world.

He had to maintain that reputation until he died.

And unfortunately, Death would never come to Subaru.

Therefore, he had no choice but to keep fighting.

Subaru: “...Forever.”

At Al’s words, a voice leaked out of Subaru’s mouth as he covered his face with both hands, and shut his eyes.

Echoing in his head this whole time were the deadly words spoken by Rem. Those devastating words had shredded Subaru’s heart to bits, making him drown in his own stream of blood.

Rem: “—Because, you’re not a hero.”

Subaru: “I’ve been relying on a single thing Rem said, all this time.”

Rem: “—Because, you’re not a hero.”

Subaru: “Rem believed in me, and that’s why I didn’t falter. It was the same in Sanctuary, in Pristella, in Pleiades Watchtower...”

Rem: “—Because, you’re not a hero.”

Subaru: “Rem woke up without her memory, but I was still happy... I’m one step closer to getting it all back, and this is the time when I need to hold on the hardest.”

Rem: “—Because, you’re not a hero.”

Subaru: “Those were the magic words that roused my spirit.”

He was a hero, Rem had told him so.

They had stopped Subaru from giving up on everything and running away; they had not allowed his knees to buckle because Rem had fallen into slumber; they had let him challenge the obstruction of the Sanctuary and the difficult problems at the mansion; they had played a role in his efforts to save the Watergate City of Pristella that had fallen into enemy hands; and they had rocked the soul of a Natsuki Subaru that had lost his Memories, and enabled him to conquer the Pleiades Watchtower.

They were—

Rem: “Because Subaru-kun is Rem’s hero.”

Because of those words, because of that trust and support, he had been capable of making it to this day.

To take those away, for Natsuki Subaru, that meant—

Al: “Then, you just gotta get them back.”

Subaru: “—Huh?”

With his face covered, Subaru was in the midst of drowning in a darkness too deep to be called the back of his eyelids when he gasped due to Al’s statement, raising his face.

Right in front of him, was Al’s face, causing him to take a step backwards. However, Al was the one to move forward this time, in a mirrored image of the previous scene.

Subaru’s back immediately made contact with the wall. He could not move back any further. As if to push Subaru, unable to retreat, Al extended his arm and blocked his escape. And then—

Al: “We’re gonna get them back. Both that girl’s expectations and your confidence, bro.”

Subaru: “Expectations and confidence...”



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Floating ([source](#))

Al: “You gotta maintain your reputation. You gotta fight. And if you can’t afford to keep losing, then you got no choice but to keep on winning just like you wish. That’s how we’re going to win and get them back.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “The expectations and reputation you lost can only be regained with better results. That’s something you too should know, because you’ve experienced it many times.”

Suddenly he brought his face closer and the cold iron helmet hit his forehead.

However, Al appealed to Subaru so strongly and sincerely that the latter did not even notice that their foreheads were touching. This had bore a great impact on Subaru. Most importantly, Al seemed to have a point or two.

Lost expectations and reputation— the most bitter of Subaru’s memories was, of course, his blunder at the Royal Castle.

At that time, Subaru had lost Emilia’s trust and expectations, and his valuation amidst the Royal Candidates dropped. The reason why he had been able to regain their trust afterwards were his actions.

For sure, not because he was banging his forehead against a wall in utter devastation.

Subaru: “...Am I an idiot? No, I am definitely an idiot.”

Wasn’t it like though nothing had changed from when he made that blunder at the Royal Castle?

At that time as well, Subaru had attempted to disregard a massive hole, by pretense of asking Wilhelm to train him, in order to escape from the immense pain in front of him.

But now, Subaru could not afford to be so weak.

He had to protect Rem and bring her home. In contrast to that time, there was no one else he could turn to for that purpose— For Rem, there was only Subaru.

And in order to reassure Rem, surrounded by anxiety and gone without memories, he could not display even a little bit of a pathetic appearance in front of her any longer.

Even if Rem, who had forgotten everything, had stated that Subaru was not a hero.

Even if the words that had so strongly supported Subaru's back were retracted by that same face and voice.

Subaru: "—I'm Rem's hero."

Yes, wasn't Natsuki Subaru's true nature to keep his head up?

Al: "...Got a tad of your energy back?"

Hearing Subaru's determination, the harshness vanished from Al's voice. Replying to his words with a "Yeah", Subaru directed his eyes towards Al from up-close, and,

Subaru: "It's gotten much better. But back off, move away! What the hell's up with this *kabe-don*¹³?"

Al: "Right! Bro's crossdressing, and I'm a forty-year-old man missing an arm!"

Laughing heartily, Al pulled his hand from the wall and stepped back.

As Subaru's field of view opened up, Subaru felt as if not just what was in front of him, but he felt like he was able to expand his horizon much more.

—In honesty, Al's words had only acted as first aid, and the fatal wound had not been closed completely.

He was not sure that his legs would not tremble in case he met Rem, that he would not be afraid of her repeating her previous words once he regarded her once again.

He had not been able to reach an answer thus far, as to how much and for what purpose he would exercise the Authority named Return by Death.

He was sure that even if he mulled it over in his head, he would be incapable of arriving at a conclusion until that moment came.

¹³ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "Kabe-don is the act of «slamming one's hand onto the wall in front of someone», where «kabe» (壁) means «wall», and «don» (ドン) is supposed to represent a bang or thump. A common trope in anime."

But he could say it clearly.

This prideful Authority¹⁴ in Natsuki Subaru's possession, was indispensable to materialize the "heroic reveries" that he must bear on his back.

Henceforth, he was certain he would continue to be confused on the manner to deal with it in the times to come.

Al: "Ohh, right bro, I just wanted to ask."

As Subaru stared downward at his hands in the process of renewing his mind, Al suddenly spoke up in an uncomfortable manner, his gaze directed toward Subaru.

Subaru wondered about Al's attitude, as he had not shown any sign of reservation up till this point.

Subaru: "What's the big deal now? If you have something to ask me, ask."

Al: "Then, I'll feel free to ask... What's your relationship with that Rem girl?"

Al uttered that question with his head cocked in puzzlement. The question was one that seemed weird to ask at this point.

But it was only when Al asked this, that Subaru realized that he had given no explanation.

Al: "She's your companion, bro, that you brought all the way to the Empire. She ain't that half-elf girl or that contracted loli. On top of that, you're treating her like a wife, right?"

Subaru: "I do that as a matter of convenience, and she herself doesn't like it."

Al: "But that girl's words are tearing you to pieces, bro— The hell's up with that?"

Al lowered his voice slightly and asked in a very serious manner.

¹⁴ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "Given the similarities, some of you may be wondering why this is translated as «prideful Authority» and not «Authority of Pride». The expression used here is «傲慢な権能», being that the particle «な» is converting the noun «傲慢» into an adjective. «Authority of Pride» would be written as «傲慢の権能», in which «の» is employed as a particle that means that the latter term «belongs» to the former."

In response to his words, Subaru frowned and searched his memories to make sure that there was no acquaintance between Al and Rem— at least not in this timeline.

In the first place, he had never even brought up the subject of Rem in front of Al. It was only natural that he did not know about her. But still, there was something peculiar about his question.

The reason was probably Al's attitude as he made that inquiry.

Al: "——"

His expression could not be seen. But he could feel the heat in his gaze.

Subaru sensed that it was a sign of seriousness and urgency. He was bewildered by the unfamiliar sides of Al he had been shown in such a short period of time, the previous exchange included.

He was his sole compatriot, one who had survived in this other world with his aloof, carefree, and unserious attitude.

As he felt his impression of Al morphing within him,

Subaru: "Rem's my... one of our companions. However, she fell victim to the Archbishop of Gluttony. Because of that, she's gone from everyone's memories. She doesn't even remember herself."

Al: "—So that's what happened. I see, I see, that makes sense."

Subaru: "Sense?"

With Subaru having simply stated the truth, Al put his hand on his chin and nodded repeatedly.

Subaru's head tilted due to the words that had leaked from his mouth, which prompted a "Right" from Al,

Al: "There were a few things that were bothering me. It was supposed to be a girl I didn't... know, but it looked like a girl I did know. It was kinda asserting itself like the small bone of a fish stuck somewhere."

Subaru: "You don't know her, but you know her... Are you talking about Ram?"

Al: "Oh, yes, yes."

Al's voice fluttered as Subaru blinked at the unexpected connection that had popped up.

But that was enough to convince Subaru of Al's attitude.

Thanks to everyone in the Emilia Camp, he was well-aware of how someone would react when one of the two, Ram and Rem, were to be forgotten.

Even Roswaal and Frederica, who had known her for a long time, had completely lost track of her existence until laying eyes on the real Rem, and once they met her face-to-face, they had never doubted the fact that she and Ram were twin sisters.

Aside from their personalities and qualities, Ram and Rem were really very similar— No, surprisingly, as of late he found himself wondering that they might be similar in nature as well.

Anyway, he now understood what Al's strange feeling had been.

Knowing Ram, it would be confusing to see a Rem who looked exactly like her.

Subaru: "But I've never heard of you and Ram knowing each other."

Al: "It's not like we know each other. We ain't really acquaintances, it's just like, we got a bit of a connection, somehow. It's not so much that we know each other— Twin sisters, huh? So you wanna reunite them."

Subaru: "...Mhm, that's right."

The top priority was to reunite Rem with Ram.

After that, Subaru's main goal was to bring Rem back to where she belonged, and have everyone in the Emilia Camp, along with him, welcome her. To do so, he could not afford to lose Rem's trust.

He must do whatever it took to regain her trust and get her to take his hand.

Al: "—Aight, okay. I'll help you, bro."

Subaru hardened his fists as he once again focused on the big goal, when Al, still at his front, having mulled over the circumstances that had been relayed to him, nodded and spoke those words.

Unintentionally, Subaru let out a dumb-sounding “Aeh?”

Al: “Bro, did you just make the dumbest squeal ever?”

Subaru: “Leave me alone! I mean, what did you say? Do you want to help? Help who?”

Al: “I’ll do it for you, bro. And I’m sure the Princess’s gonna have a lotta stuff to say about that, but she can do whatever she wants with that. Anyway, I’ve decided that I’m gonna support you.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “But I only got one arm’s worth of shoulder to put into it.”

Subaru: “That’s not funny.”

He’d stated that with annoying enthusiasm, and Subaru was puzzled even as he replied swiftly back.

That was probably true. He did not know what in the world tugged at Al’s heartstrings.

Subaru: “...Because you know Ram, that’s why you’re going to help me?”

Al: “It’s not like that. It’s you I’m rooting for, bro— In any case, if you gonna be a hero, the girl can’t be left out. That’s what I’m talking about.”

Subaru: “It’s not like I’m trying to be a hero...”

Al: “—You will be. Natsuki Subaru will become a hero.”

It was a way of interrupting that did not allow him to say no.

It was a strong, quiet statement, and the heat that it held within scorched Subaru’s heart.

Al: “...Just kidding.”

However, the intense fervor dissipated at the sound of Al’s jesting voice.

With Subaru at the mercy of the sudden change of situation, Al waved his hand and said “Sorry, sorry”,

Al: “But let’s keep that kinda spirit, bro. It’s better for lazy people like me and you bro, to bluff our way out a little.”

As he said this, Al turned away and walked off with a jaunty gait.

Lagging behind his stately steps, Subaru beckoned him.

Subaru: “Al. That just now was...”

Al: “Whoa, let’s not go off on a tangent here. After all, as I recall, I came to call you to the conference hall, bro. I’m pretty sure the Princess’s gonna gimme a hard time.”

Subaru: “———”

Al: “Com’on, let’s hurry up. There’s always gonna be a *kikai*¹⁵ to talk it out.”

With that, Al turned his head and shrugged his shoulders, gesturing for him to start running. Subaru, hastened by his gesture, had no choice but to retract his concern.

How much of what Al just said should be taken seriously, he did not know.

Even so, declaring his willingness to “cooperate” outright, gave Subaru considerably more energy to be optimistic.

Even if it was forced, Subaru had to be optimistic.

And so, he must keep his chest up, his back straight, and his legs wide apart as he walked.

Subaru: “Rem’s...”

—Hero, because he had lost the person who saw him in such a manner.



¹⁵ English flip. Means “chance” (機会), originally “チャンス” (chance).

???: “—«Heroic reveries», huh?”

As he dashed, a murmur echoed only inside his steel helmet.

He closed his eyes, uttering in a voice that could not be heard outside, only to be heard by himself.

And so, with his eyes closed, he let it echo in the darkness behind his eyelids.

Al: “I’ll have you become a hero, bro— No, Natsuki Subaru.”

Arc 7 Chapter 32 - The Path Onwards

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 3 “The Path Onwards”, Parts 2-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by [Taurace](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

???: “How much time does it take just to bring one foolish commoner back? Do you think that the value of the time that flows by is the same between you and I?”

???: “No, that’s why I’m apologizing to you...”

Greeted by his master’s frigid gaze, Al bowed his head in a sullen manner.

As soon as he returned to the conference hall with Subaru, the aforementioned reprimand awaited him.

The original purpose of his mission was to bring Subaru back to the meeting hall, so it was not unreasonable for him to be scolded for having an unplanned conversation. Not unreasonable, but—

Subaru: “Priscilla, please don’t blame Al too much. It’s not Al who’s at fault, it’s me.”

Priscilla: “Hmm. I’m sure you two clowns were consoling each other over some trivial anguish. Your forehead is red, did you bash it against the wall or something?”

Subaru: “Do you have Clairvoyance? You’re so spot on it’s scary.”

Priscilla shot back at Subaru, who had come to Al’s defense, with a comment as if she had seen it before.

The scene was not supposed to be so common as to come to mind easily, but he couldn’t help shudder at Priscilla’s insight. Anyway—

Subaru: “It’s like the conversation didn’t continue without us...”

Priscilla: “It is not facile to arrive at a conclusion. After all, are you not Abel’s military strategist?”

Subaru: “Well, um...”

Being pierced by Priscilla’s narrowed gaze, Subaru glanced at Abel. In response to his gaze, Abel, sitting on his seat, arms still crossed, paid no heed to Subaru’s questioning look.

Abel must have been reluctant to treat Subaru as a military strategist, but since he had stated such directly to Priscilla, it could be that he was unable to retract it.

As a result, they could not conclude the meeting without Subaru.

Subaru: “Aren’t you shooting yourself in the foot by acting without thinking?”

Abel: “You are the one who needs to regard the value of your words. Any great strategy can be treated as either wise or foolish, depending on how you choose your words.”

Subaru: “You’re regretting treating me as a military strategist, that’s some nerve...”

Frowning at Abel’s officious answer, Subaru sighed deeply.

He then looked around at the people in the meeting room— Abel, Priscilla, Zikr, and Taritta, who had taken over as Chieftain, and then closed one eye.

Without Subaru and Al, they didn’t think they could have reached a conclusion—

Subaru: “The conclusion you haven’t reached is about cooperating with Priscilla? What was said before, was that Priscilla had a collaborator.”

Abel: “You seem to have the brains to keep up. Of course, I am talking about that— The one who gathers the most members of the Nine Divine Generals wins, remember?”

Subaru: “Yeah, we got to the part where the First’s a pain in the ass for being useless.”

If he went unrecruited and became an assassin, there would be nothing they could do. On the other hand, if he were recruited, he would not contribute much to the situation. If this were a simulation game, he would be a troublesome unit.

Someone that lacked charm even if turned an ally, all while becoming deadly poisonous if left to their enemies.

Subaru: “But it’s about the final victory. It’s not about Priscilla and the support of her collaborators. Right?”

Priscilla: “—Hmm.”

Priscilla made a small sound in her throat as Subaru summarized the story deftly.

For an instant, Priscilla’s crimson eyes flashed with a look of curiosity that seemed unusual in Subaru’s own eyes— a reaction that suggested that she was interested in someone else, and in addition to that, it was Subaru.

I haven’t done anything special, Subaru contemplated.

Subaru: “What?”

Priscilla: “No, I thought you looked deflated in that guise, but you have made your return with a new look on your face and a new light in your eyes. On top of that, your blood circulation is a little better, so your appearance is slightly different.”

Subaru: “...Are you, complimenting me?”

Priscilla: “You may jump in jubilation if such is your wish.”

Subaru: “I won’t go that far.”

The fact that she had not denied it, must be a compliment in Priscilla’s own way.

Replying with a snort, Subaru accepted the praise for his change of heart.

From Rem’s own mouth, the words that had supported Natsuki Subaru had been repudiated.

However, he was encouraged that this was not the time for his knees to buckle because of it.

Subaru: “Well, if that’s the case, then it was worth being late for the meeting.”

Priscilla: “I see, the result of a conversation between clowns is superb. You are being so uncharacteristically friendly, Al.”

Al: “Oi, oi, it’s not unusual for a *zennin*¹⁶ like me to be friendly to someone, Princess.”

Priscilla derided him, and Al shrugged his shoulders as he replied.

Subaru could not decide whose words were correct, Priscilla’s or Al’s.

For Subaru, Al was the only person from his homeland, the one who patted him on the back and pushed him out of a dead-end situation. It was true that his image was not without its unsympathetic side, as he had been harsh to him elsewhere, and he treated any situation as someone else’s problem.

Subaru: “I can forgive it if I consider it as an after-effect of spending so much time in a different world.”

Al: “Didn’t you just say something really upsetting? Maybe I’m imagining things.”

Al tilted his head as if he couldn’t make any sense of it, but Subaru let it slide.

Neither the fact that Priscilla had changed her mind about Subaru, nor the fact that Al had contributed to that change of heart, were what was important.

Subaru: “What we need to do is settle the debate... and see how Priscilla’s willing to deal with us in the future. Let’s not go off-topic.”

Abel: “Oh, I am sorry. That someone who gets side-tracked so easily became a military strategist.”

Subaru: “———”

To Abel, who narrowed his eyes in displeasure and retorted sarcastically, Subaru stuck his tongue out and ignored him. Then, turning to Priscilla once again, he urged her to continue the conversation.

Subaru: “So, what are you going to do? With or without the support of Priscilla and her collaborators, I’m sure Abel’s still going to raise an assault on the Imperial Capital...”

¹⁶ English flip. Means “good person” (善人), originally “ナイスガイ” (nice guy).

Al: “With or without the Princess’s support, the extent of the assault will be the same.”

Priscilla: “It is that you clowns are so in tune with each other. Anyway, your assessment is correct. Therefore, for us to assist you in the future... I have raised a condition to Abel to serve as proof that he is worthy of the support.”

Subaru: “Condition?”

Priscilla: “It is simple— One of the Nine Divine Generals must be on your side.”

To Subaru’s frowning face, Priscilla presented the requirement as a matter-of-fact.

Upon hearing that prerequisite, Subaru muttered “Nine Divine Generals...”.

It was not an absurd condition, definitely.

In the first place, if one wished to mount a challenge in the battle to regain the throne, the acquisition of many Divine Generals was required beforehand. Priscilla was merely looking for that first step.

In fact, it would be a very fortunate condition if they could get Priscilla on their side just by fulfilling the prerequisites for victory, right—

Subaru: “It’s not exactly a condition to be jumping up and down about, is it?”

Abel: “Of course. As long as I remain unknowing of Goz’s safety, there are no Divine Generals among the Nine who would follow me unconditionally. Additionally, there are not many eccentrics with an inclination to trouble themselves to fight a losing battle.”

Subaru: “...If they can’t see even a small chance of winning, no one will come on board.”

As Abel described the tragic situation, Subaru also wrinkled his brow with a difficult expression.

Abel’s sad self-awareness— if the Emperor’s prestige was not enough for the Nine Divine Generals, he desired to get as much support as possible from Priscilla and her collaborators.

At the very least, the presence of such a collaborator would have been a bargaining chip to persuade the Nine Divine Generals.

At this point, Abel had only a few things to go on: “his big claim that he was the true Emperor, the People of Shudraq, and the military strength of the Fortress City of Guaral.

Subaru: “I wonder if they’ll listen to us when we say we’ll fight the Empire with one city and one tribe.”

Abel: “Those working with Priscilla... If they rank as mid-level Counts or higher, their names shall pose as good bargaining chips.”

Priscilla: “I tell you, do not expect mercy from me. I possess a certain amount of generosity, but it is not meant for beggars.”

Priscilla, with her chin resting on her hand, easily trampled their feeble hopes.

As they were already aware, there was no way she was going to change her opinion. Then, all they had to do was to directly challenge the conditions presented to them.

Zikr: “With all due respect, Your Excellency, perhaps we should turn to General First-Class Cecilus for help?”

Subaru: “Zikr-san, what are the odds of success?”

Expectations were placed on Zikr after those words, as heavy silence fell over the room. However, in response to Subaru’s expectant gaze, Zikr shook his head and said, “No”.

Zikr: “As Your Excellency stated earlier, given the current balance in strength, anyone who considers cooperating with us is not thinking straight. Therefore...”

Subaru: “Therefore?”

Zikr: “I am afraid we can only rely on people who don’t think straight, such as General First-Class Cecilus...”

Subaru: “Ah, so Zikr-san thinks that person’s nuts, too.”

Cecilus, who had only a dismal reputation, was hardcore enough that Zikr thought he could be brought to their side due to his craziness.

However, if they really had no other choice, they may have to go for the first troublesome unit they could think of bringing over to their side at some point.

Subaru: “The question is, where is he? Where does that person usually live?”

Abel: “That one usually lives in Arakiya’s house in the Imperial Capital.”

Subaru: “I see, Arakiya’s... Wait, why?”

It was said flatly, and Subaru’s understanding of Abel’s words was delayed for a few seconds.

Even Priscilla scowled in displeasure at the outlandishness of the content.

From what he had heard, Cecilus was the First, and Arakiya was the Second.

Subaru: “Does that mean that this Cecilus guy and Arakiya are lovers or something?”

If that were the case, the impression left by Subaru and the others who had repelled Arakiya could not have been worse.

Subaru and his team had successfully made enemies of both the First and Second.

However, Abel shook his head in response to Subaru’s question.

Abel: “No, that is not so. Arakiya is looking for an opportunity to kill Cecilus, but she cannot achieve such a thing if people around him are harmed every time she attempts to murder him. That is why I ordered Cecilus to do it.”

Subaru: “Ordered what?”

Abel: “If it was going to happen anyway, he should stay in places where it’s easy for Arakiya to go after him.”

Subaru: “...I see?”

Even with a concrete explanation, their relationship was difficult for Subaru to understand.

He did not understand the mentality of letting his own Generals kill one another, and he also did not comprehend the idea of living in the house of someone who would try to kill oneself. First of all—

Subaru: “How can you live with someone who wants to kill you...?”

After he asked that, he felt as if he had spoken something strange, but he was incapable of finding the answer to that odd feeling, and Subaru quickly forgot his question.

Anyway, the fact that Cecilus usually lived in the Imperial Capital was now known.

Subaru: “So, the only way to get Cecilus on our side is to head to the Imperial Capital... Hey, you sure you’re okay to go all the way to the Imperial Capital?”

Abel: “Of course not. With the current status quo, if I were to get close to the Imperial Capital, it would be no different than advancing toward my own execution. More than that, I do not even know if Cecilus is in the Imperial Capital after all.”

Subaru: “Then we’re out of luck...”

When it came to matters of the Vollachian Empire, and even military matters, Subaru’s knowledge was useless.

Though, since Zikr, who was also a commissioned officer, had been the first to suggest it, it could be considered to be one of the better ideas they could come up with.

If that idea was rejected, Abel’s path would be bleak.

Subaru: “...Yet this isn’t the time to be in a stalemate.”

A dark and heavy feeling began to assert itself in Subaru’s chest.

It was like a bittersweet stagnation, a lump of helplessness that would not vanish even if he banged his head against a wall, something like an aftereffect of Rem giving up on Subaru.

Because of it, Subaru had lost Rem’s trust.

He had to get rid of this stagnation as soon as possible and regain her trust. In order to do so, every second of time spent at a standstill was regrettable.

Abel: “—There is a way.”

However, the gnashing of Subaru’s teeth was halted due to these words of response from Abel.

One eye closed, Abel turned to face Subaru, the latter looking upwards as if he had been struck, and spoke—

Abel: “Cease with that pathetic face, I am sick of seeing it. I have an idea.”

Subaru: “Sorry, but my face’s at the limit of what I can do with the *ziki zuanka*¹⁷, without whaling for it. I don’t care about the inequality between such faces. What do you mean you have an idea?”

Abel: “It was part of Zikr’s idea. I shall adopt some of it.”

Zikr: “Some of my idea? I would be honored, but that is...?”

With furrowed thick eyebrows, Zikr displayed confusion upon hearing that his opinion would be utilized.

Subaru was just as confused as Zikr. In the first place, Zikr’s idea had been to recruit Cecilus, the First.

As long as they could not go to the Imperial Capital, they would be forced to reject that idea, and he thought that there were no other parts that could be used, outside of that.

To Subaru, who thought so, Abel exhaled via his nose, “Hmm”.

Abel: “I do not possess a chance to talk to Cecilus, but Zikr also stated— If there is someone else who does not think straight, there is a possibility.”

Zikr: “—Hk! Impossible... Your Excellency, that is dangerous! Please reconsider!”

Subaru: “Eh? Eh? Eh?”

¹⁷ English flip. Means “player character designer” (自機図案家), originally “キャラメイク” (character maker).

Abel's bold words were met with fierce opposition by a pale-faced Zikr.

Zikr's fierce determination made Subaru's eyes dart back and forth, and he was surprised to see what was going on.

Zikr seemed to have an idea of what was going on, but this seemed illogical to Subaru. From the way the conversation was flowing, it seemed as if he were going to talk to someone crazy—

Subaru: "Is there anyone crazier than that General First-Class Cecilus no one likes?"

Zikr: "I would not label them crazy! But that person is too dangerous...!"

Al: "...Well, I get what you're saying Afro General¹⁸, but from the way the conversation's going, it's one of the Nine Divine Generals, right? If you leave them out, is there anyone else you can count on? It's not a situation in which you can be picky."

Zikr: "That is true, but..."

Subaru and Al spoke to him from both sides, and Zikr quieted down with a reluctant face.

Having seen the good-natured Zikr in suffering made Subaru feel as if they had done something wrong.

Rather, the problem lay with Abel's personnel management, which had placed people in key positions that Zikr could not help but anguish over.

This was an example of how appointing people based on their abilities alone could lead to such tragedies.

Subaru: "In that respect, Lugunica was run pretty well... Basically, I've never come across a big shot who was a jerk... No, there was that old man who said bad things about Emilia-tan, but..."

In hindsight, that was also part of a statement born out of excessive fear of the Witch of Envy.

¹⁸ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: "This isn't translation flair or anything, Al literally calls Zikr «アフロの将», Afro General."

At the time, Subaru was a foolish hero who did not understand such circumstances and took on the challenge, equipped only with recklessness. Now, were he to encounter an identical situation, he would be better equipped to challenge it.

Of course, the option of not challenging someone over Emilia because of her bad reputation was not present for him.

Subaru: “So just who’s the cause of Zikr-san’s suffering?”

Abel: “What is with that foolish wording?”

Abel responded to Subaru’s question with a resentful look on his face.

Abel: “To answer your question, it is Yorna Mishigure, based in Chaosflame, the Demon City.”

Subaru: “Yorna Mishigure...”

Despite the unfamiliar name of the city, the person’s name was familiar to Subaru.

Yorna Mishigure was one of the Nine Divine Generals mentioned in the list, and he believed her nickname to be—

Subaru: “She’s called the Flamboyant, something like that, right?”

Al: “You’re good, bro. I don’t know how you managed to learn it in one shot.”

Subaru: “I like to memorize the nicknames of executive-level characters in manga and such. That said, this Yorna person is Zikr-san’s...”

As he said this, he glanced at Zikr, and Subaru became speechless.

Because Zikr’s face had gone pale, now covered by his hands.

Zikr: “The Seventh of the Nine Divine Generals, General First-Class Yorna Mishigure...”

Subaru: “Is she that dangerous? I thought the name was feminine, but...”

If his impression was correct, she would be a woman feared even by Zikr, renowned as the Womanizer, who acted like a gentleman even towards a Subaru only dressed as a woman.

He could not even envision what kind of spectacle was going to come out of her, but—

Zikr: “She is beautiful. I am sure everyone can agree on that, not just me. However, General First-Class Yorna has a small... No, not a small, rather, an inexcusable problem.”

Subaru: “Well, what’s the problem?”

Zikr: “—It’s insurrection.”

Subaru & Al: “Eh?”

Subaru’s and Al’s voices overlapped with Zikr’s, as the words spilled from his mouth.

To Subaru’s dismay, who was suspecting that his ears had heard that wrong, Zikr covered his face with his hands and continued in a trembling voice.

Zikr: “General First-Class Yorna Mishigure has rebelled many times and threatened the reign of Emperor Vincent Vollachia.”

Subaru: “You can’t put someone like that in the *kaku* of army general!”

Subaru’s angry voice echoed through the conference hall for a second time.



Priscilla: “—This affair seems to have been settled.”

After a while of listening to the ridiculous information about the Nine Divine Generals, and after Subaru’s angry shout, Priscilla adjudged that she had witnessed the conclusion of the discussion, and opened her fan with a snap.

Honestly, it was a conclusion Subaru wanted to object to, but—

Abel: "There is no other option. As of now, the only one among the Nine Divine Generals who might join us is Yorna Mishigure."

Subaru: "Didn't she rebel against you because she didn't like you in the first place...?"

Zikr: "No, actually, that would not be entirely true... It is impossible for me, at least, to know what she is thinking."

Subaru: "If Zikr-san says as much, then it must be true..."

At the words of the trustworthy Zikr, Subaru had no choice but to retract his doubts.

And Abel, having heard this, sniffed disapprovingly and spoke.

Abel: "What is it with you and your willingness to listen to Zikr's opinion?"

Subaru: "Even if the opinion's the same, who said it is important. Do you think you have more credibility in my mind than Zikr-san does?"

Abel: "I see. But what happens if Zikr dies?"

Subaru: "Even though it's a thought experiment, I'm going to kill you!"

He cursed at Abel for saying something so disturbing.

Taking Zikr's loyalty into account, if Abel ordered him to do it, he may seriously commit suicide. Subaru was doing everything in his power to prevent such an incident from happening. Anyway—

Subaru: "Silly stuff aside, Chaosflame... Where is it? Is it far from Guaral?"

Abel: "Not in terms of location. That is another reason as to why it is an appropriate place to head towards. It is located southeast of here... and south of the Buddheim Jungle."

Subaru: "I see, indeed..."

Having been shown the location on the map on the desk, Subaru was convinced by Abel's explanation.

The location of Chaosflame lay south of the jungle where the People of Shudraq lived—the distance was larger than that between Jungle and Guaral, but it was a destination far more realistic than the one till the Imperial Capital or the land further west.

Subaru: “And then there’s why it’s called the Demon City...”

Priscilla: “Rest assured, foolish commoner. It is not because of a reason that shall crush your minute heart. It is a city where many races have lived in chaos since ancient times. Vollachia is home to a much wider variety of races in comparison to Lugunica, but Chaosflame is a particularly eclectic mix.”

Subaru: “In chaos... and it’s the Demon City.”

Once that was said, the fact that the word “chaos” was connected to the city said to be “in chaos” made a lot of sense¹⁹.

Given that this was another world, it was probably just a coincidence.

Abel: “—In the Demon City, I shall add Yorna Mishigure, the Seventh of the Nine Divine Generals, to my army. I am certain you shall be able to open your heart... when that comes to pass, Priscilla.”

Priscilla: “That is fine. I am quite magnanimous. I shan’t add conditions afterwards.”

Subaru: “I thought you said something about generosity being out of stock earlier... No, never mind.”

With Priscilla’s glare falling on him, Subaru immediately withdrew his unnecessary remark.

And so, once the plan was properly settled upon—

???: “—Abel, please take me with *you*.”

Subaru: “Taritta-san?”

Suddenly, Taritta stood up and pleaded with Abel.

¹⁹ Translation note by Witch Cult Translations: “«Chaosflame» is composed by two English words, «chaos» (カオス) and «flame» (フレイム) (or possibly «frame»). That is what Subaru is alluding to here.”

Taritta had been seated in Kuna's place during the meeting, but she had never spoken up before this moment.

She was probably confused by the fact that she had to suddenly take over as Chieftain, but even now, her face had a deep sense of urgency plastered on it as she stared at Abel.

In response to her plea, Abel's dark eyes narrowed.

Abel: "What shall you do? You have inherited the title of Shudraqian Chieftain from your sister. Regardless of your confidence, that will not change."

Taritta: "I *know*, I *know*. I can't refuse the position that my older sister has given to *me*. But I'm not strong enough to lead the Shudraq..."

Taritta looked downward, as she bit her lip and stared at her hands.

In her empty hands, what she clutched was probably the same thing that Subaru held in his heart— that was, the sense of helplessness that tormented her.

Taritta: "Because I *need*... a chance to carry the position of Chieftain with *pride*."

Abel: "—Is that what you are looking for in travelling to Chaosflame?"

Taritta: "Yes, it *is*... is it no *good*?"

Taritta's voice lost some of its power, as if she had lost confidence in herself after saying that.

However, Subaru could understand the anxiety that Taritta was feeling, and what it really was.

After the sudden change in Chieftains, Taritta had been forced to play a major role, but she was not sure that she held the power befitting said role.

So, what she sought was a successful experience. With her own hands, she would seek results sufficient to convince herself, and a success story that would let her deem herself worthy.

—It was the same thing that Subaru was looking for right now.

Subaru: “Abel, I agree with her. Even if she succeeded Mizelda-san with such a mindset, I think Taritta-san wouldn’t be able to fulfill her potential...”

Abel: “———”

Subaru: “Besides, we’re going to need an escort or ally along the way anyway, right? We know what Taritta-san’s capable of. We’re friends who rode into... town together in women’s clothing.”

Taritta: “Natsumi...”

He had rephrased it somewhere in the middle of it, but he declared what he wanted to.

Taritta appeared to be very impressed by Subaru’s decision to side with her. He was painfully aware of her hard work. Therefore, he wanted to be on her side.

Abel: “What shall the Shudraq do while you are gone?”

Taritta: “I will let my sister take over for a *while*. Kuna and Holly will be assisting her a *lot*. To protect Guaral we can’t move too many *people*.”

Abel: “So you thought about that much, whilst keeping quiet?”

Having listened to Taritta’s unrestrained answer, Abel assessed her thoughts.

Then Abel tapped his temple lightly with his finger,

Abel: “Only a few are heading for Chaosflame. Of course, as long as I am meeting with Yorna Mishigure, my presence is essential. But we shall not mount an attack.”

Subaru: “At most we can only take one escort...”

Abel: “Then I shall add you, Taritta. The rest——”

???: “——I’ve been listening!”

In the middle of Abel’s sentence, the door was thrown open with great force, and a figure stepped in with vigor.

It was Flop O'Connell, the good merchant who had unabashedly referred to the Emperor as his new friend, and who had no fear of the impertinence of interrupting said Emperor's words.

Flop snorted, as he held the gaze of everyone in the room to himself.

Flop: "Miss Taritta, I'm very impressed with your spirit in volunteering for such a difficult role! I think it's great that you're finding your own way to tackle a big role out of the blue...!"

Taritta: "Ah, thank *you*, thank you very *much*, Flop..."

Flop: "I'd like to make a suggestion to keep you and Mr. Chief safe on the road— I think it'd be a good idea to take my sister, Medium, with you!"

Finger held high, Flop asserted forcefully.

Subaru almost unintentionally nodded in agreement because of his vigor, but upon examining what he had stated, it was a rather abrupt suggestion.

Subaru: "So, what's on your mind?"

Flop: "Yeah, yeah, I guess that's the question. Now let me give y'all my reasons for recommending Medium! First of all, she's skilled, and then she's charming. On top of that, she's a smooth talker!"

Subaru: "Smooth talker...!"

Flop: "She speaks pleasantly and clearly, so your chats while traveling won't be lonesome. She's not shy, so she can get along with anyone. What do you think, isn't she a gem?"

Flop, white teeth on display, praised his sister, but two-thirds of his confident selling points referred to Medium's people-pleasing nature, and the only real selling point was that she was "skilled".

In fact, Subaru had confirmed that this one point was accurate, however—

Subaru: "But, have you talked to Medium-san about it?"

Flop: "No, I haven't! But I'm going to tell her now, so it's okay!"

Subaru: "...Is this okay?"

It was no travel consultation nor a promise of fun.

Although she would be thrown into a role where her life would be on the line, would discussing it with her later work out? If this were to cause a rift in the relationship between the siblings, it would indeed be painful for Subaru.

However, he was afraid that he could picture them laughing and being okay with it.

Subaru: "Assuming that Medium-san's okay with it, Abel, what about you?"

Abel: "—I have witnessed that she possesses the right skills. If she performs her role, I have no objection."

Flop: "Then you can rest assured! My sister's one who basically gives her all to whatever she's told to do! But be careful, she doesn't get too worked up if she's not told to."

Putting his hands on his hips, Flop laughed gaily, "Hahahaha!".

It could be inferred from the way he'd stated that, and from Abel's attitude— This time, Flop would not be included in the group that would accompany them to Chaosflame.

Subaru: "But... Medium-san, doesn't have to go with us, you know."

Flop: "Don't be silly, Husband-kun, I have a goal. There's some revenge that must be done, that must be served."

Subaru: "...Oh, right."

Those were the dangerous words that spilled out of Flop's mouth, but he knew that they were by no means dangerous thoughts, but rather directed towards an outrageous absurdity even the cheerful Flop could not forgive.

Flop's goodness, which had gone unheard of by Subaru in this world— that was the reason why Subaru trusted him and had been able to spend time with him until today.

Flop: “It’s the same for my sister. My sister and I have the same goal, and the same path to walk. If I abandon you, the Wife-san, and Village Chief-kun here, I wouldn’t be able to hold my head high anymore.”

Subaru: “—I’m going to cry. I’m going to fall in love with you.”

Flop: “Hahaha, that’s a gut-wrenching thing to hear from you Husband-kun, in that outfit! But you can’t do that, because it’d be bad for the Wife-san. But I’ll take your feelings!”

Even the way he dealt with it was cool, and Subaru could only admire it.

Perhaps Medium would be willing to follow Flop’s words. In other words, one of their companions in the trip to Chaosflame would be Medium.

Flop: “Miss Taritta, be good to my sister. Hey, you got along well with me, so I’m sure you’ll get along well with my sister.”

Taritta: “Y-yes... Please take care of yourself *too*...”

Flop: “Hm? Yes, I’ll do my best with Zikr-san and the rest of the Shudraqians!”

Flop slapped himself on the chest as Taritta fidgeted and looked down.

With a smile on his face, Subaru cleared his throat.

Subaru: “By the way, I’m...”

Abel: “I shall be leaving you behind.”

Subaru: “—Hk.”

Abel: “Did you really believe I would say such a thing?”

When Subaru tried to confirm, Abel threw a feint in bad taste at him.

Even though he was enraged by it, he reacted as if he wanted to be taken along, so Subaru did his best to hold back and kept silent by clenching his teeth.

Snickering at Subaru, Abel prefaced his remarks with, “Unfortunately, though,”.

Abel: “You are already a bargaining chip. As long as it is imperative for us to append Yorna Mishigure, no talks can be held without your presence.”

Subaru: “I’ll definitely punch you in the side of the head when all’s done and dusted, but... I’m a bargaining chip?”

Abel: “The fall of Guaral was of your design. Those circumstances shall soon be known. I shall make sure that happens.”

Subaru: “What?”

Not grasping the meaning of Abel’s words, Subaru was bewildered.

There was no doubt that the fall of the Fortress City had been Subaru’s plan, but he did not understand the advantage of going through the trouble of making it known.

Basically, being underestimated was Natsuki Subaru’s starting point.

Priscilla: “—That there is someone else who can be utilized besides Abel, we must make her think so.”

It was Priscilla who answered Subaru’s question in a straightforward manner.

Hearing her words, comprehension slowly seeped into Subaru’s mind.

Priscilla: “Of course, that encompasses not only this foolish commoner. The People of Shudraq from the Buddheim Jungle, and the defender of the Fortress City of Guaral, General Second-Class Zikr Osman, are likewise material for negotiations. But the best one would be...”

Abel: “The military strategist who assisted in bringing the city down... As I had stated. In the Empire, the strong are respected. It is not merely about brute force, but intelligence as well.”

Subaru: “———”

That was why Natsuki Subaru had value, Abel and Priscilla assured this.

Honestly, from Subaru’s point of view, it was a very complicated assessment.

On one hand, he was bothered to be so highly praised.

But on the other hand, it also seemed to be an overestimation. In fact, in spite of this high evaluation, Subaru had lost the trust of Rem, and felt the ground under him collapse.

No matter how highly he was regarded in the Empire, it was nothing compared against Rem's trust.

For this reason, Subaru's heart was not moved by Abel and Priscilla's evaluation. However—

Subaru: "If I'm useful, that's fine. Use me well. In return..."

Abel: "In return?"

Subaru: "You'll definitely get the throne of the Emperor back. And you'll get us back home safely."

Subaru firmly stated that this was the only thing he would not compromise on.

Having heard this, Abel's eyes widened slightly, and then he let out a long breath.

Abel: "Being told that is needless— That is what I am supposed to do."

And so he answered.

Arc 7 Chapter 33 - Now, onto the Journey Towards the Demon City

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 3 “The Path Onwards”, Parts 4-6

Original Web Novel Chapter – [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by SapphireComet, Translation checked
by Averitius, [Taurace](#)) – [Complete](#)

—He would use what he could, to reclaim the Imperial Throne of Vollachia.

He would not only use the Fortress City of Guaral, but also the People of Shudraq, General Second-Class Zikr Osman, and of course, Natsuki Subaru.

Yes, Abel had just nodded his head in agreement to Subaru’s confirmation.

Priscilla: “—This affair seems to have been settled.”

Priscilla so muttered after seeing the conclusion of the meeting, covering her mouth with her opened fan.

Just as she had stated, the meeting had come to a consensus. The victory conditions were understood by all, their future course of action was decided, and their next destination and goal were set. And then—

Subaru: “If it’s just a select few that are going to Chaosflame, what about the others? Currently, it’s just me, Abel, Taritta-san, and Medium-san...”

Al: “—On that note, can I say one thing?”

Subaru: “Al?”

Subaru was about to select the final members for their next destination, the Demon City of Chaosflame, when Al butted in.

He raised the hand of his lone arm, then scratching the back of his own neck with said lifted hand.

Al: "Princess, can I step away from your reins for a moment? I wanna stay with bro's group."

Subaru: "Ueh?"

Al: "Oh, come on, your voice's cracking, bro. Is it really all that surprising?"

In response to that unexpected proposal, Subaru's voice cracked, which prompted a quiver from Al's throat.

But even though he had stated so like it was nothing, Subaru couldn't just voice his agreement.

Subaru: "W-why...?"

Al: "I told you everything, didn't I? I said I'd help you, bro. Even a doddering old man like me can be useful in some way."

Subaru: "You... You were that serious?"

Al answered by shrugging his burly shoulders, and Subaru thought back to the talk he'd had with him before joining the meeting, and was surprised at how he had adhered to the conversation they'd had.

It was true that he had encouraged him, it was true that he had raised his spirits, and it was true that he had pushed him onwards.

However, he had not expected him to go as far as seriously saying he would "cooperate".

Al: "Heh, why are you frozen stiff? Did my offer impress you that much?"

Subaru: "...No, shelving away my initial surprise, I haven't heard anything about you being strong, Al, and with me and Abel, the ratio of men-to-women in our group's just awful."

Al: "Sorry if I got your hopes up, but I'm a lot weaker than the amazon nee-chan over there!"

Pointing at Taritta with a snap, Al proudly assured him that he was fairly pathetic.

In fact, Taritta's ability probably ranked among the best in the People of Shudraq, but after witnessing the battle with a member of the Nine Divine Generals, she was a rather unreliable battle reinforcement. Anyhow—

Subaru: "Still, I'm glad to hear you say that. I'll accept your sentiment."

Al: "Ha, don't worry about it, bro... Huh? Just the sentiment? Are you turning me down gently, perhaps? Are you saying we're not tied together this time?"

Al had endless questions about Subaru's response, but there was no mistaking how he took it.

He was really happy about the offer, but this was the Vollachian Empire. In the first place, more so than Flop and Medium, that Al was participating in the war was purely by chance—

Priscilla: "—Al."

Al: "Yeah, Princess."

While Subaru made his conclusions, a beautiful voice next to him unexpectedly called out Al's name.

The owner of the voice was, of course, Priscilla Barielle, who sat proudly at the roundtable. She squinted her crimson eyes and turned her emotionless gaze to Al.

To her own follower Al, who had just announced his next move,

Priscilla: "You were the one who offered to accompany me to the Fortress City, were you not? And now you wish to leave me, and go on an amusement trip with your clownish friend?"

Al: "I don't think it's gonna be a carefree trip, but that's the plan. Or are you gonna miss me, Princess? If you'd like to hug me and hold me back, go right ahead..."

Priscilla: "Nonsense."

Al: "Riiight."

Al's light-hearted comment was interrupted with a snarky remark, and he sagged down. It looked he hadn't been expecting much anyway.

While staring at the top of Al's head through his helmet, Priscilla let out a small breath and said,

Priscilla: "—Dance well, as best you can."

Al: "Oh, I gotcha. Princess's the one who shouldn't be careless just because Schult and I ain't around. Princess's beauty is the world's beauty."

Priscilla: "I needn't be told that. Who do you take me for?"

Al: "Of course, you're the center of the world, my Princess, Priscilla Barielle."

Al said those pretentious words in a droll tone and bowed frivolously in front of Priscilla. Then he turned around and raised his hand to Subaru, saying "Let's go".

Subaru: "What, that exchange made everything final? What about my opinion?"

Al: "What's with all the reluctance? It's depressing. Or is it just that I haven't noticed that I smell like an old man? Like, is it a pain for you to be around me?"

Subaru: "I'm not talking about that. I mean, what gives you the right to decide...?"

Al: "No, of course you're free to refuse, you know. But how can I refuse? —It's the Princess, yeah?"

Al cocked his chin, indicating Priscilla, who was fanning her face.

This regal behavior was the overwhelming basis for Al's words. To overturn Priscilla's decision, just how terrifying would that be.

Nevertheless, if it'd lead to uncertainty in the future, refusal was not an option.

Subaru: "Priscilla, I'm..."

Abel: "—I do not mind. He may follow us if need be."

Subaru: "Abel, damn you, you're not treating me like a military strategist!"

However, just as Subaru was about to present his opinion to Priscilla, he was shot in the back again.

Subaru glared at Abel, who had interrupted him, and he, too, crossed his arms proudly as he opposed the former. Like Priscilla, he intended to stubbornly fulfill his intentions here as well.

However, Subaru had no choice but to appeal directly to him with the argument that the terms of employment were different.

Subaru: “What’s the point of being a military strategist if my opinions aren’t even taken into account?”

Abel: “Do not be presumptuous. If your opinion were worth listening to, I would listen to it. Nevertheless, I am the one who calls the final shots. I would not entrust it to you.”

Subaru: “Gnnh, are you a nasty boss who takes away the fruits of his workers’ labor...?”

Abel: “Do not force me to repeat myself— The results are yours. They must be.”

Subaru: “———”

—The Emperor who had been ousted from his throne had a wise person following him that could not be underestimated.

What Abel wanted was a Subaru with such a reputation. And he was willing to give Subaru credit and exaggerate a bit to get it.

But that was no different than building up a myth.

Subaru: “Being a fake isn’t good enough. It’s got to be the real thing, or I’ll never get back what I lost.”

Abel: “—If such is the case, then do attempt to convince me and everyone else with your own actions. If you cannot achieve it, it remains as a foolish and delusional remark harboring great ambitions.”

Subaru: “Bastard, I’ll do it. I’ll put any useless loans to good use.”

Biting down hard on his molars, Subaru replied peering into Abel’s cold black eyes.

Even though they were facing the same direction, they did not have a relationship where they could lower their guard around each other. Rather than the difference in the soil they stood on, as in the Kingdom and the Empire, it was something bigger that seemed to be the reason for such a divide.

As long as that was the case, he may disagree with Abel on a crucial point.

And once that happened, Natsuki Subaru—

Al: “...Perhaps he meant me as a useless loan, Princess?”

Priscilla: “Fool.”

Priscilla only briefly responded to Al, who slumped his shoulders and muttered that.



—The members of the expedition to the Demon City of Chaosflame had been decided, and the plan was set in motion.

Abel: “Get the soldiers of the Fortress City together by the time I return. I shall send word back soon.”

Zikr: “I will, even if it costs me my life.”

Receiving Abel’s command, Zikr knelt down on one knee and reverently obeyed it.

Zikr, who had unexpectedly found himself in the position of an enemy of the mighty Empire, had no hesitation in his stance, but, naturally, that did not apply to the entirety of the city’s troops.

In order to unify their intentions and bring them together as a single army, the efforts of the Generals would be essential. In that sense, Zikr’s presence was a boon.

Subaru: “Zikr-san, I know this is a lot of work, but...”

Zikr: “No, this is the role that I, as a General, am supposed to play. It is nothing compared to the Bloodless Siege.”

Subaru: “———”

Subaru cast his eyes down at Zikr’s words, who gave a strong and proud smile.

Subaru's track record was that he had set up a bloodless siege, claimed he could do it, and failed miserably. As a result, he had failed to meet Rem's expectations and had caused her disappointment.

However, Zikr smiled at Subaru's work.

Zikr: "Do not be discouraged, You proposed the Bloodless Siege, and His Excellency approved it. And the fact is that I and my subordinates joined your ranks without shedding a single drop of blood."

Subaru: "Without shedding a drop of blood, that's..."

An exaggerated expression, yet Subaru choked upon seeing the bandage wrapped around Zikr's injury. But Zikr's cheeks relaxed, and then he forcibly peeled off his own bandage.

The bloodstained bandage was removed, revealing the wound on his arm.

Zikr: "For a Soldier, this is merely a scratch. Moreover, you should be proud. Because, as a result of your efforts, the number of Generals and Soldiers fighting for His Excellency has not decreased."

Subaru: "-----"

Zikr: "You are to do your duty— Miss Natsumi."

Subaru knew not if he would be able to respond properly to those words from Zikr.

However, even though Subaru could not give praise to himself outright, he had a newfound fondness for Zikr's character for finding something to praise, and the fact that he had not allowed his death was an achievement. And—

???: "—Are you sure you want to go?"

Subaru: "-----"

???: "No, that was something ridiculous to say. Forget it."

And with that, Rem, whose eyes could not hide her fatigue, shook her head.

Rem stood at the entrance of the City Hall with her cane. She was not dressed in traveling gear, but in the light vestment of a healing practitioner scrambling around to help the wounded.

Rem would remain in Guaral.

It was a temporary separation from Subaru, who was on his way to Chaosflame.

Before parting, Subaru smiled at that comment from Rem, who had come to see him off. Even though he knew it was out of concern, he couldn't help it.

Subaru: "Well, it's not all been good, but it's hard on me for you to tell me to forget something about you."

Rem: "Oh, I didn't mean to..."

Subaru: "Because everything you've given me, whether a strangled neck or a broken finger, is a precious memory that I can't live without."

Rem: "Huh?"

He had not meant to make fun of her, but he ended up being pierced by Rem's glaciated eyes.

When he thought back to the events that had impacted him since he was sent to Vollachia, it was just that many of the memories that popped into his mind held a powerful pang of pain and suffering.

Of course, there were many, many memories of hope and joy that he had stored deep in his heart, such as the fact that he had been able to come to terms with Rem and that she cared for him.

—But the most painful memories were stored in the same place, too.

Rem: "You're not nervous... Are you really alright?"

Subaru: "You know, it's exhausting to be tense all the time... If you're asking me if I'm okay, I'd say I've got a lot on my mind. If I could, I'd stay by your side forever."

Rem: "Haa."

Subaru: "An indifferent reply! No, I'm just glad you're not ignoring me..."

He was hurt by that casual attitude, but the words Subaru told Rem were his true feelings.

There had been a great deal of last-minute agonizing over leaving Rem in Guaral. To be frank, even at this moment, he wanted to retract his previous statement, grab her by her slim arms, and whisk her away.

How good it would be to have Rem within Natsuki Subaru's arm's reach, to protect her from the hardships, fires, and every possible bad thing that could befall her?

Subaru: "In fact, I'd even like to tie you and me together the whole time with an unbreakable cord."

Rem: "Are you serious...?"

Subaru: "Somewhat."

Rem: "-----"

Finally, he wasn't even able to get her to say "Huh?".

Of course, he knew that he would've been rejected had been serious about it, so he just went for it. It would be best if he could tie himself to Rem all the time, so that he would always know if she was safe and sound.

Depending on the situation, he may have to resort to the power he had awakened at Pleiades Watchtower—

Subaru: "I'm not sure how to use Cor Leonis, either..."

Subaru's new Authority, Cor Leonis, which had manifested at Pleiades Watchtower— it was the ability to vaguely grasp the location and situation of his allies, with Subaru at the center. In addition, Cor Leonis allowed Subaru to take on the burden of his friends and keep them in good health.

Perhaps he could use his power to take the burden of Rem's crippled legs and let her run around the fields and mountains in high spirits.

He didn't want Rem to go out of reach by doing that, though.

Subaru: "-----"

Rem: “Hey, why do you look so depressed all of a sudden?”

Subaru: “Nothing, I’m just self-loathing here.”

Rem pointed out, and Subaru sighed, holding his own deflated face in his hands.

It occurred to him that Rem’s limp had kept her in a place where she could not get away from Subaru. The fact that she was incapable of escaping was one of the things that kept Subaru and Rem from ending their relationship.

The fact that Rem was not in perfect shape made him think that he was lucky.

Subaru: “This is why Rem can’t trust me.”

Subaru was always thinking only of himself.

He wished to be gentler. He desired to be kind, smart, and strong. He had been working hard for the sake of everyone, and now that he had taken another good look at himself in the Tower, it was still not enough.

—He could not retrieve the Natsuki Subaru that Rem believed in.

Rem: “Um...?”

Subaru: “Sorry. I was getting a little *kanjouteki*²⁰.”

Rem: “*Kanjoo*-what, now?”

Subaru: “Don’t worry about it. It’s an expression that’s only understood by Al and... my hometown.”

Rem frowned slightly as Subaru shrugged his shoulders and replied. However, she rubbed her eyes and erased the wrinkles, as if to put off the feelings growing inside her.

²⁰ English flip. Means “sentimental” (感情的), originally “センチメンタル” (sentimental).

There must be a lot of conflicts within Rem. Even the fact that she had come out to see him off like this must have been something she had put a lot of thought into.

Subaru: "I'm not going to be away for long, because I won't be able to stand it without you."

Rem: "...There you go doing that again."

Subaru: "Ugh, I mean it though... If it makes you feel uncomfortable, I'll restrain myself as much as I can."

Rem: "You're not going to try to stop, are you?"

Subaru's shoulders slumped in remorse as he was met with a stare.

Of course, he did not want to offend Rem nor to make her uncomfortable. But that would not stop his strong feelings for Rem from overflowing.

No matter what Subaru, who had disappointed Rem, said.

Subaru: "Good luck, and I'll be back soon. I'll bring back good news."

Rem: "...Yes, I'm looking forward to Abel-san, Medium-san and Taritta-san."

Subaru: "Setting aside Al, what about me?"

Rem: "———"

Subaru asked, just to be sure, but the temperature of Rem's gaze remained unchanged.

However, Subaru must have looked very miserable with that answer, because Rem fell silent for a while, then let out a small breath as if giving up, and stated,

Rem: "It'd be a lot better if I were to talk about believing or not believing in you."

Subaru: "You're not talking about believing or not believing..."

Rem: "As usual the evil smell still hasn't faded, but that's not the problem."

Subaru: “That’s not the problem...?”

Rem’s pale-blue eyes continue to do so, a glint of disbelief in them that would not vanish.

They were going to be separated from each other, even if merely temporarily. Her distrust— even though he was aware that its origin had been Subaru’s blunder in Guaral, he wished to get rid of it, even if but a tad.

Not so much for Subaru’s own sake, but for the sake of Rem’s feelings as she waited in the city.

Subaru: “Tell you what, Rem, I’ll do the best I can. How can I help you get rid of your anxiety, or whatever it is?”

Rem: “...Well, why are you still dressed like that then?”

Subaru: “Eh!?”

Subaru looked down at himself as Rem spoke so with scornful eyes.

A wig with long sable hair, white powder to hide flaws, an outfit carefully designed to hide his body’s contours, and ornaments that were not overly flamboyant—

Subaru: “Is there something strange about it...?”

Rem: “One of the strange things is that there’s nothing strange about it, and one of the strange things is that you’re still dressed like that even when you’re leaving the Fortress City. What defense do you have for that?”

Subaru: “No, that’s why I explained to you that this is something that needs to be done!”

While watching the temperature of Rem’s eyes plummet, Subaru let out a sound like a shriek as he continued his Natsumi Schwartz shtick.

It was completely unexpected that this outfit was playing a role in her disbelief, but as he had relayed to Rem, there was a good reason for this.

Subaru: “Rem, I already told you yesterday, we’re people from a neighboring country. And if my real name gets out, I’m going to be in danger across this country. That’s why I need it. I can’t be the real me, I must be Natsumi Schwartz...!”

Rem: “Huh, I see.”

Subaru: “A reply that doesn’t dispel your disbelief at all!”

The temperature of Rem’s eyes did not change, and in fact, she grew ever more distrustful.

However, this was a countermeasure devised in earnest after weighing up Subaru’s situation and the role he had been assigned.

—The name “Natsuki Subaru”, could not be permitted to gain a reputation in the Vollachian Empire.

Natsuki Subaru was already Emilia’s Knight, a major figure in the Kingdom of Lugunica. In other words, what he was doing now would undeniably count as impressive interference in the internal affairs of a neighboring country.

Subaru: “Interfering in another country’s internal affairs isn’t about being impressive or whatever.”

Whatever the case, the important point was that the consequences of Subaru’s actions, and the responsibility for them, did not rest with Subaru alone— Bluntly, it might cause trouble for Emilia.

As her Knight, Subaru, who had sworn to help her on her way to becoming the Monarch, could never allow her to be dragged down like that.

Subaru: “That’s where Natsumi Schwartz comes in. It doesn’t matter how well-known Natsumi becomes. Natsumi will just be a beautiful black-haired girl who suddenly appeared in the Vollachian Empire.”

Rem: “Are you finished?”

Subaru: “Not yet, no! Also, I wager that... Natsumi Schwartz’s name will leave a chance for my friends in Lugunica to notice me.”

Rather, that was the main reason for assuming the pseudonym of “Natsumi Schwartz”.

This instance in the Vollachia Empire did not mark the first time that Subaru had dressed up as a woman and called himself “Natsumi Schwartz”. There had been a time when he’d dressed up as a woman not as a sideshow at Roswaal’s mansion— but out of necessity, and his true identity had been known to everyone except Emilia.

The alias he had given at that time had been the same one. In other words, in the future, if Subaru’s existence became renowned in the Empire as Abel had hoped, and if the name that spread were to be that of “Natsumi Schwartz”, Emilia and the gang may have the opportunity to know that Subaru and the others have been sent to the Empire. Hence—

Subaru: “I’m dressed like this out of necessity.”

Rem: “—. -----. ----- . I understand.”

It took quite a while, but he was relieved that Rem understood his approach.

Anyway, that was the reason why Subaru’s crossdressing would be maintained for a little while longer. He did not want to undermine Rem’s trust by having it prolong itself, but that would depend on the situation.

Subaru: “Rem, if you have a problem, talk to Flop-san or Zikr-san. If it’s too difficult for a man, Mizelda-san and the others are there. Don’t keep it all to yourself.”

Rem: “It doesn’t make sense for you to say that, but I’ll consider it... You as well, please try not to bother Abel-san or Medium-san.”

Subaru: “I’ll just watch my back.”

Medium and Taritta aside, Subaru was not going to shy away from burdening Abel.

Once in a while, Abel should have his cool demeanor broken, struggle, and break a sweat.

Once they had said their goodbyes and passed a few words of caution, it was time to depart.

Repressing the difficulty of leaving before the journey—

Subaru: “Rem, where’s that girl?”

Rem: “You mean Louis-chan? I think she’s with Utakata right now...”

Subaru: “I see.”

Rem: “...You don’t want me to go and get her, do you?”

The tone of her voice dropped, and Rem gave him a questioning look.

The tone of her voice was not pleasant, though she knew Subaru’s intentions. Rather, the tone was one of deep-seated irritation and bitterness.

Since the battles at the City Hall, Subaru’s suspicions about Louis had remained unchanged, despite the fact that they’d had very little contact in their hectic schedule. In fact, his suspicions were never cleared up.

Even though she seemed to have a soft spot for Rem and Utakata, and was getting along well with the Shudraquians and the others, there was no telling when and where she might reveal her true nature.

In that sense, he was worried about leaving Louis behind. It was just that—

Rem: “You’ve already been keeping your eyes away from her for the entire duration of the mission to take down Guaral already, right?”

Subaru: “———”

Rem: “After all this time, it’s still at this.”

Upon being told that by Rem, Subaru had no words to reply.

If Louis was going to take any action, she had already possessed several chances to do so. So it was probably useless to keep on being wary of Louis.

Subaru: “For the time being, I’ve already told Kuna and the others that they should remain vigilant.”

Rem: “Stubborn...”

A minute whisper of a word, and having caught it, Subaru mulled over it for a moment.

The reason why he had not disclosed Louis's true nature and dangerous powers to Rem in the first place, was because she had no basis whatsoever to believe Subaru's story. To lose Rem's trust and alienate her by telling her about Louis's situation was not within his wishes.

But what about now?

Their relationship had improved, and she listened to him, albeit coldly. Maybe now she would not be so dismissive when he talked about Louis' true nature.

Subaru: "...No, don't do anything stupid."

Subaru shook his head and rejected the idea that had faintly popped into his head.

She might believe him, but even then it would be pointless. Thus far, Louis had not revealed her true colors. It was hard to believe that she would give away her true nature as soon as he talked to Rem. The situation would remain the same.

It would only make Subaru feel better, but in turn, it would increase Rem's anxiety.

There was no need to do that.

Rem: "...What's with that face?"

Subaru: "Yeah, I was just hoping that only good fortune rains down on Rem's life."

Rem: "Huh?"

Rem's line of sight became narrower, as Subaru attempted to keep the warmth welling up inside him at bay.

However, if he tried to say something, the conversation would go on and on and on and on.

???: "—Bro! It's high time we left."

So said Al, leaning against the carriage, waving his lone hand.

Behind him was a carriage and a single horse-like creature boasting a body as sizable as the carriage—a creature called a Galewind Horse, which was said to pull them along their journey.

Rem: "I've heard that it's a rare animal in Vollachia, it seems it's only given to Generals..."

Subaru: "Zikr-san lent it to me. She's actually female, so he's consistent..."

Rem: "Consistent...?"

Rem tilted her head, seemingly unconvinced by Subaru's words.

This was how Rem reacted to Subaru's words, for better or worse. Such happy circumstances would have to be put on hold for a while.

Al: "Oiii, bro?"

Rem: "Um, Al-san is calling for you."

Subaru: "Yeah, I know. I'm aware of that..."

Rem: "—?"

Subaru: "The soles of my shoes think it's hard to leave your side and lift off the ground... Ouch, ouch, ouch!"

The tip of the cane poked his back, and the sole of the shoe that should have been attached to the ground, left it. He was forced to take two or three more steps forward, opening the distance between him and Rem.

The distance between them became real.

Subaru: "Rem, I've told you many times..."

Rem: "I'll be careful. I'll also be vigilant. If I'm in trouble, I'll turn to someone else. Goodbye."

Subaru: "Uhh..."

Subaru's shoulders slumped and he wilted as he was told goodbye in a harsh fashion. Directing her eyes towards him, Rem sighed deeply and said,

Rem: "Take care, and have a good trip. I'll be waiting for your return."

Subaru: “Oh...”

Rem: “I’m not going to disappear all of a sudden... There are people other than you I trust.”

She added onto it, and Subaru reflected on it carefully.

Then he shook his head several times, even as Rem frowned in disgust, and,

Subaru: “—I’m off!”

And with a big wave of his hand, he was sent off by Rem.



???: “———”

The carriage was moving away, passing through the main gate of the Fortress City and disappearing into the distance.

The carriage was headed southeast of the city, to the Demon City of Chaosflame, where one of the most powerful people in the Empire was based, and the focus was on whether or not they could persuade that person to join them.

To be honest, if it meant recruiting someone, the choice to take Subaru with them was questionable.

???: “...I am certain that anyone would agree that you are putting in effort.”

With her cane, Rem squinted at the tracks of the carriage, which was no longer visible.

Subaru had been in a joking mood up until the moment they parted. He had made all sorts of excuses, but all Rem could think of was that he did not want to stop dressing as a woman.

Of course, it did not signify that she believed all of the excuses to be lies.

???: “They have parted. The city shall be a little more airy once the boisterous ones have left. I am not sure however, if they shall be bringing back good news, or Abel’s head.”

Rem: “—Priscilla-san.”

Suddenly, a voice called out from behind Rem as she stood there.

Without even needing to turn around, a beautiful woman who made a vivid impression in red stepped out beside her— Priscilla, wearing a luxurious dress and sparingly exposing her violent beauty.

Rem had not held a conversation with her since the latter had saved her life from Arakiya’s rampage, during her assault on the City Hall.

So with her suddenly speaking to Rem, her confusion and bewilderment grew stronger.

Rem: “...Thank you very much.”

Priscilla: “Hmm, what is this gratitude in regard to?”

Rem: “For what happened yesterday, at the City Hall. I was saved from that woman, Arakiya. Not only me, but everyone else as well. Thanks to you.”

Priscilla: “I saved many lives you say? In my opinion, the credit for saving their lives goes to you. You used your talent and skills to save those who were dying. It was not my intention to show mercy to them. Do not take the liberty of twisting mine actions.”

Rem: “I didn’t mean to...”

Rem thought to herself as she tried to say that she did not.

It was a bad habit to prematurely judge the thoughts and actions of others and their intentions, and try to fit them into one’s own mold. She remembered many times of such a thing, not pertaining only to Priscilla.

Considering her lost memories, she had only been alive for about two weeks.

Rem: “———”

Priscilla: “So, you will not state anything in riposte? That too, is an extremely dull decision, is it not?”

Rem: "...I'm sorry. I thought you were right. But I guess you can't twist the fact that I'm grateful to you, either?"

Priscilla: "Hoh?"

Speaking with interest, Priscilla pulled out a fan from her cleavage. Then opening it with a rapport, she hid her own shapely lips.

However, in her unconcealed eyes, there was a light of pleasure and opportunity that could not be concealed.

Priscilla: "I had heard that you had lost yourself, but... How dare you speak back to me?"

Rem: "Lost myself isn't quite the right expression. Just because I can't remember, doesn't mean it's gone."

Placing a hand on her chest, Rem defended herself from Priscilla's words.

If she had indeed disappeared, it would be no different from a dream unreachable by anyone. But Rem's lost memories were not gone. They were not in Rem, but in Subaru, who was desperately trying to attain them again.

If what he had stated was true, she had a twin sister.

She wondered if there was any trace of the person she had been before she lost her memories in that sister, or if there was any trace of her in the friends that Subaru had talked about, in the people she had not yet seen.

If Rem could be satisfied with the fact that everything in her was gone, and that everything was building up from where there was nothing, then---

Rem: "---Were I able to do that, my heart wouldn't be aching so much."

Priscilla: "-----"

Rem: "All the time, every second, I'm reminded of it. Every time I look into his eyes, I know I'm betraying his expectations."

Of course, Subaru probably did not mean to do that.

The stench was so thick and intense to the point it was difficult to even regard him— and whenever she peeked at it, his face was always desperate.

And that desperation was directed at the version of herself that had disappeared, not the Rem that remained.

Rem: “How selfish of me. I’m disgusted with myself...”

So she could not tell him that she was relieved to be apart, she found it difficult to tell him, who wished to not be separated from her.

And not only was she relieved, but also had this disgusting feeling.

Priscilla: “—What had you stated to be your name?”

Rem: “Eh?”

Priscilla: “Your name. Surely you shall not tell me you have likewise lost your name? But then again, you are not nameless, you are certainly called by your name. I am quite certain it is...”

Priscilla raised her gaze slightly, searching the void for an answer to her question.

Perhaps she would remember Rem’s name. Even in the short time she had been present here, Rem could sense that she was a very intelligent person.

At the same time, she was also a very mean person. Hence—

Rem: “—It’s Rem.”

And before Priscilla could say the wrong name on purpose, Rem said it herself.

Even though her memories had vanished, and there was no sign of them returning, and even though she was separated from the people who knew her in the past, at least the name she had been called and recognized for the past two weeks was real.

Priscilla: “Interesting.”

Priscilla muttered shortly after hearing that answer.

She then closed her fan with a snap, and lifted Rem's chin with the tip of the closed fan ever so gently. Pierced by the crimson eyes up in front of her, Rem's throat was scorched by that heated gaze.

But even though she was unable to word it, she stared back with intent in her eyes.

Priscilla: "Rem, I shall be keeping you by my side for a while."

Rem: "...By your side?"

Priscilla: "You may have the background and ambition, but not the ability. Your ugly healing magic shall be rehabilitated by me in moderation. Then it shall become something you may lay your eyes upon."

Rem: "—! You're going to teach me how to heal?"

Priscilla: "Nonsense. I hold no background in the healing arts. I only have an eye for beauty. I shall know what you are lacking when I see it."

Rem: "——"

The answer that came back was not the one Rem had expected, but in a way it was either more than she expected, or very far from what she had expected.

However, if Rem's only current skill—the healing magic able to heal others, could then be utilized, it was worth relying on Priscilla's words.

If only she had more power, she thought. It was something she regretted not having.

Rem: "But, Priscilla-san, aren't you returning to your base?"

Priscilla: "I shan't. I have also attached that Al fellow to Abel. It shall not be long before we see whether the conditions I have imposed on him can be met. I shall wait here. There will be some inconveniences, but... I shall summon Schult to resolve them."

Rem: "Ha, haa..."



Rem was unaware of what was tugging at her heartstrings, but Priscilla had settled on staying in Guaral. Either way, it would be helpful to have her as a mentor.

There were still many people in this city in need of Rem's poor healing skills. She could not leave the city without tending to them.

Priscilla: "Now, with that decided, prepare a room for me. I shall allow Schult to take care of the details, but we require a place to spend today and tomorrow."

Rem: "I understand. I'll have it ready for you right away."

Priscilla gave orders as if she owned the place, but Rem didn't feel like disobeying, so she obeyed.

Priscilla had a way of making others obey her, but Rem herself had no resistance to being ordered to do what needed to be done.

With a flurry of steps and a cane in hand, she returned to the City Hall and thought that she should consult with Zikr about Priscilla's stay and the arrangements for her room.

The People of Shudraq were not used to city life as well, and so she felt bad that she had to rely on Zikr for so many things.

However, he was a man who would not refuse, who would label something impossible, if solicited by a woman.

???: "Ah, Ree, there you *are*."

Rem: "Utakata-chan."

Inside the City Hall, on the way to the office where Zikr would be, she ran into a girl looking out of the corridor window— Utakata.

Upon noticing Rem's appearance, Utakata smiled at her with a friendly face. Rem could not avoid smiling in return, her cheeks relaxing.

Rem: "I'm sorry, I've been kind of busy."

Utakata: “Uu’s *fine*, composed *even*. I’m more worried about Taa. She’s been wobbling *around*.”

Rem: “Taritta-san, right...”

Newly appointed as Chieftain, Taritta was accompanying Subaru and the others on their journey.

Even in the eyes of the young Utakata, Taritta must have looked shaky, almost crushed by her sudden assignment. Still, it was admirable of her to seek her own way out, and take the first step to gain confidence.

While Rem had remained crouched in place, whining that she had nothing, the people around her continued to move forward, leaving Rem behind.

She definitely did not wish to curse the world with her whining and drag everyone down alongside her.

Rem: “Taritta-san will be fine. So, Utakata-chan, the others, and I, will protect the place to which Taritta-san will come back.”

Utakata: “Mhm, got *it*! Ree, you’re *dependable*.”

Rem: “I wonder. When you say that, I feel a little more confident.”

Rem’s cheeks relaxed slightly at Utakata’s unpretentious words.

Then suddenly, Rem noticed something strange and looked around. Utakata, standing in the aisle looking out the window, was alone. And there was no one else around.

It still seemed like an inappropriate environment for a child to be walking around on their lonesome, but she wasn’t trying to blame her for not being with an adult— Rather, it was something more fundamental.

Rem: “Are you alone, Utakata-chan? Where’s Louis-chan?”

Although she had been left to her own devices for a long time, Louis had grown quite fond of Utakata.

They were friends of the same age and seemed to have a comfortable relationship, which was why Utakata being alone was such a conspicuously uncomfortable situation.

Of course, she was probably overthinking this, but—

Rem: “Isn’t Louis-chan with you?”

Utakata: “Yes! Lou already *left*.”

Rem: “...Eh?”

Rem went stiff upon hearing Utakata’s words, the former’s head tilted back.

Stopping her thoughts from going blank for a moment, Rem did her best to use her brain to ascertain the truth of Utakata’s words.

Louis was not with her, so the meaning of Utakata’s words was—

Rem: “L-Louis-chan’s—”

Utakata: “Mhm, she’s *gone*! Uu helped her get into the *carriage*.”

And the brave and courageous Shudraq girl puffed up her chest with pride, speaking those words to Rem, in a completely nonchalant manner.

Arc 7 Chapter 34 - A Quarrel in the Carriage

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 4 “Chaotic Demon City”, Parts 1-2

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Swan, Translation checked by [Taurace](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

The carriage moved slowly, but not to the extent of being idyllic, down the road.

The chestnut-haired Galewind Horse, swinging its huge body with a delicacy that belied its sturdy figure, was carefully escorting the carriage carrying Subaru and the others.

Subaru: “How predictable, we’ve got Leidy, who isn’t quite Lady²¹... Given it’s Zikr-san’s beloved horse.”

Subaru recalled this as he looked at the Galewind Horse as it dashed, its master in the forefront of his mind.

Zikr’s beloved horse, which they had borrowed, was named Leidy— a name very close in meaning to “lady”, and a surprisingly fateful one for a person dubbed the Womanizer.

In any case, thanks to Leidy’s efforts, the group’s journey to the Demon City of Chaosflame had been progressing smoothly. If things continued at this pace, they expected to arrive in about four days.

Subaru: “But it’s not just about arriving, you know. Not only the reputation of member of the Nine Divine Generals we’re going to meet, but the sound of the name «Demon City» is also scary in the first place.”

The Demon City, a city bearing the word “demon” in its name. It seemed unlikely to be a simple matter.

²¹ Subaru is making a pun on how Zikr’s horse’s name, “レイディ”, is very close to the English word “lady”, “レディ”. This is technically English, but I’ll leave it as-is for obvious reasons.

He'd gotten word that it was a melting pot of a diverse mix of races, but was that enough to crown the city with the words "chaos" and "demon"?

With the fact that one of the Nine Divine Generals, someone who often caused a rebellion, was in charge included, there was the impression that they were only trying to urge on Subaru's sense of danger— That was one of the reasons why he had not brought Rem along.

Subaru: "I wonder what kind of chaos awaits us..."

Al: "As chaotic as it sounds, it still confuses the hell out of me. That outfit and the bro I know don't seem to go together quite as well, and it's starting to look like a *fuguai*²²."

Subaru: "Ah? You're still saying these things?"

Subaru, who was in the front seat of the spacious carriage, looking out the window at the back of Leidy's nimble running figure, turned around while gently using his hand to stroke his long black hair blowing in the wind.

Raising his chin as if he were exasperated was Al, sitting at the back of the carriage.

Al was occupying a three-seater in a slouched posture. He then hooked his fingers on the chin of his helmet, making his raised head look down.

Al: "You're definitely doing that on purpose."

With a bitter tone, he blurted that out due to Subaru's behavior.

Subaru shrugged his shoulders, feeling disappointed at Al's strong rejection. Surprisingly, Al was the second person after Rem to criticize Subaru's crossdressing.

Abel, the Shudraqs, the O'Connell siblings, and Zikr, all of them naturally indulged him once they accepted it, but Al kept harping on it.

²² English flip. Means "bug/ flaw" (不具合), originally "バグ" (bug).

Subaru: “The same mouth that had said they were going to support me is now complaining... So that whole mysterious conversation was a lie?”

Al: “It was no lie, and my decision to help you’s genuine bro, but that’s not the same thing as this. I’m sure you’ll be able to understand why I ain’t happy with your crossdressing, bro.”

Subaru: “If you’re on my side, you’ll have to accept me as I am in the meanwhile.”

Al: “You sure you wanna keep being called bro when in that disguise? For real?”

Once someone reiterated this to him, even Subaru would feel that it was a bit unreasonable.

Natsuki Subaru and Natsumi Schwartz— albeit the two names may share the same body, there was a clear difference in the way they were and the way they stood.

In other words, Natsuki Subaru was his grounded self, and Natsumi Schwartz was an idealized image of his own fickle self.

Subaru: “Of course, I don’t want to be a woman. It’s about self-confidence and all that.”

Al: “I didn’t ask!”

Despite being rebuffed out loud, Subaru looked down at his body and changed his perception.

Natsumi Schwartz had now been recreated with the use of a wig and makeup, but unlike the time he was posing as a dancer, his role in the future would be more intellectual.

Therefore, the costumes and makeup had been put together to reflect that impression.

The red-colored outfit with a collar was a one-of-a-kind design based on the uniforms of the Vollachian Empire’s officers— the one worn by Zikr had a similar design. He didn’t normally wear a cloak unless necessary as it inhibited his movement, but he was proud of the fact that this bluff was working.

Further down were pants, on his feet were tough boots, and on his head lay a military cap with a bird’s feather on it.

This was the complete picture of the Female Military Strategist, Natsumi Schwartz.

Subaru: “Well, I guess I’m more of a female soldier than a female strategist. When you think of women in military attire, you’d expect them to be dressed as men, right?”

Al: “Even when I’m literally looking at the fact, of you, bro, crossdressing as a woman, who’s crossdressed as a man, my confusion is only getting worse.”

Subaru: “I don’t want to stand out, so it’s put together in the Empire’s style. It’s a male look, so I drew a bit of inspiration from Crusch-san’s *shikou*²³.”

Al: “I ain’t sure if the Duchess’ll be pleased with that expression, saying that you got a little inspiration from your previous encounters with her... Am I the only one who thinks that this is strange? What do you think about it, Emperor-san?”

Al raised his right arm in exasperation to Subaru, who explained the concept. With that, Al then turned his lifted right arm to the front, pointing at the figure in front of him.

In the middle seat of the carriage, or in other words, the position where he was endlessly sandwiched in between their conversation, was Abel, looking out the window with a grim expression.

He seemed to be pondering something with a serious look on his face. He raised his eyebrows at the imprudent name Al used, and without turning around, he coldly voiced a “Clown”.

Abel: “I do not have the recollection of allowing you to call me that. Know that one careless word can jeopardize the very existence of the Empire. If you do not, you shall lose more than just your other arm.”

Al: “Ugh, gimme a break. I’ve gotten used to it, but an inconvenience’s an inconvenience. If I lose another one, it’ll be more than just an inconvenience.”

Abel: “Then you should bear that in mind.”

Al: “*Neneee*, the imperial Way’s not even funny. It’s hard for *sanmaime* like ourselves. Right, bro?²⁴”

²³ Engrish flip. Means “taste/liking” (嗜好), originally “テイスト” (taste).

²⁴ Two Engrish flips. First one means “heyhey” (ねね), originally “heyhey” (へいへーい). Second one means “comedian” (三枚目), originally “コメディアン” (comedian).

Subaru: "I don't want to be asked for my agreement."

The atmosphere was tense, with no room for jokes or light-hearted conversation, but Subaru had no intention of criticizing the Empire, like saying that it was a problem of the country's character.

At most, as an individual, he found Abel to be difficult to get along with. The answer itself was light-hearted, so it was a complaint that he had never felt on the surface.

Of course, when it came to issues of beliefs and values, it did not stop at that.

Al: "So, what do you think of bro's outfit, Abel-chan?"

Abel: "-----"

For a moment, Abel's brow creased at the new name.

Subaru was surprised by Al's daredevil approach, but after a few moments of silence, Abel snorted roughly at the insolence and disregarded him.

Was it better than being called "Emperor-san"? Unsure of Abel's thoughts on this, Subaru suppressed an inner chill with a sigh.

In the meantime, Abel looked at Subaru again to answer Al's question,

Abel: "Yes, it is a ridiculous look, but I do not care as long as it pays off. You should separate your abilities from your hobbies."

Subaru: "Don't stab me in the back under the guise of backing me up. How many times do I have to tell you that it's not a hobby, but a necessity? Do you think I dress like a woman because I like it?"

Abel: "-----"

Subaru: "Don't just say nothing!"

Because of the suggestive silence, Subaru's suspicions were unfairly intensified.

Naturally, this was a very unpleasant understanding for Subaru. He did not want to dress as a woman at all, if it was not required.

However, if there was even the slightest possibility that it would resolve the situation, he would not exclude crossdressing as an option. That was all there was to it.

Subaru: “Everyone has a proper... argument prepared by them, listen.”

Al: “You said you were armed with an argument. Anyway, I’m pretty sure it’s a cliché. The Emperor who was expelled from the throne recruits allies to regain it... In that case, it’s only natural that there’s a position for a mysterious woman to accompany him.”

Subaru: “Yeah, that’s right. Like a strategist or a mage. And usually in those stories they have that sort of position be the *onnashujinkou*²⁵... I’m not the *onnashujinkou*!”

Al: “Don’t get mad even though you said it yourself. You’d surprise everyone, not to mention me.”

Subaru was indignant, but his intentions were not understood by anyone other than his fellow countryman Al.

In the first place, there were many phrases that would not be understood even in their homeland. Al’s knowledge was quite close to Subaru’s, as evidenced by the fact that he could even employ it.

Subaru: “...I never asked about which time period he came from, or anything in depth.”

So far, even though Subaru had shared the information that he and Al were from the same place, they had never talked about which period they had arrived from.

Al had once told Subaru that he had been summoned to this other world nearly twenty years ago.

Furthermore, his experience had been so terrible, that he had even lost one of his arms.

Though the confession itself had been done without a care, the reality of it was not so frivolous.

The anguish and despair that Al had endured must have been a constant part of his everyday life. Al was a man who had been tormented by the harshness of this other world much more than Subaru.

²⁵ English flip. Means “heroine/female protagonist” (女主人公), originally “ヒロイン” (heroine).

Now that he was speaking about it, he realized how blessed he was compared to him.

At the same time, he was wondering what the difference was between himself and Al.

Because of this fear, Subaru had not tried to have deep conversations with Al, and Al had not tried to go any further either.

However, considering the language used and the sub-cultural topics that they could understand, the original world where Subaru and Al lived must have been in the same time frame— If he had been summoned twenty years ago, he must have been the same age and from the same epoch.

The current age difference between Subaru and Al was merely a function of the time in this other world they had been summoned to. Henceforth, despite the age difference, he and Subaru were on the same wavelength in their conversations.

—That seemed to be the cause of the vague tingling sensation Subaru felt when interacting with him.

Al: “—I hate clichés.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Al: “A suspicious mage beside the Emperor... Ain’t that a cliché? What about that?”

Al’s light-hearted comment snapped Subaru, whose thoughts had gone astray, back to reality.

Blinking his eyes, Subaru nodded his head in agreement with what he called “a cliché”, with a “Yeah”.

Subaru: “It’s a cliché, indeed. A bewitching female mage seduces the Emperor and slowly turns him into a puppet of her will... And then the prosperous country collapses.”

Abel: “I shall not allow it to collapse on its own. I shall take it back no matter what. It just—”

Subaru: “Just?”

Abel: “It was neither a mage nor a woman, but it is true that there was one dubbed the Stargazer.”

Subaru & Al: “—Stargazer?”

The words from Abel's mouth were met with overlapped doubts from both Subaru and Al.

It was a word they had never heard before, but they thought it strange.

Subaru had never heard of this word before, but strangely enough, he held an idea of the characters in his head. And once the characters fit, the role of the word also came to mind, vaguely.

Subaru: "Maybe they're a Feng Shui master, or something of the sort... kinda like the position of a fortune teller?"

Al: "It's more like a prophet, ain't it? I mean, that's what the stone tablet does in the Kingdom."

Subaru: "Yeah, the Dragon History Tablet, they called it..."

Convinced by Al's words, Subaru retrieved the knowledge of the prophetic tablet passed down in the Kingdom from his head.

Although Subaru hadn't laid eyes on the actual artifact, it seemed that the tablet contained information about future events that would occur in the Kingdom of Lugunica, and was said to be a useful artifact that also provided solutions to said problems.

However, having forecasted that the Royal Family of Lugunica would succumb to illness, the Tablet had presented an approach for the selection of the next Monarch— In other words, the Royal Selection, in which Emilia and Priscilla were partaking.

Honestly, it was a result that made him tilt his head at the idea of being grateful to the prophecy tablet.

Subaru: "If it was serious about giving advice on how to save the Kingdom, it would tell them how to cure or stop the disease in the first place..."

As he deepened his knowledge as a Knight of a Royal Candidate, he learned that the Royal Family of Lugunica possessed no tyrannical behavior or imbecility, and were, at the very least, loved by their people.

Many of their subjects and citizens had been saddened by their deaths, but none had been happy about it— It was still a mystery as to why the Dragon History Tablet had forsaken them.

Subaru: “If the other party’s a slab of stone, it’d be a pipe dream to get any answers.”

Al: “If they’re a stone slab, then sure, but the Stargazer ain’t one, right? What role did he play in the court, Abel-chan?”

Abel: “—Not too far from all of your perception. Because the power of the Stargazer was to peer into the future, to preserve the Empire.”

Abel’s answer to the question was roughly in line with the impression Subaru had gleamed from the name “Stargazer”. Nevertheless, there was one problem.

Subaru: “...But they weren’t able to predict things. You were driven out, after all.”

Abel: “As I told you before. The Stargazer’s power is for the preservation of the Empire— It does not necessarily coincide with my safety.”

Subaru: “That would mean... that it’d be better for the Empire if you were chased away.”

Abel: “At least, I suppose that is what the Stargazer has settled upon.”

Abel crossed his arms quietly as he answered nonchalantly.

It could be argued that the Tablet and the Stargazer, two objects with similar roles, had both overlooked the plight of what should be the most noble position in their respective countries.

To suspect a connection between the Kingdom and the Empire was tempting, however—

Subaru: “Before that, I’m starting to feel that there’s a problem with you, who got abandoned by the Prime Minister, your right-hand man, and this prophet. You sure it’s okay to put you back on the Emperor’s throne?”

Al: “Oioi, that’s too *massugu*²⁶ of a fireball, bro.”

Subaru: “No, don’t you feel concerned when hearing the situation surrounding this as well!?”

²⁶ English flip. Means “straight” (まっすぐ), originally “ストレート” (straight).

Al: "But that's it. Afro General approved of Abel-chan, didn't he?"

Subaru: "Yeah, that's right. Then I guess it's okay..."

With the mention of the Afro General, Zikr, Subaru was peacefully convinced.

Zikr was on Abel's side, which was a relief, although it made him worry about a lot of other things. On the other hand, without Zikr, it was highly doubtful that he could have gone along with Abel, given his suspicions.

Regardless of how much he wanted to get himself and Rem back to the Kingdom safely, it did not mean that he did not care what happened to the Empire.

To be honest, Subaru held more bad memories of the Empire than good ones, but there were many people he wished to see happy, including the People of Shudraq and the O'Connell siblings.

Subaru: "I'm starting to get pretty worried about including you in that, but..."

Abel: "Whatever you say, no matter what the Stargazer sees regarding the future, I have my answer."

Subaru: "-----"

Abel: "If the Stargazer decides that I cannot remain on the throne, I shall not comply. If the Stargazer declares that my presence shall destroy the Empire, then I shall disprove that with my own hands."

Abel's declaration was a little too passionate to be casual.

Abel's fervor was equal to the fervor with which he had stated he would take back his throne on numerous other occasions. This was Abel's unyielding position and his unshakable heart.

Subaru did not doubt Abel's last line, because he could feel that it was not merely revenge or rebellion, but a larger and purer belief.

Other than that, he really wished more of the surrounding parts could be embellished to make it believable.

???: "—Ah! Guuuys! Look ahead a little bit, look ahead-!"

Subaru: “Hm?”

Just as the conversation was coming to a close, from the front of the carriage— from the coachman’s bench suddenly came a boisterous voice, and Subaru and the others turned their attention to it.

Medium, who was holding the reins of Leidy on the coachman’s bench, was the one to raise that lively voice.

It seemed she had not been allowed to take the reins during her travels together with Flop, so she had taken the initiative by speaking up, “I want to!”.

Medium, her tall, slender frame tucked into the platform, grasped the reins in one hand while pointing to the path ahead with the other.

Medium: “I see a lot of hustle and bustle up ahead! Can you see it too, Natsumi-chan?”

Subaru: “Uh... Barely looks like anything, I guess.”

Subaru leaned out of the window of the carriage, but he could not be sure of what Medium had been talking about with “hustle and bustle”. Maybe it was the angle, or maybe it was just his eyesight.

Subaru had believed to be in possession of good eyesight, but in this other world, that was no longer the case.

People from this other world had eyesight of a different level. Emilia probably had a visual acuity of five-point-zero. Subaru had the impression he had seen a TV program in his original world that said people in Africa had exceptionally good eyesight.

In this regard, Taritta’s eyesight, as one of the amazonesses of this other world, was quite impressive.

Subaru: “So, what about you, Taritta-san? Can you see it?”

Taritta: “Wait a minute, *that’s...*”

She answered Subaru’s call, but Taritta was neither inside the carriage nor on the driver’s platform.

Leaning out of the window, Subaru beckoned her; she was atop of carriage, of all places.

Positioned on the roof of the moving carriage, from which Taritta served as a sentinel keeping watch of all directions.

Al: “Is it just me, or is it kinda uncomfortable to have people on the roof like that?”

Subaru: “I don’t know about Abel, but I’m used to it with our Garfiel.”

Al mentioned Taritta whose task lay atop the horse-drawn carriage, but Subaru, familiar with Garfiel who wished to play the same role, was not particularly uncomfortable with it.

In fact, in this other world, it was essential to be vigilant while on the move, so it will have proper effects rather than just a *chuuni*²⁷ thing. The fact that Abel did not halt her was proof of that.

Taritta: “...Looks like Imperial Soldiers are *gathering*. Looks like an Ox Cart or something is being stopped in front of *us*.”

Subaru: “That’s...”

Abel: “—A checkpoint.”

So muttered Abel to himself after receiving Taritta’s report and understanding the situation.

The checkpoint that came to Subaru’s mind was the one at the main gate of Guaral. However, the fact that the checkpoint was not at the entrance to the city, but in the middle of the road, seized his attention.

It was natural to check the comings and goings in a city, but the impression given by checkpoints on the roads was different, in that they were in response to some kind of anomaly.

In short, they were most likely looking for something specific.

Subaru: “No way, us? Arakiya got away from us, and that’s how things got spread?”

²⁷ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “«Chuuni», also known as «chuunibyou» (中二病), or literally translated as «middle two disease» or, alternatively, «middle-school second-year disease». Well-known term to describe kids in middle school who have delusions of grandeur, like special powers.”

Abel: “Of course, it is inevitable that information shall eventually leak out from Arakiya. But I do not believe it can move as quickly and accurately as this. In addition, the Demon City is in the opposite direction of the Imperial Capital.”

Subaru: “So location-wise, they shouldn’t have any reported information?”

Abel: “Yes— Although there is the matter of her companion, is there not?”

With his arms crossed, Abel was concerned not about Arakiya, but about her companion.

Arakiya’s companion was the person who had retrieved her from Guaral.

Al: “The guy who dragged Lil’ Miss Arakiya away? He’s the kinda guy who’d fearlessly ride into the middle of enemy territory in the situation, he’s proly a sharp and able person.”

Subaru: “A sharp and able person...”

Abel’s concern and Al’s point of view made Subaru imagine something unpleasant.

As far as the Imperial Soldiers in the Fortress City were concerned, Subaru had an idea of who the “sharp ones” were. And amongst the Imperial Soldiers who had surrendered after the fall of the City Hall, the object of Subaru’s fear could not be counted.

Perhaps they had mixed amidst the soldiers who had abandoned the city and fled.

Subaru: “No way.”

He did not want to think that it was *that* man who had taken Arakiya away, no matter how much he wanted to.

He wished that the fate of their relationship would not grow any deeper.

Subaru: “—Right now, we need to focus on the problem at hand. What do we do? Do you think we can bypass it?”

Taritta: “Right *now*, I don’t think they’re even aware of us *yet*...”

Medium and Taritta, two people with excellent eyesight, had been the first to spot them.

Before the Soldiers ahead of them noticed, they could go off the road and avoid the checkpoint. If nothing about them was found to be amiss, they could pass through brazenly, but if they had contraband or something, they would have no choice but to evade. But—

Abel: “—Hold it, do not take detours.”

Subaru: “Ahh?”

And just before he gave the order to get off the road, Abel, of all people, stopped him.

In response to his call for restraint, Subaru turned his suspicious eyes to Abel.

Subaru: “You tell us to not take a detour, what else do you want us to do? If they find you, we’re in trouble.”

Abel: “I want to know their goal. If the fall of Guaral is the matter, the developments would be too swift. If it is my whereabouts, I would like to learn what the Soldiers say they are searching for.”

Subaru: “Sooo, what’s going to happen when they find you? You’ll poke the beehive and we’ll end up getting into a raging *kuruma okkake*²⁸.”

Of course, the possibility existed that they would be caught on the spot.

Of the five people in the horse-drawn carriage, only three, excluding Subaru and Abel, were capable of fighting, but their total strength was not much different from that of the dancing troupe that had ridden into Guaral. In the event that they were to escape in their carriage, it would be extremely difficult to shake the enemy off on the wide-open road.

Subaru: “The conditions are too bad. Or do you have a better plan?”

Abel: “There is— You.”

Subaru: “Heh?”

²⁸ English flip. Means “car chase scene” (車追っかけ), originally “カーチェイス” (car chase).

Subaru was stunned as he weighed the risks and rewards and decided that the odds were not in his favor.

They were supposed to be talking about the odds of taking on a dangerous bet right now.

Subaru: "What do you mean, you want me to be the one to appear out there?"

Abel: "There is already a precedent for this in the Fortress City. The carriage is disguised so as not to be recognizable as one from the army. It shall be as we agreed upon in advance."

Subaru: "Wasn't that just preparation for small talk while on the road!?"

Abel's brash statement had been a set-up for making conversation with other vendors and travelers along the way, not a premise to fool the carefully watching Imperial Soldiers.

Yet, Abel turned a deaf ear to Subaru's complaints that sounded like screams,

Abel: "I shall hide at the bottom of the wagon. You get the Soldiers to talk."

Subaru: "Wait, wait, wait, are you serious?"

Abel: "Do not allow the soldiers to look into the bottom of the carriage. You too might lose your life."

Subaru: "I don't know why you're so high and mighty...!"

With that said, Abel stood up from his seat and put his hands on the floor. There was a slight gap in the floor underneath the seats, and the floorboards flipped up, allowing him to descend onto the bottom part of the carriage.

The horse-drawn carriage had been originally intended to be pulled by the Galewind Horse of General Second-Class Zikr.

The exterior of the carriage had been replaced to disguise the fact that it was related to the Imperial Army, but this did not mean that its functions had been disabled. The carriage, designed to be used by people of high rank, had a mechanism which allowed the floorboards to come off, so that they could hide in case of emergency.

Subaru was sure the one who had crafted this horse-driven carriage had never imagined that it would be the Emperor who would be hiding there.

Anyway, Abel quickly lifted the floorboards and twisted his thin body into the narrow space. In earnest, he had entrusted the rest to Subaru.

It was not so much daring as it was pride.

Al: “Good grief, Abel-chan’s so pushy. Nevertheless, we got no choice but to do it, bro.”

That was Al’s comment about Abel, who had only made his point and quickly made his retreated. His words after that were based on the reaction of the checkpoint in the carriage’s path.

It seemed that their presence had become known to their side as well.

Taritta: “Natsumi, they’re aware of our *presence*.”

Medium: “Then, it looks like we have no choice but to go! Alriiight~, good luuuck~, Natsumi-chan!”

Courteously, Taritta’s and Medium’s shouts eliminated the option of a detour. Changing direction at this point would be like advertising “It’s inconvenient to have the carriage inspected”.

Therefore, they had no option but to proceed as His Majesty, the Emperor, desired, even though it was annoying.

Al: “Bro, you ready?”

Subaru: “—Yeah, yeah, I know right! It’s nice to meet you!”

Al: “...Well, that was some switch.”

Delivering a light tap to his cheeks with both hands, Subaru flipped a switch inside himself.

If he slapped his cheeks hard enough, his makeup would be ruined. If he scratched his head, his hair would get messy. If he did not shelve his inner irritation, his words would become rough— He could not fool the Imperial Soldiers with that.

He had to play the part that was required of him, and accomplish the duty that was expected of him.

That was the first step for Natsuki Subaru to regain the lost trust.

Subaru: “Oh, thank you for your service, gentlemen of the Army. What can I do for you?”

Subaru said, as he leaned out of the window, smiling as dainty and charming as he could, and waved cheerfully to the Imperial Soldiers who stopped the carriage.



—The Imperial Soldiers who had halted the carriage did not take the presence of a carriage carrying only Al, in addition to the three “women”, Medium, Taritta and Subaru, seriously.

What they had requested, was the identity of the group and the purpose of the trip.

As they had agreed upon beforehand, Al and Medium had been hired to guard Subaru, the daughter of a lower-ranking count, and Taritta was to be Subaru’s servant.

Before leaving Guaral, Taritta’s style had undergone trial and error, and been changed from the Amazoness style that was instantly recognizable as that of the People of Shudraq.

Currently, Taritta was dressed in the style of a male butler, which was Subaru’s preference. Al given rave reviews, his words being “Bro’s dressed as a woman who’s dressed as a man, and Taritta-chan’s dressed as a man... I don’t understand anything anymore”.

Anyway, the Imperial Soldiers at the checkpoint had not been suspicious of Subaru and the others’ kind of behavior.

Only when being told that their destination was Chaosflame did they display a meaningful hesitation, saying, “Well, that’s...”. Even among them, the Demon City’s impression seemed to be poor.

Soldier: “I wouldn’t really recommend visiting the Demon City, young lady.”

Subaru: “Even if you say so, I’m afraid my father will be angry with me. Even though I’m a noble, it’s not a luxury the family of a lowly Count can afford...”

Soldier: “Hmm, I see. Well, you seem to have a good head on your shoulders, so I guess there’s nothing to worry about.”

Subaru: “Oh my, you flatter me.”

Smiling with the back of his hand over his mouth, Subaru elegantly sidestepped the Soldier’s suspicion.

In general, there seemed to be no problem in getting through the checkpoint. The only thing left to do was—

Subaru: “Well, there appears to be quite strict security... Has something happened?”

Soldier: “Oh no, it’s nothing serious. There’s deserters from a recent skirmish up north near Buddheim, so we’re looking for them... And we’re also looking for a wanted criminal.”

Subaru: “Wanted, is it?”

Careful not to let his voice waver, Subaru frowned at the sound of that.

Fortunately, the soldier did not seem to notice Subaru’s surging inner thoughts and nodded, “Yeah”.

Soldier: “There’s talk of a man wanted in the Imperial Capital being sighted around here. It’s said that he’s about fifty-years-old and has blue hair, do you have any knowledge of him?”

Subaru: “—No, I’m afraid not. But to have deserters from the Imperial Soldiers, who are renowned for their strength, makes me worry that the mantra of the Empire is being disturbed.”

Medium: “It’s okay, Natsumi-chan! We’re here for you, so don’t worry, don’t worry! Let’s hold our chests out strong!”

Subaru: “Well, that’s reassuring, Medium-san. Ohohoho.”

Subaru had not meant for that to happen, but Medium’s blunt words made the Imperial Soldiers lose their composure.

There was the possibility that by probing into it, they would become suspicious, but it seemed that they had been successful in evading that worry. Taritta, too, was silent and played the role of a butler who did not interrupt her master unnecessarily.

She had a tendency to be shy, though, so the silence may just have been natural.

And, except for the women, the most worrying person was Al and his suspicious appearance—

Al: “My oh my, thank you Soldiers for all your hard work. It’s thanks to your hard work that a half-wit like me’s allowed to work so lazily.”

Soldier: “...We are only working for the well-being of the Empire. Definitely not for someone as weak and lazy as you.”

Al: “I know, I know. I understand where I stand.”

Al, too, had perfectly handled the disrespectful move from the Imperial Soldiers, having been met with scorn.

It was hard to discern if he was acting or not, but he had a good point. The unnaturalness of hiring the one-armed Al as a bodyguard was also quashed ahead of time by Subaru.

Subaru: “It wouldn’t look good if I didn’t say I hired him as a bodyguard, would it? With his arm like that, I’m sure he used to be a Soldier serving this country as well.”

Soldier: “...If he resigned his position because of his injuries, there’s nothing for us to say. Just be very careful, because it doesn’t mean that he doesn’t have evil intentions.”

Treating Al’s arm as a strength rather than a weakness reinforced the rationale for his frivolous attitude.

The Imperial Soldiers, with their aversion to weakness and their respect for the strong, were also considerate of those who had retired from the front lines due to unhealable wounds.

—With that, they had been capable of getting through the checkpoint without any major problems.

Medium: “Well, Natsumi-chan was really good. I’m so impressed with you!”

Medium praised him as he waved from the platform towards the Imperial Soldiers in the distance. At her words, Subaru shook his head with a, “No, no”,

Subaru: “It’s no big deal. If the checkpoint had been set up for a more pressing reason, we would’ve had to use a lot of finesse to get through... In that sense, I guess you could say we were lucky.”

Medium: “Yeah? Then I guess so. I’m often told I’m lucky by big bro too! I feel that way too.”

Subaru: “Hehe, both Medium-san and Flop-san are naturals at finding happiness, aren’t they?”

Subaru smiled at Medium’s pleasant answer as he put his hand on his cheek.

At this exchange between Subaru and Medium, Taritta, who was sitting in the front seat of the carriage with an exhausted look on her face, turned around. Subaru tilted his head at her meaningful gaze, as she was relieved of her tension and patted her chest in relief.

Subaru: “What’s the matter, Taritta-san. Is there a problem?”

Taritta: “No, I don’t have a *problem*, *but...* Natsumi, how can you be so *bold*? I’ve been wondering that ever since you planned to dress as a *dancer*.”

Subaru: “...Yeah, I guess.”

Taritta had found Subaru’s transformation into a woman hard to get used to.

The time Taritta had spent with him in women’s clothing was the same as Abel’s; ever since they had entered Guaral. And yet, it seemed strange to her.

In a way, Abel and Flop had been able to pull it off with zero effort— Bianca and Flora were able to overcome all problems with their natural good looks.

Of course, Subaru’s character, Natsumi Schwartz, had no such sort of grounding.

There was a quality that could not be disguised by clothes or makeup alone, and it was a problem that inevitably arose for those who were not in its possession— It took effort to compensate for that.

Subaru: “So, I just tried my hardest, that’s all.”

The perfection of Natsumi Schwartz was part of the results of humanity's accumulated quest for beauty.

Were it not for these pioneers, Subaru's crossdressing would not have been accepted even at a school festival. Behind its success, were the forefathers' many wishes and efforts.

Because of this, he also had a sense of being unable to disregard what had been established.

Taritta: "I'm jealous of your *confidence*... I don't have *that*."

Subaru: "Confidence... What I have is trust in Natsumi Schwartz, but confidence is a different thing."

Taritta: "Eh? Eh? Eh?"

Al: "Oioi, bro, don't do that. You'll confuse Taritta-chan. That level of thinking's a bit too much for us to follow, y'know?"

In place of Taritta, her flickering to and fro, Al interrupted Subaru's self-assertion.

He was unaware that he was talking about something so difficult that it would confuse the two of them. He had merely stated that even though it was difficult to believe in himself, he could believe in the ideal image he had created in his mind — one that he could believe in.

Subaru: "I always envision myself as the best version I can be— you know?"

Taritta: "I-I find that a difficult concept to *understand*..."

Subaru: "But I'd recommend trying that mindset, you know? Comparing yourself to the person you admire can be painful, but... you can envision your ideal self."

Taritta: "——"

Taritta's eyes widened slightly as Subaru put his hand on his chest and spoke.

Something about it seemed to resonate with her in no small manner.

Taritta: "*Envision, your ideal self*..."

Resonated such, that it seemed that she had quietly stored it within her heart

Al: “Deserters aside, dunno what the wanted guy did. Even if it’s a big help that Abel-chan’s story hasn’t spread, that was a pretty big deal.”

Subaru: “Well... A blue-haired man of about fifty years of age, I’m sure there are many gentlemen who fit that description, and I can even think of one in my memory, you know?”

In his original world, blue hair did not occur naturally, but in this other world, it could be seen as a not-so-uncommon hair color, Rem at the forefront.

The wanted man at the checkpoint earlier also fit that description, as did the heavy drinker who had once helped him in the city of Guaral—the mercenary named Rowan also possessed said characteristic.

Unfortunately, Rowan’s demonstration of his abilities had been foiled by Todd’s surprise attack, but Subaru believed that he would have been quite good were he able to do battle in a proper fashion.

However, Subaru did not believe him to be a wanted man, one that would require the mobilization of so many Imperial Soldiers. So it was possibly a matter of someone else, with similar characters, that was wanted.

Subaru: “In any case, Abel’s situation hasn’t been reported to the ordinary soldiers yet... Given there’s no disorder in the Imperial Capital, it seems safe to assume that a body double’s acting as Emperor.”

Al: “Dunno if that’s a good thing or a bad thing. Honestly, I think it would’ve been more convenient for us if the Emperor’d been absent and that there was a lotta commotion.”

Subaru: “I feel like it has its advantages and disadvantages. Setting handling things if he’s discovered aside, the gravity of finding Abel remains unchanged.”

If the Emperor’s absence were to become public and the Empire thrown into turmoil, it was currently unknown whether Subaru and the others would be able to handle it effectively. At the very least, Abel’s perception was that they were still lacking in strength to claim the throne, and Subaru was of the same opinion.

However, the insistence of going through the checkpoint had made him very nervous.

Al: “At any rate, now that we’ve escaped the checkpoint, let’s get Abel-chan outta there.”

Subaru: “Right. Besides, I want to complain about something.”

Nodding at Al’s suggestion, Subaru crossed his arms over his fake cleavage to assert his indignation.

The reason for Subaru’s indignation was, of course, the unreasonable reason given so they would go through the checkpoint. But beyond that, it was the reckless flailing by Abel during the checkpoint.

While talking with the Soldiers, noises had echoed from the bottom of the carriage several times, which had been disguised with great difficulty.

In the end, it was settled that Subaru, posing as a woman, had a stomachache, saying “It’s not easy being a lowly count...”. But it was an outrage that damaged the reputation of the elegant Natsumi Schwartz.

Subaru: “It seems that His Majesty, the Emperor, isn’t fully aware of his position.”

Al: “Oh bro, you seem angry. Well, guess I should be mad too.”

Al agreed with Subaru, who was eager to complain to His Majesty, the reckless Emperor.

Then Al flipped up the floorboard, and Subaru peered into the bottom of the rocking carriage to complain bitterly to the face that appeared—

Subaru: “Hey, Abel, what’s going on? You have no idea how hard it was for us to cover up for you after you did that—”

???: “Uu—!”

Subaru: “Uhyaahhh— Hk!?”

Subaru’s “Or at least I think”, which was about to come with his candid advice, was swallowed by a shout, causing him to jump away landing in Taritta’s arms. All of a sudden, Taritta was holding him in a bridal carry, but he did not have the leisure to admire her core strength.

What appeared was not Abel breaking into laughter— but a young girl of golden hair.

The girl was more than familiar to him, and he had more than enough bad memories of her.

It was Louis, a girl who should not be present.

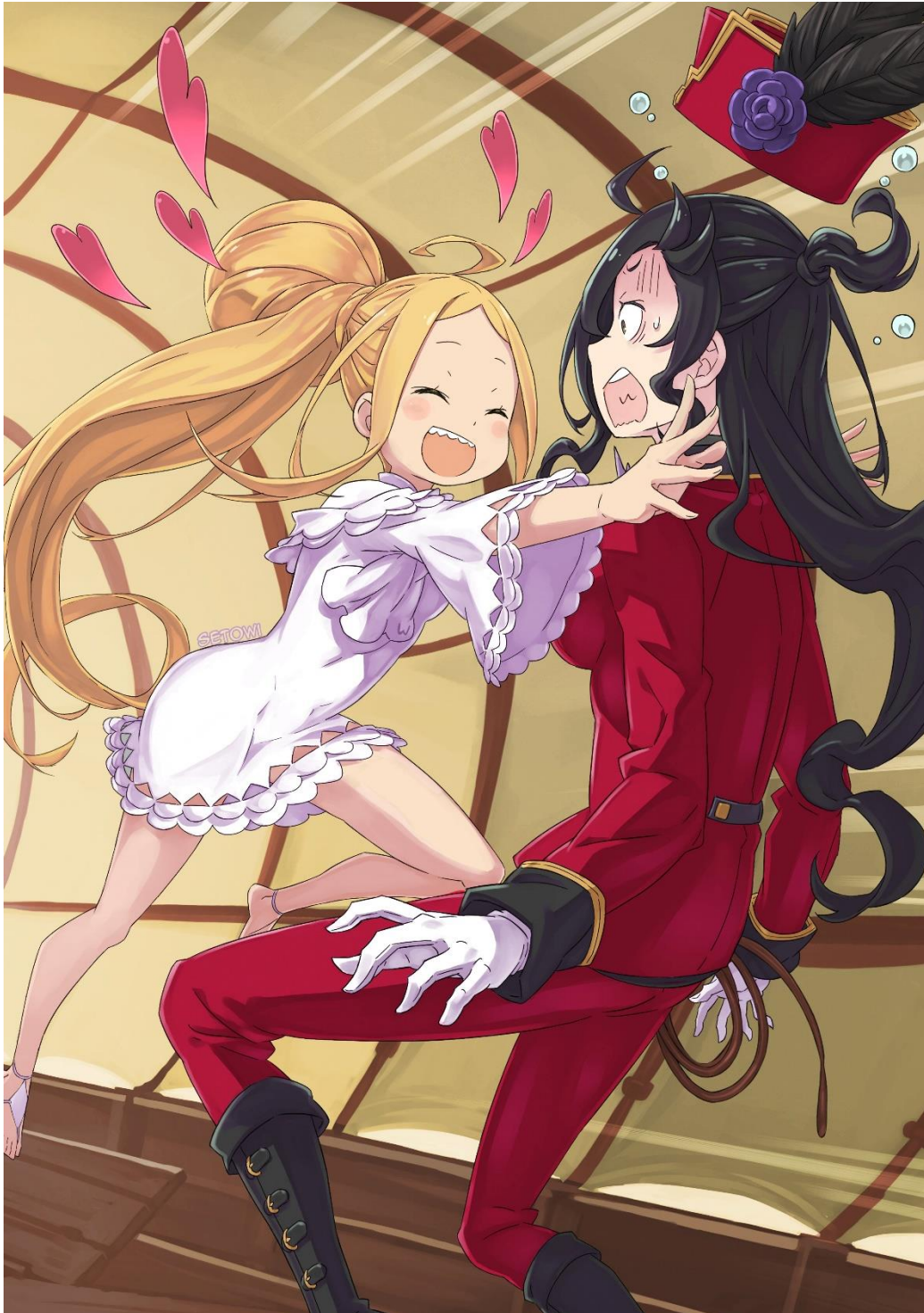


Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Setowi ([source](#))

Louis Arneb, an irregular representative in the Empire, burst cheerfully out from under the floor.

Subaru: “W-w-w-wha...”

Louis: “Aa, uu?”

Subaru: “Why! Why are you in the carriage...?”

???: “—Apparently, she had been hiding under the floor all along. I cannot believe no one had noticed it until now. It was probably the work of Utakata.”

His eyes going wide, Subaru’s voice quivered. Following up Subaru’s question was Abel, his figure emerging from the bottom after Louis.

He patted the dust off his dirty traveling clothes and hand-combed his wildly-disheveled sable hair. Then, regarding Louis leaning in towards Subaru, the latter still being held up by Taritta,

Abel: “Hmm. It appears that she missed you a lot. So much that rather than being with Utakata or your woman, she opted to be with you.”

Subaru: “W-what are you so composed for... were you okay with being under the floor with her?”

Abel: “How could it have been fine? She was unnecessarily rampaging at the bottom, and even I was chilled by it. I mulled over about how it could be explained away once the Soldiers discovered me due to her.”

Shutting the floorboards and returning to his seat, Abel’s words made sense to Subaru.

It seemed that the cause of the commotion that had distracted Subaru’s mind so much during the Imperial Soldiers’ inspection of the carriage was none other than Louis.

Perhaps Louis, hiding in the bottom of the carriage as she was, had jostled with Abel, who had come down there to hide. He did not seem to have any talent for caring for children, although it was unclear how Abel was treating Louis.

Subaru: “Then, what the hell can you do...?”

Abel: “You have been speaking disgracefully about me to no end, but what are you planning to do with that thing?”

Subaru: “What should I do...?”

Abel: “I am telling you now, that there is absolutely no way we can turn back anymore. That checkpoint and time both, shall not allow it.”

Al: “Well, Abel-chan’s right about that, ain’t he?”

Touching the clasp of his helmet, Al nodded his head in agreement with Abel’s words.

Meanwhile, an anguished Subaru had Taritta put him down on the floor, then held down Louis’s forehead as she giggled with “Auu”, and snuggled up against him.

Subaru: “Why did this happen...?”

Confusion and bewilderment swirled within his head.

On the other hand, there was a part of him that felt relieved that Louis was here— that he did not have to deal with this uncertainty being beside Rem who had been left behind in Guaral.

However, the fact that Subaru had been followed did not make him any less cautious about Louis’s true nature and what could be in her plans.

Taritta: “Subaru, there’s nothing we can *do*, we’ll take Louis with *us*.”

Subaru: “Even you are saying that, Taritta-san?”

Taritta: “Abel’s *right*, we don’t have a choice but to keep going *now*. But we also can’t leave Louis *behind*. I know that you and Louis have a complicated *relationship*...”

Subaru: “———”

Looking at Subaru and Louis alternately, Taritta timidly offered a neutral opinion.

In addition to their mission to infiltrate Guaral, they had also spent time together in the People of Shudraq's settlement. The majority of the Shudraquian, though not as much as Rem, were aware of Subaru's wariness and hostility towards Louis and her existence.

Even with that in mind, Taritta had stated that leaving Louis behind was not an option.

And, much to his own chagrin, Subaru agreed with her.

Subaru: "We can't just leave her here and let her cause trouble for people who don't know anything about her..."

Louis: "Uu?"

Inclining her neck, Louis looked clueless.

As things stood right now, ever since they had been sent to Vollachia, Louis had never shown her true face as the vicious Sin Archbishop of Gluttony. But that did not mean it would not happen in the future, and Subaru would be responsible for any damage that may occur once her true nature surfaced.

Subaru had enough conviction that she was dangerous and countless opportunities to preempt a lot of damage from being done.

That was exactly why he felt he should strangle her thin neck this very moment, and sever her future.

With that and that alone, many seeds of anxiety would wither and die without sprouting. And yet—

Subaru: "——"

Al: "Oh man... I dunno what's going on here, but that lil' girl's fond of you bro, right? I'm sure you understand that she might slow us down in the future, but we'll have to consider how to use that too."

Subaru: "Al..."

While saying this, Al tried to help the anguished Subaru reach a decision.

Walking over toward Louis standing beside Subaru, he took some steps upon the floor of the horse-drawn carriage with a casual gait. Then, trying to stroke the girl's blonde head gently—

Al: “Maybe with a child it’ll be easier to have them look away in case there’s another checkpoint like that. Traveling with a child ain’t so bad after all... Ouch!”

Louis: “Gauuk!”

Just as Al’s hand was about to stroke her head, Louis suddenly bared her fangs, literally.

Louis opened her mouth wide and chomped at Al’s outstretched hand as hard as she could. With a scream, Al pulled his hand away and Louis hid behind Subaru, snarling like an animal.

It was an ingrateful act, like an unwanted stray cat biting the person who had tried to feed it.

Al: “Whoa, that shit really hurt! I tried to help you out, but that was wrong!”

Subaru: “Y-you’ve done it, haven’t you...! I knew it was your style to prey on others like that!”

Louis: “Uu! Aa! Aauu!”

Subaru: “I can’t understand you with your uhhs and ahhs!”

Louis was clinging to Subaru’s waist, shaking her head. Subaru was struggling to pull her off, but the pressure was too tight for him to wriggle free.

Luckily, Subaru knew Al’s Name and who he was, and Al himself did not appear to have lost himself due to having his Memories snatched away. But the damage was yet to be confirmed—

Taritta: “—Please calm *down*!”

Subaru: “Hyaan!?”

Louis: “Uu!?”

Once Subaru and Al began raising a ruckus, Louis started screaming like a child with a tantrum.

To interrupt them, Taritta had intervened by raising her voice.

Putting her hands under Louis’s arms, she picked up the child, shooting Subaru and Al both with a potent gaze, her eyes like those of her sister’s, conveying a strong impression.

Taritta: “You’re a grown man and you’re acting like a *child*! Even *more*, why don’t you behave like a calm *adult*? The little ones will mimic *you*.”

Subaru: “Uh, kuh... bu-but, Taritta-san, the girl’s...”

Taritta: “No *buts*, Natsumi. I know your relationship with this girl is *complicated*. But even if that’s the *case*, what are you going to accomplish by making a *scene*?”

He was reprimanded directly, and the simplicity of the reprimand was the most effective reply for Subaru.

How many could win against the argument that they had been acting immature towards a child? However, such naïve theory would not be applicable to a Sin Archbishop.

If only she was privy to the dangers posed by Louis Arneb, Taritta would surely possess a different opinion—

—Then, why didn’t he just tell everyone who Louis was here and now?

Subaru: “———”

The black emotions echoing from within his own heart caused his throat to clog.

Subaru’s cheeks tensed up, and Taritta and Al reacted in a quizzical manner.

In the end, the whole situation had been brought about by Subaru’s vague decision-making abilities.

The only way to make them understand Subaru’s wariness of Louis, was to disclose the fact that Louis was the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony. Unlike Rem, who had lost her wariness of the Witch Cult along with her Memories, the people in this room would be able to understand the threat.

Once they realized the gravity of the situation, they would not treat Louis as the child she seemed to be. And to get rid of the disturbing threat—

—What could be done to get rid of her?

Subaru: “———”

Louis: “Uu?”

Louis tilted her head at Subaru’s expression while being held by Taritta.

Immediately once Subaru and Al stopped being rowdy, Louis calmed down as well. As they had found out in the time so far, Louis would only make noise if there was a lot of it in her environs.

If her surroundings were quiet, Louis, by her lonesome, would not make a peep. The reason as to why Utakata was such a good match for Louis was because she was an exceptionally calm child.

Perhaps this form of behavior was another way for Louis Arneb to blend in with her surroundings.

That girl, so vicious and irredeemably evil, that Subaru had come into contact in the white world he had arrived at the Pleiades Watchtower; was this the guise she had adopted?

He was aware he must consider that way, and deal with it. And yet—

Abel: “—I shall tell you this, our purpose here is neither pleasure nor amusement.”

Abel, alone in the seat, coldly said this to a Subaru still agonizing over the situation.

For a moment, Subaru could not make out the true meaning of his words, but quickly realized that it was Abel’s opinion on how Louis should be treated.

This road trip was no game, Abel asserted. As soon as he voiced that and regarded Louis with his dark eyes, Subaru gasped at their coldness.

Abel’s eyes, directed towards Louis, were devoid of any warmth.

This was a sign that Abel had not found any value in bestowing Louis with any consideration or warmth, and that he did not distinguish between Louis and a stone by the roadside or a wildflower.

The warmth of his eyes made Subaru understand the consequences of revealing Louis’s true identity.

Subaru: “—Let’s take her.”

Abel: “———”

Immediately after making his decision, the dark eyes looking at Louis were turned to Subaru. The sharpness of his gaze felt like it was burrowing into Subaru's chest, but clenching his molars, he drove that out of his mind.

Subaru: "Since this isn't a pleasure trip, show them you're useful... That's how it works, isn't it?"

Abel: "Yes, it is of no consequence— I had a feeling you would state such a thing."

Subaru: "...That's a difficult evaluation to interpret."

Whether it was disappointment or some other sort of emotion, it was hard to tell.

Naturally, Abel wished to have his real intentions go unrevealed, and Subaru was afraid that rehashing them would lead to a different conclusion.

Medium: "Hey, hey, are you done with that? Louis-chan, come here when they are finished talking!"

Taritta: "...Is that *okay*?"

Feeling the tense atmosphere between Subaru and Abel, Taritta asked for permission to respond to Medium's voice coming from the driving platform.

Abel was already unconcerned, and although he had decided to take Subaru with him, he did not want to take Louis, so he decided to take advantage of their generosity.

Medium: "Alright, Louis-chan, you want to hold the reins? Try to steer Leidy-chin!"

Louis: "Uu!"

Taritta: "Let's not do *that*!"

Louis was welcomed by the two women, although there was a lot of noise coming from the driver's seat all of a sudden.

Subaru was the only one who had originally been quite wary of Louis, so there was nothing surprising about their reaction. If something had to be said however, was that Louis's disappearance may have caused Rem, who had remained in Guaral, to panic in search of her.

Abel: “I do not believe that girl could have gotten into the carriage by herself. If there is someone who assisted her, that one should reveal the situation.”

Subaru: “...Well, I guess that’s true.”

Perhaps sensing the nature of Subaru’s anxiety from his expression, Abel dispelled without emotion.

If he was right, and Utakata had helped Louis stowaway, that information would have been shared with Rem and the others back in the city.

With him and Louis together, Subaru wondered if that would help with Rem’s anxiety.

Subaru: “Which would be better, her not knowing where she is or knowing where she is...?”

Al: “—? Of course it’s safer to have her with you, bro. I mean, from what Taritta-chan said, it sounded kinda complicated.”

With Al having overheard his muttering, Subaru’s feelings were further muddled by Al’s words.

The relationship between Subaru, Rem, and Louis was not as simple as it appeared.

Subaru: “...But, that’s right.”

With Rem’s figure behind his eyelids, Subaru found an excuse within himself.

Regardless of Louis’s identity, Rem would be concerned for the girl. Even if he told her the truth the next time he got the chance, it would be one-sided without Louis’s presence.

For that reason, Louis must be kept safe.

Al: “Bro?”

Subaru: “No, nothing unless... Al, do me a favor —Please, pay as much attention to Louis as you can.”

Al: “...What’s with the out-of-the blue request, anyway? What’s with that little girl?”

Al, who’d just had his hand bitten, seemed to have some difficulty with Louis, and responded to Subaru’s request in a reluctant voice, questioning his intentions.

It was a natural question, but for a moment, Subaru hesitated to answer.

When it came to Al, he would believe Louis's identity more frankly than the others.

However, how would Al act upon learning that Louis was a Sin Archbishop? Would he understand the danger and become an advisor that held the same worries as Subaru?

Subaru: "—If she gets hurt, Rem will suffer. Please, I beg you."

Al: "——"

Subaru was troubled, but, a moment later, he kept the truth to himself much like he had done with the rest of the group.

Hearing Subaru's answer, Al went silent for a moment, and,

Al: "Yeah, sure. I'm worried she might eat my remaining arm, but I'll deal with it."

With that as his reply, Al settled into the front seat of the carriage as if he had heard Subaru's request. He threw his legs out lazily as he listened to the voices of the three girls bustling around the driver's platform.

It could be said it was his typical way of accepting a request.

Subaru: "—? What is it?"

As he directed his gaze towards the back of Al's head, Subaru noticed Abel's own trained on himself.

He folded his arms and slumped in his seat, his unreadable black eyes reflecting Subaru, frowning with just a hint of displeasure.

This made him feel terribly anxious, so Subaru's question had ended sharply.

Abel, however, gave a small "Hmm", and said nothing.

Subaru: "...You still haven't thanked me for successfully getting us past the checkpoint in the first place."

Taking out his frustration on Abel's attitude, Subaru stroked his long black hair and settled into a seat a little farther away from both Al and Abel.

The journey to the Demon City of Chaosflame continued with a sense of uncertainty about the future.

However, upon hearing the bustling voices from the driver's platform, especially that of Louis...

Subaru: "Really, who do you think is the cause of my suffering?"

The sound of the horse-drawn carriage swallowed his words of complaint up entirely, and so they did not reach anyone.

Arc 7 Chapter 35 - A Night for Talking

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 4 “Chaotic Demon City”, Parts 3-4

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, thevoidzero, Translation checked by [Taurace](#), Averitius) — [Complete](#)

Medium: “The place where big bro and I were was a really bad place.”

That was what Medium had said in her usual tone, as they surrounded a campfire at night.

Always bright and cheerful, Medium never cared to keep her voice down. What had come out from her mouth, was the story of the orphanage in which Flop and her used to be previously.

From Flop, too, it had been heard that the two of them had grown up in poor conditions.

The siblings had grown up while being beaten every day, in a facility that took in orphans. Flop had stated that they resented a world where unfortunate adults would beat up unfortunate children, and that they had vowed to take revenge, as well.

Medium: “I don’t get everything big bro says ‘cause it’s too difficult for me. But when he’s walking around with such big steps and his chest puffed out, I wanna help him.”

Subaru: “Even if it’s revenge against the world?”

Medium: “Yes, yes! Though, I dunno how he’s gonna do it.”

With a bashful smile, Medium plunked down cross-legged, taking Louis into her lap then brushing the girl’s hair from behind.

The reason she had spoken about the orphanage in the first place, was because of her skill in dealing with children.

He was surprised that Medium, who, if he may say so, gave the impression that she did everything in a relatively rough manner, was taking such good care of Louis.

So, he asked her about her familiarity, which led them to the previous point.

Medium: “Because there were other children in the facility besides big bro and me, you know. Some of them were smaller than me, and it wasn’t much fun, so I wanted to at least let their hair grow.”

Subaru: “So because of that, you’re good with the little ones. It makes sense, since you’re very good at taking care of people.”

Medium: “Uhehe, you think so? Well, if that’s the case, I’m glad I could help.”

Medium’s beautiful blonde hair glimmered, illuminated by the red glow of the bonfire. Louis, to her front, had hair the same color. The two of them were so intimate they appeared to be sisters.

If Flora was considered and not Flop, one could say that there were three beautiful sisters.

Subaru: “...I shouldn’t have thought of imposing such a liability onto you and Flop-san.”

Medium: “—? Natsumi-chan, did you say something?”

Subaru: “No, it’s nothing. It’s just that I really feel that Medium-san’s been a great help to me.”

Setting aside the improper connection between the O’Connell siblings and Louis, it was a statement that seemed to have been wasted under false pretenses, but that was how he truly felt.

There was a great deal of help from the presence of Medium and Flop being there, both militarily and emotionally.

Had it not been for Flop and her, Subaru and the others’ march through the Empire would have been much bleaker.

Subaru: “In that respect, shouldn’t you be more grateful?”

???: “———”

Narrowing his eyes as he said it, Subaru tried to lure a response out of Abel, who was sticking right by the bonfire.

Surprisingly, Abel had not made his quick return to the carriage for rest after dinner, instead remaining, in silence. However, it did not appear that his attention had been focused on the chit-chat, or on Subaru's words that were merely sarcastic and teasing.

Abel: "Medium, where are you and your brother from?"

Medium: "Huh?"

However, though not in response to Subaru's words, Abel posed a question to Medium.

The content of the question was based on the conversation that had just taken place.

Caught off-guard, Medium's large eyes widened to their fullest and her mouth dropped open. It seemed she was surprised that Abel had started a conversation with her, and that he was listening.

Medium: "Abel-chin, you know my name?"

Apparently, those were not the sole reasons for her surprise.

Anyhow, Abel let out a small sigh at Medium, the latter having utilized a way of addressing him equally as disrespectful as what Al had used, one that could displease His Majesty the Emperor.

Abel: "Remembering names is a trivial task. Cease such trifling admiration. Answer my question. Where are you and Flop from? Who was the head representative of that facility?"

Medium: "Representative? You mean the director? I don't remember his name, but me and big bro were in a little town called Averyk."

Abel: "Averyk... That's a town to the west. I shall remember that."

Medium: "—? You're gonna remember it? What for?"

Abel: "It shall be dealt with accordingly. Whether I do it directly or not."

Abel's answer was succinct, but his true intentions were lost on Medium.

A question mark appeared on Medium's face, and her expression was like her head had been stuffed full of questions. And Abel, unkind as he was, did not attempt to try and dispel the mystery.

Subaru, for his part, did not quite get the whole idea, but,

Subaru: "So you want to listen to the people's frank opinions and immediately apply them to national politics?"

Abel: "I am not that laudable. I have told you— It is a matter of definite punishment or reward."

Achievements should be rewarded, and foolishness punished.

That was Abel's creed as a ruler, and it seemed to be an unmovable way of being.

Thinking back to the Lifeblood Ritual at the Shudraqian Village, he had desperately appealed to Subaru as the latter was on the verge of death, to tell him of his wish. Behind that desperation laid the same belief. Namely—

Subaru: "—You're the kind of person who can't stand it when other people come up empty-handed, aren't you?"

Abel: "Many are dropped into this world as have-nots. What they grasp in their hands and what they die with, is their life. There should be no thing such as letting go of something one has earned."

Subaru: "Hearing that from the Emperor's mouth having been born as a have-not's unpleasant."

Most people were have-nots, and had no choice but to struggle on, lamenting their incompetence and inability. They knew that life was like that, but could not tolerate being told that from the standpoint of those who are blessed.

However, Abel did not even regard Subaru, who took this as irony.

Abel: "—I am no exception."

Subaru: "—? What do you mean?"

Abel: "With the position, comes a certain amount of responsibility. If one carries a burden that they cannot bear, then those who are crushed are no more than fools. Character and pride can only be honed by daily self-awareness."

In response to Subaru's question, Abel's gaze slowly turned toward him.

He observed Subaru sitting next to the bonfire, and directed his sight to his dark hair and clothes, as if to examine them.

Abel: "False and contrived identities shall eventually be exposed. You seem to be quite adept at disguising yourself, but it shall take some effort to mend it once it comes off."

Subaru: "-----"

Abel: "I do not interfere with other people's interests as long as they produce results. I do not mean to contradict that statement, to see a false image as a pillar of support is something I cannot tolerate. Eventually, the entire foundation shall tilt."

Abel's eyes, bathed in a feverish breeze, were as clear as a cold night.

The words he had chosen had no room for consideration or understanding by others. Therefore, the true meaning of his words was not even half-understood by Subaru.

The only thing that remained, was the pain of having had his heart insulted so callously.

Abel: "...I have spoken too much. I shall be leaving the rest to you."

After saying that, Abel stood up and disappeared into the carriage.

The thick door closed with a thud. The only people now remaining around the fire were Subaru, Medium, and Louis, who was oblivious to the topic at hand.

Subaru: "...What's with that guy?"

Then, making a bitter face as he held his own mouth, Subaru blurted out those words.

It was as if he was a sore loser of a villainess, wasn't it? The iron-blooded female military strategist, Natsumi Schwartz, was much tougher and more supple.

That was Subaru's never-ending desire for a heart of steel, and the image of the strongest woman in its possession.

Medium: "Natsumi-chan, are you okay?"

Medium's hand gently stroked Subaru's conflict-laden head.

Medium moved dexterously next to him, sitting on her haunches not letting her buttocks touch the ground. Her hands were proportionate to her height, large enough to grasp Subaru's head with ease.

Her large palm gently, and softly, wrapped around Subaru's heart.

Subaru: "Yes, I'm fine. I mean, that guy was so insinuating... Did you understand what he was trying to say, Medium-san?"

Medium: "Hmmm, not at all! But I could see that Natsumi-chan looked like she was in pain, so this is the least I could do."

Subaru: "That's not true..."

Medium: "It's okay, it's okay, I know! I'm in charge of using my big body to do my best and leave the hard stuff to big bro and everyone else."

Medium smiled pleasantly and continued to pat Subaru's head, her face not showing any lie.

Even though she was aware of her shortcomings, she did not permit it to bother her and had a sunny disposition, something she had in common with the people Subaru admired.

Subaru: "You're very mature, aren't you, Medium-san?"

Medium: "No one's ever told me that before! Although I've been told things like, that I'm a good older sister, or that I eat a lot without having any issues after."

Subaru: "Those are other nice things about you, Medium-san."

Medium: “Uehehe~.”

Because he was unable to express his gratitude and admiration even with all his words, Subaru was frustrated. However, Medium merrily accepted Subaru’s hollow words of praise.

Louis, curled up in her lap, was happy, like she was being carried along by her cheerfulness.

It was a moment so peaceful that, to Subaru, it felt as if he’d been cut off from all hardship and anxiety.

He ended up imagining it as such, so peaceful was this time.



Time flowed protractedly, as he gazed at the flickering flames of the fire.

Subaru: “———”

The world was so quiet, with the crackling sound of burning chips of wood popping.

Subaru used to hate this kind of idle time. When spending it in a daze, he would feel tormented and driven by an unfathomable sense of urgency.

He wondered if he was allowed to spend his time aimlessly, as if he were in a stupor.

An unidentified black shadow would creep up behind him, crossing their arms around his shoulders in an intimate manner, persistently hounding Subaru.

Keeping this nightmare away was impossible, even if he plugged his ears and closed his eyes— to escape from it, Natsuki Subaru had attempted everything.

At times, he would be praised for his versatility and guile.

But all of that, was just an excuse to escape from responsibility and guilt.

Natsuki Subaru was papier-mâché, the result of a series of excuses——

Subaru: “—I’m just a little relieved that it didn’t end up being just an excuse.”

???: “Is that so...”

After listening to Subaru’s story, Taritta nodded her head.

On the other side of the flickering flames, Taritta’s face was lit up red as she knelt on the ground. The shimmering radiance of the flames appeared to suit her brown skin quite well.

And to mention something suiting, so did her outfit that concealed her identity as a Shudraqian.

Taritta, having removed the white patterns on her body and being dressed like a civilized person, coupled with her tall and well-proportionate body, looked like a beautiful woman dressed in men’s clothes.

However, as she stood guard as a night watchman, she had taken off her jacket and rolled up her sleeves, giving the impression that she was more wild than smart.

Taritta: “———”

In the slight silence that fell, Taritta was lost in thought.

She had pestered Subaru into speaking of his personal circumstances— of his original world; he had made the darker and heavier parts of his life ambiguous, but how had it affected Taritta?

It had all begun when Taritta saw Subaru cleaning his nails and asked, “Where did you learn to wear *makeup*?”.

Using makeup and crossdressing, were not that big of a deal to him.

Subaru had spent his junior high-school year in disarray, and had taken up the challenge as a bit of entertainment to make a spectacular comeback in his high-school life to come.

Subaru: “I’m a bit of a meticulous person, so if I’m going to do something... I want to be thorough and not embarrassed to present it.”

As would be the case in any field, the efforts of many predecessors were involved in the development of arts.

Subaru's high-school life ended as a result of his attempt to show that he was not embarrassed of it. Since then, he had made up his mind that he would never dress as a woman again, but here he was.

One'd never know what would be useful in life until it was over— In Subaru's case, who would not die even if he died, that rang especially true.

Subaru: "Oh, that's not funny—"

Taritta: "...Natsumi's *attitude*, I'm jealous of *it*."

Subaru: "W-whaaat?"

Taritta: "Wh-why are you so *surprised*...?"

Subaru: "Oh, no, it isn't something I've been told very often..."

It was a rather serious shock, and it took Taritta by surprise.

However, the shock in Subaru's mind, as he pressed his fake breasts, did not go away. Objectively speaking, Subaru did not feel that his position was worthy of jealousy.

It was partly from his own perspective, but ever since he came to this other world— and, in retrospect, even before that, his life had been a series of failures and disappointments.

To be honest, had it not been for his encounter with Emilia, he doubted he would have had the chance to turn things around.

Subaru believed that all his encounters and happiness had been given to him by Emilia, who had tried to save him from being beaten up by some thugs in that alley.

—The memory of that moment no longer was present in Emilia's mind, though.

Taritta: "I've always grown up hiding behind *Sister*. Sister's as we all know her to *be*, so no one doubted she'd eventually become the *Chieftain*. Neither did *I*."

Subaru: "Taritta-san..."

Falteringly, Taritta began to talk about herself.

At first, Subaru had intended to stop her if she started talking about something she did not want to speak about, as a response to his confession. She had inquired him about the source of his makeup and crossdressing skills, and Subaru had told her about himself, which were his own problems. He had no intention of forcing her to do so.

However, upon noticing Taritta's moist eyes and trembling voice, her visage downcast, he halted.

She was talking because she wished to, that was what Subaru felt.

Taritta: "Sister and I are three years apart in *age*. But the reason why I feel Sister's so big isn't because of the three years *difference*. That's *right*, isn't it?"

Subaru: "-----"

Taritta: "What Sister could do when she was *ten*, I couldn't do when I was the same *age*. It wasn't a difference in *age*, it was a difference in something *different*. What that *is*, I don't *know*."

Every word that Taritta spoke pierced through Subaru's heart.

It was a story he had heard somewhere, yet, simultaneously, it was a story he had never disclosed to anyone.

An inferiority complex towards her outstanding elder sister, something Rem had been harboring.

An inferiority complex towards the person he yearned to be like, something Subaru had been tormented by.

Taritta: "Why did my sister make me the *Chieftain*? I just can't see myself in that *role*."

???: "—He's that guy's child, after all."

The disappointment in oneself. The feeling of guilt regarding the expectations of someone dear.

Nearly overwhelmed by these feelings, Taritta had embarked along on this journey. Mizelda, the former Chieftain, had pledged to assist Abel on his journey with the goal of reclaiming the throne.

Perhaps it was a journey for Taritta to reflect and acknowledge herself, and at the same time, a way to escape the burden of expectations that had fallen upon her.

Taritta: “During this *journey*, I have to find an *answer*. No, I need to harden my *resolve*.”

Subaru: “Resolve... Is that resolve to take over as Chieftain?”

Taritta: “———”

Subaru’s question was met with a nod from Taritta’s thin chin.

It would be unfitting to say she had arrived at an answer, but to say she had readied herself to a fitting fate was possible— The duty of being the tribe’s next Chieftain had been entrusted to her by Mizelda, he could understand that was the way she considered it.

Taritta believed that taking over as Chieftain was inevitable.

She believed that she had no right to reject it. That it was the duty of a sister who had been appointed by her elder sister, and that she must lead the next generation of the clan—

Subaru: “Even if you run away...”

Taritta: “Eh?”

Subaru: “Even if you run away, I think it’d be fine. I wouldn’t blame you for that.”

The astonished expression on Taritta’s face conveyed to him that she had not expected to hear such words.

Though that had been the flow of the conversation, Taritta had confided in him her innermost thoughts. Her situation, the insecurities, the responsibility she carried on her thin shoulders, could be seen.

He could also see that she was extremely responsible and self-punishing, and that she was struggling to cope with it.

Or perhaps Taritta had wished that Subaru would tell her to “get a grip” here, to encourage her to make a decision that she could not make herself. Perhaps she wanted him to advise her that there was no such

thing as a lack of self-confidence in the sight of Subaru proudly and unashamedly wearing women's clothes.

But what Subaru had told her, had betrayed her expectations.

Subaru: "If you can't bear it, if you think there's someone better suited than you, we won't blame you if you pack up and leave the carriage. At least, I won't."

Taritta: "B-but, if I'm *gone*, our strength will *be*..."

Subaru: "Of course, I'm worried about that. But I'll do whatever I can."

Taritta: "-----"

Subaru inwardly ridiculed himself for saying such selfish things, though he did not display it.

If he heard this exchange, Abel would be discontent. As Taritta had said, she was a valuable military asset to their faction, which lacked in strength.

That could be attributed to both their faction as a whole, as well as to the group on this journey.

Of all things, he wondered whether it'd be fine to let them go.

Taritta: "You're saying I'm not *needed*..."

Subaru: "No, that's a big mistake. I also want Taritta-san to be with us in terms of both personality and strength. But that'd be selfish of me, wouldn't it?"

Taritta: "Selfish..."

Subaru: "Because I'd be telling you to numb your feelings, so that I can live."

Being an experienced and kindred spirit, Subaru could not force Taritta to do that.

Subaru, who had been given the opportunity to exit that dark place previously, had declared to Taritta, who was older and possibly more experienced than Subaru in this matter, much like if they were senior and junior.

—*You cannot be someone else.*

No matter if they were a blood relative or just someone close. No matter the degree one had longed for them, envied them, or scorched them into their heart. *You cannot be someone else.*

Subaru: “We can’t be anyone but our own «self».”

He could not be anything other than himself, and he had to at least become something he could like, something he could be comfortable with, something he could be confident in.

Like a butterfly that would hatch after repeated disappointments, discouragements, and a small sense of accomplishment.

Subaru: “...It’s unpleasant, isn’t it?”

So whispered Subaru, in a voice so quiet that Taritta had been unable to hear him.

What he was recalling as he spoke, was the ideal that Abel had conveyed to him a few hours prior, around the same bonfire. What many of the have-nots were clutching at, living with, in their empty hands, he had wondered.

The essence of what he had stated, seemed to overlap with what Subaru was attempting to say.

Taritta: “———”

Listening to Subaru’s story, Taritta’s eyes swayed, her hesitation becoming even stronger.

It was up for Taritta to decide which way her hesitation would lead her, but he knew that he should respect whatever she chose.

Subaru had run away from the expectations placed on him and the guilt of not living up to them.

He even suspected that his being summoned to this other world had been an act of consideration by someone who had taken in his desires to escape.

Of course, that was the reason as to why he had been unable of saying goodbye to his parents, his real parents——

Subaru: “You know, the fact that I was able to escape was salvation.”

At the very least, had he stayed locked in his room, always trapped between expectations and guilt, Natsuki Subaru would not have been able to catch up with his current emotions.

He would still be Subaru, his hands full with himself and no opportunity to strain his own heart, or to do something for someone else, or to give something to someone else.

There was nothing wrong with running away until one was ready to fight.

This should be a world in which everyone could choose not to fight.

Taritta: “Confidence and *determination*...”

Subaru: “What?”

Taritta: “I’m lacking in confidence and *determination*. But that’s not all...”

Hearing Subaru’s story, which came from his own experience, Taritta muttered, her lips trembling.

It had been so small that it seemed to have been drowned out by the sound of the crackling bonfire. Or perhaps she was filled with acute emotion, more so than when she had recounted the tale of her own powerlessness.

Taritta: “If I make a big *mistake*, how could I... Make up for it?”

Subaru: “Mistakes and making up for it... Taritta-san?”

Taritta: “———”

The question was repeated and Taritta let out a small “Ah”.

Her eyes widened, and Subaru could see the regret in them. In the same way she had spoken of making a mistake before, her regret for what she had ended up telling Subaru peeked through.

It seemed like Taritta had been burdened with a lot of guilt regarding that big mistake.

Not only the helplessness of comparing herself to her sister, but also the existence of her sister seemed to be a factor that prevented her from making her own decision.

Taritta: “The strange things I *said*... Please, forget *them*.”

What followed in the end, was the conclusion that her untold story could not be told.

He could tell by Taritta’s voice and expression that she had not arrived at an answer, but Subaru interpreted it as a sign that he could not force her to talk.

If only he could be there for her when she eventually felt the need to vent—

???: “—Bro, time for a shift change.”

Upon Subaru’s conclusion, a voice called out from the carriage.

It was Al, twisting his thick neck as he slowly walked over to the campfire. The time for Subaru’s shift was over, as the night watch was supposed to change every three hours.

Subaru: “I’m not happy that Abel and Louis are out of the *rinban*²⁹, but...”

Al: “Stop it, stop it. It’d be a terrible thing if we get executed for having Abel-chan work the night shift once he returns to the throne.”

Subaru: “If you’re on about grudges, I don’t think I’d be able to decide how many of my heads should be lined up for that.”

Al: “If you’re aware of it, please control it. Because it’ll make me nervous to be around you.”

Overhearing Subaru’s rambling, Al made a reasonable complaint.

Nevertheless, he would continue complaining about Abel’s attitude going forward. The reason why Abel was so arrogant and tyrannical was because no one had ever spoken up.

²⁹ English flip. Means “rotation (turns)” (輪番), originally “ローテーション” (rotation).

While he remained as a fugitive with no real power, to correct that character as much as possible was needed.

Subaru: “Otherwise, even if he returns with our help, another rebellion will soon ensue, and he’ll lose his head that time.”

Al: “Yeah, I’ll leave that to you. As you can see from the Princess, I’m basically a laissez-faire kinda guy.”

With a fluttering wave of his hand, Al threw out the idea of getting Subaru to change his mind.

Sighing at Al’s unreliability, Subaru turned to face Taritta again. “Taritta-san,” he called out to her as she gazed at the fire, lost in thought,

Subaru: “I’ll leave you to it. If you find Al’s *seiteki iyagarase*³⁰ or silly jokes unbearable to listen to, please let me know immediately.”

Taritta: “*Seiteki iya...*?”

Al: “I’m not gonna act the same as I do with the Princess! It’s a matter of distance and intimacy, and TPO³¹.”

Subaru: “That’s something I’m not good at.”

Taritta replied in a faint voice, while Al loudly proclaimed his innocence.

After comparing the two, Subaru stood up and whispered to Al as he brushed off the dirt on his hem and buttocks.

Subaru: “Perhaps Taritta-san’ll ask you for some life advice. If she does, please guide her as an experienced leader.”

³⁰ English flip. Means “sexual harassment” (性的嫌がらせ), originally “セクハラ” (sexual harassment).

³¹ Loan-word abbreviation meaning “(appropriate) time, place and occasion”.

Al: “«Experienced leader» seems to be the opposite of my description, doesn’t it? I can’t be responsible for other people’s lives, as I’ve been actively running away from such things.”

Subaru: “This is your chance to overcome your weaknesses. It’s the same with peppirs.”

Emilia and Beatrice, who were not fans of peppirs as well, were also trying their best to overcome their dislikes in various ways, without losing their bold challenging spirit.

The two of them had yet a single battle together, but Subaru believed that as long as they kept fighting, one day they would be able to win.

Subaru: “So, please do your best, Al.”

Al: “Is it just me, or that doesn’t resonate that much...?”

At least, what he had just said met the conditions to inspire Subaru, so he concluded that the problem was with Al, who was not affected by it.

Taritta: “Natsumi, see *you... tomorrow*.”

Subaru: “—Yeah, see you tomorrow.”

Taritta called out to Subaru, who handed over the shift to Al and turned to head back to the carriage.

That feeble yet certain promise of tomorrow, gave Subaru hope that she would accept Subaru’s words, and that they would meet face-to-face the following day.

Running away was not a bad thing. There was power to be gained as a result of running away.

But there were also people who would steel themselves to fight instead of running away, and were able to overcome it.

Subaru hoped that was the case with Taritta.

Subaru: “———”

Back at the carriage, Subaru was greeted by the tranquil air of the dark interior.

The interior of the carriage was divided by a simple curtain, separating the sleeping quarters for men and women in the front and back. The men were at the front, the women at the back, but the group currently sleeping was surprisingly quiet.

Abel, Medium, and Louis were the three resting right now, and how quietly Medium and Louis were slumbering, Abel notwithstanding, seemed to him relatively surprising.

Upon questioning them about their sleeping patterns, knowing that it was against etiquette, Medium had cheerfully replied, "If you snore too loudly, people will know where you are".

It was not until some time later, that Subaru realized that it had been during her travels as a peddler, or during her days in the facility that had been stated to have been in poor condition.

A skill acquired out of necessity.

In that sense, it might also be the reason as to why Abel slept quietly.

Subaru: "...You look odious, even when you're asleep. Perhaps I should doodle on you."

???: "—What, you are staring at me quite rudely."

Subaru: "—Hk."

In the middle of the allotted space in the carriage, Abel was sleeping. Upon peeking at his slumbering face, Subaru was startled by the sudden voice. He almost let out an instinctive scream, but Subaru managed to restrain it, instead saying, "You're awake?".

Subaru: "...Since we're keeping watch, I'd hoped you could at least enjoy the benefits of it."

Abel: "It is the custom of the Vollachian Imperial Family to sleep with one eye open. I am no exception to that rule."

Subaru: "With one eye open, this isn't a movie... Eh, you serious?"

Abel: "Why should I crack a stupid joke with you?"

Subaru's breath hitched after Abel's retort, the latter unconcerned, one eye open as he had declared.

The light in his dark eyes proved that his earlier words had been no deception.

There was an old movie that talked of an assassin with the habit of sleeping with one eye open.

Apparently, the structures of the human brain made performing this difficult, but seeing Abel doing it as a matter-of-fact in front of him, made Subaru realize that it was not impossible.

But that was not the same thing as being convinced.

Subaru: “Why don’t you sleep properly? Do you think we’re going to hurt you in your sleep?”

Abel: “If there is a small chance, then it is a possibility. You cannot lose your life for lack of attention.”

Subaru: “Lack of attention...!”

Hearing that detached reply, Subaru’s voice trembled and he pointed out the window.

All that could be seen through the carriage window was the light of a campfire some distance away. Two people, Al and Taritta, stood on night watch, on the lookout for any looming danger.

Of course, it was also for their own safety, but—

Subaru: “—Who the hell do you think they’re doing that for?”

Abel: “———”

Subaru: “After all this time, you still can’t even close both eyes in front of us?”

Natsumi Schwartz’s skin peeled away, revealing Natsuki Subaru from their contorted expression.

Faced with this, Abel’s clear expression did not waver. As he had done in the past, Abel blinked alternately with his right and left eyes.

Even the number of blinks was minimal, which was the same reason as to why he could not sleep with both eyes closed.

The time they had risked their lives together in the Lifeblood Ritual, when they infiltrated Guaral dressed as dancers, and when they boarded the carriage and headed for their destination, were no different.

Subaru sympathized with the people who had to be on-guard, in a situation where failure was not an option.

So, why would Abel not make an effort to loosen up before entering a place that could be hostile territory, at least?

At Subaru's raised eyebrow, Abel closed one eye— A single eye.

He closed a single eye, folded his arms, leaned his back against the seat, and snorted.

Abel: "Do not consider any ideas about distorting my way of being. Mind your place."

Subaru: "——"

Abel: "The Demon City is close by. You must do your part. I desire no more, nor shall I allow it."

Subaru clicked his tongue as he was confronted with an untenable disconnection.

There had been times when he thought he could be able to make some progress, but it was still no use.

Subaru: "Oh, yeah... Oh, yeah! I'm going to snore so hard."

He raised his voice in annoyance, but Abel did not respond.

Subaru frowned in bitterness as he settled into a seat as far away from Abel as possible, loosened his clothes, and laid down, with care not to damage his wig.

He thought about keeping himself awake as an act of rebellion against Abel, but Subaru was unsure what would be the point of doing so, or whether sleeping or staying awake would be the right thing to do; and so, his consciousness went blank.

The carriage ride continued with various problems, anxieties, and relationship values in the air.

—The arrival at the Demon City of Chaosflame was just around the corner.

Arc 7 Chapter 36 - Chaotic Demon City

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 4 “Chaotic Demon City”, Parts 5-8

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Shuxk, Translation checked by Averitius, PaperKaminari) — [Complete](#)

Louis: “Aah! Uuh!”

As she pointed at the cityscape in front of them, Louis bounced her butt off the driver’s seat.

Subaru would’ve liked to warn her that she was disturbing the handling of the Galewind Horse, however Medium, the one who held the reins, pulled Louis by her shoulders and said with a cheerful, yet unrefined “I know, I know!”.

In addition, Subaru, who had also been watching the same thing, was suitably overwhelmed.

Subaru: “So that’s the Demon City of Chaosflame...”

With a gulp, Subaru couldn’t help but express his surprise with his own body.

In Lugunica, he had been amazed by the scenic beauty of the Watergate City of Pristella, and in Vollachia, he had been impressed by the difference in architectural styles. However, the spectacle of the Demon City looming before him had bore a different impact on Subaru compared to either of these.

In Subaru’s perception, a city was an assembly in which a large number of people lived, and for this reason, unified styles and rules should be laid down for architecture.

However, in the streets of Chaosflame, no such sense of unity could be sensed.

Undoubtedly, it was a crucible of miscellaneous and haphazard principles, befitting a city crowned by the term “chaos”.

At the heart of the city lay the most conspicuous feature: “a castle painted in vermillion glossy paint, and the streets expanded out as a circle as if encasing the castle. At first glance, it appeared similar to the structure of the Royal Capital of Lugunica, but even there one would notice a clear difference between noble, commoner, and poor.

Chaosflame, on the other hand, had none of that.

Old ruins beside gleaming buildings, streets were lined with short buildings with sudden appearances of spires twice their size, and desolated sandy areas were adjacent to lush parks.

There were countless beams and scaffolding that had been arbitrarily pieced together on top of these streets, and from a distance it seemed as if the entire city were covered in a lattice of spider webs.

This was a city that had nothing to do with discipline, neatness, or decency in general— there was only one way for it to be called. The Demon City.

He could tell, at a glance, that this was without a doubt, a place where chaos prevailed.

Al: “—It looks like a city that could easily crumble with a «giant’s thrust», doesn’t it?”

Said Al calling out to Subaru, the former having been squinting at the mayhem, shading the tops of his eyes with his hands, spilling his thoughts about the spectacle that was Demon City.

It was a trivial matter, but what was the point of putting his hands over the helmet?

Al: “I’ve lived in Vollachia for a long time, but this is my first time coming to the east, so it’s refreshing.”

Subaru: “Is this your first time in Chaosflame too? So you’ve been on the west side of Vollachia all this time?”

Al: “It’s more like, I’ve been in only one place on the west side. There’s a colosseum smack dab in the middle of a lake, called Gladiator Island. I was a gladiator there for a long time.”

Subaru: “A gladiator in a colosseum...”

Subaru was taken aback by the tumultuous grandness of Al’s career, which he had incidentally heard about before.

The loss of his arm included many of the things that Al had talked about without hesitation were very serious. It was because of the gravity of his situation that he spoke so casually, in order to not make the other person feel uncomfortable, but—

Subaru: “That doesn’t relieve my mental burden at all...”

Al: “Mh? What did you say, bro?”

Subaru: “No, not a thing... By the way, what’s a «giant’s thrust»?”

Al: “Huh? Didn’t they say that in your hometown? You know, earthquakes and stuff like that?”

When asked about the unfamiliar expression, Al twisted his head and replied to Subaru with a question.

Although Al and him were from the same hometown, hometown in this case broadly referred to their original world, so of course their real hometown would be different.

That said, while there were many proverbs related to demons, he could not recall many related to giants.

Subaru: “Maybe it’s related to a baseball team? I don’t really know much about it.”

Al: “Oh, no, I’m not sure. I don’t remember where I got the word, and I don’t remember being particularly fond of baseball, but...”

Subaru: “I see. Even though you’d look right at home drinking beer and watching a baseball game.”

Al: “In the first place, I never drank anything of the sort.”

Sharing a bitter smile with Al at those words, Subaru remembered the age at which Al had been summoned to this other world, and inwardly agreed, “Yeah, that makes sense”.

In any case, during their little chat, the carriage that transported the group approached the front of the Demon City, the entrance to the city of chaos.

Speaking of entering and exiting the city, the most recent thing that came to mind were the checkpoints in Guaral.

Checkpoints had been set up at the main gates of the city, one in the north and one in the south, and in each the identity of people entering and leaving the city would be inquired, along with the purpose of their stay.

In the end, it was possibly debatable whether the checkpoints were functioning properly, since they had allowed Subaru and the others to infiltrate, but Zikr's words should then be taken in consideration: "The soldiers' eyes must have been burned by the sheer beauty of Natsumi and the others". So it should be treated as a result of their side's skillfulness.

Regardless, the existence of such checkpoints was not different between the Kingdom and the Empire.

Every city in Lugunica had such checks. Therefore, Subaru thought that this was a win-or-lose moment, and stepped into the shoes of Natsumi Schwartz again—

Guard: "—Enter."

Medium: "Understooood! Thanks."

Louis: "Uuh!"

The man had looked around the carriage and given them permission to pass; he was supposedly a part of the city's garrison, and a member of the Cyclops Tribe— a man from a race with a single large eye at the center of their face.

To Subaru, the fact that he had been given permission to enter with just a quick glance was anticlimactic. He wondered if, possibly, the guard held the power to see something special in that characteristic single eye.

Subaru: "Maybe that's why he's been appointed as a gate guard, isn't it?"

Abel: "It appears that you are reading too much into it, but the Cyclops Tribe does not possess power of that nature. I have heard that they can see a little farther than normal people, but generally, there is no difference in the functioning of their eyes."

Subaru: "Right! Because how'd he let such a suspicious carriage pass by!"

Subaru, who had put his hand on his chin while trying to convince himself in his own way, barked at the unkind words.

Hearing Subaru's high-pitched complaint, the other party emitted a small snort, as they adjusted the angle of their face, a mask— an oni mask in red. Following this, they sank back down in their seats.

As soon as he had arrived at the Demon City, Abel had equipped the mask he had brought along. Subaru had protested that such an action would make the guards and soldiers suspicious of him.

However, Abel's mask did not come off, and the guards had reacted as he had foreseen, leaving Subaru bitter twice over.

Of course, it was good news that Abel had not been suspected.

Subaru: "It's a serious matter, really. What kind of laws are in place, so that the city's first line of defense, the gate guard, is in such a state?"

Taritta: "I agree with Natsumi. I'm wearing clothes with *sleeves*, and they didn't say anything about *it*."

Subaru: "Hmm... your surprise's of a slightly different nature than mine..."

Taritta agreed with him, her cheeks stiffened, but unfortunately, the gap in cultures she had experienced was different from that which Subaru had experienced.

While Subaru's pertained more so with the way the city carried itself; hers was attributed to her self-identification as a Shudraqian.

Subaru: "——"

It reminded him of the conversation Taritta and him'd had around the campfire, prior to their arrival at the Demon City.

Following that event, she never again spoke of the same worries and anxieties, but that did not mean that Taritta had been freed from their fetters. It was a concern that might not go away, even if she were able to achieve the decisive event of taking over as the Chieftain.

Subaru sincerely hoped that she could reach a resolution that would put her mind at ease if possible, however---

Subaru: "Well, let's focus on the problem of the Demon City."

After overcoming the careless checkpoint, the carriage was swallowed by the chaotic and disorderly city itself.

The high-pitched cheers of Medium and Louis being impressed at every step arose from the coachman's seat, and Subaru too witnessed the spectacle of what lay within the Demon City, of that which could not be seen from the exterior alone.

The first thing that struck him as he entered the city, was the unprecedented number of races.

The impact caused by the one-eyed guard at the gate had been quite potent, but once inside the city, he realized that the guard's presence was not particularly eye-catching.

In broad terms, there was a large variety of beastmen--- And it wasn't just catfolk and dogfolk, there were also rabbit and lionfolk, with a clear distinction between small and large among them, passing through the streets.

A group of reptilian-looking lizardmen set up a store, a member of the Multi-Arm Tribe with many arms, and a group of people with unusually long hair that might or might not be a fashion statement or a racial trait.

As soon as he thought that, he noticed a race that appeared to be made of actual stone walking around, and a chimera whose body parts seemed to be mixed with another race's as well.

Subaru: "-----"

Subaru was left speechless by this senseless mixture of races.

Of course, even in the Royal Capital of Lugunica, there were scenes that had reverberated within Subaru similarly, which had made him realize that he had been summoned to another world immediately. But later, as he acquired the knowledge required to live in this world, he also learned a smidgen of the complicated circumstances surrounding demi-humans.

With how Emilia was ostracized for being a half-elf as an example, the environment for demi-humans in this world could not exactly be labelled as favorable.

For better or worse, the custom of keeping away those who were different did not change even across worlds.

Consequently, many demi-humans whose appearance very much reflected their characteristics left human settlements and kept to themselves to avoid trouble, so he had heard.

The Sanctuary, that which Garfiel, among others, called home, was one of those.

But what about Chaosflame, which lay in front of Subaru's eyes?

The variety of species living side-by-side and without prejudice aside, what had struck Subaru the most, was the way they stood.

With their backs straight, everyone was proudly asserting their own species.

Beastmen that did not curl their claws and fangs, lizardmen that would not polish their scales, and those whose shapes were considered abnormal would not cover their faces and bodies with cloth—— To Subaru's eyes, this was novel.

Abel: "What kind of laws are in place, you said?"

The one to speak suddenly was Abel, sporting the oni mask, remaining in his seat.

While not only Medium on the platform, but also Subaru, Al, and even Taritta were looking around curiously, the Emperor, his visage concealed, drew Subaru's attention with his words and continued.

Abel: "As you can see, what we have here, is lawlessness. If you ask what sort of law prevails, that would be an intangible sort. It is a mockery of the nature of order, a city of vices, if you will."

Subaru: "Vices...? People are impressed, yet you still managed to put a damper on it."

Abel: "Impressed? It left a deep impression on you? I guess that is to be expected from an outsider such as yourself."

Abel shrugged his thin shoulders at Subaru's response, with a slight grimace on his face.

The word "outsider" once again made him feel like he did not belong, which in turn reminded Subaru of the argument they'd had in the carriage a few days prior. In spite of that, as Subaru had been the only one becoming emotional, the other party would probably laugh at him labelling it an argument.

Al: "But ain't the concept consistent throughout this city that of disorder itself having become order? What do you think, Abel-chan?"

Abel: "If you question the nature of order, you shall know whether this city is disorderly or not— Where do you believe the essence of order resides in, in the first place?"

Al: "Getting all philosophical on me... Bro, *subete anata no mono*³²!"

Subaru closed one eye at Al, who had given up on thinking pretty quickly.

However, unlike Al, bereft of pride, Subaru was not willing to raise the white flag so easily. He crossed his arms and twisted his neck, permitting his long hair to flow over his shoulders, then stated,

Subaru: "The essence of order is not that, you know. Everyone getting along! Harmony!"

Abel: "—The essence of order is to be the same."

Without reacting to Subaru's opinion, which sounded like he was in the lower grades of elementary school, such was Abel's statement.

Frowning upon his words, Abel resumed piling on.

Abel: "It is many beings sharing the same values. It may be doctrines or beliefs, goals or self-interest. When as a group, rather than as an individual, the identity that does not deviate from each other is called order. What is built on the foundation of that order, is the pipe dream you spoke of."

Subaru: "Pipe dream... Do you think peace is that ridiculous?"

³² English flip. Means "it's all yours" (全てあなたのもの), originally "パス" (pass).

Abel: “Struggle is an unavoidable human instinct. Even if the weapon for that is not a sword, but a language or a country, the essence remains the same. But order is the perfect mechanism for shaping an environment far from collapse— Behold.”

Jerking his chin, Abel urged Subaru and the others to look out the window.

As he sat in his seat, he presented them with something that they could be confident of its presence without bothering to look out the window— the red castle, the symbol of the Demon City.

Abel: “As the clown said, there is an order called disorder in this city. And that poses as the reason as to why the city has not fallen into collapse, despite its existence as a melting pot for myriad species.”

Subaru: “That castle... No, inside the castle...”

Abel: “—Yorna Mishigure.”

The sound of Abel’s voice assaulted Subaru’s eardrums, which trembled slightly.

Abel, his expression unseen behind that mask, spoke of that name. But what did he think of the existence of the most problematic person in the Nine Divine Generals? One who could be indispensable for him to regain the throne?

The Demon City where various things stood in close proximity, both vertically and horizontally; Where people without any sense of unity would arrive, and leave.

The castle at the city’s core appeared to be looking down on the Emperor’s group that had arrived at its laps, its glossy outer walls glowing with a mysterious light.



—The information provided in advance regarding Yorna Mishigure, amounted to little.

One of the Nine Divine Generals, the strongest of the Vollachian Empire, and a woman who had been anointed with the rank of Seventh.

Although she held a position as a General of the Empire and was counted as one of the swords of the Emperor, she was a loose cannon who had brought unnecessary chaos upon the country by committing rebellion many times.

Zikr had been the one to supply information about the Nine Divine Generals to Subaru on the behalf of the Emperor who was incapable of communicating with others, but the only two people whose humanity he had vaguely spoken about were Yorna and Cecilus, the First. In short—

Subaru: “Among the craziest men and women of the Empire, she’s the woman who’s the one recognized as such...?”

With those words, as he mulled over what laid ahead, Subaru’s fake chest became laden.

Negotiating with the woman was the challenge at hand, but eventually he would have to face the man as well. Moreover, there was also an agreement on the fact that if they did not have him as an ally, they were almost certain to lose.

Although when he started to say the same thing, he was reminded of the talk about order that Abel had given,

Subaru: “It’s those who are far from orderly that we’ve got to deal with, isn’t it...?”

With a slight headache, Subaru muttered as he brushed a strand of hair off his forehead with his fingers.

Abel’s reasoning was deeply interesting, as expected of the Emperor, but whether it would be of use in capturing Yorna soon was debatable.

However, he was not simply trying to assert his dominance by telling Subaru something clever, instead he wished to convey something else— The order of the Demon City.

Chaosflame seemed to be overflowing with people and things in a chaotic and disorderly manner, but even in a pot brewing such bedlam, an order that would not crumble existed.

Abel had declared that this order was Yorna Mishigure.

In other words, Yorna was in possession of the ability and ingenuity to bring all this disorder together and keep it from overflowing out of the pot.

That was why Abel had not ordered her removal from the Nine Divine Generals, or even her execution, despite the fact she was a dangerous rebel with a history of multiple revolts.

Al: “But I’m sure she’s got a screw loose, and I don’t wanna get the short end of the stick, bro.”

While Subaru was lost in thought, Al, casually sitting cross-legged, laughed at him.

Subaru exhaled lighted as he peeked at Al, the latter sitting in a slouched position on the wooden floor. There were times when his calmness would save the day, but it was on a case-by-case basis.

Subaru: “Al, please behave yourself. You never know when, where, or who might be watching you. Also, please stop calling me bro.”

Al: “Hearing you out about my attitude and posture’s fine, but aside from... bro, what should I call you? Something like, bro but written as sis³³?”

Subaru: “Isn’t that something that can’t be conveyed without the Kanji?”

The beauty of the Japanese language’s variety of expressions was mind-boggling, but at present, there was no use in increasing the number of exchanges between Subaru and Al that could only be understood by the two of them.

What they needed was a way to call each other externally.

Subaru: “Since you address Medium-san, Taritta-san and Abel as «chan», wouldn’t it be more natural if you addressed me as such?”

Al: “Then, Natsumi-chan? Whoa, gives me goosebumps!”

Subaru: “Please withstand the urge! You lack so much composure...”

³³ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “In «姉妹って書いて兄弟?», the word «兄弟» (read as «kyoudai») refers to «bro» but can also be used for a generic sibling. Its reading can also apply to the version for female siblings, «姉妹»; in there lies the crux of the pun Al is making in Japanese, hence prompting Subaru’s response, because, when spoken, the vocalization «kyoudai» can be used for both meanings.”

As the leader of the group, Subaru reprimanded Al, who showed the hair on his right arm standing on end.

It was a strange thing to say, but it was unavoidable, because seniority had not played a role in the selection of personnel this time around. Considering the weighty part he had to perform, tempering his behavior was something Subaru had to do. At any rate—

Subaru: “—We’re already inside the Crimson Lapis Castle.”

The whisper not leaving his mouth, Subaru began putting his mind in order.

Yes, Subaru and the others had already been invited to enter the Crimson Lapis Castle at the heart of the Demon City, as they had sought an audience with Yorna Mishigure, the Lord of the city.

—After the entrance to the Demon City had been accomplished, the subsequent actions were swift.

They had procured an inn in which they could stay with their Galewind Horse and carriage, booked a room, and began actions towards their goal of conquering Yorna.

Having said that, because they had already decided what steps were required on the way there, no hesitation was to be found in their actions.

The action to be taken was—

Abel: “Deliver this to the lord of the castle, Yorna Mishigure. She should respond.”

With that, Abel handed Subaru a letter written by him.

The envelope containing the letter was enclosed with beeswax, rendering it impossible to open. It was customary for important documents to be stamped with a ring, or similar, bearing the family crest before the beeswax hardened, as proof of their origin.

However, there was no such proof stamped on the sealing wax of the letter he had been given.

Abel: “Both of the Emperor’s symbols I took with me have already been shattered. One by you, the other in the City Hall of Guaral.”

Subaru: “Oh... the Lifeblood Ritual and the Arakiya *Kyoukou*³⁴, yes. But if we don’t have anything to show where it came from, I wonder if she’ll read it. Even if she does, will she really believe us?”

Abel: “There is no need for unnecessary concern. I shall not disclose the contents of the letter, but I have made it so that if she reads it, she shall know I am its writer.”

Subaru: “I see... By the way, wouldn’t it be more reliable if you went there in person?”

Subaru asked frankly as he put the letter he received in his pocket.

The reason why he had been requested to hand over the letter, was because Abel would not accompany him to the castle. It seemed like a problem that could be solved in one go had he gone along, even if it meant proving his identity and circumstances.

In the first place, hadn’t Abel gone along with them to negotiate directly with Yorna?

Technically speaking, with Abel not going there, wouldn’t it be the same as if he had stayed behind in Guaral?

Subaru: “If anything, I think the journey would’ve been much more relaxed that way, without having to worry about checkpoints along the way...”

Abel: “Your disrespect knows no bounds, does it?”

Subaru: “Because you’re disrupting our vibe all by yourself...”

More precisely, it was not restricted to just Abel; Louis’s presence, too, was one of the disruptors.

But since he wanted to give Abel a snide remark at this juncture, he put aside the matter of Louis, a specialist in disturbing Subaru’s mind.

Abel: “It goes without saying, but I shall be having a direct word with Yorna Mishigure. However, it is not convenient for me to make my entrance so prematurely. You, too, should perceive that.”

³⁴ English flip. Means “panic/alarm” (恐慌), originally “パニック” (panic).

Subaru: “Perceive... Oh, yeah, that’s right.”

Abel’s grumpy words, conveyed through that oni mask, peacefully convinced Subaru.

Now you mention it, this was an opponent who had been involved in several rebellions in the past. From Yorna’s point of view, the rebellion had most likely been raised because of her dissatisfaction with Abel’s rule.

Naturally, the relationship between Abel and Yorna was like water and oil, or in some cases, like a smoldering powder keg. It’s already something that he dragged himself all the way to the Demon City.

Abel: “At present, your task is to deliver the letter to Yorna Mishigure. However, you must keep it secret that it is a missive from me... from the Emperor.”

Subaru: “Eh, why not? If I don’t say that, won’t I get turned away at the door?”

Abel: “It’s just in case. Nothing bad shall befall you for allowing her to read the letter, however I cannot read her mind before you hand it over. Therefore, be creative.”

Subaru: “Creative...”

Subaru looked at Abel in surprise as he was thrown an unexpected challenge.

The latter crossed his arms, his expression still hidden by the oni mask,

Abel: “If you look at this city, you can get a rough idea of her temperament and how she weighs her likes and dislikes. Use all the gumption you possess to get her interest.”

Subaru: “There was some malice in your phrasing!”

Abel: “I do have a back-up plan, but I would prefer to not rely on it. It shall not endure for much time. Considering my purpose, we have a long way to go. Do you comprehend that?”

Subaru: “You really are a pompous man, aren’t you...?”

Subaru’s lips curved in a grimace at the manner in which Abel spoke his instructions.

He was not afraid to side with Yorna now, and raise a rebellion against Abel. With that rumination in his consciousness, he felt like he could get along with Yorna.

If they could both have a chat about their grievances against His Majesty the Emperor, they could become best friends.

Subaru: "...Well, I guess I'll proceed in that direction then."

Abel: "You seem to have had a flash of inspiration, however, it does not appear to be anything proper."

As far as he was concerned, there was nothing persuasive about being told that by the initiator of something improper himself.

—And so, after going through with this, Subaru and the others had made their way to the epicenter of the Demon City, the Crimson Lapis Castle, the residence of Yorna Mishigure.

In accordance with Abel's instructions, they were taken up to the castle while going without the mention of his name.

Although this was a somewhat unusual move, Yorna's private soldiers, who were as unconcerned as the gate guards, ordered Subaru and the others to enter the castle and await an audience with Yorna.

All said, Subaru and the others were now spending their time inside the castle, within a large waiting room with a wooden floor, until Yorna, the lord of the castle, was ready.

There were no guards in the waiting room, and they could leave at any time if such was their will.

The laxity and carelessness of the security system was enough to make Subaru, an outsider, nervous. In the first place, things had proceeded so smoothly that even Subaru was bewildered.

Subaru: "Of course, it's convenient, but... if they let visitors into the castle like this, with or without the General First-Class, wouldn't they be given free rein to assassinate?"

Al: "In fact, they haven't even taken away our weapons. I was surprised when they said we could enter with them."

Medium: "Well, we don't mean to be violent or anything. They won't get mad."

Subaru and Al were taken aback by their response, which frankly smelled more of defenseless than magnanimity. However, Medium, who had been sitting calmly beside them, laughed boisterously at their conversation.

Subaru, Al, and Medium had been the three to embark to the Crimson Lapis Castle as messengers. The remaining people, Abel, Taritta, and Louis, were currently waiting at the inn.

Since Abel could not come to the castle, one of them had to stay behind to guard him.

And since he wanted to avoid having to spare hands for Louis's protection, who would be in no conceivable scenario be useful, their split had resulted in this.

Subaru: "I also briefly thought about the possibility that the owner of this castle likes unusual things."

If that were the case, it was possible that the People of Shudraq, who would scarcely leave the forest, would attract Yorna's interest; so making Taritta a member of this had come to mind.

However, leaving Abel and Louis alone at the inn was not an option, so the outcome produced was that Taritta had been left with a rather laborious load.

Al: "Even if she likes unusual things, with so many species in the city, wouldn't one or two Taritta-chans be considered unusual now?"

Subaru: "Yes, I thought so too. That's why we're going with this plan."

Medium: "Natsumi-chan, you're so bold! I was surprised, and so was Al-chin."

Al: "Yeah, Al-chin was so surprised."

Even though Subaru had his reservations about Al, who shamelessly took advantage of Medium, the latter saying "Right?" with a tad of pride.

Subaru'd had a bright idea upon being asked to deliver Abel's letter as a messenger while being disallowed to mention his name.

In fact, the reason they had been allowed to enter the castle this way, was probably because his idea had worked out so well.

Subaru: “The *aizu*³⁵ for our conquest is, «Abel pisses me off».”

Medium: “Haha, Natsumi-chan, you do snap at Abel, don’t you? I think it’s awesome.”

Subaru: “Awesome? Am I? Or is it Abel’s terrible character?”

Medium: “Both of them!”

Subaru: “You’ve got some nerve too, Medium-chan.”

Raising her hand cheerfully, Medium alluded to the relationship between Subaru and Abel.

The relationship between Subaru and Abel was not quite like that of water and oil, but they had no choice but to walk along the same direction; hence, they were bumping shoulders with each other as they went.

In terms of a close relationship, it could be said to be similar to that between Subaru and Julius in a time past.

However, taking in mind the stuff at Pleiades Watchtower, Subaru put a lot of faith in Julius— Though he would never tell him that, nor was he intending on displaying it via his attitude.

Subaru: “But it’s not that easy either, you know.”

To put it plainly, one could guess that the rivalry had faded and that they had come to terms.

However, that too was the result of a long road, as well as a reasonable quantity of peaks and valleys, having been overcome.

Improving relationships was no trivial undertaking.

A rough road would never be leveled unless both parties were willing to make it better, at the very least.

³⁵ English flip. Means “cue” (合図), originally “ヒント” (hint).

Even if one side attempted to smoothen it, as long as the other trampled and laid waste to it, it would never happen.

???: “—Thank you for your patience. Messengers, this way.”

Such bitter sentimentality was interrupted by the words of a servant who had made her appearance in the waiting room.

The girl who had shown up, was the same girl who had guided them here— a deerperson with large antlers on her head. She was a half-beastman who, the antlers on her head aside, mostly resembled a human being.

The girl, still in her mid-teens, wrapped her slender body in a *kimono*-like outfit, its long hem sweeping the floor as she led Subaru and the others.

The grace of that figure and that gesture, made Subaru’s knowledge tingle slightly as he recalled something similar.

With Subaru not being capable of putting a finger on it, the girl who was guiding them conducted them to the upper parts of the Crimson Lapis Castle— to the very top level.

The construction of the Crimson Lapis Castle gave the impression that it was closer to the old-fashioned Japanese castles in Subaru’s knowledge, rather than the Western-style castles that he had grown used to seeing. Naturally, the materials used and the architectural style were different, but the interior and the way the floor had been designed with big open spaces gave him the aforementioned impression.

One of the reasons for this, could be the fact that here and there people clad in a *kimono* could be seen, together with the girl who had been showing them around.

In any case, Subaru and the others followed the guide in a well-behaved manner, having been brought to a room where they would meet Yorna.

???: “Please wait here— Yorna-sama shall be here shortly.”

Subaru: “Yes, thank you... Oh?”

After thanking the girl for showing him around, Subaru was ushered into the hall, where he tilted his head.

The reason for this was the presence of previous guests in the hall— Within the atrium, there were figures other than the three of them who had been ushered in, all facing away as Subaru's gang entered from the back of the room.

That neither of the figures was Yorna, the lord of the castle, was clear from the fact that the chair placed at the far end of the room was empty.

Subaru: "Those people over there are ..."

???: "These are the people who, much like you, have requested a meeting with Yorna-sama. Yorna-sama is a capricious person, so she wishes to see everyone at once."

Subaru: "Yes..."

Subaru groaned a little from the difficulty of nodding at the girl's nonchalant words.

It was an idea that was not only unreasonable, but also illogical. In the first place, even if such a situation had been arranged, it would be an extremely awkward one for people who did not even know each other.

There were times a party would wish the contents of their words would go unheard by strangers.

Al: "And that's exactly what we are, Natsumi-chan."

Subaru: "...If you call me that, then I'll get goosebumps too."

Having had his innermost thoughts peeked into and been called out, he replied to Al.

In fact, albeit the details of the letter he had brought along were unclear, it would undoubtedly describe the circumstances in which Abel had been forced to abdicate his throne, and request Yorna's cooperation as a foothold to regain it.

Since they had no clue about Yorna's personality, what her reaction to the letter was likewise unknown. At the very least, Abel had stated that she would not wrong them, were she able to read the missive.

Servant: "Please wait inside. Yorna-sama is here."

Ignoring Subaru and Al, who were whispering to each other, the girl who was leading the way bowed and stepped back.

Of course, stopping her would not change the situation. If the one who had ordered her to do so was her master, Yorna, it would be pointless to blame her for this.

Medium: "So, what are we gonna do?"

Medium tilted her head as she shook her tied-up hair as she pleased, and touched the twin blades on the back of her waist.

She was quietly following Subaru and the others' plans, which made her surprisingly reasonable. Medium, who gave the impression of being uninhibited and emotional, was, however, obedient to the directions she had been given.

Perhaps this was the result of the partition of roles between her and Flop in their journey as a duo.

Subaru rubbed his eyes in response to Medium's straightforward and honest question, rocked his head, and with a "We can't do anything about this", he stepped into the room.

Subaru: "Just in case, let's ask her to clear the room before handing her the letter. We may be refused, but things are what they are. There's no harm in trying."

Al: "If it were the Princess, there's a chance she would have your head chopped off, saying it didn't suit her fancy, y'know?"

Subaru: "Please don't give me such an example..."

Having been presented with this most extreme of cases made him become more wary of Yorna, who may also be one such extreme being.

As Subaru hesitated a little to enter the hall, Al tapped him on the shoulder,

Al: "Don't worry. I told you. I'll lend you a hand. Today, I ain't gonna let br... Natsumi-chan get into any trouble."

Subaru: “Al... You’re the one who’s making me nervous.”

With those words, Subaru then glared at Al’s hand on his shoulder. Al hurriedly withdrew his hand, but for better or worse, his shoulders had relaxed.

Accepting Al’s sentiment with gratitude, the three of them also stepped into the hall.

The atmosphere of the large hall was, the absence of tatami mats excluded, akin to that of a tatami room in a historical drama, where the lord of the castle would hold council with his vassals.

Same went for the messengers in the seats below, waiting for the lord of the castle to make their appearance in the upper seat.

Subaru: “For the moment, let’s stay over here, shall we?”

Advancing through the hall, Subaru settled down in a position opposite to that of the previous guest.

It seemed strange to sit in front of or behind the guests, so he took a position on either side of the hall, keeping a slight distance from them. In historical dramas, there was a strange pattern in which the vassals would deploy to the left and right of the lord of the castle, leaving the front of the hall open. And they had ended up in a matching arrangement.

Pondering that this coincidence was strange, Subaru took a glance at the guests that were there before.

The other party amounted to four people, and like them, they had kept their weapons on their bodies. Among them was one devoid of weapons, sitting a tad ahead of the other three.

Perhaps that person was their representative, and the other three their guards.

Subaru: “They all seem more dependable than Al...”

So did Subaru speak, while looking sideways at the three guards and trampled all over Al’s earlier concern.

Moving on, he turned his attention to the front of the guards, to the person being protected by them, even though he thought it rude.

What kind of person had required to seek audience with Yorna, and for what purpose—

Subaru: “—Hk.”

At that very moment, Subaru’s throat tightened up due to shock, his cheeks and neck completely frozen stiff.

An inaudible voice leaked out, and as he turned his face down in a panicked reaction, the person in question heard the sound, then directed their gaze towards him.

However, having seen Subaru’s face directed downwards and in line with the elevated seat in front of them, his gaze fell away, as if he was not interested, and his attention was diverted.

Sensing this, Subaru took a gentle breath at the explosive beating of his heart.

Al and Medium behind him seemed to think it strange to see Subaru like this, but they soon would experience the same jolt that Subaru had. Because—

Subaru: “...You’ve got to be kidding me.”

That was Subaru’s bitter complaint, and, just five meters next to him, waiting for Yorna Mishigure to make their appearance—

—Was a man donning the same visage as Abel, who was not supposed to be here.

Arc 7 Chapter 37 - The Lord of the Crimson Lapis Castle

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 5 “A Reward Eight Years in the Making”, Part 1

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by RoutineCouple, Translation checked by Averitius) — [Complete](#)

—Towering at the heart of the Demon City of Chaosflame, the Crimson Lapis Castle.

The city had an appearance like that a wedding cake with no sense of unity, created by painting chaos on top of disorder— beams and scaffolding of different materials and styles had been strung together, and the castle, with its alternating shimmering red and blue hues, was one-of-a-kind, amidst the Demon City. A city that could not be understood without a certain artistic vein.

To begin with, the word “lapis lazuli” essentially referred to the color blue, so utilizing the word “crimson” in conjunction would be contradictory. However, a glance at the exterior of the Crimson Lapis Castle would convince anyone that such usage was accurate.

The stone used abundantly in the foundation and framework of the castle was, as its name implied, quite literally lapis lazuli.

The jewel emitted a deep-blue luster, and within said gem, crimson was swirling, like a drop of blood slowly dropped into water. So occasionally this supposedly-blue lapis lazuli would be clad in a red glow like that of ichor.

A castle of chaos, clad in ever-changing colors, refusing to stay as one single shade.

That was the Crimson Lapis Castle of the Demon City, the residence of its Lord, Yorna Mishigure.

Subaru: “———”

Having been summoned to the top-most floor, where he would soon meet Yorna, Subaru's back was drenched in cold sweat.

The reason behind this was because he laid eyes upon a group of people waiting for Yorna in the same keep— and in that group, a face that should not be there was present.

Accompanied by three men who appeared to be his escorts, there sitting with all the composure in the world was a familiar black-haired fiendish figure— That was to say, it was none other than the countenance of that who was supposed to be waiting for him at the inn, Abel.

But there was no way that they could have possibly come across him here. It was for this reason that Subaru and the others had gone to the Crimson Lapis Castle as messengers without him.

In other words, the reason he was here, even though it was impossible was—

Subaru: “—He's a fake, disguised as the Emperor.”

Muttering this to himself, Subaru's face turned stark white.

They had been told beforehand that there was someone who looked like Abel and behaved like him. The accuracy and suddenness of the encounter had floored him, but that was why he held no doubt about it.

He was one of the Nine Divine Generals, the body double of Emperor Vincent Vollachia—

Medium: “Eh, Abel-chin? Why are you here... Mguh.”

Al: “Whoa, everything's aight, Medium-chan. Al-chin's here.”

Behind a Subaru frozen in shock, a dangerous scene occurred.

Having found a familiar face in the crowd, Medium then approached in a friendly manner. Al rapidly covered her mouth and pulled her backwards. Although Medium was taller than him, she obeyed quietly, even though she was surprised at the outburst of the one-armed man.

A close call, but Medium's action had been negated.

???: “—?”

But the exchange seemed to have attracted some suspicion from the other party. Aside from the man with the same face as Abel, a man with yellow-green hair, someone who was probably his bodyguard, glared towards them as well. That said—

Subaru: “That was a *yoi hannou*³⁶, Al.”

Al: “Yeah, I’d like to pat myself on the back for my godly reaction, too... But that guy’s a lil’ bit too much of an *ihyou*³⁷, ain’t he?”

Subaru: “...Yes. I agree.”

As Al retracted Medium, Subaru nodded with a serious face next to him.

Battling with an unforeseen opponent— and the worst collision imaginable. With this turn of events, it was fortunate that Abel was not with them at this moment.

Had he been present, it would have sparked the start of the battle to determine the true Emperor of Vollachia.

Subaru: “Perhaps that’s an option as well...”

Glancing over at the three guards accompanying the man donning Abel’s face, Subaru was being cajoled by temptation.

The vastness of the troops hiding inside and outside the city was unclear, but at least there were only three of them belonging to him here— He was a false Emperor protected by tens of thousands of Imperial Soldiers within the Imperial Capital, but here and now would be a great opportunity to unmask him.

Subaru: “—No, it’s too soon to tell.”

If they were to believe Abel’s words, the position of the Emperor was no cradle of peace.

³⁶ Engrish flip. Means “nice reaction” (よい反応), originally “ナイスフォロー” (nice follow).

³⁷ Engrish flip. Means “surprise/unexpected” (意表), originally “サプライズ” (surprise).

Abel never even shut both of his eyes simultaneously in public, constantly on alert for people attempting to slay him in his sleep. Considering the position of Emperor was one in which this was a normal behavior, even if this Emperor was an imitation, it was unthinkable that he would make a public appearance devoid of any protection.

In other words, either the three people he brought with him as guards were quite powerful, or he had other measures in place.

Al: “You wanna take a shot and see if it works?”

Subaru: “If it were easy to *tsuzuku*³⁸, that could be an option. However, what I’m more afraid of, is a development we can’t recover from. So, please, don’t do anything rash.”

Al: “Yeah, yeah.”

Subaru did not know how serious he was, but Al appeared to not mind the rejection of his proposal.

Al’s opinions tended to be rejected relatively often, but that was only because he tended to come up with them faster than Subaru could, giving them time to calmly assess it.

This reduced the number of detours in his train of thought, and allowed him to spend more time examining proper options.

At the very least, they should find a way to get through this without upsetting the false Emperor and his group. He also wished to determine the purpose of the other party’s visit.

Why had he made his appearance in Chaosflame with this timing?

Plus, even though things were in reality different, it appeared like the Emperor himself had shown up.

Medium: “Mm~! Mmphn~!”

In the midst of his thoughts, Medium, who had her mouth covered, groaned something.

³⁸ English flip. Means “(to) continue (with the nuance of repetition)” (続く), originally “コンティニュー” (continue). Witch Cult Translations also adds: “The expression used by Subaru here is commonly used in the connotation of »restarting a video game from a savepoint«. With that, the meaning of the sentence is more like »If we could just rewind/restart, that would be an option«.”

She had been forced to step back without explanation, and her mouth was being kept shut, so her indignation was understandable. Al released her with a “Sorry, sorry”,

Medium: “Pffhaaa, that was tough!”

Al: “Sorry, I didn’t notice. It’s not like I did it on purpose just because of how soft Medium-chan’s cheeks are.”

Subaru: “The more you say, the more the *seiteki iyagarase*³⁹ allegations increase.”

Medium: “I don’t really get it, but more importantly!”

Al’s excuse was met with a blank stare from Subaru, and Medium, who took a breath with all her might, thrust a finger at them with both hands.

Subaru and Al both recoiled from her forcefulness, and then,

Medium: “You know, I still don’t really get it but... is that Abel-chin a different person from the Abel-chin we know?”

Al: “Oh yeah, you ain’t wrong. After all, the real one’s supposed to be sitting in an inn downtown, waiting for us to come back, right? That’s why we’re in a pickle...”

Medium: “Wouldn’t that be bad? Because of Natsumi’s plan?”

Subaru: “Me? What have I done... Ah.”

Medium pointed out that although she did not grasp the details, she comprehended the essence of the problem. Subaru, frowning at being the subject of her point, immediately understood her concern.

Medium’s point, and what she intended to do, was obvious.

And it was something that Subaru and Al should have realized before she had spoken.

³⁹ Same English flip as in Chapter 35.

Of course, there would be no time to take action once the realization dawned on them. Even so, they should have been prepared enough to discuss how to proceed---

Deergirl: “---Yorna Mishigure-sama has arrived.”

Without giving them a chance, it was the deergirl acting as a guide to announce that their time had run out.

Upon her reappearance, the girl lowered her large horned head and bowed to Subaru, the false Emperor, and their groups. Then opening the door at the front of the hall, she voiced, “Come in”.

At that moment a figure slowly stepped into the room, and upon seeing their figure with his own eyes, Subaru succeeded in putting the impression he had of the deergirl into words.

Subaru’s conception of the deergirl, was that she resembled a *kamuro*.

Kamuros were apprentice prostitutes who worked in Japanese red-light districts in the olden days, learning etiquette and the arts while taking care of the other prostitutes in these glamorous pleasure districts.

The unexpectedly stylish *kimono* and hair ornaments were likely what had brought such a notion to Subaru.

More than anything else though, was the person who brought the girl in question with her---

Subaru: “-----”

The reason why Subaru had succeeded in using “*kamuro*” for the girl, was precisely because of the person who had made its entrance.

Forgetting to breathe and regarding that other person with eyes wide open was a reaction arisen from instinct. Because his mind had been corrupted, his consciousness was dominated by a human being so beautiful and overwhelming.

Yorna: “---There are a lot of guests today, aren’t there?”

The one to speak those words, was a tall woman, as she narrowed her almond-shaped blue eyes.



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Norvak ([source](#))

Her tall, slender body was wrapped in a bright *kimono* with a floral pattern, and her hair, which faded from white to orange progressively as it reached the tips, was tied with care and allure.

Her hair was adorned with *kanzashi*⁴⁰ fashioned from animal bones and horns, and many other hair ornaments made of fangs and scales played a role in pleasing the eyes of those laying their eyes upon it.

However, they were merely ornaments, forms of beauty crafted by human hands.

In order to truly exhibit their charm, the person being put on display, and the quality of their inner nature was important.

And in this regard, the quality of the person wearing the *kimono* was something that need not be questioned.

Yorna: “———”

Her beauty was stunning as she moved her svelte body in a supple and relaxed manner.

Those sophisticated gestures and actions that seemed to have taken the eyes of the beholder into consideration, despite the somewhat languid atmosphere, were glimpses of the optimal solution to the act of attracting focus.

What made the impression of the shuffling gait even more striking were the fox tails that looked too large for her slender body— nine of them, with rich fur.

Given the fact that her hair was tied up in a bun, the *kanzashi*, and between all her hair ornaments, were perked-up animal ears, the information that she was a beautiful foxwoman, clad in a *kimono*, seeped into his brain like the smell of liquor.

Yorna: “Welcome to my castle, you’ve come a long way.”

⁴⁰ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Kanzashi (簪) are hair ornaments used in some traditional Japanese hairstyles, referring to a wide variety of accessories such as rigid hairpins.”

With that, she sat on the chair in the upper part of the hall and threw out her long, supple legs, resting her weight on the armrest. She reached out her hand, and the *kamuro* girl who followed her held a fine, gold-painted *kiseru*⁴¹ in her pale fingers.

The beautiful woman lit the end of the *kiseru* in her hand and smiled bewitchingly, as she let the rising purple smoke fill her lungs.

She was sitting in the seat of honor, looking down at her guest—the Emperor of Vollachia seated below.

Yorna: “——”

Her majestic and gorgeous appearance, her way of speech, and her manner of wearing the *kimono*, exposing her thin shoulders, allied with the presence of the *kamuro* accompanying her, reminded Subaru of the words “prostitute” and “courtesan”.

Of course, Subaru had never seen a brothel or a prostitute in person. It was just knowledge he had acquired from period dramas and other works that dealt with past epochs, but there was nothing else that came to mind.

—No, to say that there was a lack of further words to describe her would be an overstatement.

At this juncture, there was undoubtedly another word to describe her. It was true that she was both beautiful, and it was true she behaved like a prostitute; however, taking precedence over that, she held the position of Seventh among the Nine Divine Generals—

???: “—Yorna Mishigure.”

The beautiful woman who appeared— Yorna Mishigure, was called by name, then directed her gaze at the man who had named her.

On the wooden floor, their eyes focused on Yorna’s own blue ones, was the fake Emperor— for the purpose of differentiating him from Abel he would be called Vincent, but it was him.

⁴¹ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “A *kiseru* (煙管) is a Japanese smoking pipe traditionally used for smoking a small serving of *kizami* (刻みタバコ or 刻み for short), a finely-shredded tobacco product resembling hair. The sturdier and longer ones sometimes would double as weapons for self defense.”

Subaru: “Naturally, the same voice...”

Only a scant quantity of words had been issued, but the voice was very much that of Abel’s.

Apparently, the resemblance was not only in appearance, but also voice. However, provided his appearance was being copied, that the voice would be likewise similar was natural. Henceforth, there had been no shock.

Rather, Subaru gasped at the sight of Vincent and Yorna facing each other.

They quietly looked at each other and exchanged glances; their appearance was as magnificent as a painting.

A beautiful and lustrous beauty, and an Emperor with a magical appearance that miraculously combined dignity and majesty. What kind of event would the meeting between the two on this day leave in the history of the Empire?

Whether this affair would lead to love or bloodshed would depend on what was to come.

Subaru: “...What on earth’s the purpose of their visit?”

Why Vincent’s party had come to the Demon City was currently something that was currently unreadable.

The reaction to their encounter with them and Yorna’s entrance was what took priority, but regarding the aim of Vincent’s visit— What was the purpose in him having come to one of the Nine Divine Generals who kept rebelling?

Provided he was playing the role of the true Emperor, he must hold some legitimacy. However, why would Yorna welcome the Emperor, given that there was bad blood between them, into the castle?

If he were to end up saying that, due to Yorna’s position, she could not refuse it, then that would be all she wrote.

Yorna: “My oh my, Your Excellency, it’s been a long time.”

As Subaru had a rough time with those thoughts, to his front, Yorna smiled with the corners of her eyes lowered, inserting the *kiseru* in her mouth. Then exhaling a puff of purple smoke, she closed one eye rudely, and said,

Yorna: “I’m honored to have the privilege of seeing your countenance. No matter how many times I’ve invited you to the Demon City, you’ve never come.”

Vincent: “An invitation, is it?”

Without touching on the two instances of disrespect, her posture and the smoke, Vincent frowned in displeasure.

Then, crossing his slim arms and tapping his elbows with his fingers while in thought,

Vincent: “Raising an army against me every so often was your invitation? If so, my response would have been evident.”

Yorna: “Yes, indeed. That’s correct, but my neck’s still connected to my chest. In addition, it seems that you don’t have that troublesome little boy with you today.”

Vincent: “———”

Yorna: “Yes, my chest’s throbbing with excitement to think that my feelings may have reached you. Please forgive me.”

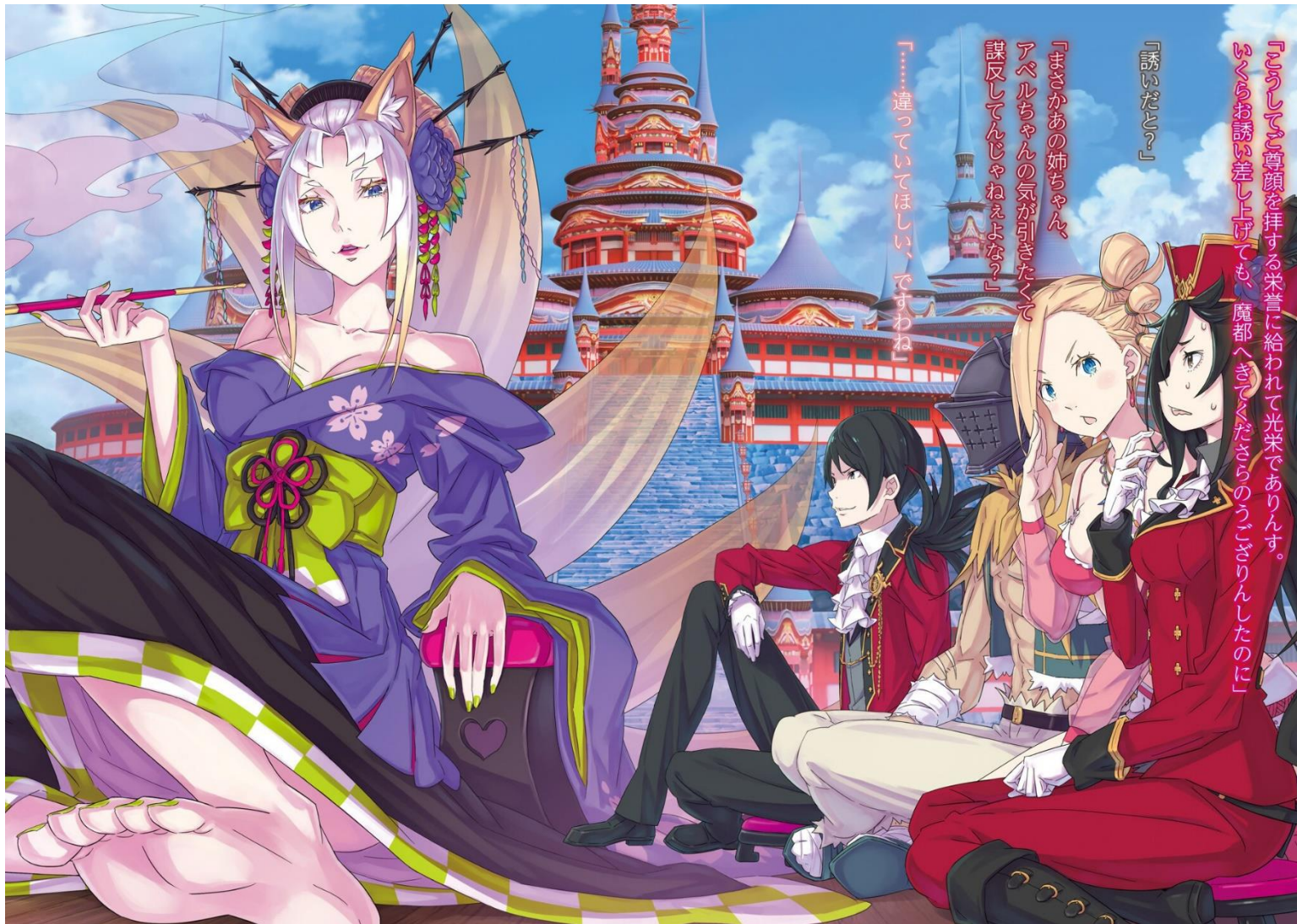
Yorna cleared her throat and let out a chuckle. Her seductive tone of voice and smile, however, did not cause Vincent to waver in his expression.

Vincent’s perfection as a false Emperor was remarkable, but at the same time, Subaru was concerned about Yorna’s attitude— about the passion in her eyes and words toward Vincent.

It had only been a brief exchange, but in Subaru’s eyes, the two of them—

Al: “No way, did that girl plot rebellion just to get Abel-chan’s attention?”

Subaru: “...I really hope you’re wrong.”



Al seemed to have arrived at the same conclusion as Subaru, those words causing Subaru to clack his molars.

He preferred that one of the Empire's greatest warriors would not be someone to deploy their army out of a personal grudge, and it was hard to imagine that there would be anyone around with feelings of goodwill towards Abel, while the latter did not consider them a person.

That was the main reason for the tense state of Subaru's cheeks, but something more important existed.

That being the pretext for Subaru and the others to request an audience with Yorna in the first place.

It was an attempt to capture her attention with the slogan "Abel pisses me off", with the presumption that it would not get through to anyone who was favorable to Abel.

Were the unpleasant imaginations of Subaru and the others true, it would be a not-so-entertaining matter for Yorna. Yet, in spite of this, she'd shown Subaru's group up into the castle.

In fact, that would be why she'd had them being sat alongside none other than Vincent's party.

???: "General First-Class Yorna, is that behavior not a disrespectful one to take? What are you thinking?"

Yorna: "Hmm?"

While Subaru and the others were worried about the unclear situation, the Emperor's group continued their conversation.

In Vincent's stead, who had fallen silent, the figure with yellow-green hair that appeared to be Vincent's bodyguard was the one to cause Yorna to raise her eyebrows.

A man with short, upswept hair, with a portion hanging down as long braids; he seemed to be about the same age as Vincent, perhaps a little older.

Clothed with a sand-colored cloak over light armor of black color, his face and physique gave the impression of being as sharp as a wire. His piercing eyes glared at Yorna as if to denounce her.

Yorna: "So you there with His Excellency, you're..."

Kafma: “I am Kafma Irulux. I have been ordered to accompany His Excellency. I was planning on only being a bodyguard, but... your demeanor is disgusting.”

Yorna: “My attitude, is it? What do you mean by that?”

Kafma: “Everything!”

Yorna’s words sounded leisurely, to which the man who called himself Kafma became enraged.

He glared at Yorna and pointed his hand at Subaru and the others witnessing the scene in silence,

Kafma: “In the first place, why do you want others to be present here! This is your castle, but at the same time, a territory of the Empire... Did you forget that fact!?”

Yorna: “Of course I did not forget. I belong to His Excellency.”

Kafma: “I am not talking about that! You guys there, you guys!”

Subaru: “Wha!? Us!?”

With Kafma’s anger being directed at them, Subaru’s shoulders trembled, startled. He would have preferred to be left alone, outside of their attention, if possible, but that was quite hopeful.

However, when someone asked you something, there was a way to take advantage.

Subaru: “Um, are we interrupting something? If so, we’ll come back another day...”

Yorna: “That’d be a problem. I have a limited number of hours in a day, and if you miss today, I don’t know when a next time will be.”

Kafma: “Do not keep them here! Those girls are probably feeling awkward too!”

Subaru: “Yes, yes, that’s right.”

For some reason, Yorna was trying to keep Subaru’s group present, but Kafma somehow agreed with Subaru. As long as he was by the false Emperor’s side, he and Kafma were enemies, but the latter’s words and actions were so upright that he seemed to be the sole ally in this situation. However—

Vincent: “Yorna Mishigure, what are you thinking?”

Suddenly, the one to break the tension was Vincent Vollachia—the false emperor himself.

After he spoke, Kafma, who had been worked up, immediately backed down. Even though the voice and the face were familiar, Subaru also felt his guts shrink.

Even though he was cognizant that he was a fake, the feeling of intimidation was genuine.

Vincent: “Answer. What are you thinking?”

Having silenced both his servant and the uninvited attendee, Vincent inquired Yorna yet again.

In response to that question and the high spirits, Yorna narrowed her eyes slightly. Gently bringing the *kiseru* to her mouth, allowing the fluttering purple smoke into her lungs, she exhaled sweetly, giving exaggerated emphasis to her answer.

Kafma’s cheeks tugged slightly at the disrespect of keeping the Emperor waiting yet again,

Yorna: “Of course, I am always thinking about Your Excellency... About Your Excellency the Emperor of Vollachia.”

Vincent: “———”

Yorna: “Hehe. Don’t give me those cold eyes. But I’m sure His Excellency will be more pleased if you knock the guests over there down a few pegs, right?”

With a small laugh and a confident attitude, Yorna pointed at Subaru and the others with her chin.

Then, for the first time, Vincent’s consciousness turned his attention to Subaru’s group. He must have judged that there was a reason for the previous exchange, aside from Yorna’s whims.

In order to stop this bad turn of events, Subaru cleared his throat with a “Ahem”, in preparation for a reprimand,

Subaru: “I’m sorry, but I have a new suggestion. We seem to be in the wrong place and there are some things we should most likely not hear. We’d like to step back and go to...”

Yorna: “My oh my, that’s a very timid thing to say.”

Subaru’s words were interrupted as he bent at the waist and attempted to leave the scene politely.

Noticing Yorna’s eyes hidden by the purple smoke for only a moment, and the glint of childishness therein contained, with an “Oh” Subaru realized that he had committed a misstep.

If he was going to go back, he should have made the decision upon seeing the faces of the people ahead of him.

He had misjudged it, and now ended up regretting it. Because——

Yorna: “I heard it from Tanza...You came here to tempt me into becoming the enemy of His Most Gracious Excellency the Emperor, didn’t you?”

And, such was the manner in which she disclosed the entirety of their intentions.

Arc 7 Chapter 38 - A Reward Eight Years in the Making

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 5 “A Reward Eight Years in the Making”, Parts 2-3

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, PaperKaminari) — [Complete](#)

—“*Abel pisses me off*”.

Subaru had believed this slogan to be a good strategy for conquering the Flamboyant, Yorna Mishigure.

After all, Zikr, a man of distinguished character, had branded her as an owner of a destruction wish, someone who had, time and time again, raised an insurrection.

Subaru’s pretext for requesting an audience with her, was that “a suitably powerful person wished to speak to her privately in order to rebel against the current Emperor of Vollachia”.

Subaru’s group of three were visiting the Crimson Lapis Castle with a missive from that powerful man.

In truth, he had not told a single lie.

The “current Emperor of Vollachia” was none other than the one who had ousted Abel, having usurped his name and position. The “suitably powerful person” who wanted to talk privately happened to also be the real Emperor, the one supposed to be sitting on the throne, so there was no falsehood in his words.

Subaru’s aim was to ensure that the letter from Abel was received no matter what. If necessary to achieve this goal, they would tell as many lies as possible.

Subaru: “This is what Natsumi Schwartz’s plan is all about...!”

In the end, he had been applauded by Al and Medium for his ingenuity. However—

Kafma: “—Rebels against His Excellency, you say?”

With what had been said to Yorna now laid bare, the atmosphere of the hall grew more gelid.

Kafma Irulux, Vincent's bodyguard, who had been displaying the most passion from amidst the people in the hall for a while now, exuded a hostility that could be mistaken for cold air.

Subaru could tell by the sternness of his gaze that a peaceful exit from this place was no longer possible.

—"A schemer drowns in his own tricks", that phrase that had never before been more veracious for him.

Subaru: "But aren't the timing and lack of shared information both Abel's fault...?"

Kafma: "Keep your mouth shut— General First-Class Yorna."

Kafma silenced Subaru, who cursed Abel for getting him into this absurd situation. With that, he then thrust his steely gaze toward Yorna,

Kafma: "Did you knowingly allow His Excellency and these people to attend at the same time?"

Yorna: "——"

Kafma: "I demand you answer!"

As Kafma raised his voice, his anger was not directed at neither the increasingly anxious Subaru nor his group, but rather at Yorna for having created this tense situation.

The reason for this was not because the blame lay with Yorna.

In simpler terms, it was a sign that they did not regard Subaru and the others as a threat.

In fact, the fighting spirit emitted by Kafma, now standing up vigorously, gave Subaru the feeling that he was as strong and threatening as Arakiya, whom he had encountered at the City Hall in Guaral.

At the very least, there was no doubt that he was powerful enough to be assigned to accompany the Emperor.

From his perspective, it was probably inevitable that Subaru, who went without saying, but even Al, and Medium would be judged as being unworthy of caution.

Al: “We’re the ones this concerns but we’re being excluded? Is that good or bad...?”

Feeling the same about Al’s dim complaint, the tense exchange continued, with Subaru and the others not included in it. Kafma questioned Yorna, who put her mouth on her *kiseru* and let out a puff of purple smoke.

Then she tilted her head with an “I wonder...”, as she shook her vibrant hair ornaments.

Yorna: “What do you mean by «knowingly»?”

Kafma: “How shameless...! As I have repeatedly advised His Excellency, you are still dangerous.”

Yorna: “You’re stating the obvious. With all the mess I’ve made... do you perhaps not know what I’ve done?”

Kafma: “—Hk.”

Yorna’s words, that could not be thought of as anything other than a provocation, caused a vein to bulge out on Kafma’s forehead.

Albeit odd, from what he could gather from their exchange, Subaru found himself agreeing with Kafma. Yorna’s personality was honestly the worst, even from Subaru’s point of view.

Although they had readied themselves for a certain degree of viciousness based on her reputation, it had exceeded their expectations.

However, it seemed that she was not simply planning to give up Subaru and his group, who were plainly rebellious elements, to Vincent and his men, who happened to be visiting.

The air was too far tense for a scene in which traitors were being presented to the Emperor.

Most of all—

Vincent: “—As usual, your taste is repulsive.”

And then, disregarding Yorna’s intentions, Vincent’s voice was loosed.

At Vincent’s cold words, Yorna raised her shapely eyebrows slightly,

Yorna: “Oh, does it not suit your taste, Your Excellency?”

Vincent: “Preposterous. If too one-sided, it is akin to letting a rabbit hunt a dog. I have not grown tired of the Empire to the point of making mere cruelty an amusement.”

Vincent’s statement was one of indifference, but with a definite air of authority.

Taking it in stride, through the gaps of her tied-up hair, Yorna’s fox ears quivered. Subaru could not ascertain what sort of emotion she was expressing.

However, the same went for Vincent’s feelings.

Subaru: “———”

What sort of storm would brew in his heart upon confronting rebels face-to-face?

Understanding the inner thoughts of the fake Emperor was even more difficult than imagining the thoughts of the real one, especially when he knew that the person in front of him was an imposter.

The fake must think badly of Abel, as he had driven the other away, but——

Subaru: “Can’t be stupid enough to let it show...”

Vincent: “——You.”

Subaru: “——Hk!”

Subaru gasped for breath as Vincent’s black eyes pierced straight through him. In an instant, Subaru was forbidden even to avert his eyes, and while still unprepared, he locked eyes with his greatest foe.

His face was a replica of the real one, though how it had been made was unclear.

Both the genuine and the fake possessed the same sharp black eyes that attempted to peer through one’s every action. This made Subaru’s insides squirm——

Vincent: “If you have something to say, say it now.”

Subaru: “...Those are some annoying eyes.”

Kafma: “Wha...!”

Subaru: “Ah! No, no, no! I didn’t mean it like that! It was just unintentional!”

At the most inopportune time, the questioning of the false Emperor coincided with a leak of annoyance.

Kafma was lost for words, his face one of absolute surprise, after Subaru hurled verbal abuse straight at the Emperor. Subaru then gave a hurried wave of his hand, to which Vincent closed one eye and became silent.

He was surprised, but at the same time, he regarded Subaru as if assessing him.

The look the real Abel had directed at Subaru in the Buddheim Jungle, the Shudraqian village, and the City Hall in Guaral— this one was of the same kind as those.

Subaru: “Uh, anyway, we...”

At his back, Al and Medium were also watching the situation with bated breath.

Subaru’s shocking rant must have put them under a lot of pressure. The atmosphere in the hall was cold and tense, and one additional gaffe would shatter it into pieces.

The situation they had been put into was too painful to begin with.

Not just Yorna but Kafma as well, were not the kind of opponents that Subaru and his group could compete with.

If that were the case, wouldn’t it be wiser to recant their opinion to Yorna, emphasize that them being rebels was outrageous, bow their heads, and leave? Even if it would make the scene bland?

With that in mind, Subaru tried to loosen the corners of his mouth in an attempt to put on an amiable smile.

—Subaru then realized Yorna’s gaze homed in on him, with nary a motion.

Yorna: “———”

In silence, Yorna watched Subaru’s movements as she took a drag of her *kiseru*.

It was a very ambiguous look, neither disinterested nor indifferent. Uncertain as the rising purple smoke, it was like a phantom that disappeared even when one tried to grasp it.

He thought it would be deeply foolish to try to rely on it.

However, Subaru had a hunch that this was a turning point.

That gaze, on the verge of losing interest in Subaru's group, was not as capricious as to consider taking back what had once been given up on. The opinions discarded here could never be scooped up again.

In other words, Yorna Mishigure's cooperation could nevermore be obtained.

It was synonymous with blocking the way to an unreliable victory in the dark. Therefore—

Vincent: “—Answer me carefully. What were you going to tell me.”

Subaru: “Well, um—”

At Vincent's question, Subaru took a heartbeat too long to look up.

Kafma, beside the false Emperor, narrowed his eyes and turned his attention to Subaru. Behind him, Al and Medium's tensions swelled, while Yorna sustained a mouthful of purple smoke in her lungs.

Seeing those changes at the corner of his eye, Subaru looked at Vincent, and declared,

Subaru: “It is as Yorna-sama said. We are declaring war on you.”

Yes, as if clinging onto a position that he should not withdraw from, a piece that he should not give up on.

Rem, who was waiting for his return in Guaral, Abel, who was absent, and Al and Medium, who were bracing themselves behind him, had entrusted Subaru with this decision.

In order for Natsuki Subaru not to misunderstand the significance and weight of this, and not throw it all away—

Vincent: “———”

Vincent's dark eyes flickered slightly upon hearing the hostile declaration.

Subaru's insightfulness was not able to decipher which emotion it corresponded to; joy, anger, sorrow, or pleasure. Instead, he experienced the rapid parching of his tongue, brought by the enthusiasm of his own words.

Naturally so. Unlike Abel, who had been deprived of his real power as the Emperor of the Vollachian Empire, which boasted of a vast territory, the fake Emperor in front of him was the one who definitely held it as leverage.

Had Vincent not raised a hand to halt Kafma after hearing the gaffe from earlier, the latter would have exploded in rage and Subaru's life would have been cut short.

But that had not come to pass. Vincent would not allow it to happen.

Yorna: "Kuhu..."

Looking down at the confrontation between Subaru and Vincent from her high seat, Yorna let a faint sound slip out from her throat.

A chuckle escaped from the corner of her mouth as smoke leaked out of her mouth, and her shoulders trembled with amusement. It seemed that Subaru's life-threatening pronouncement had taken an effect in relieving her boredom, at least.

Vincent: "What are you laughing at, Yorna Mishigure?"

Yorna: "First of all, these guests have not retracted their words. In addition, the three of them might possibly put His Excellency's life in jeopardy... What do you think?"

Vincent: "Do not taunt me, woman. Even you, who believes in disobeying me, understands my intentions."

Vincent's expression did not change as he met Yorna's provocative gaze.

Like that, he once again cast his dark eyes to Subaru, who had declared his hostility.

Vincent: "This is the land of the Sword Wolf. Only if you possess the mettle to aim at my head can you truly be called a citizen of the Empire."

Subaru: "...That's very sweet of you, isn't it?"

Vincent: "Hmph."

With a snort, Vincent dismissed Subaru's sarcasm with a laugh.

Vincent's behavior, the way he responded included, was a perfect facsimile of the real thing. If Abel were here, he would have responded exactly the same way.

That Abel was together with Subaru and the others made the latter suspect the possibility that he was the false Emperor.

Although in that case, Subaru and the remaining people would be at a complete impasse, so he wished for it to not be the case.

Vincent: "But the value of my head is not so low that I can hand it to you that easily."

Subaru: "—Then, what do you intend to do with us?"

Vincent: "Well, that's the problem."

The statement acknowledged Subaru and the others who had shown outright defiance to the Emperor by getting the better of Kafma, who was on the verge of a violent outburst. However, the following words showed that there was no change in the cold gaze Vincent directed at his opponents.

Even if he valued their spirit, there was no reason for him to give allowance to those who sought to harm him.

Subaru's and Vincent's black eyes met, the atmosphere of the room an infernal blaze.

Yorna: "Oh, I'm a sinful woman, too. When I see men fighting over me like this, it makes me quite excited."

Kafma: “As if it were someone else’s problem... First, there are more women over there than men. Saying men is not accurate.”

Yorna: “Kuhu.”

Yorna let out her impressions, which really stuck out like a sore thumb, about the staring contest between Subaru and Vincent.

In reaction, Kafma’s face grew increasingly angry.

Kafma: “My Excellency! Order me! Those people are...”

???: “—Kafma, ya did that thingy... You’ve been makin’ a bit of a ruckus for a while now.”

Fed up with the stalemate, Kafma attempted to appeal directly to Vincent. However, it was not Vincent who interrupted him, nor was it Yorna, but someone else.

Subaru: “Ah...”

Subaru’s mouth involuntarily let out an exhale as he turned to the direction of the voice.

The voice had been so far outside of Subaru’s consciousness that the very fact that it had been uttered startled him.

It was one of the three people Vincent had brought along as escorts— a small figure sitting cross-legged on the wooden floor, someone other than Kafma.

???: “Ya know, most things work out better when His Excellency’s the one ta do the thinkin’ rather than us. We’re seriously goin’ to be in the way if we keep yappin’, really.”

It was a wrinkled old man who spoke those words, his hair colored white, donning long eyebrows.

He was an old man who had carefully crafted an atmosphere of annoyance in both the tone and content of his speech. His appearance was so striking that it was hard to understand why he had not been seen before.

—No, he had been in sight. It was just that he had been out of awareness.



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by DdukaE ([source](#))

Perhaps that would be what it meant to truly be out of sight.

Once the old man pointed this out, Kafma turned to him and said, “But”,

Kafma: “It would be the duty of a loyal subject to remove His Excellency’s troubles, Master Olbart!”

Olbart: “When ya call yerself a loyal subject, doesn’t it sound like a prelude ta someone bein’ purged for bein’ self-servin’? I don’t like the idea of choppin’ off the head of a promisin’ young man.”

Kafma: “Guh... Hk.”

Shaking his head lazily, the old man—the one called Olbart, picked at his ear. Kafma’s cheeks tensed up, making one wonder what kind of pressure he had felt from that gesture.

However, Kafma was not the only one who had caused their cheeks to stiffen. Upon hearing the name mentioned, Subaru’s cheeks tensed up as well.

Subaru: “Master, Olbart...”

Olbart: “Oh? Ya know me? I’m kinda well-known after all.”

Subaru: “...If you’re aware that you’re a celebrity, then yes, I’m sure of it.”

His lips trembled as he spun the name that Olbart reacted to.

If he had that reaction upon witnessing Subaru’s look of shock, then there was no doubt about it. In the City Hall of Guaral, and then on their journey to the Demon City, he had heard of Olbart’s name.

From here on out, the Nine Divine Generals would be an inevitable part of Subaru’s strategy to conquer the Empire. One of them was Yorna, and the other was—

Subaru: “The Vicious Old Man, Olbart Dunkelkenn...!”

Olbart: “I don’t really like that name, ya know. Vicious Old Man sounds awful. Do I look like such a vicious ol’ man? Well, if someone asked me directly, I wouldn’t be able ta say that I do. I wouldn’t be able ta say it, kakakakka!”

The old man smiled, as he opened his mouth wide and displayed his beautiful white teeth, which looked great for his age.

However, Subaru was in no laughing mood— They had encountered Vincent, the false Emperor, as they worked towards their goal of getting Yorna on their side, and in the end, he had brought Olbart with him.

This meant that, at this point, Olbart too was a member of the other faction.

Subaru: “Arakiya and Chisha, and also Olbart...”

Subaru felt like he was reaching his wits’ end; members of the Nine Divine Generals they were aiming for had seemingly been secured by the enemy already. And furthermore, they were just going for those said to be high ranking.

The problem was that not only the future, but also the situation in front of them was getting worse at an accelerating pace.

Even if it had been just Kafma by himself, he’d have been way too much to handle, and now Olbart of the Nine Divine Generals had joined the fray.

It was not they could have arranged all those terrible conditions thus far, even if they’d planned to—

Al: “—Hey, old man, do you remember me?”

Olbart: “What’s that?”

Sweat flowed down Subaru’s forehead, running down his cheeks and dripping from the tip of his chin.

Amidst all this tension, an unexpected voice made Olbart raise his eyebrows. It was Al, who had called out from behind Subaru.

Al leaned forward, Subaru’s eyes widening in surprise at that action.

Subaru: “Al? What are you... doing all of a sudden, when every move we make’s being questioned right now?”

Al: “Natsumi-chan’s still talking like a woman for the most part in this situation, but I didn’t just butt in without thinking. No, I didn’t think about it, but... Hey, old man! It’s me, hey hey!”

Subaru: “It sounds like you’re a phone scammer talking like that...”⁴²”

It would be rash to think that just because he was an old man, he would be able to pull off such a scam. In fact, in response to Al’s call, Olbart leaned forward and snorted, “Hmm?”.

Olbart: “Well, that’s quite the eccentric look ya got there, boy. Even tho’ I’m an ol’ man, I wouldn’t be able ta forget someone who looks like that. Do we really know each other?”

Al: “Maybe I don’t know you that well, and the last time I saw you, I wasn’t wearing my helmet. But I didn’t have an arm, and we chatted a bit.”

Olbart: “You’re the armless one who talked ta me at...?”

Al: “Oh, right— Lil’ Miss Arakiya was with me, too.”

Lowering his voice slightly, Al mentioned Arakiya’s name, the fearsome girl who had stirred up so much trouble for Subaru and the others and, like Olbart, was a member of the Nine Divine Generals.

Al’s words were something Subaru could make no sense of; but as soon as Olbart heard them, his eyebrows shot up and he shouted, “Oh!”.

Olbart: “You’re that guy! You’re the guy who took back the island with Araki! Now that ya mention it, ya look similar ta him. Kakakakka, I can’t believe you’re still alive!”

Al: “Oh, I’m alive, I’m alive. Somehow, my stars have come full circle.”

Olbart: “So, by some chance, you’ve become an enemy of His Excellency. Maybe I should’ve talked to ya earlier to make His Excellency’s reputation better. I messed up, I messed up.”

Al and Olbart exchanged words, the former speaking in an easy-going tone, the latter with a broad smile.

⁴² Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The way Al addresses Olbart is reminiscent of an infamous, common telephone scam in Japan, called the «ore-ore» scam, which is often played on older parents. For more information, see [here](#).”

Unknowing of the relationship between the two, Subaru could only stare blankly. As for whether things were getting better or not, even that was difficult to gauge.

Vincent: “—Olbart, you know that man?”

The one person to intervene to put an end to such doubts was Vincent.

Olbart, with crossed arms, replied, “Oh, yes!” to the false Emperor’s query,

Olbart: “Two or three years ago when you’d just ascended to the throne, there were revolts all over the place, weren’t there?”

Kafma: “Master Olbart, His Excellency ascended to the throne eight years ago now...”

Olbart: “Huh? Thought it’d have been ‘bout three years ago. Dangnabbit, it’s been ‘bout ten years, which to me seems recent, guess I just screwed up.”

Vincent: “Never mind that, just proceed. Eight years ago, what happened?”

With Olbart going off on a tangent, Vincent set him back on track. In accordance with that correction, Olbart pointed to Al and said, “So,”.

Olbart: “There was a rebellion on Ginunhive back then... and the ones to stop it were this guy with the helmet and Araki.”

Vincent: “Hoh.”

After hearing Olbart’s story, for the first time, Vincent’s interest turned to Al.

It was difficult to ascertain which way the pendulum had swung, good or bad, but it seemed that his effort had not immediately led to him being punished for his rudeness.

On top of that, Al stepped forward so that he was alongside Subaru,

Al: “Your Most Gracious Excellency the Emperor, as Old Man Olbart over there is seemingly aware of... Actually, eight years ago, I was of service to His Excellency, and I have yet to receive my reward.”

Olbart: “Altho’, ya said ya didn’t want anythin’.”

Vincent: “Olbart, keep your mouth shut— You may resume, clown.”

Al: “—I was hoping to get my reward today.”

Subaru imagined a sound that seemed to silently freeze the air in the hall.

Al’s fearlessness in demanding a reward for his own achievements over eight years ago, coupled with the presence of someone who knew of Al’s deeds, was certainly a gamble worth taking.

The fake Emperor who had not opted to execute them immediately after hearing Subaru’s declaration of war— Vincent possessed both reasons and resolution to act as the Emperor of Vollachia.

And, if Abel’s words were veracious, then his beliefs would include “definite punishment or reward”. Then—

Vincent: “What do you request? My head?”

Al: “It would be a massive victory for me if I could get you to give it to me, but it would take a lot of courage to ask for it. So...”

As he said this, Al turned his head to look at Subaru. Realizing what he was being asked to do, Subaru pulled out an envelope from his pocket.

All along, their objective had been to deliver Abel’s missive.

Subaru: “It is our purpose to give this missive to Yorna-sama. If you would like to reward my companion for his service, please allow it.”

Vincent: “A missive?”

Subaru: “A love letter from our... Master, to Yorna-sama.”

Hesitant to call him “Master”, Subaru stuck his tongue out internally and continued to speak.

Hearing the expression “love letter”, Yorna, who was sitting at the head of the room, laughed and cleared her throat with a “Kuhu”. Her interest seemed to have been piqued. And Vincent’s reaction was not an undesirable one either.

As he squinted his dark eyes, Vincent pondered for just a few seconds,

Vincent: “Over eight years have passed, but the Gladiator Island incident was troublesome.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Vincent: “You may have your reward if you so desire it. You may deliver the missive to Yorna Mishigure.”

Gesturing with his chin, Vincent indicated Yorna.

It took Subaru a moment to comprehend the intent of Vincent’s words. But upon realizing that it meant that Al had won his bet, Subaru and the others looked at one another.

It had been a high-stakes gamble, and Al’s decision to go for it had been the correct one—

Vincent: “—However.”

Subaru: “Huh?”

Just as they were about to burst in jubilation, Vincent held up one finger and spoke up.

To Subaru and the others turning to look at him, the false Emperor closed his black eyes, which felt like darkness itself, and said,

Vincent: “The only thing I shall allow you to do, is to hand her your missive. You know the meaning of that, do you not?”

And thus, the words spoken were processed.

Subaru’s eyes widened at this, and he quickly turned around, gnashing his teeth as his gaze fell on Yorna, gazing over the situation with a grin.

The goal of Subaru’s party, though, was to give her a missive and get her to respond.

Subaru: “If I were to give you the missive, when should I expect a response from Yorna-sama?”

Yorna: “Yes, I see...”

Upon that question of Subaru's, Yorna cast her gaze towards the void.

Then turning the *kiseru* upside down, dropping the ashes into a jar prepared by the attending *kamuro*.

Yorna: "I'm a woman, after all... I don't want to be seen opening a love letter as soon as I receive it. That's why... I'll carefully read and respond to the guests after they have left the castle."

Subaru: "—So you will read it once we leave the castle, won't you?"

Yorna: "As the Lord of the Demon City, I won't speak lies in front of my attendants."

Subaru could not tell whether the light in her blue eyes was sincere or naive, as he was unfamiliar with her. However, he no longer had a choice.

For example, were he to alter Al's reward, instead saying that the reward would be to exit the castle safely, Vincent probably would have allowed for that as well.

However, much like the previous one, that plan would terminate the possibility of joining forces with Yorna. Meaning—

Subaru: "Al, Medium-san."

Before he completely made up his mind, Subaru called out the names of his two companions.

What was going to happen and what needed to be done required the cooperation of both of them. So, it made sense to get their approval before taking any action.

Subaru turned around and met their gaze, as Al and Medium nodded to each other.

Al: "Well, I told you bro, that I'd lend you a hand."

Medium: "Big bro asked me to take care of you, too! He said to take care of Natsumi-chan for him!"

Al tilted his head, and Medium exclaimed with powerful words.

Encouraged by the answers of those two, Subaru nodded back at them.

Then Subaru slowly walked towards the front of the hall— towards Yorna leaning on the armrest in the seat of honor, while she puffed on her *kiseru*.

With her bewitching beauty in close proximity, Subaru presented her the missive amidst a sweet scent.

Subaru: “Here you go, a missive from our Master.”

Yorna: “Thank you for your hard work. But it’s going to be a lot harder from here.”

Subaru: “Yes, I am aware.”

Supple fingers took the missive, and the words expressed with a smile, cursed the future of Subaru and his friends.

But Subaru responded to her words with dignity and turned around. And then—

Subaru: “—Your Majesty the Emperor, I’m afraid we’re going to have to take your throne.”

And so, right in front of him, he announced a declaration of war even more clearly than before.



The events that took place at that moment were dramatic.

Kafma: “How dare you, you insolent little—!!”

Immediately after their declaration of war, Kafma’s eyes went wide open.

Following Subaru’s proclamation, the height of rudeness and disrespect, Kafma Irulux wished to prove his loyalty to the Emperor with his own power.

—As a result, Kafma’s clothes exploded as his arms were extended, and countless thorns rushed towards Subaru.

Dark-green-colored thorns like slithering snakes surged toward Subaru, their overwhelming mass blanketing his vision. The ivy of thorns, each of which in possession of needles as thick as Subaru's arms, was a deadly weapon that would squeeze its prey out of every last drop of life.

It was a strike that would not permit for any reaction from Subaru, and akin to a snake swallowing a rat, it engulfed Subaru's body in thorns with no effort.

Al: "—Well said, bro."

The thorns pierced through his entire body, and he prepared for the fierce pain to come.

However, it was not the pain that struck Subaru, who had tensed up his body, but rather the shock of him being pulled backwards and falling on his buttocks. Stepping before Subaru was Al, whose words had reached him from the side, taking the thorns on with his *dao*.

Al, with Subaru behind him, drew out the thick blade and parried the enemy's attacks. Incapable of blocking their entirety, his shoulder and side were stained with blood.

Nevertheless, Al had been able to protect Subaru from this overwhelming mass.

Subaru: "What about Medium-san!"

Medium: "Uuaah! That was so close! If I hadn't done what Al-chin said, I would've died!"

Subaru turned around hurriedly, and right beside him was Medium answering in a loud voice, having pulled her twin swords.

Glancing over, she was swinging her twin blades up and down, slashing away, or catching, or stepping on, preventing some of the thorns approaching her from all directions.

Subaru breathed a sigh of relief at the certainty of her skills, and the fact that she was safe. However, relief was too premature. After all, this was merely the first wave—

Yorna: "What an extravagant magic trick."

Subaru: "—Hk."

To the rear of Subaru's group putting themselves on guard, was Yorna, who would have been within range of the thorns as well. She pulled her *kamuro* into her arms and exhaled purple smoke, while remaining in the same posture as when she had accepted the missive.

There were signs of thorns closing in on her from all sides as well, but they avoided her as if by design, the thorns twisting unnaturally as if there were a circle of space around only Yorna.

It was impossible to speculate whether it was Kafma who had intentionally bent it or Yorna who had done something about it, but—

Subaru: "I apologize for the disturbance. We will leave you to it."

Yorna: "Have a safe return home. If the three of you fail to leave the castle..."

Subaru: "You won't read the missive. I understand."

When explained once again in simple terms, Yorna's intentions could be understood without doubt, no matter how hard to grasp they may be. Vincent too, had made it clear that the game was on—

Subaru: "Game's on 'til we leave the castle— Al, Medium-san!"

Al: "Yeah!"

Medium: "Alright!"

Subaru: "To the right!!"

Immediately after the strong replies, Subaru barked loudly.

Hearing this, his two companions comprehended Subaru's decision that very instant, and three blades were brandished.

The *dao* of the one-armed man, and a pair of supple swords furiously cut through the thorns, blowing away the mass that blocked their vision and their path, and the three figures flew out of the greenery.

Just like that, they pressed down on the wooden floor to gain speed and momentum.

Kafma: "You think I am going to let you escape?"

However, after one step forward, a needle as thick as a thumb snagged the tip of Subaru's nose.

As it flashed across his vision, it appeared to be more akin to a piece of white bone to him a rather than a thorn. It was not a shot intended to deter Subaru, but a blow that should have pierced his temple.

He would have died had Al not swiftly placed his blade in the path of the launched needle.

Subaru: "Thorns and needles, along with a freak show!?"

Al: "It's the Insect Cage Tribe! They attack with the insects they carry inside their bodies!"

Subaru: "This isn't the Aburame Clan⁴³!"

While having a dispute over something trivial, Subaru kept his stance low and moved forward with Al and Medium providing support. It was not the exit of the hall that they were headed for.

Even if they headed that way, they would have had to retrace their steps the long way back down the castle Tower. There was no way they could continue to be exposed to Kafka's attacks for that long.

In other words, Subaru and others would need to take a significant shortcut. Therefore—

Subaru: "Medium-san!"

Medium: "Yeah!"

Subaru: "Do your best!"

Medium: "—I'll do my best!"

The moment she received that encouragement, without exaggeration, Medium's whole body bounced and her momentum increased.

With her long hair billowing, she swung the twin swords in her hands, fiercely dispatching the thorns that rushed forth in complicated and bizarre trajectories.

⁴³ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: "The Aburame clan is a reference to the Naruto series. At birth, members of this clan are offered to several special breeds of insects as a nest, residing just under their host's skin. These insects will then live in symbiosis with their host from that point on. Because of this, its members are characterized by their use of insects as weapons."

Of course, this was partly due to Medium's own skills. But in addition to that,

Al: "Right! Right knee! Nape of the neck! Sexy hips!"

Medium: "Uh! Ha! Take this!"

Al's blood-curdling shouts told Medium of the aim of the approaching dangers, and Medium responded instantly, successfully guarding against and handling the thorns just before they hit.

Subaru wondered how far he could see, but Al's high level of survivability, which had also been demonstrated against Arakiya, apparently applied not only to himself, but to others as well.

Taking advantage of this, Medium reached the window of the hall. With a single swing, she destroyed the wooden railing, and her long, leaping legs blew down the wall.

Beneath their gaze, the hall of the castle tower, which was more than thirty meters above the ground, had opened up. The blue sky of Demon City spread out in full view, and a wild wind greeted Subaru and the others.

It was not a matter of all or nothing, but—

Subaru: "—If we get out of the castle!"

Yorna put her hand on the missive.

Since they'd accepted these terms, Vincent's group would cease from doing anything further. Perhaps, it wasn't like they had made such a promise explicitly.

But with nothing else to believe in, it was the only way to see things through—

Medium: "—Natsumi-chan!"

Medium, who had smashed through the wall, beckoned him, and Subaru ran as fast as he could.

He was grateful for not having worn a skirt carelessly. If the cause of death were crossdressing, Subaru would not be able to face the efforts of his many predecessors.

At the last moment, Subaru, while even forgetting to keep his appearances up, kicked the floor as hard as he could.

He would then catch up with Medium, and exit through the wall with her—

Olbart: “Sorry, but I got a job ta do too, ya know.”

Subaru: “Kah... Hk.”

At the same moment, intercepting Subaru and Medium, the old man appeared in front of them as if from out of nowhere, and his piercing hand struck them both squarely in the chest.

His breath caught in his throat as he was struck by the impact. Subaru’s consciousness cracked, everything seemed to shatter after he took the blow from the Divine General. However—

Medium: “Natsumi-chan! It’s nothing!”

Subaru: “Huh!?”

A loud voice called out next to him, and Subaru regained the consciousness he had almost lost. Looking down at his chest in a panic, no damage from Olbart’s piercing hand could be seen.

There was no blood, no sign that his heart had been removed without bleeding.

Medium: “Let’s go, Natsumi-chan! Don’t bite your tongue, okay?”

Medium grabbed Subaru by the collar as the latter looked around in confusion. With a large step, she then crossed the wall she had breached, and threw herself out of the Crimson Lapis Castle without hesitation.

Subaru and Medium leapt into the blue sky, intertwined with each other; the sensation of rising through the air caused by the jump disappeared in an instant, only for them to be thrown into a falling trajectory a second later.

Subaru: “Uh, kyaaaaa—!”

With a high-pitched scream, Subaru pulled Medium close into him and then felt around his own waist. Following that, he pulled out the familiar feeling in his hand and held up his weapon— a whip, while in midair.

Had he simply jumped without any preparation, it would merely amount to an act of suicide.

Albeit the preparations performed towards their odds of success had not been many, Yorna's provocation, their declaration of war on Vincent, plus the offense and defense with Kafma and Olbart, had all been a series of gambles.

He had barely picked up everything that was there, so he just had to trust that he could pick up the very last one as well.

Subaru: "Don't miiiiss!!"

While hugging Medium's thin waist, Subaru swung his arm and unleashed the whip. The tip of the whip extended not into the void, but towards one of the beams that stretched throughout all parts of the Demon City— stretching like a spider's web all throughout the city, reaching likewise one of the outer walls of the Crimson Lapis Castle.

Hooking the whip onto that place, and utilizing it as a stepping stone to get out of the castle grounds. That was the best move Subaru could come up with amidst the chaos of the hall.

Subaru: "—Hk!"

Feeling the tug on his arm, Subaru wrapped the whip around his wrist with all his strength. He thought that this would support his body even if his grip were not strong enough; at worst, the damage would shatter the bones in his wrist. And then—

Subaru: "Al's... Gyahk!"

Al: "My bad!"

The moment the whip came taut, Al came crashing upon Subaru's back. Apparently he had been able to jump out of the castle, just like Subaru and Medium.



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by coolcollin007/SoupVEVO ([source](#))

As a result of having crashed into each other in midair, the three of them clung to each other and hung down, entrusting nearly one hundred and fifty kilograms of weight to a single arm of Subaru's.

Subaru: "G-guaaahhhh—!"

The bodies of Subaru and the others arced around one of the beams outside the Crimson Lapis Castle, using it as a pivot, while the screams of his arm and wrist, elbow and shoulder, of his entire right arm, were replaced by real screams.

As it was, the best thing to do was to wait for the recoil to subside, and have everyone climb up the whip and return to the beam one-by-one. Subaru clenched his molars, as he compared the time it would take to get there to the time it would take his right arm to necrotize—

Al & Medium: "—Ah."

And just as he was about to exert all his strength, Al and Medium's voices overlapped.

Before he could see what was up, the burden on Subaru's right arm vanished— No, to be precise, the burden had not vanished, but the beam onto which the whip was attached had snapped.

By the thorns extending from the breached walls of the keep, by their fierce mass.

Subaru: "Uh, AHHHHH—!"

With screams trailing behind them, Subaru's group of three flew through the air in a tangled heap. Their bodies flew in a parabola, recoiling from the whip on the beam.

Even though it was better than jumping from the castle tower, Subaru and Al, as ordinary people, would not be able to survive being knocked down a height of more than twenty meters.

As he searched a way out of the situation, while screaming his head off, the faces of Emilia, of Beatrice, and of Rem popped up one after another in Subaru's mind—

Everyone: "——"

—With a ferocious crash, the three of them crashed through the roof and into the castle stables, entangled with one another atop haystacks.

Arc 7 Chapter 39 - Vicious

Light Novel Adaptation found in Volume 28, Chapter 5 “A Reward Eight Years in the Making”, Part 4-7

Original Web Novel Chapter — [Complete](#)

Edited Machine Translation by Witch Cult Translations (Original by Goldkills, Translation checked by Averitius, PaperKaminari) — [Complete](#)

Taking a look outside through the large hole in the saloon wall, Kafma twisted his lips in disgust.

Under him, in the raging wind, smoke lingered. He strained his eyes towards the building into which the three of them had disappeared to, having successfully escaped the hall— He could not see the fugitives anywhere.

Kafma: “———”

The beam that had developed a crack crumbled with a loud sound, but as it was too far away, to hope that its debris would crush that insolent group would be folly. But—

Kafma: “I will not let you escape. I will do whatever it takes to avenge your disrespect towards His Excellency...”

Olbart: “No, no, we can’t do that. They bet their every card on this opportunity to escape, didn’t they? If we chase ‘em now, wouldn’t we make it pointless?”

Kafma: “Master Olbart!”

Having been stopped from pursuing the fugitives, Kafma turned around, his teeth chattering. Receiving that gaze, the diminutive old man voiced a “Oh, scary”, and made himself smaller.

Seeing his reaction, Kafma’s eyes grew even sharper and angrier,

Kafma: “Why did you let those girls go in the first place? If it’s you, Master, you should have been able to seize them in the blink of an eye!”

Olbart: “Oh? I could tell ya the same thing. And I didn’t cut corners too much either. That young fellow with the helmet, he’s got some strange tricks up his sleeve.”

Kafma: “...Young fellow, I got the impression that he really was not that young.”

Olbart: “That’s not really important. Most of ya look like waddlin’ kids to me, actually. I’ve been an old man since ya were born.”

Twisting his wrinkled face into a smile, Olbart pointed at himself. Kafma was about to point out this light-hearted attitude of his yet again, but Olbart continued with “And”,

Olbart: “Ya may’ve forgotten, but I got ta keep an eye on that foxgirl over there, don’t I? Ya never know when she might turn on Your Excellency.”

Kafma: “General First-Class Yorna... Indeed, I have been rash.”

Olbart: “Kakakakka, as long as ya understand.”

Once that was mentioned, Kafma sagged down as if ashamed of himself for losing his cool. At the exchange between the young man and the old man, Yorna, having been designated as a dangerous person, put her hand over her eyes and spoke,

Yorna: “That’s quite rude of you. How dare you speak of a delicate woman such as I as you’d speak of a dangerous animal... I’ve never been so humiliated in my life.”

Kafma: “Who do you think you...!”

She mocked them while faking tears, and Kafma’s anger was directed at Yorna. But Yorna cleared her throat while bathed in his gaze, then gently lowered her hand to touch her eyes.

As she did so, she brought her *kiseru* to her mouth, filled her lungs with purple smoke, and deeply exhaled, letting out a large plume of smoke— The smoke slightly wavered as it made its way to the big hole in the wall.

Once the fluttering purple smoke reached it, an astonishing change was born.

In nature very much like that of a hallucination, the demolished wall was mended in a spectacle.

The wood used in the areas where the collapsed walls of the Crimson Lapis Castle had been damaged, wriggled and mended akin to a creature's wounds being healed. It was a building being repaired, but a strange and unearthly one; the impression it gave was more of a living being, rather than something inorganic.

That unrealistic scene caused Kafma, standing by the wall while tensing his cheeks, to retreat, and look back at Yorna.

Yorna: "With this, everything's back to normal now... So if you could as well, please fix your mood."

Kafma: "This is, General Yorna's..."

Vincent: "This is why one cannot mess with the Demon City without proper care... But that is not the sole danger posed by this woman."

After she finished repairing the outer wall, Kafma gasped towards Yorna, who produced a supple smile.

His shiver was complemented by Vincent, who had not even twitched during the earlier commotion. The man at the top of the Empire glanced at the wall, then focused on Yorna,

Vincent: "They have exited the castle. The conditions set forth by you and I have been met."

Yorna: "So, if that's the case, it'd be somewhat unseemly for us to deny their efforts. I hope you understand that, Your Excellency."

Vincent: "———"

Yorna: "Of course, you've got your own ideas, Your Excellency. I respect that. But don't forget."

The Lord of the Demon City, Yorna Mishigure, who had not made an effort to correct her posture against the Emperor from beginning to end, smiled as she looked at the silent Vincent.

Yorna: "This is the Demon City, my city— Even that blue youngster's sword cannot reach me."

Albeit that declaration was appropriate for the Lord of the Demon City, it was inappropriate to announce it to the Emperor.

For the Emperor of Vollachia, who carried out his rule across the entire Empire, for Yorna to act as if her control over even a single city was superior was more than just disrespectful.

However, the words of Yorna Mishigure could not be denied.

Because everyone knew it veracious, regardless of whether she was right or wrong to speak them.

In this Demon City of Chaosflame, Yorna Mishigure possessed absolute power. Therefore—

Vincent: “I shall give you one night.”

To consider it a defeat for the Vollachian Emperor would disregard that very Emperor’s foresight and deep thinking. However, it was not easy for even those close to the Emperor to discern the intrigues the Emperor held within the depths of his dark eyes.

They must only believe that Vincent’s words were not unreasonable nor erroneous.

Yorna: “Thank you. Then I’ll take my time to examine the reply to the letter.”

And so answered Yorna to Vincent’s permission, and while her words were spirited on the surface, her attitude and face did not display any gentleness at all.

Both of Vincent’s guards, Kafma and Olbart, had their own opinions regarding Yorna’s attitude. But the reason as to why they allowed that from Yorna was their own guilt for letting those three escape.

With Vincent’s admission, there was nothing to be gained from backtracking.

Kafma: “But your attitude is inexcusable. I will continue to repeat this.”

Yorna: “Kuhu. If you look at me with such scary eyes I won’t stop shivering. Master Olbart, could you do something about it for me?”

Olbart: “You’re goin’ ta spring this on me? I’m an ol’ man with a short life ahead of me, it’s the duty of young’uns ta be kind to the older generation. Wait, maybe I’ve found the best idea ta get goodwill from most people? Is my era comin’?”

Kafma: “Master Olbart!”

Kafma raised his voice in anger at Olbart’s mischievous remark.

Watching it with a smile, Yorna shook the smoke fluttering from her *kiseru*. Squinting at the appearance of these Generals, Vincent gave a light snort of his nose.

Then turning, the Emperor regarded the final person accompanying him— the one who, contrary to Kafma and Olbart, had not moved any more than Vincent.

Vincent: “You have been talking very little. It is unlike you.”

???: “...It is, isn’t it? Well, it’d be complicated if I were to meet some people.”

The voice of a young man donning a wry smile responded.

The young man was wearing a blue robe over his head, which prevented his face from being seen by others. That in itself was a normal thing for him, but the fact that he had tightened the neck of the robe even more than usual apparently had something to do with the guests previously present.

The man sighed, and shrugged while being in the line of sight of the silent Emperor,

???: “I thought I had to clam up in this Demon City— The stars, too, seem to want that.”

Vincent: “Is that what the stars want? Nonsense.”

???: “I’d prefer if you didn’t call it nonsense.”

Shrugging, the man grinned at Vincent’s words of disregard.

With this bitter smile, he continued.

???: “If Your Excellency were serious and took heed of the stars’ desires, you wouldn’t have come all the way out here, would you?”

Vincent: “You fool, do you believe you know what lays within my heart?”

???: “Please don’t be absurd.”

The man’s shoulders shrunk as Vincent folded his arms and lowered his voice one note.

Vincent then looked away from the man— from the Stargazer, and narrowed his eyes at the sky into which the three rebels had disappeared, beyond the wall that had already closed.

And then—

Vincent: “—The wishes of the stars are nonsense.”

That murmur that no one was capable of hearing remained as a whisper to himself, then vanished.



Subaru: “Coughk! Kahk! Atchoo!”

Coughing into the thick cloud of dust, he desperately worked his lungs.

His back aching from the impact, Subaru ran his hand over the affected area to check for injuries. He fearfully retrieved his hand to see it not stained by blood; it seemed it was merely a bruise. It was a miracle.

The probability that the building materials from the destroyed building or the pieces of the collapsed beams could have pierced him or tore his vitals was high. Just how much luck had he?

Subaru: “We don’t have time for this... Medium-san! Al!”

???: “I-I’m here... Ouchouch.”

Shaking his head, he quickly called out the names of the two people he was supposed to be with. And hearing a reply originated from beneath the rubble at his side, Subaru moved to push aside the debris in a hurry, as to search for those people.

The buried Medium coughed, then blinked her eyes.

Medium: “Uwah, I thought I was gonna die! Are you okay Natsumi-chan?”

Subaru: “I managed somehow, thanks to Medium-san’s and Al’s protection... Medium-san, are you hurt? Does it hurt anywhere?”

Medium: “Uhyahyaha, that tickles~! It’s okay, it’s okay! I’m fine!”

Checking Medium’s shoulders and back, she wriggled and pushed back against Subaru’s chest.

It was no bluff nor lie; it appeared she had no noticeable injuries either. It would seem that both of them had been blessed with a tremendous amount of luck.

Subaru: “Al’s—”

Looking for Al, who did not respond, Subaru scanned his surroundings.

As the clouds of dust finally settled, Subaru noticed that he and the others had jumped into an empty stable. The building beside the Crimson Lapis Castle was apparently a warehouse where hay for Galewind Horses was stored.

The reason as to why Subaru’s party had been saved from their helpless fall off a great height was said hay, which had acted as a cushion. Had it not been for the hay, at a minimum Subaru would have died a horrible death; being crushed like a tomato.

In Vollachia, where healing magic was rare, Rem not included, there was a high possibility that those with serious injuries would not be saved. In that sense, the environment of the Empire was much more conducive to death than Lugunica.

Of course, it could be said that the Empire’s notion of survival of the fittest was what had caused all this danger in the first place.

Medium: “There he is! Al-chin!”

And then, as Subaru looked around the dimly-lit room, Medium next to him moved as if to jump out.

She bent down beside a cart that had been overturned by the impact of the fall. Under the heavy pile of hay the three had fallen upon entangled with one another, something had begun to stir.

Subaru hurriedly rushed over, and the two of them, him and Medium, shoveled through the hay. Eventually, a listless thick arm appeared from under the hay, and they pulled it up. And then——

Al: “Yeooh! My right arm’s gonna come off as well!”

Subaru: “That’s not funny!”

Medium: “But Al-chin’s alive too! That’s amazing!”

Subaru scolded Al for his unfunny joke, but was relieved by Medium’s words.

Al was pulled out of the haystack; his body was in a terrible state. Unlike Subaru and Medium who had miraculously escaped with only a few bruises and scratches, Al’s body had numerous lacerations and bruises all over.

He had fended off Kafma’s thorns and, if only temporarily, Olbart as well. As of his jump onto Subaru and Medium at the very end, he was in a position in which he could easily be pursued by the enemy.

—Each of the wounds he had received, were wounds that were supposedly Subaru and Medium’s to receive, originally.

Subaru: “———”

Al: “What’s the matter, bro... You got a depressing look on your face.”

Subaru: “Well, it’s...”

Al: “It’s a miracle that we all survived the *anzentai nashi no tobikomi*⁴⁴. Looking at me like that won’t make me feel better about the scars on my back, though. It’s a shame for a swordsman, you know?”

Turning his shoulders in a languid manner, Al ran his mouth, as to encourage Subaru.

⁴⁴ English flip. Means “jump without a safety harness” (安全帯なしの飛び込み), originally “ノーロープバンジー” (no-rope bungee).

That attitude caused Subaru to choke up, but he then nodded quickly, “I guess so”.

Al tried to act aloof and as if everything were someone else’s problem, but his efforts in the offense and defense so far were all due to his sincerity to Subaru.

He sympathized with Subaru’s goals, and promised to assist him.

To that end, the man who was even willing to fight for Subaru’s life, was Al.

Subaru: “I was wrong about you...”

Al: “Huh?”

Subaru: “I thought you were always aloof and irresponsible, unreliable and unserious about everything.”

Al: “Oi oi.”

Subaru: “But you risked your life for me—I won’t forget that.”

Putting his hand on his fake chest, he spoke of his genuine resolution to Al.

Without him, Natsuki Subaru, would not be alive, at this moment. Therefore, from now on, Natsuki Subaru would fight without forgetting the favor he received from Al.

Even if his life could come to an end the next moment—

Medium: “Natsumi-chan, Al-chin, if you two mess around too much...”

Subaru: “Yes, I know, I know. Let’s get out of here as soon as possible. Otherwise, Al’s sacrifice will have been in vain.”

Al: “It ain’t a sacrifice!”

At Medium’s urging, Subaru wiped his face with his sleeve and gave a strong reply.

It was fortuitous that all three of them had survived, however it was still too early to be relieved. The conditions proposed by Yorna and Vincent had been met, at least, but whether Kafma and Olbart would back off was uncertain.

Until he knew that for sure, they would have to survive.

Subaru: “We need to leave now. Hide ourselves and get the answers over there at...”

???: “—No need to worry about that.”

Subaru: “—Hk!?”

He was about to walk out while lending his shoulder to Al, when a voice called out to him.

Surprised by this, he abruptly moved his hands away, and Al, who was leaning on his shoulder, tipped over and screamed, “Guoh!”. But he did not have the leisure to worry about him.

A confrontation had begun between Subaru’s group, and this new figure at the entrance of the stable.

Subaru: “You’re...”

???: “My apologies for the delay in greeting you. A servant of Yorna Mishigure-sama I am, called Tanza.”

The person to speak these words with a respectful bow of her head, was a person with a distinctive *kimono* and deer antlers— the deergirl who had been beside Yorna.

The girl who called herself Tanza slowly looked up and faced Medium, who stood in front of her as if protecting Subaru and Al, and shook her head.

Tanza: “Do not be alarmed, all is fine. I mean you all no harm.”

Medium: “Really? But we broke the walls of both this place and your master’s castle, didn’t we?”

Tanza: “The castle and the stables will be fixed by Yorna-sama— Yorna-sama has accepted you as messengers. No one will interfere with you again.”

Medium’s anxiety was dispelled by the words Tanza had added at the end. That line caused Medium’s eyebrows to lower in relief, but Subaru’s impression was the complete opposite.

Aside from Yorna going to fix the walls and stables, the question was more, what would happen afterward?

Subaru: “To say that no one will interfere with us, is a big deal. We know His Majesty the Emperor was there, you know?”

Subaru stood behind Medium, protected by her, not worrying about looking good. Tanza’s gray eyes stared at Subaru as he stepped forward.

In spite of her pretty face, she was a girl whose emotions did not show. Amiability was supposed to be a crucial part of a *kamuro*, but her behavior reminded him of a doll.

Subaru: “At the very least, we are those who’d hurt His Majesty the Emperor... and you’ll all overlook that? Is that what Lady Yorna said?”

Tanza: “Yes. No one can stand against Yorna-sama here in the Demon City. I believe Vincent-sama too is aware of that.”

Subaru: “Oh...”

Tanza’s answer was matter-of-fact, but with absolute certainty. Hearing this, Subaru was taken aback, swallowing down the words he was about to continue with.

Following that, Subaru and the others looked up at the ceiling of the stables they had just broken through and confirmed that there was no movement in the Crimson Lapis Castle. Based on his short impression, Kafma would have followed them right away.

Subaru: “Not even that’s happening... Apparently, you’re to be believed.”

Tanza: “Vincent-sama will return as well. Your letter will be answered tomorrow.”

Subaru: “...I understand.”

Tanza: “Then, have a safe trip back.”

Tanza bowed in response to Subaru’s sigh, and turned her back on the three of them.

She had performed the minimal amount of work precisely, and was now seemingly returning to Yorna’s company. Suddenly as her back departed, Subaru called her out to stop her with “Tanza-san”.

Tanza stopped and turned around; As he stared back at that motionless, doll-like expression on her face,

Subaru: “What kind of person is Yorna-sama to you?”

The pretext for that inquiry was because Subaru had too many inner impressions of Yorna.

As long as she remained unknowing that Vincent was a fake, the way she treated him should be the same as the way she treated Abel, the Emperor.

He did not believe it fair to overlook her disrespectful and rude behavior only because of the pretense that she was a powerful woman, but it was unclear to him as to why she was acting in such a manner.

What was it that Yorna had for Abel, affection or hostility?

Combined with the fact that she had encouraged Subaru and the others to struggle, the depths of her heart were almost unreadable. Therefore—

Subaru: “I would like to hear it from someone who’s beside her. Their impressions of Yorna Mishigure-sama.”

Tanza: “She is a loving woman. Loves her allies and hates her enemies— Lover of all things that reside in the Demon City.”

Subaru: “———”

Tanza replied without hesitation, and for the first time a hint of emotion flashed through her eyes.

It disappeared in a flash, but to Subaru’s eyes, it seemed to be filled with a faint passion, and he was unable to say anything else.

Unable to follow up, he could only watch the girl’s back as she walked away.

If asked if he had obtained the answers he desired, he would have to say that he had not.

Instead, the mysterious impression he had of Yorna had only been deepened. He could not detect falsehood in Tanza’s words. But it was difficult to believe that that woman was a loving person.

Ever since they had arrived at the Demon City, Subaru and the others had been toyed with at her mercy.

Al: “Good grief, she’s gone... What are we gonna do?”

Subaru: “... There’s nothing we can do but go back. For now, we have to trust Tanza-san’s word and wait for a reply tomorrow.”

In the stables from which Tanza had disappeared, Subaru again lent a shoulder to Al, who had fallen on his butt.

While supporting his weight, Subaru looked up at the Crimson Lapis Castle once more.

Subaru: “A showy, eye-catching castle... Is this what «flamboyant» had been referring to?”

While he muttered to himself, Subaru realized that Tanza’s words had been true.

This strange castle that edged between blue and red was devoid of the hole that he and the others had created. No matter how much he strained his eyes, it was nowhere to be found, not even a shadow remained.



Abel: “I see, so he came, huh.”

Subaru: “Do you have something to say? Maybe along the lines of I’m sorry, or I apologize, or please forgive me?”

After scrambling back to the inn, Abel received a report of the incident regarding the delivery of the letter. Frowning heavily at his first remarks, Subaru’s face filled with hatred, as he pressed for an answer.

Despite this, Abel, donning the oni mask, pushed Subaru’s forehead with his palm with annoyance,

Abel: “Why must I apologize? You guys did well. I was just about to praise you on a job well done.”

Subaru: “Praise!? Praise, you say!? Don’t give me that condescending attitude together with that phrasing! You don’t have to praise me, I’m just doing what needs to be done. Hey, you two!”

Al: “Don’t get me involved.”

Subaru stuck his tongue out at the dissatisfied Abel while protesting furiously, calling for backup. Al, however, sprawled his feet on the floor and waved his hand saying, “Gimme a break”.

By net content, Al was the one to display the hardest work of the job. Leaving the first aid of his body with injuries all over to Taritta, his body started to resemble a mummy from all the bandages.

With the combination of his black helmet and the bandages all over his body, the surrealness of his appearance was incredible.

Taritta: “I’m glad that Natsumi and Medium are *okay*. I really should have gone with *you*, I was so *worried*.”

Subaru: “Hey, hear that? This is the correct response. As Emperor, why don’t you follow the example of Taritta-san, who’s taking over as the Chieftain?”

Taritta: “Please *stop*, I’ll *die*...”

Having been appraised as a good role model by Subaru, the latter currently explaining what should be the mindset of someone of higher position, Taritta, shook her head, her face turning pale.

Even though her attitude was fearful, Subaru could not help but feel disappointed. Was there nobody out there capable of punishing Abel?

At times like this, he felt ashamed that he had no choice but to take advantage of someone’s vulnerability.

Louis: “Uu! Auu!”

Medium: “Ah! Louis-chan, you can’t do that! You see, Natsumi-chan and the others are in the middle of an important conversation!”

Louis: “Uu! Uu!”

And then, Subaru’s thoughts were disturbed by a high-pitched scream coming from the adjacent room.

Taking a glance at the doorway to the neighboring room, he saw that Louis and Medium were having a scuffle with each other. Of course, there was no way Louis could resist Medium, so it resembled a sumo wrestling match between an adult and a child.

Soon after, Louis was carried away and her figure once again disappeared into the other room.

Louis: "Auu!"

Subaru: "...Sheesh, what the hell's going on there? Ever since I came back, she's been trying to jump at me."

Al: "For some reason, she seems to be attached to you the most, bro. She doesn't even look at me. Not that I want her to be attached to me."

Hearing Subaru's sighs, Al let out a grumble in his final form, which looked like a cheap Halloween costume. Next to him, Taritta wiped her forehead with satisfaction, her aesthetic sense not too bad.

Subaru had found someone who would compete with Emilia and Beatrice, making him miss them all over again— No, it was not just the two of them that he missed, but everyone on the other side of the border.

Soon, it would be twenty days since Subaru was sent to Vollachia.

As long as Beatrice and Ram were around, they should be aware of Subaru and Rem's safety, but that was all; that they would not be able to convey any information beyond that made it even more frustrating.

He wished to find a way to meet up with Emilia and the others as soon as possible.

Subaru: "And yet, this masked man keeps leaving all the important bits out..."

Abel: "Hmm, you can point at me and say I am the masked one? If I am masked, what are you? A fool and a clown, perhaps?"

Al: "I'd say we're all wearing cheap Halloween costumes, ain't we?"

Al's words had guessed Subaru's innermost thoughts from just a moment before, and that expression, coupled with Abel's point, caused Subaru to gnash his back teeth with a "Grr".

In fact, Subaru, dressed as a woman, Abel, donning his oni mask, and Al, as a man wrapped in bandages and wearing a helmet, all looked like participants in a costume party. It somewhat mirrored Chaosflame; in this place where many different races were mingled, it seemed as if they were all trying to keep their individuality from being buried.

Of course, Subaru's crossdressing was for practical purposes, that it was something that could not be avoided.

Subaru: "Anyway! I was able to meet Yorna-san at the castle, but I also ran into the Emperor's entourage... That was your body double, correct?"

Clapping his hands, Subaru corrected the flow of conversation by force.

He was careful to keep his voice low to avoid being overheard, but he wanted those in front of him to hear exactly what needed to be heard.

In response, Abel nodded his head sporting the oni mask with a "Yeah",

Abel: "Even if there are many who may resemble my appearance, there is merely a single person in a position able to perform an impersonation of me— Chisha Gold."

Subaru: "Chisha Gold... One of the Nine Divine Generals. If I remember correctly, the White Spider, right?"

Abel: "That is correct. Quite wise, and excellent at commanding a large army. And..."

Al: "The first person who betrayed Abel-chan."

Following Al's last comment, Abel, his arms crossed while sitting on the bed, silently affirmed it.

He had been the first one among the treacherous Nine Divine Generals, a person who Abel must have trusted very much. That was Abel's substitute— no, rather than a substitute, he was now in the seat of the Emperor.

Subaru: “Chisha... Why do you think the fake Emperor came to the Demon City?”

Abel: “He understands the conditions of victory in a battle against me.”

Subaru: “The one with more Nine Divine Generals on their side wins.”

Securing the Nine Divine Generals, the symbol of strength in the Vollachian Empire, was the decisive key to victory.

To obtain this key, Subaru and the others had taken the trouble to go to Chaosflame. However, based on Abel’s current answer, there was only one possible purpose.

Subaru: “So, are they also trying to get Yorna Mishigure on their side?”

Abel: “That is difficult to imagine. Yorna Mishigure... He is not reckless enough to believe that she would listen to persuasion or negotiation.”

Subaru: “—? Then what are they doing here?”

Abel: “That much is obvious— He knew that I would come to the Demon City.”

After hearing Abel’s answer and being unable to comprehend it, a question mark popped up above Subaru’s head.

Equally puzzled, Al raised his hand voicing an “Abel-chan”,

Al: “Are you really saying that fake Emperor was able to predict that Abel-chan was gonna come to Chaosflame? If that’s for real, ain’t we in trouble?”

Abel: “He can follow my thoughts with considerable accuracy. After all, starting with where I would show up after having left the throne and the capture of the Fortress City, plus the arrangement of the Nine Divine Generals... Naturally, the Demon City would be narrowed down as a critical location.”

Subaru: “Knowing that... No, no way!”

Subaru widened his eyes as he processed Abel’s nonchalant words. Then he pointed at Abel, who looked at him quietly, with a trembling finger.

Subaru: “You were expecting us to run into the fake Emperor, weren’t you? To avoid running into each other in person, you stayed at the inn by yourself...”

Abel: “Fool. What is the point in doing such a thing? If you have the number of pieces under your control reduced without resistance, you shall spoil the path to victory even in an already-won match of Shatranj.”

Subaru: “...Well, I guess that’s true, but.”

The only point that did not make sense, was that Abel would make a move detrimental to himself.

The only problem was that he could not disprove it; and as long as that was the case, Subaru’s conspiracy theory that Abel was a malevolent mastermind would end up being labeled as quite literally just a conspiracy theory. In any rate—

Subaru: “Anyway! Back to the point, what do you mean? That the false Emperor knew that he couldn’t convince Yorna-san to join his side. Yet, he still showed up at the Demon City because you’re coming...”

Abel: “He will take the initiative, and ruin the relationship between Vincent Vollachia and Yorna Mishigure. Do you think it would be so easy for me to reach the top of the Tower of the Crimson Lapis Castle after such an event?”

Al: “Oh, that’s kinda... What a devious guy, oy!”

Once Al nodded his head in agreement, Subaru became annoyed and agreed as well.

At last, Subaru understood what Abel intended to say. In other words, Vincent’s goal was to make Yorna neither friend nor foe, but to keep her cut off as an invalid vote.

To do so, he had personally gone to the castle and had planned a decisive breakdown of the negotiations with the Emperor.

Subaru: “...So, if we had arrived one day later.”

Abel: “Their plan would have been in place. Hence why I stated it. That it was a job well done.”

Subaru: “———”

Motionless with surveying eyes, Subaru stared at Abel without blinking.

In other words, the previous exchange had been his way of displaying appreciation. If that was the case, a boss could only be so bad at praising his subordinates.

Even patting himself on the back would be more effective than the compliment from Abel.

Subaru: “Well done, me... Al and Medium-san too!”

Al: “Oh? Oh, yeah, well done, us.”

Medium: “Yeaah~. Natsumi-chan’s cutting remarks were awesome!”

The three of them, who had overcome death together and become more united, praised each other. Unlike Abel, Subaru felt pity for Taritta, the latter feeling lonely for having been left out of the group.

Subaru: “But there are many things I wish you’d told me beforehand. For example, the fact that Yorna-san has feelings for you.”

Al: “Oh, that’s something I’ve been meaning to say as well. I’m begging you Abel-chan. It can’t be helped that you’re a lady-killer by nature, but in that cast you gotta pay the *ikemen*⁴⁵ tax.”

Abel: “I really do not understand what you are talking about, clown. Furthermore, you too misunderstand.”

Al: “What do you mean misunderstand? I’m just looking at the actual interaction.”

Despite saying “actual”, it was Yorna and Vincent’s interaction, but the fact that she was directing flirtatious glances at Abel was true.

However, Abel heaved a deep sigh upon Subaru and Al’s persistence,

Abel: “I am not one towards whom Yorna Mishigure’s thoughts are being directed at. It is the Emperor of Vollachia.”

⁴⁵ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Ikemen (イケメン) is modern slang used to call someone a good-looking man.”

Subaru: "...So that's you, right? You're not going to tell me now that you're actually the fake, and the other Emperor's the real one, are you?"

For a moment, the suspicions born in him back at the Crimson Lapis Castle were rekindled, and Subaru glared at him as if he were telling a joke. However, Abel dismissed him with a "Preposterous",

Abel: "Do not take it at face value. It is true that I am the Emperor of Vollachia, however, «Emperor of Vollachia» does not refer to solely me. There have been Emperors of Vollachia in the past, and there will be Emperors of Vollachia in the future."

Subaru: "That's..."

Subaru rolled his eyes after digesting Abel's concise explanation. Next to him, Al let out a dumb-sounding "Huuuh-?",

Al: "So you're saying that Yorna-chan's goal's Abel-chan's wealth or status?"

Abel: "I shall not delve into the details, but I am pretty certain that is what it is about. What she desires is the pinnacle of the Empire... to be the most favored mistress of the Emperor of Vollachia. It does not necessarily mean me."

Subaru: "...I kind of feel sorry for you."

Abel: "Do not pity me based off your own advancing narratives."

In a sense, it was a clearly-defined prerequisite for love.

The Emperor's most favored mistress— In other words, Yorna's goal appeared to lay in becoming the Emperor's wife. Certainly, in that position, she could rule the Empire both in terms of power and financial strength without becoming the Emperor.

To rule the Demon City of Chaosflame was not enough to satisfy the greed of that beautiful foxwoman.

Taritta: "Now that you mention *it*, what did you write in your *letter*?"

Al: "Well, maybe that he'll take her as a wife if she comes to us or something. I think that's the quickest way to do it, and she's so beautiful."

Subaru: "I wonder if her beauty's enough to make up for the fact that she was so difficult to handle..."

Subaru believed that it was possible to tolerate some selfishness and bad character provided it was a beautiful woman, but only up to a point.

Priscilla and Yorna were undoubtedly beautiful, but Subaru would not take either as his wife. No matter how many lives he had, he could not handle living in a state of constant anxiety like that.

Abel: "I have no intention of revealing the contents of the missive. However, it shan't disappoint your expectations. I can assure you of that."

Subaru: "Guarantees can only be established when there's trust... Oh no, let's not go there. There's no point in saying it. Stop, stop!"

Clapping his hands together, Subaru forced the topic to end there.

Abel looked at him disapprovingly upon witnessing that unsatisfying conclusion, but Subaru, looking at Al and prefacing with "By the way", continued with a new topic of conversation,

Subaru: "A Divine General was there, you called him Olbart. Vicious Old Man, was it?"

Al: "Yeah, he was there. That old man's bad news. I've met a lotta guys in my time, but he's on a class of his own among those I've come across."

Subaru: "Do you think that old man's already been recruited by our opponent? If that's the case, then Arakiya, Chisha, and a third person have already been taken."

To have the majority of the Nine Divine Generals, five must be held.

But whereas Subaru and the others were still struggling to recruit the first one, there were already three Nine Divine Generals on the opposing side.

Al: "By the way, from what I heard before, that old man's ranked Third. They also got the Second, Lil' Miss Arakiya, and the Fourth, Chisha."

Subaru: “They’ve got the biggest *ban*⁴⁶ pretty much covered!”

Upon hearing Al’s bleak report, Subaru shouted aloud.

If the ranks were in order of strength, the difference in strength seemed hopeless already. Since Yorna held the rank of Seventh, Subaru’s distress was to be expected.

Abel: “Do not bellow... It is likely that Olbart has not allied himself with the other faction. Currently, he is merely obeying the orders of the Emperor as a Divine General.”

Subaru: “...And your basis for that is?”

Abel: “Olbart Dunklekenn is too, a man whose following plays cannot be read. If one wishes to shift the current situation, the path to victory must be rectified. Influencing Arakiya might be trivial, but Olbart is not as easy to ensnare.”

Subaru: “So what you’re saying, is that the Nine Divine Generals can’t be controlled completely after all...?”

In other words, since he had been unable to hold the reins of power, the body double who had taken his place would be unable to hold the reins of power either.

It was a conversation that he believed there was nothing to be happy about, one that made him feel uneasy about the future to come.

Taritta: “*Then*, the old man named Olbart has room to be on our *side*.”

Abel: “Naturally, adequate leverage must be brought to the negotiation table. He is a crafty old man with needs and expectations. Once the situation becomes clearer, we can decide what to bring.”

Subaru: “...Oh, by the way, you knew him Al, didn’t you? What’s your relationship with him?”

If they wished to negotiate with Olbart, Subaru believed Al to be the best choice.

⁴⁶ English flip. Means “number/rank” (番), originally “ナンバー” (number).

The conversation between Al and Olbart at the castle Tower had revealed this possibility.

Subaru: “Gladiator Island, was it? So you played a role in resolving a case that happened there...”

Al: “Oh, yeah. There ain’t much to add, though? Eight years ago, when I was still a gladiator in Vollachia, I got caught up in a rebellion on the island. Gladiators from the island took a High Countess hostage during a deathmatch, and gave demands for his release.”

Subaru: “That sounds like a major incident to me... And you solved it, Al?”

Al: “To be exact, it was me and Lil’ Miss Arakiya when she was still a loli. And then there’s the High Countess who was supposedly being held hostage... We can talk about those details later.”

Clouding the second half of the story, Al scratched his neck awkwardly. It seemed to be something difficult to speak of, but even without the hidden details, the gist of it could be understood.

Al had resolved an incident in the Empire and eight years later sought a reward for his achievement. That had permitted Subaru and the others to fulfill their purpose and return with their lives.

Subaru: “Did you really want to use it that way?”

Al: “I don’t think I’d ever have a chance to use it anywhere but there, so why not? To be honest, I didn’t think it’d be such amazing foreshadowing. I wanna thank the lethargic me of the time.”

Al gave a cheerful chuckle, apparently wishing to avoid making Subaru feel any more self-conscious.

At the same time Subaru felt grateful for his concern, Abel, voicing an “Is that so”, nodded his head in assent.

Plucking the chin of his oni mask and gently flipping it upward, Abel exposed his bare face to Al, and,

Abel: “I had gotten word that a gladiator of the Gladiator Island had labored in the turmoil immediately after my accession. I too had heard that he had requested no reward... Would that be you, clown?”

Al: “Seems like it was. I’m more surprised that it reached the Emperor’s ears and that he was able to remember it. Feels like he’s also gonna remember later all the frivolous talks we had during our travels.”

Abel: “It was a great deed— I shall reward you for your service. No matter what happens.”

Al: “Oh...”

Abel’s words were grave and adorned with an unmovable sincerity as he showed his true face.

Abel’s creed of “definite punishment or reward” once again gave him the appearance of an Emperor. Abel’s upbringing as an Emperor would not overlook those who did not seek rewards for their achievements.

Al too, would not be able to escape this time without receiving a reward.

Abel: “Whatever the case, now that the missive is in her hands, we cannot avoid waiting for tomorrow’s response.”

Subaru: “That’s right, isn’t it? There’s nothing more we can do... In the meantime, Yorna-san’s attendant girl said that the fake Emperor’s group would not lay a finger on us.”

Abel: “If that is what Yorna Mishigure said, there is no reason to cast doubt onto it.”

Abel accepted Tanza’s assurance of safety without hesitation. It seemed that there was something hidden there that Abel had yet to tell, something that had not been conveyed to Subaru and the others. However—

Subaru: “Even if I told you to tell me about it...”

Abel: “I am the one who shall choose what information to relay to you. The information you shall get is what you are capable of handling— At least for the time being.”

Subaru: “At least for the time being... Huh.”

For a moment, Subaru’s manner of speaking returned to its original form, and he admonished himself for the discord that had formed in his heart.

It would be easy to dismiss this as uncooperative from Abel. But, he himself wished not to be defeated. Just like Subaru was doing his utmost, Abel too was doing his utmost.

That approach might be something desired by Subaru, but he was still not in step with Abel.

Al: “So, that’s it for today, huh? Fortunately, we were able to save our lives and be able to connect them to tomorrow. In addition, we’ve thwarted our opponent’s goals, so I’d say we’ve done well.”

Al spoke in a loud voice, breaking the delicate atmosphere between Subaru and Abel.

Taking this into consideration, Subaru nodded and said, “I guess so”.

Despite the unusual circumstances, the first step toward winning over Yorna Mishigure had been taken, thanks to Al and Medium.

There was no option but to wait for Yorna’s response the following day.

Subaru: “...As expected, I’m very tired.”

As soon as he concluded that there was nothing else to do today, his body became heavy.

The tension must have dissipated, and so his body had become aware of his fatigue. From having to go up the castle right after their arduous journey, to meeting with Yorna and encountering the false Emperor, it was the conclusion of an important bout.

His right arm was sore from the strain he had put on it, and he had to take care of his whip, which had been utilized quite recklessly.

After the completion of a large task, it was important to maintain your body and tools.

Subaru: “Nevertheless, I’m sleepy...”

Holding his wobbly head, Subaru muttered to himself in a daze.

Seeing Subaru’s condition, Taritta supported him while saying, “Natsumi”,

Taritta: “You’ve finished an important *mission*. I’ll take care of your *equipment*, so please rest early *tonight*. I’ll also take care of the night *watch*.”

Subaru: “Being wary of night attacks in the city’s so post-apocalyptic⁴⁷...”

With a small smile at Taritta’s concern, Subaru decided to take her word for it.

Exhaling deeply, he went to his assigned room. However, as he did so—

???: “Uu!”

Subaru: “It’s you again...”

Louis, who was supposed to have been separated from him in the adjacent room, jumped on Subaru as if she had been waiting for him. At Louis’s behavior of grabbing onto Subaru’s arm, Subaru put his hands on her head, utterly fed up.

Were it not Louis, he would not have minded the childish pleas for attention. However, it was hard to let his guard down considering it was Louis, particularly so when he was tired.

Wordlessly putting his finger on Louis’s forehead, Subaru flicked her white forehead prompting an “Ua” from her.

Subaru: “I don’t have time for you. Now, please step aside.”

Louis: “Aa, uaa!”

???: “Oh, she’s out of bed again! I’m sorry, Natsumi-chan. Hey, Louis-chan, come here! You’re with me!”

Louis’s body, as she clutched her forehead, was carried by Medium’s arms stretching out from behind her. After that, Louis continued to flap her legs, struggling to jump towards Subaru.

Her figure disappeared behind the door again, and this time Louis’s misdeeds came to a definite end.

Subaru: “Sheesh, what was that...”

⁴⁷ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “The expression used here is «世紀末», which might be something Subaru got from Hokuto no Ken, as it is used there as well.”

Al: “She’s gotten even more attached to you, bro. Ain’t that it? Even if she hasn’t followed the story, she feels that you almost died.”

Subaru: “———”

If Al’s point was right, then Louis’s attitude was out of concern for Subaru.

It was hard for Subaru to accept that, emotionally. Louis was acting like an innocent child, but deep down, an evil and unforgivable malice was present.

Stubbornly believing this was the basic premise of the relationship between Subaru and Louis.

Subaru: “Abel, I’m going to go to my room to rest. You can...”

Abel: “Do not bother. You being present would not be of much use to us in a crisis.”

Subaru: “Don’t just leave it to Taritta-san. Be on the lookout for night raids all night.”

Upon obtaining a response devoid of any concern, Subaru replied with a scathing remark.

He was sorry that Taritta, who had to mediate all this, was in a panic, but for the time being, he was relieved that everything that had to be done before he went to rest, was now over.

Subaru: “I’m going to take off my makeup, undress... and sleep like a log.”

Returning to the room he had been assigned to, Subaru bobbed his head as he undressed.

Now that he had left the Shudraqian village, it was not possible to repair his wig easily. It needed to be treated with great care and attention, so the process was very delicate.

He washed the wig by pressing it into a fine mesh net, then carefully washed his clothes and shoes after taking them off.

After the minimal treatment, Subaru sunk into bed.

Closing his eyes, he slowly drifted away from consciousness.

Subaru: “Tomorrow, then...”

The circumstances had evolved again.

If the situation changed, what he saw would change. If what he saw changed, a path would open. If a path would open, he could get closer to his goal. That was where everyone he had been separated from was.

Subaru: “Rem, Beako... Emilia, tan...”

With an ache in his heart, Subaru called out the name of his loved ones in another country.

As he dreamed of his loved ones’ names and his reunion with them, his consciousness faded—



???: “———”

At a slow pace, the awakening of his consciousness came, and Subaru opened his eyelids atop the bunk.

He was not one to fall asleep easily, usually, but last night he had been so tired that he slept very well. So deeply that he did not even remember having dreamt.

He’d thought that would have been enough to rid him of much of his fatigue, but—

Subaru: “What⁴⁸?”

However, it was not sufficient rest that prompted Subaru’s awakening, but a noisy presence.

In the bedroom where Subaru slept, some kind of lively voice and presence came from the other side of the door. This had served as an alarm, having pulled Subaru out of sleep.

—A noisy atmosphere upon waking, was never a good sign.

⁴⁸ Translation note from Witch Cult Translations: “Subaru stops using his Natsumi style of speech (feminine, more polite), and starts using his usual style again after this, for the most part.”

Outside the window, the morning sun was leaking through the closed curtains, indicating that it was a little too early in the morning.

Feeling the already-noisy atmosphere of the Demon City, Subaru looked at the wig drying in the shade, at a loss what to do with it.

Considering what he had done so far, he should dress like a woman with his Natsumi Schwartz persona.

But if the situation on the other side of the door was dire, there was no time for crossdressing. Mulling it over for a moment, he decided that first priority went to finding out what was occurring.

There was a high likelihood that he was jumping into the wrong conclusion. If it was indeed important, Al, Medium, Taritta, or someone other than Abel would have woken Subaru up. Therefore—

Subaru: “Ah!?”

With this thought in mind, Subaru attempted to get out of bed, and fell from his shoulders to the floor.

The impact sent sparks flying in front of his eyes, causing Subaru astonishment at what had happened to him. It was not that he was sick, or that he had stepped on the clothes he had taken off.

It was, however, that his foot had missed the floor entirely as if he had misjudged the height.

—Subaru’s legs had been unable to cover the distance from the bed to the floor.

Subaru: “That’s ridiculous...”

Subaru, too, was troubled by the fact that his legs were short, but not to the extent that it interfered with his daily life in any way. Even with his short legs, he had been with his body for eighteen years.

He sat up, only to realize that he could not have messed up that badly.

—Strangely, compared to last night, everything in the room looked bigger.

Subaru: “Hey, heyhey, what kind of joke’s this...”

His cheeks tensed and his voice quivered, as Subaru touched his face. Gasping at the loud sound of his heartbeat, he crawled, his arms and legs clutched by his bulky clothes.

Just like that, Subaru headed for the mirror in his bag. A mirror was essential for fixing his makeup and getting dressed, so he reflected himself in it to see what had happened and—

Subaru: “What the hell is this...?”

Looking at what was reflected by the mirror, Subaru muttered in dismay.

The mirror trembling in his hand, its reflection was none other than Natsuki Subaru. However—

Subaru: “———”

—However, there he was, young Natsuki Subaru, as a boy around ten years old.



Illustration from Volume 28, coloring by Setowi ([source](#))

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